

MILK IS GOLD:
AN ENVIRONMENTAL AND ANIMAL HISTORY OF LIVESTOCK HERDING IN
SOCIALIST MONGOLIA

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¹ Erdene Seng, "Solitude," trans. Kenneth Linden, *Words Without Borders*, October 2018, <https://www.wordswithoutborders.org/article/october-2018-dalit-writing-solitude-erdene-seng-kenneth-linden>

² Kenneth E. Linden, "Animals, Socialism, and Continuity: Wolf Hunting in the Mongolian People's Republic," *Inner Asia* 23, no. 2 (November 18, 2021): 257–84.

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In this dissertation, I show how leaders in the Mongolian People's Republic used the collectivization campaign from 1956-1960 to change the way in which Mongolians interacted with animals and the environment. Collectivization, which followed the Soviet model, was the confiscation of private livestock to create collectively owned and worked livestock herds, and was seen as one of the building blocks of a modern socialist state. Mongolia had, and still has, a nomadic pastoralist economy, but this was subject to change over time, rather than being a romanticized and timeless way of life, and one of the largest changes occurred during the socialist era. My sources for this dissertation are Mongolian and Russian language archival sources, oral histories, socialist era handbooks, periodicals, and histories, as well as Mongolian short stories, poetry, songs, and films.

I divide my dissertation into four chapters, which consist of the main elements of the collectivization campaign. In the first chapter I show how socialist leaders pursued collective ownership of livestock and professionalization of herding, and emphasized development through traditional knowledge and strategies. The second chapter covers the introduction of international veterinary science which consisted of the introduction of a professional class of veterinarians, vaccines, and improved and hybrid livestock breeds. In the third chapter, I cover how leaders introduced policies and infrastructure to alleviate the two main climatic disasters in Mongolia, *zud* (winter disaster) and drought. Finally, I show how wolf extermination designed to protect livestock called upon centuries of antipathy towards wolves in Mongolia. These campaigns were both firmly rooted in Mongolian history and environment and inspired by Soviet and global modernization campaigns. As such collectivization resulted in a mix of traditional strategies and new technologies. Many former leaders and members of collectives reflected fondly on the state of herding during socialism as better as the uncertainty that followed during the capitalist period.

My dissertation contributes to the study of Mongolia and Central Eurasia history, socialism, and global environmental and animal history. I show the socialist modernization of Mongolia within the context of Soviet and global modernization campaigns to change human, animal, and environmental relations.

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Transcription System

For Mongolian language transliterations and transcriptions, I follow the system of transcription for Cyrillic Mongolian in Christopher Atwood's *Encyclopedia of Mongolia and the Mongol Empire*. This system consciously does away with the Russian transcription holdovers and tries to represent Mongolian the way that Mongolian is pronounced. Thus, x is kh, в is w, з is z, and ж is j. I also prefer to represent ь as an i. Umlauts must always be used as the difference between y (u) and ү (ü), and o (o) and ө (ö) is critical. I follow the Cyrillic spelling for figures like Sükhbaatar and Choibalsan, despite their use of the Classical system for ease and consistency. For Russian, I use a modified Library of Congress system.

Introduction

The primary lifestyle of what is today's independent Mongolia for over two millennia has been a mobile form of livestock herding, often referred to as nomadic pastoralism. Herders usually move in a regular seasonal migration with their herds, which generally consist of some combination of the “five snouts” (*tawan khoshuu mal*): horse, cattle, camel, sheep, and goat. The environment of Mongolia is varied, from semi-desert to mountainous forest to semi-arid steppe, and herding strategies vary based on the environment.³ Observers outside and inside of Mongolia have long positioned it as a timeless, untouched land inhabited by nomadic pastoralists living in harmony with their animals and environment in the same manner that their ancestors have for thousands of years. This mythology is reinforced time and time again by lay people, the tourism industry, and governmental and non-governmental officials angling for funding, as well as many scholars.⁴ Yet this vision is not based on reality. Beyond the fact that a static nomadic Mongolia is, as many scholars have shown, a damaging and infantilizing mythology, it is also fundamentally incorrect.⁵ Mongolia, and herding in Mongolia, has a concrete history that can and ought to be traced. Herding in the Mongol Empire differed greatly from herding in Mongolia today, and herding under capitalism differs a great deal from that under socialism. Most research on Mongolian herding is based on the post-socialist period. This lacuna serves as a call for historians to examine the viability of these models in specific regions and periods both socialist and pre-socialist.

³ See Caroline Humphrey and David Sneath, *The End of Nomadism? Society, State, and the Environment in Inner Asia*, Central Asia Book Series (Durham: Duke University Press, 1999) for a history of modern Inner Asian herding and regional strategies.

⁴ For a detailed discussion of foreign and Mongolian notions of Mongolia as a nation of nomads, see Orhon Myadar, *Mobility and Displacement: Nomadism, Identity and Postcolonial Narratives in Mongolia* (Routledge, 2020).

⁵ David Sneath, *The Headless State: Aristocratic Orders, Kinship Society, & Misrepresentations of Nomadic Inner Asia* (New York: Columbia University Press, 2007); Humphrey and Sneath, *End of Nomadism?*; Myadar, *Mobility and Displacement*.

In this dissertation, I show how socialist policies in the Mongolian People's Republic shaped herding, from herders' lives to the breeds of livestock, and how Mongolians interacted with animals and the environment through the process of collectivization from 1956–1960. Mongolian leaders followed the Soviet model of collectivization as part of socialist modernization, but they adapted it to fit the Mongolian society, economy, and environment. Socialist human-animal and environmental relations were not a clear break from the past, and many leaders argued that the best of traditional knowledge (as defined by socialist leaders and herders) had to be preserved and combined with the latest modern theory and technology. According to leaders, collectivization would solve inequality and cultural, economic, and technological backwardness. The collectivization campaign promised a system of shared ownership and increased production, and the promise of shared ownership has made socialism very attractive to millions of people throughout its history.

The 1966 edition of the *History of the Mongolian People's Republic* posits that for the MPR, “the sole path for thoroughly improving the herdsmen.... [in terms of] economy, living, and cultural-educational levels was the path of cooperatives, the path of socialism.”⁶ Collectivization was a fundamental building block of socialist modernity, or as socialists phrased it, “building socialism.” Sometimes “modernity” is seen to be a charged concept peculiar to the West.⁷ However, I follow historians such as Melissa Chakars and Sarah Cameron in their use of the term *socialist* (or *Soviet*) *modernity* to understand the process of socio-economic

⁶ B. Shirendev et. al., *History of the Mongolian People's Republic*, trans. William A. Brown and Urgunge Onon, (Cambridge: East Asian Research Center, Harvard University, 1976), 550; B. Shirendev et. al., *Bügd Nairamdakh Mongol Ard Ulsyn Tүүkh* 3, (Ulaanbaatar: Ulsyn Khevelelin khereg erkhlekh khoroo, 1966), 592.

⁷ Michael E. Latham, *Modernization as Ideology: American Social Science and “Nation Building” in the Kennedy Era* (Chapel Hill: University of North Carolina Press, 2000).

transformations embarked on by the Soviet and other socialist states.⁸ Indeed, Yuki Konagaya, whose oral history interviews form a core of this dissertation, refers to “socialist modernization” during this period in Mongolia.⁹ Socialism promised a utopian vision of equality and an advanced cultural, technological, and economic life. In practice, state socialism operated on a centralized planned economy, in which outputs and inputs for all industries were planned five years at a time, and the state would redistribute goods to everyone based on their needs.¹⁰

Socialist modernization was carried out by Mongolians, rather than solely being an imposition from abroad. Mongolians changed how herds were managed, created new hybrid breeds, formulated methods to combat climatic disasters, and attempted to exterminate wolves. Collectivization, and socialism, shows that Mongolians and other North Asians have shaped their environment for centuries and questions of the uses of nature, the proper use of the environment, protection of animals and the environment, exploitation of natural resources, and more are not unique to the West or the 20th century. Many methods of modernizing the herding economy are similar to those found not only in the Soviet Union but also Western Europe, North America, and Japan. This demonstrates a shared culture of modernization to which Mongolia belonged, regardless of whether the society was socialist or capitalist, Christian, Buddhist, or atheist. The archives are clear that every year thousands of livestock were killed, along with thousands of fur bearing animals hunted, most often for export to the Soviet Union. While similar extraction occurred over the millennium, the extraction of both domesticated and wild animals, and exploitation of the environment for maximum production, was a hallmark of socialist modernity.

⁸ Melissa Chakars, *The Socialist Way of Life in Siberia: Transformation in Buryatia* (Budapest: Central European University Press, 2014), 3–10; Sarah Cameron, *The Hungry Steppe: Famine, Violence, and the Making of Soviet Kazakhstan* (Ithaca: Cornell University Press, 2018), 3.

⁹ Yuki Konagaya, “Socialist Modernisation in Mongolia as Narrated after Socialism,” *Inner Asia* 12, no. 1 (2010): 5–23.

¹⁰ For a basic introduction to socialism, see Katherine Verdery, *What Was Socialism, and What Comes Next?*, Princeton Studies in Culture/Power/History (Princeton: Princeton University Press, 1996).

Socialist modernity followed a developmentalist philosophy of exploitation of nature in order to maximize production, which it shared with capitalism. As J.R. McNeill argues, “the same ambitions—economic development and state power—that inspired state-sponsored industrialization elsewhere drove the heroic sprints of communist five-year plans.”¹¹ McNeill continues to argue that “capitalists, nationalists—indeed almost everyone, communists included—worshiped at this same altar because economic growth disguised a multitude of sins.... Economic growth became the indispensable ideology of the state nearly everywhere.”¹² Mongolia followed the model of socialist modernity pioneered by the Soviet Union, and though herding was looked down upon in the Soviet Union and the People’s Republic of China, in Mongolia it was elevated to the level of proper proletariat labor.¹³ This remained one of the most important distinctions in socialist herding across North and Inner Asia.

Continuity versus Change

Socialist reformers of herding and related economic activities like hunting had to play a constant balancing act between revolutionary change of human-animal and environmental relations and promotion and elevation of traditional pre-socialist knowledge and strategies. This tension between continuity and change manifested differently within each element of collectivization. Collectives and collectivization were billed and portrayed as a radical break from the old societal structure by removing the wealthy and the risk of private ownership, but advice for herders often emphasized the importance of listening to elder skilled herders who obtained their skills in the pre-collectivization period. Veterinary care represented the greatest

¹¹ J. R. McNeill, *Something New Under the Sun: An Environmental History of the Twentieth-Century World*, 1st ed, Global Century Series (New York: Norton, 2000), 278.

¹² McNeill, *Something New Under the Sun*, 280.

¹³ For Soviet views of nomadism, see Alun Thomas, *Nomads and Soviet Rule: Central Asia under Lenin and Stalin* (London: Bloomsbury Publishing, 2018).

rift from the past, with a corps of newly trained socialist professionals, and official denigration of the old “superstitious” style of veterinary care. Vaccines were celebrated new scientific advancements, as were improved and hybrid breeds. Still, the hardiness of native Mongolian breeds was well known and noted by herders, zootechnicians, and socialist leaders. Indeed, hybrid breeds embody the literal melding of the new foreign improved breeds with the old native breeds. Protection and mitigation of climatic disasters often relied on infrastructure like shelters and wells and tactics such as hay collection which existed in the pre-socialist period but were able to be built in a more regimented manner thanks to the reorganization of laborers into collectives. Finally, hunters and leaders called upon centuries of anti-wolf sentiment to promote the professional extermination of wolf. The melding of new and old most often left strong continuities with pre-collective human-animal and environmental relations, but organized in a more systematic manner.

This dichotomy follows an important aspect of Soviet socialist development, “indigenization” (*korenizatsiia*), where local leaders were intended to lead and any non-natives were expected to learn the local languages in places like Central Asia and Siberia.¹⁴ In a similar vein, the People’s Republic of China was supposed to promote language and culture of autonomous regions, though in both cases these policies were jettisoned when politically convenient.¹⁵ Still, this left a blueprint for a “translation” of Soviet-style socialism into Mongolian, from language to culture to economic activity. Collectivization’s resulting blend of traditional and modern elements reflects the tensions in the various socialist states’ attitudes to

¹⁴ For a detailed description of *korenizatsiia* in the Soviet Union, see Terry Martin, *The Affirmative Action Empire: Nations and Nationalism in the Soviet Union, 1923-1939*, The Wilder House Series in Politics, History, and Culture (Ithaca: Cornell University Press, 2001), 125-181.

¹⁵ See David Sneath, *Changing Inner Mongolia: Pastoral Mongolian Society and the Chinese State*, Oxford Studies in Social and Cultural Anthropology (Oxford: Oxford University Press, 2000); Uradyn Erden Bulag, *The Mongols at China’s Edge: History and the Politics of National Unity*, (Lanham: Rowman & Littlefield Publishers, 2002), 105-136.

“less developed” peoples, but unlike in the Soviet Union and the People’s Republic of China, Mongolians were in charge, albeit influenced, at times heavily, by the Soviet Union.

Modern Mongolian History

Before 1911, what is now independent Mongolia was part of the Manchu ruled Qing Empire.¹⁶ In 1911 what was then Outer Mongolia declared independence under the theocratic rule of the incarnate lama Eighth Jibzundamba Khutugtu, also known as the Bogda Khan (Holy Emperor). This restoration of independence placed the Buddhist clergy and nobles in charge of the country while retaining the servitude of the commoners to their noble or religious superiors. In 1915 Mongolia signed the Kyakhta Trilateral Treaty which granted it autonomy, but not independence, under the Republic of China. However, in 1919 disgruntled Mongolian nobles agreed to a revocation of autonomy which led to a Chinese occupation of Mongolia.

This was not well received by numerous Mongolians in the capital, and three city dwelling “parties” formed with the intention to remove the new Chinese rule: the “officials,” “commoners,” and “nobles.”¹⁷ The “officials” faction, led by Danzin, consisted of low-ranking bureaucrats in the Theocratic government, while the “commoners” faction, led by Bodô, had numerous ties with the Russian consulate. These two factions formed the People’s Party of Outer Mongolia. First without, and then with, the Bogda’s backing, the People’s Party reached out to the Bolsheviks, which was still embroiled with the Russian Civil War against White Russians. Of particular note was the assistance given by Buryat leaders and intellectuals including Tsyben

¹⁶ For a detailed history of modern Mongolia see Charles R. Bawden, *The Modern History of Mongolia*, 2nd rev. ed., KPI Paperbacks (London: Kegan Paul International, 1989), and various entries in Christopher Pratt Atwood, *Encyclopedia of Mongolia and the Mongol Empire*, Facts on File Library of World History (New York: Facts On File, 2004). For socialist era Mongolian histories, see the various editions of B. Shirendev, Sh. Natsagdorzh et al., eds., *Bügd Nairamdakh Mongol Ard Ulsyn Tuiikh* (Ulaanbaatar: Ulsyn Khevreliin khereg erkhekh khoroo, 1966).

¹⁷ Fujiko Isono, “The Mongolian Revolution of 1921,” *Modern Asian Studies* 10, no. 3 (1976): 375–94; Hiroshi Futaki, “A Re-Examination of the Establishment of the Mongolian People’s Party, Centering on Dogsom’s Memoir,” *Inner Asia* 2, no. 1 (January 1, 2000): 37–60.

Zhamtsarano. When the White Russian Baron Roman Ungern-Sternberg invaded Mongolia, he cooperated with the “nobles” party to create his new government which again placed the Bogda Khan as the titular head of state.¹⁸ Ungern-Sternberg’s invasion gave the Soviets an excuse to support the Mongolian revolutionaries by framing their intervention as part of the Russian Civil War. The Mongolian forces, led by the former theocratic army officer Sükhbaatar, first defeated the remaining Chinese troops, then turned to face the Whites with Soviet assistance. The Mongolian-Soviet alliance defeated Ungern-Sternberg’s forces, first in the capital and then the rest of the country, while various Mongolians who sided with Ungern-Sternberg betrayed him to join the revolutionaries.

The revolutionaries established a constitutional monarch on July 11, 1921, which retained the Bogda Khan as a figure-head of the country as the party began implementing relatively modest socialist-style social reforms. In 1924 the Bogda Khan died, and the party abolished the monarchy, wrote a new constitution, and declared the Mongolian People’s Republic, the second socialist country in the world. The ruling party officially became the Mongolian People’s Revolutionary Party in 1925. After sporadic party purges in the 1920s, the MPRP attempted to democratize and then collectivize the herding economy in 1929, contemporaneous with the Soviet collectivization campaign. Widespread resistance followed, and in 1932, a civil war broke out with the resistance to the MPR led by Buddhist clergy. After the rebellion was put down with Soviet assistance, collectivization was shelved.¹⁹ After the rebellion was put down lamas’ rights were curtailed, and various arrests were made through the mid-1930s.²⁰

¹⁸ Willard Sunderland, *The Baron’s Cloak: A History of the Russian Empire in War and Revolution, The Baron’s Cloak* (Ithaca, NY: Cornell University Press, 2014).

¹⁹ B. Shirendev et. al., *History of the Mongolian People’s Republic*, trans. William A. Brown and Urgunge Onon, (Cambridge: East Asian Research Center, Harvard University, 1976), 261; B. Shirendev et. al., *Bügd Nairamdakh Mongol Ard Ulsyn Tүүkh* 3, (Ulaanbaatar: Ulsyn Khevelelin khereg erkhlekh khoroo, 1966), 277.

²⁰ Christopher Kaplonski, *The Lama Question: Violence, Sovereignty, and Exception in Early Socialist Mongolia* (Honolulu: University of Hawai‘i Press, 2014).

In 1937 the anti-lama sentiment culminated in a campaign to exterminate the lamas and destroy Buddhist monasteries, a campaign which was connected to the Stalinist purges in the Soviet Union.²¹ Authorities feared a parallel power structure outside of the state as well as possible collusion with the neighboring Japanese Empire. Stalin first removed, exiled, and eventually killed two leaders, Gendün and Amar, after they resisted pressure to further execute purges. Then Stalin found his man in Choibalsan, one of the few remaining original revolutionaries. From 1937 to 1939, Choibalsan, who by the end of the purges was the last remaining founder of the revolutionary party, carried out the purges of lamas, Buryats, Kazakhs, Inner Mongolians, many existing elites, alleged pan-Mongolists, and alleged counter-revolutionaries. By the end of the purges, over 20,000 lamas had been killed and over 20,000 so-called counter-revolutionaries had been killed, with thousands more imprisoned.²² It is important to acknowledge that while purges were carried out under Soviet influence, Choibalsan and other Mongolians guided the purges.

After the purges, Choibalsan became the unquestioned single leader of the party-state. He positioned Mongolia as an enthusiastic “younger sibling” to the “elder sibling” of the USSR. Mongolia played a role in fighting against Imperial Japan during the Battle of Khalkhyn Gol, and provided large amounts of livestock and supplies to the Soviets during their war against the Nazis. Pride in Mongolia’s role in fighting fascism continued through the socialist era. During World War II, Choibalsan had ambitions to expand the Mongolian borders to include Inner Mongolia and parts of Xinjiang, which Stalin gave support to while he secretly undermined Choibalsan’s efforts.²³

²¹ Christopher Kaplonski, *The Lama Question: Violence, Sovereignty, and Exception in Early Socialist Mongolia* (Honolulu: University of Hawai‘i Press, 2014).

²² Kaplonski, *The Lama Question*, 5.

²³ Sergey Radchenko, “Choibalsan’s Great Mongolia Dream,” *Inner Asia* 11, no. 2 (2009): 231–58.

At the Yalta Conference, Stalin acquired assurances that Mongolia would remain independent from China. This culminated in a plebiscite of independence in 1945, which resulted in an official vote of 483,281 to 0 for independence from China.²⁴ Stalin first made the Republic of China then the People's Republic of China acknowledge the independence of the Mongolian People's Republic, though unfortunately the agreement left both Mongolian and Inner Mongolian leaders unable to achieve their dream of unifying the two as one independent state.²⁵

When Choibalsan died in 1952, followed by Stalin's death in 1953, Mongolia no longer had a paramount leader. The new crop of party leaders who came to prominence after the destruction of the old elite in the Purges shared power with Choibalsan's second in command Yu. Tsedenbal for a time. In 1956, following Khrushchev's Secret Speech in which he denounced Stalin, Mongolia embarked on its own de-Stalinization (and de-Choibalsanization) campaigns, despite Tsedenbal's clear misgivings. It is against this backdrop that Mongolian leaders decided to finally move forward again with collectivization. The *History of the Mongolian People's Republic*, the official history commissioned by the socialist state, continually stresses the voluntary nature of the second round of collectivization, and its transformative role in Mongolian society and culture.²⁶

The political drama continued, and during the late 1950s and early 1960s, Tsedenbal removed the other party members with whom he shared power. In 1958 he removed Damba, who was far more sympathetic to de-Stalinization efforts, then Tömör-Ochir over the Chinggis Khan controversy in 1962, and finally Ts. Lookhuuz, B. Nyambuu, and B. Surmaajaw in 1964 in

²⁴ Christopher P. Atwood, "Sino-Soviet Diplomacy and the Second Partition of Mongolia, 1945-1946," in *Mongolia in the Twentieth Century: Landlocked Cosmopolitan*, 1999, 156.

²⁵ Atwood, "Sino-Soviet Diplomacy and the Second Partition of Mongolia, 1945-1946," 137-161.

²⁶ B. Shirendev et. al., *History of the Mongolian People's Republic*, 566; B. Shirendev et. al., *Bügd Nairamdakh Mongol Ard Ulsyn Tүүikh*, 609.

response to their criticism of Tsedenbal's rule and the country's socio-economic conditions.²⁷

Unlike Tsedenbal's mentor's treatment of his fellow party members, Tsedenbal's rivals were exiled to the countryside rather than killed. Tsedenbal became the unquestioned leader of the Mongolian People's Republic from 1964 to 1984, when he was removed at Soviet urging due to increasingly erratic behavior.²⁸ When the socialist government dissolved itself in 1990, the transition to capitalism followed, and collectives were dissolved in 1993 after over 30 years of existence.

Revisionist Mongolian History

Mongolian history has long been subjected to stereotypes and misinterpretations by historians, social scientists, and in popular culture. The first and most dominant stereotype portrays a timeless nomadic society and culture which was in tune with the environment thanks to their nomadic lifestyle. Due to this lifestyle, they were said to be more egalitarian than neighboring societies, in part because they were mobile wanderers who would simply move away in the face of an unwanted oppressor. In addition, decades the dominant anthropological and historical scholarly narrative held that Inner Asian, including Mongolian, societies were organized by kin-based tribes and clans. There is a growing scholarship that pushes against these stereotypes, of which this dissertation is just the latest.

In *The End of Nomadism?* Caroline Humphrey and David Sneath provide important corrections to outdated notions such as a free roaming nomadic society.²⁹ They dispel the idea of an ahistorical "nomadism," and instead show that across Inner Asia herding strategies varied

²⁷ Sergey S. Radchenko, "Mongolian Politics in the Shadow of the Cold War: The 1964 Coup Attempt and the Sino-Soviet Split," *Journal of Cold War Studies* 8, no. 1 (January 1, 2006): 95–119.

²⁸ Sh Nadirov, *Tsedenbal and the Events of August 1984*, trans. Baasan Ragchaa, Mongolia Society Occasional Papers 25, (Bloomington, Ind: Mongolia Society, 2005).

²⁹ Humphrey and Sneath, *End of Nomadism?*.

based on state policies and environmental conditions. They propose that “mobile-pastoralism” is a better term than “nomad,” given the latter’s connotation of wandering freedom.³⁰ This historicization and categorization of mobile herding in Mongolia and Inner Asia as an interaction between government policies, people, and the environment is extremely influential on this dissertation and my other research projects.

Orhon Myadar provides an important examination and pushback against tropes of Mongolian nomadic society in *Mobility and Displacement: Nomadism, Identity and Postcolonial Narratives in Mongolia*. She argues the romantic ideas of timeless nomads are both “orientalizing projections by spectators of Mongolia and the self-objectifying tropes Mongolians routinely deploy to represent Mongolia as a land of nomads.”³¹ She argues that given the fact that the majority of the population lives in cities and towns, and has done so for some time, the idea of Mongolia as exclusively as a land of nomads is inaccurate. Of course, compared to other countries, Mongolian herding economy is very extensive and culturally and economically significant. Orhon Myadar’s discussion of the socialist period examines the transformation of the herding economy, particularly due to collectivization. Elsewhere she also proposes the provocative interpretation that the Mongolian People’s Republic’s relationship with the Soviet Union should be understood as a colony, and studied using postcolonial theory.³²

Orhon Myadar’s work is an important reminder that while the transformation of Mongolian herding changed Mongolian society, it did not directly encompass every Mongolian, though socialist policies, many of which were related to collectivization, did change the lives of people living in Ulaanbaatar and other cities and towns. Those city dwellers were, and are, no

³⁰ Humphrey and Sneath, *End of Nomadism?*, 305.

³¹ Orhon Myadar, *Mobility and Displacement*, 2.

³² Orhon Myadar, “In the Soviet Shadow: Soviet Colonial Politics in Mongolia,” *Inner Asia* 19, no. 1 (2017): 5–28.

less Mongolian than the herders on whom my research focuses. Ganchimeg Altangerel of Humboldt University's current research on the rise of sedentarization during the socialist era will also serve as an important addition to the understanding of socialist transformation of society.

Sneath continues his corrective of older Inner Asianist thinking in *The Headless State*, first showing the evolution of the anthropological theories of tribe, clan, and kinship and how they became applied to Mongolians and Inner Asia, and then going on to argue that aristocratic orders and states, not kinship, were the basis of historical Mongolian societies.³³ Despite resistance amongst many Central Asianists, particularly Turcologists, Sneath's arguments are accurate in the Mongolian case.³⁴ He bases this on the long history of statehood in Mongolia, from the Xiongnu to the Mongol Empire to modern Mongolia, and the strong presence of aristocratic elites. In the Imperial case the aristocracy was based on descent from Chinggis Khan's loyal followers in the Empire. After the Empire, Chinggis' Borjigin descendants dominated in Mongolia and Inner Mongolia, while non-Chingissid aristocrats ruled among the Oirats. Aristocratic orders persisted in periods which lacked strong centralized states. The Borjigin Chinggisid aristocracy continued to be a dominant political force from the Empire through the Qing Empire into the 20th century independent period, until the socialist government disenfranchised them in the 1920s. Sneath's well-sourced argument of the Mongolian case at the very least and should give pause to many Central Asianist readings of herding societies which emphasize tribes and clans over states and aristocracy.

Christopher Atwood further dismantles the notion of tribe in Mongolian and Central Eurasian history in various publications. He proposes that rather than being organized in tribes,

³³ Sneath, *The Headless State*.

³⁴ Nikolay N. Kradin et al., "Forum AI Debating the Concepts of Evolutionist Social Theory: Responses to David Sneath," *Ab Imperio* 2009, no. 4 (2009): 110–63.

Mongolian society from the Mongol Empire to the Qing can be understood as being constructed of “appanage communities.”³⁵ Atwood argues that appanage communities

on one hand... function as fiefs or appanages, that is, a defined territory and people assigned to the hereditary jurisdiction of a particular nobleman and his descendants, as a unit of local government. On the other hand, each such appanage also normally functions as a closed, corporate community, that is, a group of people who maintain a perpetuity of rights and membership in appanage resources, who limit these privileges to insiders; and who are discouraged from active contact with outsiders.³⁶

Many early socialist districts inherited their boundaries from Qing-era banners, though they were often redrawn over time. The appanage community is not dissimilar to the district-collective model formed post-collectivization in the early 1960s, in which populations had rights to their land not given to outsiders but were generally discouraged, and often forbidden, from traveling outside of their territory save in cases of disasters. Like appanage communities, they were a local form of governance formed by a central state that closely oversaw the proper allocation of resources. And just as with appanage communities, socialist and contemporary districts were not and are not inhabited by shared lineage groups, much less tribes or clans.

Socialism in Mongolia

To understand the history of socialist Mongolia, a basic understanding of socialism is necessary. Socialist Mongolia is rarely studied in Euro-American scholarship. Despite being the second socialist country in the world, the Mongolian People’s Republic is often ignored in discussions of the socialist bloc and the Soviet sphere of influence.³⁷ Socialism is primarily studied from the experiences of peoples whose main agricultural production was farming, most prominently Russians and Han Chinese. This is both because these were the dominant ethnicities

³⁵ Christopher Atwood, “Banner, Otog, Thousand: Appanage Communities as the Basic Unit of Traditional Mongolian Society,” *Mongolian Studies* 34 (2012): 1–76.

³⁶ Atwood, “Banner, Otog, Thousand,” 2.

³⁷ David Stuart Lane, *The Rise and Fall of State Socialism: Industrial Society and the Socialist State*, (Cambridge, Mass: Polity, 1996).

in the largest socialist countries, and because Marx and Engels' theories were based on a European idea of teleological stages of production in which farming societies would give rise to industrialization, which left little room for Eurasian mobile pastoralism.³⁸ The notion that socialism, which was supposed to form from an industrialized working class, would occur in the largely agrarian Russia, much less China, was far from what Marx theorized, the idea of a proletariat of mobile herders required even more theoretical modification. While the MPR took its lead from the Soviet Union and shared much in common with other socialist states, Mongolian socialism was shaped by and in turn shaped the Mongolian environment which had helped establish mobile herding as the primary mode of production.

A quick word on the use of the word "socialism" when referring to the Mongolian People's Republic is necessary.³⁹ Despite some scholar's use of "Soviet" or "communism" as adjectives for the period from 1921 (or 1924) to 1990 in Mongolia⁴⁰, I am a firm proponent of the use of "socialist" to describe this period. First, Mongolia was never part of the Soviet Union, despite the best attempt of some Mongolian leaders in 1949, thus making the term "Soviet Mongolia" as nonsensical as "Soviet Poland." To call the MPR "Soviet" implies that they were mere puppets of the USSR and denies the agency of Mongolians. "Communist" is less problematic, but I argue is not technically accurate: the Mongolian People's Revolutionary Party was not a communist party the same way that the Communist Party of the Soviet Union or the Chinese Communist Party were, as the MPRP never claimed to achieve communism. From 1924 to 1940, Mongolian leaders described their government as "people's government" or

³⁸ Leszek Kolakowski, *Main Currents of Marxism: The Founders – The Golden Age – The Breakdown*, trans. P. S. Falla, (New York: W. W. Norton & Company, 2008).

³⁹ The intellectual history of Marxism, from Karl Marx and Fredrich Engels to Lenin and Stalin's innovations are a fascinating and important topic. However, the degree to which it is necessary to understand collectivization, or broader state socialist history, is often limited due to the local adaptations and interpretations of Marxist theory.

⁴⁰ For one example, see Phillip P. Marzluf, "The Pastoral Home School: Rural, Vernacular and Grassroots Literacies in Early Soviet Mongolia," *Central Asian Survey* 34, no. 2 (2015): 204–18.

“revolutionary.” During the second round of collectivization, Mongolians used the term “socialist” to describe their government, and the “socialist period” is the term used by Mongolians today. It is important to acknowledge the terminology used by Mongolians themselves, and it is vital to understand and engage with local understandings of history and politics. The term socialist is often used to describe the democratic socialist system of countries like Sweden, which are quite politically and economically from Soviet-style state socialism, but this should not prevent us from using the term. In short, it is most accurate to Mongolian historiographical terminology to describe the period of 1921 to 1991 as “socialist,” and I follow this convention.

The Mongolian People’s Republic practiced state socialism, which is a political socio-economic system notable for having a single party which controlled the state through which they dictated all economic plans. The state created five-year plans which laid out all inputs and outputs in the economy. In the Mongolian case this ranged from the number of goat kids born, to milk processed, to wolves killed. The degree to which the plan was achieved was documented, though did not always lead to adjustments in the next year’s plan. Katherine Verdery’s *What Was Socialism, and What Comes Next?* offers an introduction to understanding state socialism. Verdery argues that centralized planning was at the core of the socialist state’s weakness “which the center neither adequately planned nor controlled.”⁴¹ Caroline Humphrey records the problems Verdery describes in the case of collective farm production in Buryatia. For example, milk was sometimes watered down to make the production quota, or non-standard grain included to bump up to the required weight.⁴²

⁴¹ Katherine Verdery, *What Was Socialism, and What Comes Next?*, Princeton Studies in Culture/Power/History (Princeton.: Princeton University Press, 1996), 20.

⁴² Caroline Humphrey, *Marx Went Away—But Karl Stayed Behind* (Ann Arbor: University of Michigan Press, 1998), 221.

Collectivization of land and agricultural production was a key building block in the state socialist project. Collectivization was designed with the Russian peasant in mind, and its basic model was exported across the socialist world from Vietnam to Cuba. Farmlands were confiscated from individual ownership and organized into collective and state farms, while workers became assigned to those lands to work in return for a salary (either in goods in kind or cash). This was in a reaction to a perceived lack of agricultural inputs necessary for industrialization. To activists and leaders, collectivization would address the backwardness and inequality of peasant life.

The study of collectivization in the Soviet Union has a long lived and robust field, and understandably usually focuses on the Russian and Ukrainian farmlands. Scholars moved away from an older totalitarian model which emphasized a top-down approach to understanding collectivization “from above” and to instead understand it as a reciprocal social process “from below,” a school championed by Sheila Fitzpatrick.⁴³ Scholars such as Lynne Viola combine political and social history to show that collectivization came both “from above,” as policies dictated by the state, and “from below, carried out and shaped by local actors. Viola gives particular attention to resistance and death from collectivization.⁴⁴

This dissertation’s use of archival and oral histories is influenced by Gail Kligman and Kathryn Verdery’s *Peasants Under Siege*, an exemplary study of Romanian collectivization.⁴⁵ They meld archival and oral histories to “look for relationships formed among activists themselves and between them and the peasantry and then examine the practices and technologies

⁴³ R.W. Davies and S.G. Wheatcroft, *The Years of Hunger: Soviet Agriculture, 1931–1933*, (New York: Palgrave Macmillan, 2004); Sheila Fitzpatrick, *Everyday Stalinism: Ordinary Life in Extraordinary Times: Soviet Russia in the 1930s*, (New York: Oxford University Press, 1999).

⁴⁴ Lynne Viola, *Peasant Rebels under Stalin: Collectivization and the Culture of Peasant Resistance*, (New York: Oxford University Press, 1996).

⁴⁵ Gail Kligman and Katherine Verdery, *Peasants under Siege: The Collectivization of Romanian Agriculture, 1949–1962* (Princeton: Princeton University Press, 2011).

activists employed, thus gaining a glimpse of the sites at which peasants encountered ‘the Party-state’ directly.”⁴⁶ As they argue, “collectivization not simply as an adjunct to industrial development, as is common in the literature, but as part of a broader set of modernizing technologies.”⁴⁷ This was also the case in Mongolia and to many Mongolians socialism was the same as modernity and collectivization was necessary to build socialism. Mongolian leaders packaged cultural, technological, and environmental transformations along with collectivization.

James C. Scott, a political scientist and theorist of peasant resistance with fieldwork experience in Southeast Asia, characterizes Soviet collectivization as an “assault” that was “imposed by all the brute force at the state's disposal” and that it was an ultimate failure.⁴⁸ Scott’s representation supports the totalitarian model rather than the Fitzpatrickian “from below” or more nuanced later scholarship which shows the complex interaction of both central state and local peasants. Scott’s characterization of collectivization as a complete failure fails to consider the transformation it enacted upon the countryside, including achieving one of the main stated goals of creating a society without wealthy farmers or herders. Of greater importance, collectivization also succeeded in turning peasants into workers integrated in the socialist state which persisted in the Soviet Union for almost sixty years in the Soviet Union and thirty years in the Mongolian People’s Republic and the People’s Republic of China.

Scholarship on collectivization in the Soviet Union and People’s Republic of China’s traditional herding lands are of special interest as a basis of comparison to Mongolian collectivization. While designed with farmers in mind, collectivization was applied to people of all lifeways. In most cases this meant that herding peoples, both Mongol speaking (Buryat and

⁴⁶ Kligman and Verdery, *Peasants under Siege*, 7.

⁴⁷ Kligman and Verdery, *Peasants under Siege*, 4.

⁴⁸ James C. Scott, *Seeing Like a State: How Certain Schemes to Improve the Human Condition Have Failed*, Yale Agrarian Studies (New Haven: Yale University Press, 1998), 202.

Inner Mongolian) and Turkic speaking (Kazakh, Kyrgyz, Tuvan) were collectivized, either directly or indirectly, by non-native peoples who did not have personal experience with herding, a clear example of colonialism. Locals who grew up in herding communities participated in collectivization campaigns, but they were not the ones who created the policies. Soviet criticisms of mobile herders in Central Asia and Siberia were based on the perceived underutilization of their environment and livestock through mobile herding, which was alleged to be less productive than farming and sedentary ranching.

Kazakhstan stands out as the most prominent, and tragic, example of a collectivization campaign targeting herders, during which in which 1.5 million people died and a million fled their homes, while the survivors were forcibly sedentarized. There is a healthy field of scholarship on Kazakh collectivization, and how it fits in the Soviet and broader socialist policies and views towards nomads.⁴⁹ The push for sedentarization during the collectivization campaign in Kazakhstan serves as a contrast to Mongolian collectivization, as herding in Mongolia remained mobile. However, the first round of collectivization from 1929-1932 in Mongolia resulted in violence and migration as well, if not to the same extent as in Kazakhstan. While collectivization led to sedentarization in much of the Soviet Union, in the far North regions of Russia reindeer herding still required migrations of livestock.⁵⁰ In the field of sedentary Central Asian collectivization, Marianne Kamp and Russell Zanca's works on oral history of

⁴⁹ Sarah Cameron, *The Hungry Steppe: Famine, Violence, and the Making of Soviet Kazakhstan* (Ithaca: Cornell University Press, 2018); Robert Kindler, *Stalin's Nomads: Power and Famine in Kazakhstan* (Pittsburgh: University of Pittsburgh Press, 2018); Mukhamet Shaiakhmetov, *The Silent Steppe: The Story of a Kazakh Nomad under Stalin* (London: Stacey International, 2006); Thomas, *Nomads and Soviet Rule*.

⁵⁰ David G. Anderson, *Identity and Ecology in Arctic Siberia: The Number One Reindeer Brigade*, Oxford Studies in Social and Cultural Anthropology. Oxford: Oxford University Press, 2000.

collectivization in Uzbekistan show the importance of class rhetoric in collectivizing, and the utility of oral histories to study collectivization.⁵¹

In the People's Republic of China is an important topic as well. Like research in the Soviet Union, most studies focus on ethnic majority agricultural communities, in this case mainland Han Chinese. As collectivization in the PRC occurred close to the Mongolian collectivization campaign, it is a useful point of comparison. Huaiyin Li focuses on peasant resistance to collectivization and connects peasant's strategies of resistance to centuries of peasant rebellions in pre-socialist China.⁵² Xiaojia Hou emphasizes focuses on collectivization in Shanxi and emphasizes the multi-actor interactions in collectivization over a top down approach, similar to the evolution of historiography of collectivization in the Soviet Union.⁵³ Gail Hershatte's *The Gender of Memory: Rural Women and China's Collective Past* explores how rural women remember the 1950s in the People's Republic of China, including the period of collectivization.⁵⁴

As in the Soviet Union, policies designed for agricultural societies in mind were exported to herding societies in Inner Mongolia, Xinjiang, and Tibet. Benno Weiner's *The Chinese Revolution on the Tibetan Frontier* shows the Chinese Communist Party's efforts to incorporate Amdo in the People's Republic of China. Many Amdo herders reacted violently to collectivization, as they did in other parts of the socialist project, though ultimately the

⁵¹ Marianne Kamp and Russell Zanca, "Recollections of Collectivization in Uzbekistan: Stalinism and Local Activism," *Central Asian Survey* 36, no. 1 (2017): 55–72; Russell Zanca, "Writing the History of Collectivization in Uzbekistan: Oral Narratives," *National Council for Eurasian and ...*, January 1, 2008.

⁵² Huaiyin Li, "Confrontation and Conciliation under the Socialist State: Peasant Resistance to Agricultural Collectivization in China in the 1950s," *Twentieth-Century China* 33, no. 2 (2008): 73–99.

⁵³ Xiaojia Hou, *Negotiating Socialism in Rural China: Mao, Peasants, and Local Cadres in Shanxi, 1949–1953* (Ithaca: East Asia Program, Cornell University, 2016).

⁵⁴ Gail Hershatte, *The Gender of Memory: Rural Women and China's Collective Past*, (Berkeley: University of California Press, 2011), 1.

collectivizing process prevailed.⁵⁵ David Sneath's *Changing Inner Mongolia* explores collectivization as part of the process of the Chinese state transforming Inner Mongolia's society and economy.⁵⁶

The Mongolian case therefore stands out clearly in one major way: policies designed to reshape herding were created and implemented by Mongolian herders, and sons of herders. While many of the leaders of Mongolian collectivization lived in the capital and were urban elite, they were still largely descended from and related to herders. In Euro-American Mongolian scholarship, collectivization appears either as contemporary reports on collectives produced during the socialist period or as an anthropological study looking back from the point of view of the post-collective present. Important early works on collectivization include Daniel Rosenberg's ethnography of the Ikh Tamir collective.⁵⁷ This work also serves as an important primary source. My dissertation differs as it is a history that foregrounds animal and environmental relations, rather than the political leadership of collectives. This distinguishes it from the English language scholarship, as well as Mongolian and Russian scholarship which is rarely in direct conversation with environmental and animal history scholarship.

The *History of the Mongolian People's Republic*, published in Mongolian, Russian, and an abridged version in English, continually stresses the voluntary nature of the second round of collectivization.⁵⁸ The authors emphasize the contrast between the first round of collectivization,

⁵⁵ Benno Weiner, *The Chinese Revolution on the Tibetan Frontier*, (Cornell University Press, 2020).

⁵⁶ David Sneath, *Changing Inner Mongolia: Pastoral Mongolian Society and the Chinese State*, Oxford Studies in Social and Cultural Anthropology (Oxford: Oxford University Press, 2000).

⁵⁷ Daniel Rosenberg, "'Negdel' Development: A Socio-Cultural Perspective," *Mongolian Studies*, 1974, 62–75; Daniel Rosenberg, *Political Leadership in a Mongolian Nomadic Pastoralist Collective* (University of Minnesota, 1977); Daniel Rosenberg, "The Collectivization of Mongolia's Pastoral Production," *Nomadic Peoples*, 1981, 23–39; Daniel Rosenberg, "Leaders and Leadership Roles in a Mongolian Collective: Two Cases," *Mongolian Studies*, 1981, 17–51.

⁵⁸ B. Shirendev et. al., *History of the Mongolian People's Republic*, 566; B. Shirendev et. al., *Bügd Nairamdakh Mongol Ard Ulsyn Tүүikh*, 609.

which was executed before the Mongolian people were ready, with the second round when everyone was ready to join.

N. Altantögs' study of collectives focuses on the procurement and export of livestock and argues that one of the primary purposes of collectives was integrating the economies of the MPR and USSR.⁵⁹ He argues that the extractive exportation of livestock, meat, skins, and dairy to the Soviet Union must be considered when discussing collectivization in the MPR. This integration included the implementation of five-year plans that corresponded with Soviet timing of plans. His arguments are supported by the extensive archival evidence of thousands of tons of livestock per year exported to the Soviet Union.

Environmental History

My work in this dissertation is heavily shaped by the theories and methods of environmental and animal history. Put simply, environmental history is the idea that humans shape the environment and are shaped by it. Environmental and animal history allows us to break down the perceived division between humans, animals, and the environment by demonstrating the entangled relationship between the three. By examining how different peoples in different eras related to the rest of the non-human world, a greater understanding of the history of humans, animals, and the environment can be gleaned, as well as insights on how to navigate the increasingly dire environmental situation in the present day.

A pervasive myth among popular culture and scholarly works emphasizes that Mongolians are “in tune with nature.” Ivan Mikhailovich Maiskii, in his *Contemporary Mongolia* which was based on his travels in 1919-1920, depicts Mongolians in an orientalist light which emphasizes their connection to nature. He states “basic economy of Autonomous

⁵⁹ N. Altantögs, Khödöö aj akhuin negdliin mal aj akhuin tavaaryn бүтээгдэхүүний борлуулалт, khereglee (1960-1990 on), *Historia Mongolarum* 8, 147–68.

Mongolia may be called a primitive or extensive stock-breeding economy. Its most characteristic feature is man's minimal interference in local natural processes.”⁶⁰ In Maiskii’s mind, Mongolians did not exploit their natural resources, and had too much reverence for nature. To Maiskii this was a weakness, though other authors portray this as a positive. Both are inaccurate, however. The very process of selecting pastures, moving herd animals, and choosing which livestock and wildlife to kill, is an anthropogenic transformation of the environment. There has never been a period of Mongolian history where Mongolians did not shape the Mongolian environment.

William Cronon provides one of the most important fundamental ideas to understanding environmental history in “The Trouble with Wilderness: Or, Getting Back to the Wrong Nature.” In this influential article, he shows that the concept of wilderness is a modern cultural construct, shaped by, rather than untouched by, humans and that “everything we know about environmental history suggests that people have been manipulating the natural world on various scales for as long as we have a record of their passing.”⁶¹ This is especially relevant in the study of Mongolia, as it is all too easy to step out into the gorgeous open steppe and see unending wilderness. But the Mongolian environment has been shaped by millennia of the use of the land by humans and livestock. Just as Cronon critiques the celebration of American wilderness as erasing or vilifying the Native Americans whose lands were stolen to create wilderness, the celebration of Mongolia as an untouched wilderness erases Mongolians from the picture and their relation to the environment and animals. From state-wide policies like collectivization, to the selection of

⁶⁰ I. M. Maiskii, *Mongoliia Nakanune Revoliutsii*, 2., perer. izd (Moskva: Izd-vo vostochnoi lit-ry, 1960), 140; I. M. Maiskii, *Contemporary Mongolia* (New Haven: Human Relations Area Files, 1956), 276.

⁶¹ William Cronon, “The Trouble with Wilderness: Or, Getting Back to the Wrong Nature,” *Environmental History* 1, no. 1 (1996): 19.

regular seasonal herding grounds, to the decision to kill a wolf and her pups, all these are decisions that reverberate out and shape and reshape the environment.

As J.R. McNeill states in the introduction of *Something New Under the Sun*, “the modern ecological history of the planet and the socioeconomic history of humanity make full sense only if seen together.”⁶² This is the case of Mongolian collectivization: it cannot be understood without understanding the environment it took place in and the animals that were collectivized (and those which were killed). Nor can Mongolia’s environment be understood without understanding its history of human inhabitation.

While humans have been shaping their environment for as long as they existed, as J.R. McNeill and Peter Engelke argue, the 20th century firmly is no longer part of the geological age the Holocene but the Anthropocene. McNeill and Engelke emphasize that the “Great Acceleration” since 1945 has exponentially increased the rate in which humans change their environments.⁶³ The notion of the Anthropocene, popularized by Paul J. Crutzen, has spawned a great deal of research and various ‘spin-offs’ playing on the idea. One of the more flawed is that of the “Capitalocene,” in which capitalism is highlighted as the major transformer of the environment.⁶⁴ Even a cursory examination of the environmental history of the Soviet Union and the People’s Republic of China shows, however, that capitalism is not the only political-economic system to radically transform the environment. Although not as direct a transformer of the environment as its neighbor the Soviet Union or the People’s Republic of China, Mongolia was and is part of this Anthropocene era, and is especially vulnerable to the impacts of climate

⁶² J. R. McNeill, *Something New Under the Sun: An Environmental History of the Twentieth-Century World*, 1st ed, Global Century Series (New York: Norton, 2000), 18.

⁶³ J. R. McNeill and Peter Engelke, *The Great Acceleration: An Environmental History of the Anthropocene since 1945*, Illustrated edition (Cambridge, Massachusetts: Belknap Press: An Imprint of Harvard University Press, 2016).

⁶⁴ Jason W. Moore, “The Capitalocene Part II: Accumulation by Appropriation and the Centrality of Unpaid Work/Energy,” *The Journal of Peasant Studies* 45, no. 2 (February 23, 2018): 237–79

change. Climate history is understandably one of the biggest fields of environmental history.⁶⁵ Mongolia has always suffered from the climatic disasters of *zud* (winter disasters) and *gan* (drought), and climate change has increased the frequency and damage of these disasters.

Shepard Krech's arguments about the myth of the "ecological Indian" provide an important framework in understanding what can be expanded to be known as the "environmental other."⁶⁶ Krech's work was and is very controversial, but his basic point that Native Americans are fetishized in popular and often scholarly imagination to being near magically in tune with their environment is hard to dispute.⁶⁷ These same stereotypes of a people living in perfect harmony with animals and the environment is often seen in Mongolia as well. Mongols, and other Inner Asians, are in many ways the prototypical "environmental other" for Eurasian sedentary peoples. Their mobile herding lifestyle is either to be looked down upon for being backwards or fetishized for being more in tune than nature than capitalist consumption; and in many cases the two ideas are intertwined.

While some scholars split the two, in my mind the fields of animal and environmental history ought to be understood as two subfields of the same discipline. Still, there are important debates specific to the field of animal history which need to be addressed. One early example of the intertwined histories of animals and the environment is Elinor Melville's *A Plague of Sheep*, which shows how the introduction of European livestock by Spanish colonizers reshaped the Mexican environment.⁶⁸ Indeed, the introduction of Old World animals to the New World is one

⁶⁵ John L. Brooke, *Climate Change and the Course of Global History: A Rough History*, Studies in Environment and History (New York: Cambridge University Press, 2014).

⁶⁶ Shepard Krech, *The Ecological Indian: Myth and History* (W. W. Norton & Company, 1999).

⁶⁷ Michael E. Harkin et al., *Native Americans and the Environment: Perspectives on the Ecological Indian* (Lincoln: University of Nebraska Press, 2007).

⁶⁸ Elinor G. K. Melville, *A Plague of Sheep: Environmental Consequences of the Conquest of Mexico* (Cambridge ; New York: Cambridge University Press, 1994).

of the main fields of animal studies, often inspired by Alfred Crosby's field defining *Ecological Imperialism*.⁶⁹

Susan Nance posits “animals are everywhere, and there has never been any purely human moment in world history.”⁷⁰ Another notable animal historian, Ann Norton Greene, points out that “one of the difficulties of animal history is a lack of understanding that animals change over time. There is a tendency to see them as static, in contrast with changes in human society.”⁷¹ Mongolian leaders and herders clearly distinguish between different breeds and types of livestock. While livestock are often divided into five snouts in plans and general discussion, and “native sheep” may be the default, when improved breeds and hybrids are discussed the new nature and break from the past is implicitly emphasized.

Scholars like Baratay, Nance, and Greene emphasize the importance of agency in animals.⁷² They argue that many animal histories are in fact about the way that humans see animals, rather than animals themselves. For example, Amy Nelson argues that the dogs in the Soviet space program were more than just unwilling participants and sacrifices for human progress, as scientists noticed were clear that the dogs were distinct, and had agency, which is why they were useful as analogues for humans.⁷³ In the Mongolian context, Dulam Bumochir, Byambabaatar Ichinkhorloo, and Ariell Ahearn emphasize this in the aptly named “Herd Agency” article.⁷⁴

⁶⁹ Alfred W. Crosby, *Ecological Imperialism: The Biological Expansion of Europe, 900–1900*, 2nd ed. (Cambridge: Cambridge University Press, 2004).

⁷⁰ Susan Nance, ed., *The Historical Animal*, (Syracuse, New York: Syracuse University Press, 2015), 5.

⁷¹ Ann Norton Greene, *Horses at Work: Harnessing Power in Industrial America* (Harvard University Press, 2009), 7.

⁷² Éric Baratay, “Building an Animal History,” *French Thinking about Animals*, 2015, 3–14; Nance, ed., *The Historical Animal*; Greene, *Horses at Work*.

⁷³ Amy Nelson, “What the Dogs Did: Animal Agency in the Soviet Manned Space Flight Programme,” *BJHS Themes* 2 (2017): 79–99.

⁷⁴ Dulam Bumochir, Byambabaatar Ichinkhorloo, and Ariell Ahearn, “Herd Agency: Rethinking Herd–Herder Relations in Mongolia and Qinghai, China,” *Inner Asia* 22, no. 2 (2020): 183–98.

In this dissertation I often struggled to adequately discuss animal agency, in part due to the sources I utilize. Government plans and data points have little room for questions of animal agency, and socialist thinking emphasized the role of humans in shaping animals and the environment, not vice versa. Despite that, animals do have agency. Rather than attempting to divine agency of animals without adequate evidence, I will instead focus on how Mongolians saw animal agency. And they did see animal agency, from where sheep choose to move when grazing to attributing malicious intent to a wolf's predation of livestock. A life of close interaction with animals often encourages people to acknowledge the agency of animals, and this was certainly the case of Mongolian herders and hunters. While wolf pelts appeared as mere numbers in the archives, oral histories, news reports, and literature provide stories of famous wolves who were said to evade capture from hunters due to their age and skill. Similarly, herders recognized the differences between different types of livestock, and individuals within them. For now, this will have to suffice, though perhaps future studies will allow a greater analysis of animals' own agencies.

Eurasian Animal and Environmental Histories

Eurasian environmental and animal histories are especially useful comparisons when studying Mongolian environmental history. East Asian environmental history is a growing field, including scholarship on the environmental history of mainland China. These scholars often focus on the degradation of the environment, usually due to population pressures or state policies.⁷⁵ Judith Shapiro's *Mao's War Against Nature* shows the extreme steps the PRC took

⁷⁵ Mark Elvin, *The Retreat of the Elephants: An Environmental History of China* (New Haven: Yale University Press, 2004); Robert B. Marks, *China: An Environmental History* (Rowman & Littlefield, 2017).

against animals and the environment in their drive towards socialist modernity.⁷⁶ Many of the extermination campaigns embarked on animals by Maoist China have parallels with other global extermination campaigns, including Mongolia's campaign against wolves. Judith Shapiro also cowrote *China Goes Green* with Yifei Li, which examines the policies enacted by the PRC in the name of environmental protection.⁷⁷ The section on ecological migration and forced sedentarization of nomads is especially relevant as many of the disingenuous reasons used by the PRC to evict herders from their homelands have been taken as objective fact and applied to Mongolia, such as the vilification of goats as the cause of desertification.

Neighboring regions also help provide greater context of the term "traditional" herding. I use this term throughout the dissertation to refer to the pre-socialist herding that socialists both criticized and lionized, depending on the context and topic. Traditional is a moving target however and is often invented explicitly in the modern era. For example, Liz Chee tackles the sometimes-heated topic of so-called "Traditional Chinese Medicine," specifically the use of animal parts.⁷⁸ She shows that rather than a timeless tradition, these cures were formulated and promoted during the Maoist era and shows the extreme abuse and damage to conservation wrought by the normalization of Traditional Chinese Medicine. Her work shows the importance of finding the history of mythologized human-animal relations, and facing the damage wrought by alleged traditional practices.

Japanese environmental history is an especially robust field, with Conrad Totman's *The Green Archipelago: Forestry in Preindustrial Japan* as one of the first major works.⁷⁹ Brett

⁷⁶ Judith Shapiro, *Mao's War Against Nature: Politics and the Environment in Revolutionary China*, Studies in Environment and History (Cambridge; New York: Cambridge University Press, 2001).

⁷⁷ Yifei Li and Judith Shapiro, *China Goes Green: Coercive Environmentalism for a Troubled Planet*, (Cambridge: Polity, 2020).

⁷⁸ Liz P. Y. Chee, *Mao's Bestiary: Medicinal Animals and Modern China* (Durham: Duke University Press Books, 2021).

⁷⁹ Conrad Totman, *The Green Archipelago: Forestry in Preindustrial Japan* (University of California Press, 1989).

Walker's works cover a range of topics on the environmental history of Japan.⁸⁰ His *Lost Wolves of Japan*, on the history of wolves in Japan from the start of recorded history to extinction in the early 20th century serves as an excellent example of animal and wolf history.⁸¹ Scott O'Bryan's work on climate and urbanization shows that modern city planning has major environmental consequences.⁸²

Scholars working in Mongolia and neighboring regions must work to historicize human, environmental, and animal relations that are all too often idealized in an ahistorical imagination. Johan Elverskog's *The Buddha's Footprint: An Environmental History of Asia* is an important work that challenges the dominant narrative of Buddhism and Buddhists existing in harmony with nature.⁸³ He instead highlights three main categories of actors: monks, lay people, and states:

Driven by the Dharma's prosperity theology, these three categories of Buddhist actors moved out onto the commodity frontier and there drove the large-scale interlocking processes of agricultural expansion, marketization and commodification of the economy, urbanization, deforestation, landscape transformation, and the transmission of crops and disease.⁸⁴

Elverskog's argument is certainly applicable to Mongolia which is historically and today primarily Buddhist. Mongolians are often portrayed using many of the same stereotypes of harmonious living that Elverskog dismantles, in part due to its Buddhist heritage but also due to Mongolia's historical mobile pastoral economy.

⁸⁰ Brett L. Walker, *Toxic Archipelago: A History of Industrial Disease in Japan*, Weyerhaeuser Environmental Books (Seattle: University of Washington Press, 2010).

⁸¹ Brett L. Walker, *The Lost Wolves of Japan*, Weyerhaeuser Environmental Books (Seattle: University of Washington Press, 2005).

⁸² Scott O'Bryan, "The Climatic Dilemmas of Built Environments: Tokyo, Heat Islands and Urban Adaptation." In *Environment and Society in the Japanese Islands: From Prehistory to the Present*, ed. Philip Brown and Bruce Batten, 230–45. Corvallis: Oregon State University Press, 2015.

⁸³ Johan Elverskog, *The Buddha's Footprint: An Environmental History of Asia* (University of Pennsylvania Press, 2020).

⁸⁴ Elverskog, *The Buddha's Footprint*, 15.

Russian and Soviet environmental history often shows the developmentalist attitude in socialist modernity, where the environment is to be used to fuel economic development.⁸⁵ Kate Brown examines the history of the disastrous Chernobyl power plant meltdown in *Manual for Survival: An Environmental History of the Chernobyl Disaster*, and a comparison of American and Soviet plutonium mining towns in *Plutopia*.⁸⁶ Sarah Phillips shows how Chernobyl continued to be a potent symbol in popular discourse and understanding the production of food after the event.⁸⁷ Rachel Koroloff shows the evolution of Russian natural history and the cultivation of botanical gardens.⁸⁸ These works are important in the context of modern Mongolia due to the influence the Soviet Union and Russia had on Mongolian People's Republic.

Other environmental histories show Soviet environmental histories in lands outside of the historical Russian heartland and geographically closer to Mongolia. Northern and Arctic environmental histories show the scope of Soviet power in reshaping and responding to the environment, and the limitations. Andy Bruno examines the environmental history of the Soviet Arctic.⁸⁹ His work on avalanches provide a particularly interesting comparison case to the response to climatic disasters in Mongolia.⁹⁰ Pey-Yi Chu provides a history of permafrost in the

⁸⁵ Douglas R. Weiner, *Models of Nature: Ecology, Conservation, and Cultural Revolution in Soviet Russia*, Pitt Series in Russian and East European Studies (Pittsburgh: University of Pittsburgh Press, 2000); Stephen Brain, *Song of the Forest: Russian Forestry and Stalinist Environmentalism, 1905–1953* (Pittsburgh: University of Pittsburgh Press, 2011); Nicholas B. Breyfogle, ed., *Eurasian Environments: Nature and Ecology in Imperial Russian and Soviet History*, Pitt Series in Russian and East European Studies (Pittsburgh: University of Pittsburgh Press, 2018).

⁸⁶ Kate Brown, *Manual for Survival: An Environmental History of the Chernobyl Disaster*, (W. W. Norton & Company, 2019); Kate Brown, *Plutopia: Nuclear Families, Atomic Cities, and the Great Soviet and American Plutonium Disasters* (Oxford University Press, USA, 2013).

⁸⁷ Sarah Drue Phillips, "Half-Lives and Healthy Bodies: Discourses on Contaminated Food and Healing in Postchernobyl Ukraine," *Food and Foodways* 10, no. 1–2 (2002): 27–53; Sarah D. Phillips, "Chernobyl's Sixth Sense: The Symbolism of an Ever-Present Awareness," *Anthropology and Humanism* 29, no. 2 (2004): 159–85.

⁸⁸ Rachel Koroloff, *Seeds of Exchange: Collecting for Russia's Apothecary and Botanical Gardens in the Seventeenth and Eighteenth Centuries* (University of Illinois at Urbana-Champaign, 2014); Rachel Koroloff, "Juniper: From Medicine to Poison and Back Again in 17th-Century Muscovy," *Kritika: Explorations in Russian and Eurasian History* 19, no. 4 (2018): 697–716.

⁸⁹ Andy Bruno, *The Nature of Soviet Power: An Arctic Environmental History* (Cambridge University Press, 2016).

⁹⁰ Andy Bruno, "Tumbling Snow: Vulnerability to Avalanches in the Soviet North," *Environmental History* 18, no. 4 (2013): 683–709.

Soviet Union, which has increasing resonance as the permafrost melts due to climate change.⁹¹

Nicholas Breyfogle examines the rise of environmentalism at Lake Baikal, which occurred at the same time Mongolian leaders framed the loss of endangered species as a major problem.⁹² These regions were part of a larger conversation about the role of animals and the environment that Mongolia was a part of.

In Central Asia, Maya Peterson's work on the environmental history of water in Central Asia shows the extreme level of environmental transformation during the Soviet Union, with the most notable impact being the disappearance of the Aral Sea.⁹³ This massive environmental degradation shows that the idea of the Capitalocene is insufficient in describing the massive environmental change in the modern era caused by both capitalist and socialist governments. Peterson's work on Russian Imperial and Soviet consumption and imagination of fermented mare's milk provides an animal and environmental history of a key steppe animal food product.⁹⁴ Previously discussed scholars of collectivization in Kazakhstan integrate environmental history as part of their research.

Bathsheba Demuth's *Floating Coast: An Environmental History of the Bering Strait* is an excellent example of cutting-edge environmental and animal history, in which she convincingly argues for the similarities in how humans related to the environment and animals in the opposing

⁹¹ Pey-Yi Chu, *Life of Permafrost: A History of Frozen Earth in Russian and Soviet Science* (University of Toronto Press, 2021).

⁹² Nicholas B. Breyfogle, "At the Watershed: 1958 and the Beginnings of Lake Baikal Environmentalism," *The Slavonic and East European Review* 93, no. 1 (2015): 147–80; Nicholas B. Breyfogle, ed., *Eurasian Environments: Nature and Ecology in Imperial Russian and Soviet History*, Pitt Series in Russian and East European Studies (Pittsburgh, Pa: University of Pittsburgh Press, 2018).

⁹³ Maya K. Peterson, *Pipe Dreams: Water and Empire in Central Asia's Aral Sea Basin* (Cambridge University Press, 2019).

⁹⁴ Maya Peterson, "Steppes to Health: How the Climate-Kumys Cure Shaped a New Steppe Imaginary," *Slavic Review* 81, no. 1 (ed 2022): 8–31.

socialist and capitalist production systems across the Bering Strait during the 20th century.⁹⁵ Her work also shows that collectivization of reindeer herding in Soviet Chukotka featured many of the same innovations (veterinary care, predator extermination, disaster mitigation) as in Mongolia, though the fact that it was Russians driving the collectivization remains a major point of contrast.

Mongolian Animal and Environmental Histories

The scholarship on human-animal and human-environmental relations in Mongolia is a growing field and consists largely of anthropological works. Their work provides important observations and analysis of contemporary human, animal, and environmental relations, but by the nature of their sources, these studies are largely presentist. Natasha Fijn's *Living with Herds*, based on her field research with a herding family, is an example of scholarship of human-animal relations in Mongolia, the contribution of which should not be underestimated.⁹⁶ Fijn often emphasizes the perceived differences between Western and Mongolian viewpoints of animals. Post-socialist herding centered around household units in a religiously free society stands in sharp contrast to the socialist and earlier eras of Mongolian herding.

Bernard Charlier's *Faces of the Wolves* uses the wolf as a metaphor to explore the spiritual relationship some herders have with their environment.⁹⁷ One of the most recent scholars to engage with human-animal and environmental relations in Mongolia is Charlotte Marchina, whose research is an exemplary example of how studying people's interaction with

⁹⁵ Bathsheba Demuth, *Floating Coast: An Environmental History of the Bering Strait*, (New York: W. W. Norton & Company, 2019).

⁹⁶ Natasha Fijn, *Living with Herds: Human-Animal Coexistence in Mongolia* (New York: Cambridge University Press, 2011).

⁹⁷ Bernard Charlier, *Faces of the Wolf: Managing the Human, Non-Human Boundary in Mongolia*, Inner Asia Book Series, volume 10 (Leiden: Brill, 2015).

animals and the environment provides greater understanding of all three.⁹⁸ Other anthropologists focus on mining and the destruction and inequality created by post-socialist mining companies.⁹⁹ Saskia Abrahms-Kavunenko provides an anthropology of Ulaanbaatar and connection between Buddhism and environmental issues in the increasingly polluted capital.¹⁰⁰ One of the more novel studies of human-animal relations in Mongolia is by KG Hutchins on how herders use singing and music to connect with their livestock, and use livestock to connect to traditional music in a conservatory setting.¹⁰¹ Robert O. Beahrs's work on throat singing in Tuva also emphasizes the connection between music and landscape.¹⁰²

Recent anthropological work by Charles Stépanoff, Charlotte Marchina, Camille Fossier, and Nicolas Bureau emphasizes the autonomy of animals in North Asian (in this case primarily Siberian and Mongolian) herding systems.¹⁰³ The emphasis on animal agency is an important one that is increasingly emphasized in animal history and animal studies in general. Marchina emphasizes the importance of a horse's individuality and autonomy when Mongolian riders train and select a horse to ride when using a pole lasso.¹⁰⁴ Rather than the binary between domination and symbiosis proposed by some studies of herding and hunting and they instead propose that herders alternate between "five modes of herding" which rely on humans and animals actions:

⁹⁸ Charlotte Marchina, *Nomadic Pastoralism among the Mongol Herders: Multispecies and Spatial Ethnography in Mongolia and Transbaikalia* (S.l.: Amsterdam University Press, 2021).

⁹⁹ Mette M. High, *Fear and Fortune: Spirit Worlds and Emerging Economies in the Mongolian Gold Rush*, (Ithaca: Cornell University Press, 2017); Dulam Bumochir, *The State, Popular Mobilisation and Gold Mining in Mongolia: Shaping 'Neoliberal' Policies* (UCL Press, 2020).

¹⁰⁰ Saskia Abrahms-Kavunenko, *Enlightenment and the Gasping City*, (Cornell University Press, 2019).

¹⁰¹ K. G. Hutchins, "Like a Lullaby: Song as Herding Tool in Rural Mongolia," *Journal of Ethnobiology* 39, no. 3 (2019): 445–59; K. G. Hutchins, "The Melodious Hoofbeat: Ungulate Rhythms in the Post-Socialist Conservatory," *Inner Asia* 22, no. 2 (2020): 217–36.

¹⁰² Robert O. Beahrs, "Gifts of the Sygytchy-Sons: Tethering Melodies to Land, Kin, and Life Energy at the Khöömei Ova, Tyva Republic," *Asian Music* 52, no. 2 (2021): 72–107.

¹⁰³ Charles Stépanoff et al., "Animal Autonomy and Intermittent Coexistences: North Asian Modes of Herding," *Current Anthropology* 58, no. 1 (February 2, 2017): 57.

¹⁰⁴ Charlotte Marchina, "'Follow the Horse': The Complexities of Collaboration between the Lasso-Pole Horse (Uurgach Mori) and His Rider among Mongolian Horse Herders," in Davis and A. Maurstad (eds), *The Meaning of Horses: Biosocial Encounters* (New York: Routledge, 2015), 109–110.

seasonal freedom, attraction, checking, watching, and captivity.¹⁰⁵ Using Charlotte Marchina and other scholar's anthropological research, they propose that the most common modes in contemporary Mongolian herding are checking (in which herders direct livestock to particular pastures and round them up when needed and to move but are most often left alone during the day) for large livestock, watching (regular surveillance for purpose of protection and most often rounded up at night) for small livestock, and captivity for birth and milking seasons.¹⁰⁶ They also point out that herders prefer to designate static watching of sheep and goats to children as it is "boring" compared to the long distance travel needed to look after large livestock.¹⁰⁷ Shared knowledge of the landscape by both humans and livestock increases the bond and autonomy of both, as herds will memorize the seasonal migration between pastures whereas livestock brought in from other areas are often "animals which "run" (Mongolian *güideg*) and that try to reach their "homeland" (Mongolian *nutag*)."¹⁰⁸ This can be a particular problem when engaged in *otor*, an emergency long distance movement due to disaster.

Ultimately the team proposes North Asian herding should be understood as "intermittent coexistence" where animals and humans closely cooperate at certain times and are separate during others.¹⁰⁹ They suggest that this model had a "break" in the socialist period from the five modes but do not offer historical evidence for the domination of certain models in the pre-socialist era and only offer generalizations for the socialist era. This dissertation will help fill in these gaps.

¹⁰⁵ Stépanoff et al., "Animal Autonomy and Intermittent Coexistences," 60.

¹⁰⁶ Stépanoff et al., "Animal Autonomy and Intermittent Coexistences," 62.

¹⁰⁷ Stépanoff et al., "Animal Autonomy and Intermittent Coexistences," 63.

¹⁰⁸ Stépanoff et al., "Animal Autonomy and Intermittent Coexistences," 64.

¹⁰⁹ Stépanoff et al., "Animal Autonomy and Intermittent Coexistences," 69.

There are some notable environmental histories of Mongolia, most of which focus on the pre-modern era. Jonathan Schlesinger's work is an important example of Mongolian and broader North Asian environmental history.¹¹⁰ In the vein of Cronon, he shows that Manchurian and Mongolian environments were not inherently natural paradises but rather shaped by protective policies by the Manchu Qing after elite consumer demands put heavy pressure on the environment.¹¹¹ His work is an important example of how Mongolians and other North Asians have shaped their environment for centuries, and the proper use of environmental resources were long a topic for debate. Schlesinger's archival work is also a strong example of the importance of learning Mongolian, rather than relying merely on Chinese or other imperial languages.

Thomas Allsen was an important voice whose works in animal and environmental history that show the importance of hunting and animal resource extraction in Mongol Imperial and other Eurasian states stand alongside his revolutionary works in Mongol Imperial studies.¹¹² He unfortunately does not engage with animal and environmental scholarship, and perhaps is therefore largely ignored in the field. Despite this unfortunate lack of communication, his *The Royal Hunt in Eurasian History* shows the importance of a shared Eurasian elite hunting culture and was an early introduction for me into the importance of studying animals.¹¹³ Allsen shows both the mass destruction noble Eurasians wrought on wildlife and the close relationship that hunters cultivated with their animal hunting partners. His final book, *The Steppe and the Sea*:

¹¹⁰ Jonathan Schlesinger, *A World Trimmed with Fur: Wild Things, Pristine Places, and the Natural Fringes of Qing Rule* (Stanford University Press, 2016).

¹¹¹ Schlesinger, *A World Trimmed with Fur*, 14.

¹¹² Thomas T. Allsen, *Mongol Imperialism: The Policies of the Grand Qan Möngke in China, Russia, and the Islamic Lands, 1251–1259* (Berkeley: University of California Press, 1987); Thomas T. Allsen, *Culture and Conquest in Mongol Eurasia*, Cambridge Studies in Islamic Civilization (New York: Cambridge University Press, 2001).

¹¹³ Thomas T. Allsen, *The Royal Hunt in Eurasian History* (Philadelphia: University of Pennsylvania Press, 2006).

Pearls in the Mongol Empire, is largely framed as a history of luxury goods, but is still a history of an animal product.¹¹⁴

Nicola Di Cosmo's recent work on climate change in the Mongol Empire, as well as the Uyghur Empire, showcases the strength of interdisciplinary work in environmental history.¹¹⁵ His first article, written together with Neil Pederson's team of climatologists, uses tree ring samples to argue that the period of Temüjin (Chinggis Khan)'s rise coincided with a hot and wet period, which may have contributed to the rise of the Mongol state.¹¹⁶ Merging scientific knowledge and writing with historical knowledge is far from easy, but Di Cosmo shows it is possible and provides new insights and generates new debate. Environmental history allows new interventions and interpretations of historical events and theories.

Sources and Methods

In this work, I deploy a constellation of sources to provide as many points of view as possible and let my sources shape my dissertation. Based on the main areas of concern in which Mongolians implementing collectivization interacted with the animals they were keeping and fighting off, I focus on the ways in which the collectives shaped human-animal relations: collectivization (chapter one), veterinary science (chapter two), climatic disasters (chapter three), and wolves (chapter four). I created these chapter divisions to reflect the most important issues highlighted by my sources, both archival and oral. Collectivization, veterinary science, climatic

¹¹⁴ Thomas T. Allsen, *The Steppe and the Sea: Pearls in the Mongol Empire* (Philadelphia: University of Pennsylvania Press, 2019).

¹¹⁵ N. Pederson et al., "Pluvials, Droughts, the Mongol Empire, and Modern Mongolia," *Proceedings of the National Academy of Sciences* 111, no. 12 (March 25, 2014): 4375–79; Ulf Büntgen and Nicola Di Cosmo, "Climatic and Environmental Aspects of the Mongol Withdrawal from Hungary in 1242 CE," *Scientific Reports* 6, no. 1 (May 26, 2016): 25606; Nicola Di Cosmo et al., "Environmental Stress and Steppe Nomads: Rethinking the History of the Uyghur Empire (744–840) with Paleoclimate Data," *The Journal of Interdisciplinary History* 48, no. 4 (March 1, 2018): 439–63;

¹¹⁶ N. Pederson et al., "Pluvials, Droughts, the Mongol Empire, and Modern Mongolia," *Proceedings of the National Academy of Sciences* 111, no. 12 (March 25, 2014): 4375–79.

disasters, and wolves were always on the top of the lists of what the new socialist system of herding would provide. The introduction of veterinary science, the mitigation of climatic disasters, and the extermination of wolves were all designed to change how Mongolians interacted with the non-human world around them.

The sources I use are primarily Mongolian (specifically modern Cyrillic Mongolian, though documents through the 1950s and 60s featured notations in Classical Mongolian to clarify spelling and grammar), as well as a smaller body of Russian language materials. English translations have been consulted when available, however I have always compared the translation to the original source and utilized my own translation when necessary. To properly understand Mongolia, Mongolian language materials must be front and center.

During the bulk of my time in Mongolia I was engaged in archival research, in the Central Archives, Party Archives, the National Library, as well as in the South Khangai provincial archive in Arwaikheer. Scholars of Mongolia, particularly those of modern history, would do well to take advantage of the provincial archives that have received very little attention from outside researchers. By far the most productive week I spent in Mongolia was in the Arwaikheer archives working with local materials not available in Ulaanbaatar.

Sources compiled by the government include a variety of genres. The most common were five-year and yearly plans and reports on achievements of plans. Long tables of numbers may seem sterile and completely divorced from the lived experience of Mongolians, but sometimes they tell a compelling story with proper effort. Conference reports international, national, and provincial show the exchange and debate over major aspects of collectivization, which were at times still under debate internationally and within Mongolia. Internal party reports on the plans and progress of collectivization reveal the concerns of leaders, and which aspects of

collectivization they were most concerned with. On a local level, the minutes of a collective's meetings can show the latest problem plaguing the collective, while an award to a hunter, for example, demonstrates the worth of certain game over others. Taken together, these sources show government concerns from the very top of the central committee to the leader of a single collective brigade.

There are issues in interpreting government documents that must be addressed. From the lowest level of administration to the top of the party-state, document authors frame numbers and reports in ways to help themselves. Individuals may inflate their numbers in order to make themselves look better. Collective bosses and veterinarians, who were part of the administration of the collective, were on constant watch for misidentification of cause of animal death, as certain deaths would result in punishment for herders, while others were forgiven and if the livestock were those owned privately by the herder, subject to compensation. Collective leaders were often motivated to underreport livestock numbers in order to acquire greater resources from the central government. While government sources are certainly biased, all sources are biased, and as long as the shortcomings of the sources are acknowledged they provide a wealth of information.

There were more practical issues with the archives as well, often resulting from the multiple reorganizations of the archives over the years. Most painful were the documents written in light pencil, compared to the more common pen. Interestingly, most reports had spelling errors, with notations in the margins in Classical explaining the correct spelling in Cyrillic, which reflects the gradual process of adopting the new writing system even for government officials.

My next major set of sources in this dissertation are oral histories and interviews. I did not conduct these myself, given time and methodological constraints. I use the extensive collection of interviews found in the “Oral History Project of Twentieth Century Mongolia,” collected by the Mongolia and Inner Asia Studies Unit at Cambridge University, and was supervised by Caroline Humphrey, David Sneath, and Chris Kaplonski, with the interviews conducted by a team of Mongolian interviewers.¹¹⁷ This collection of over six hundred interviews include numerous interviews of everyday herders recalling the push to join the collectives and what life was like as members of collectives. I also use the excellent in-depth interviews conducted by I. Lkhagvasüren and Yuki Konagaya of various famous socialist Mongolian leaders collected in 2001 and 2006.¹¹⁸ These interviews of different people of different social classes, opinions, and experiences of collectivization give a different perspective than those found in the archive. While there are published English translations of these interviews translated by Mary Rossabi, they hold numerous errors.¹¹⁹ As such, I translated the relevant materials myself.

Oral histories have their own set of challenges for historians. As recollections of the past, they are filtered through the interviewee’s memories, personal and official ideologies, and the present situation, which the past is often used to praise or criticize. Many interviewees speak positively of the socialist past, in what may be described as nostalgia. Yuki Konagaya offers an

¹¹⁷ *The Oral History of Twentieth Century Mongolia*, <http://amantuuh.socanth.cam.ac.uk/>

¹¹⁸ I. Lkhagvasüren and Kokuritsu Minzokugaku Hakubutsukan, eds., *XX Zuuny Mongolchuud*, Senri Ethnological Reports 42 (Osaka: National Museum of Ethnology, 2003); I. Lkhagvasüren, ed., *XX Zuuny Mongolchuud 2: Sotsialist Mongolyn Yls Töriin Am'dral*, Senri Ethnological Reports 72 (Osaka: National Museum of Ethnology, 2007).

¹¹⁹ Yuki Konagaya, I. Lkhagvasüren, and Morris Rossabi, eds., *Socialist Devotees and Dissenters: Three Twentieth-Century Mongolian Leaders*, trans. Mary Rossabi, Senri Ethnological Reports 96 (Osaka: National Museum of Ethnology, 2011); Yuki Konagaya, I. Lkhagvasüren, and Morris Rossabi, eds., *A Herder, a Trader, and a Lawyer: Three Twentieth Century Mongolian Leaders*, trans. Mary Rossabi, Senri Ethnological Reports 107 (Osaka, Japan: National Museum of Ethnology, 2012).

interpretation of his interviews with various socialist leaders, and proposes that their discussions fell into two categories of “admiration” and “accusation,” which was usually based on their experiences during the period but which took on new meaning in the post-socialist era.¹²⁰ Otto Boele, Boris Noordenbos, and Ksenia Robbe’s *Post-Soviet Nostalgia* provides an important theoretical framework for understanding memory and nostalgia in the post-socialist world.¹²¹ They propose that nostalgia can be understood through three main categories: “affect,” which is in response to items or other positions, “appropriation,” in which the state co-opted the frustration of many after the Soviet collapse, and “contestation,” in which the past is used to contrast and critique the present.¹²² Boele, Noordenbos, Robbe, and Konagaya all emphasize the importance of using the memories of the socialist era to contrast and criticize the current situation. One major difference in the Soviet and Mongolian case is the level to which the state shapes the nostalgia. While the dominant Mongolian People’s Party is the heir to the Mongolian People’s Revolutionary Party, and statues of socialist luminaries, including Choibalsan, dot the capital and towns, there is not a concerted effort to promote the socialist era as one of lost glory the way there is in the Russian Federation.

In a similar vein, I utilize autobiographies, most of which were published after the end of socialism, of major leaders, intellectuals, and decorated herders and hunters. Like oral histories, authors most often use the past to comment on the present. For example, authors like Sambuu and Shirendew who wrote and published their autobiographies published during the socialist era often cited their poor and difficult childhood to justify the socialist persecution and expropriation

¹²⁰ Yuki Konagaya, “Socialist Modernisation in Mongolia as Narrated after Socialism,” *Inner Asia* 12, no. 1 (2010): 5–23.

¹²¹ Otto Boele, Boris Noordenbos, and Ksenia Robbe, *Post-Soviet Nostalgia: Confronting the Empire’s Legacies*, vol. 76 (Routledge, 2019).

¹²² Boele, et al., *Post-Soviet Nostalgia*, 8-15.

of nobles, lamas, and wealthy herders. Namkhainyambuu's emphasis on high quality socialist herding should also be understood in part as a criticism of the perceived flaws of post-socialist, post-collective herding practices.

The third main body of primary sources that I use are books published during the socialist era, many of which are handbooks for herders, veterinarians, and hunters, as well as academic, historical, and literary works. It is often unclear how widespread the circulation of these works was but handbooks for herders and hunters likely had a wider spread than academic works. Socialist publications show the production and spread of (usually) officially sanctioned rhetoric about herding, hunting, and the environment. The books I used was largely chosen based on which were available in libraries or a found in the collection of a used book seller, as such there are many more that I did not consult due to availability.

Organization of the Dissertation

In the first chapter of this dissertation, I examine how Mongolian human-animal and environmental relations were changed through the formation of collectives, where Mongolians herded collectively owned livestock, which herders were first encouraged and then forced to join. I use the point of view of collective leaders, top herders, average members, and reluctant collective members, alongside official plans and publications, to explore life inside the collective and how collectivization changed many elements of herding while preserving others. Collectives introduced new technologies and methods for animal husbandry and changed how livestock and pastureland were managed, while the wisdom of elder herders was promoted as an ideal to emulate.

In the following chapters, I explore three major problems facing pastoralism that Mongolian leaders aimed to solve through collectivization. Veterinarians and zootechnicians

were trained using Soviet educational standards but were overwhelmingly Mongolian and formed a new cadre of socialist specialists who spread across the countryside. Vaccination programs aggressively targeted numerous diseases that plagued livestock and succeeded in decreasing the number of livestock that died from disease. Finally, improved breeds which were the embodiment of modern veterinary science, were far from ill planned Soviet impositions, but did suffer from lack of investment and proper infrastructure. In the balancing act of old and new herding strategies, veterinary science was the most that leaned towards new international technologies, though old methods were still written about and acknowledged.

In my third chapter I examine how Mongolian leaders implemented policies and constructed infrastructure to protect against climatic disasters, specifically winter disaster (*zud*) and drought (*gan*). Collectives built warm livestock shelters to protect animals during the winter, hay stations to provide fodder for livestock, and dug wells to protect against drought. These infrastructures used forms that existed before socialism, but utilized the collective labor which the socialist government could mobilize. Environmental disasters were historically a major threat to Mongolian livestock, which climate change has greatly exacerbated. These disasters must be understood as a social process rather than simply as a question of statistics of temperature or precipitation.

Finally, in the fourth chapter I show how socialist Mongolia embarked on a campaign to exterminate wolves, using methods similar to other modernizing countries like the United States. Wolves were a major threat to livestock, and targeting wolves was an easier task than preventing a climatic disaster. In contrast to the common claim of Mongolian reverence of wolves, antipathy for the wolf was more common, and socialist officials, intellectuals, and hunters used pre-existing tropes to justify the persecution of the wolf. The socialist government created a

professional hunting class, but they drew on previous Mongolian hunting history to emphasize the threat that wolves had to the livestock economy.

Together, the chapters of this dissertation show that socialist leaders integrated socialist and traditional ideas and strategies to implement their vision of a new socialist society with transformed relationships between humans, animals, and the environment. The Mongolian government declared success in collectivizing the herding economy, but continued to work on implementing veterinary scientific improvements, infrastructure and policies to combat climatic disasters, and exterminate wolves. The government never reached the increase of livestock numbers that they planned for, but the campaign clearly reshaped herding life for the next three decades—and socialist-era herding continues to have legacies today. Mongolian mobile pastoralism has a long history, but collectivization demonstrates that herding in Mongolia was and is dynamic, and the peculiarities of herding strategies and societal organization shifted a great deal over time, while still retaining certain strategies and attitudes towards animals and the environment.

Chapter 1

Collectivization and Collectives

Introduction

On January 27th, 1956 Tsodol and Yanjidulam in South Khangai province (*aimag*) Öndörönts district (*sum*) joined a newly formed collective (*negdel*).¹²³ The husband-and-wife pair, aged 37 and 26, signed their names on a document handwritten in pencil, became members of the collective, and gave the collective their eight camels, twenty-four horses, twenty-four sheep, and twenty-four goats, a total of seventy-five head of livestock. Why did this couple, and many families like them, willingly give their livestock and labor to a collective? Collectives were especially attractive to poorer herders, and while Tsodol and Yanjidulam had a decent number of livestock by the official socialist metric, the collective promised a level of security and stability that private herding could not. Tsodol and Yanjidulam were apparently successfully persuaded by a campaign to convince Mongolian herders to form and join collectives, which would achieve socialist Mongolian leaders' aim of transforming Mongolian culture, society, economy, and their relationship to animals and the environment.

Collectivization was fundamentally shaped by the realities and restrictions of the Mongolian environment and its traditional herding economy. Although leaders planned to use science and technology to improve yield and quality of livestock, they were very aware of the realities of Mongolian herding and planned to include what they considered to be the best aspects of traditional herding as well. Socialist leaders began to seriously push for complete collectivization of the herding economy in 1956. The collectivization campaign (*negdeljikh khödölgöön*) was a necessary step to follow the Soviet-style blueprint for creating a socialist

¹²³ AA, kh 54 khn 1 pg 3.

state, the penultimate goal of Soviet-style modernization before the achievement of communism.¹²⁴ Socialist leaders set out to address two major concerns: backwardness and inequality. Inequality would be solved by confiscating livestock from the wealthy and holding them collectively where everyone would have the same level of wealth and opportunity based on their labor. According to activists and leaders, collective livestock would receive better care and infrastructure, and have protection from disease, disasters, and predators. Furthermore, they would also create more logical and efficient methods of herding using new technologies and a mix of new and old strategies.

Collectivization in Mongolia merged traditional pre-socialist knowledge with new strategies and technologies, generally adopted from the Soviet Union. However, Soviet innovations were used to improve and increase livestock production well suited to the Mongolian environment. Collectivization also combined the intensification of labor in order to exploit animals and the environment found in other socialist states. This included the land management of pastures which aimed to combine traditional knowledge with scientific methods to scientifically maximize pasture and livestock productivity. The reorganization of land was different than that in other socialist states where farming was the dominant form of agriculture, but collectives did have set lands which became more organized when the district (*sum*) and collective (*negdel*) became coterminous. Collectives were fundamentally extractive enterprises, and plans called for every imaginable metric of growth, including livestock numbers, births, various dairy items, skins, and more. Leaders like Sambuu and Jagwaral argued livestock needed to increase, but the private economy could not be trusted to act in the best interest in the whole and would be unable to create adequate infrastructure needed to modernize herding.

¹²⁴ B. Shirendev et. al., *History of the Mongolian People's Republic*, 561; B. Shirendev et. al., *Bügd Nairamdakh Mongol Ard Ulsyn Tüükh*, 603.

In 1959 Tsedenbal officially declared collectivization a success. This was followed by a deceleration in 1960 of officially achieving socialism with an accompanying new constitution. Collectives continued to be reorganized and changed in the first half of the 1960s. Everyone belonged to a collective but that did not mean that all collectives functioned as planned. Over the next few years collectives were merged until finally the district (*sum*) and collective were made coterminous. The regular evolution of collectives continued to modify and transform Mongolian society, economy, and culture.

Herdling and the Mongolian Environment

Nyamiin Jagwaral, the Minister of Agriculture from 1957 to 1961 and later Secretary and briefly Chairman of the MPRP Central Committee, articulates the mission of collectivization in his 1957 book *Herders and Herder's Economy* (*Aratsvo i aratskoe koziaistvo*):

As a result of their centuries-old activity, Mongolian breeders have developed wonderful ways of conducting livestock husbandry in the conditions of Central Asia. It is necessary to scientifically comprehend the rich experience of livestock breeders and use it in the further development of agricultural production, while discarding everything mystical and backward and selecting all the best and valuable.¹²⁵

As in the case of other aspects of socialist reforms of herding, there is a clear balancing act between new technologies and pre-socialist knowledge and strategies. What were these conditions and rich experiences that Jagwaral wanted to preserve?

Mongolian livestock is currently, and was during the socialist era, divided into five snouts (*khoshuu*), or types: horse, cattle, camel, sheep, and goat, and socialist planners and herders followed the division of the five snouts and monitored the number and needs of each

¹²⁵ N. Zhagvaral, *Aratsvo i Aratskoe Khoziaistvo*, (Ulan-Bator: Akademiia Nauk Mongol'skoi Narodnoi Respubliki, 1974), 188. Though written in 1957, the book was not published in Mongolian and was only published in Russian in 1974, which made the book available only to a certain educated class of Mongolians. As such it reflects Jagwaral's academic studies and internal justifications of collectivization more than other public facing documents.

type carefully. While the socialist era brought a Russian influenced emphasis on other animals, in particular pigs, poultry, and rabbits, they were never reckoned to be as important as the five snouts. This reflects the importance of continuity in the livestock economy, as the five snouts were always reckoned to be the most important. As discussed in Chapter Two, veterinarians and leaders were extremely invested in improving the quality of livestock, especially through veterinary science.

Caroline Humphrey and David Sneath proposes that historical and contemporary Mongolian herders should be understood as “mobile pastoralist,” which is “compatible with many different social and economic systems, including technologically advanced and market-oriented ones.”¹²⁶ In their model, herders carry out seasonal migration between fixed pastures with the most common model having a separate pasture for each season. Humphrey and Sneath also propose that historically Mongolian herding can be understood as belonging to two production modes: “the ‘yield-focused’ or ‘specialist’ mode at one end of the spectrum and the ‘subsistence’ mode at the other extreme.”¹²⁷ Specialist herding is characterized by a wealthy herder who owns most of the livestock employing other herders to take care of their livestock. In contrast, subsistence mode herders have a smaller, more diverse herd that is focused on providing food for the family rather than the market. Specialist herders tend to move greater distances as they both were more likely to have greater resources to facilitate these movements and were often instructed to do so by their employers. These modes were not exclusive, and most herders engaged in some degree of subsistence style herding.

¹²⁶ Humphrey and Sneath, *End of Nomadism?*, 1.

¹²⁷ Humphrey and Sneath, *End of Nomadism?*, 225.

Humphrey and Sneath argue that collectives followed a yield-focused model to that was previously found among herders employed by the wealthy.¹²⁸ They argue “in both ‘feudal’ and collective periods there were centralized, commandist politico-economic units that regulated residence, the use of pasture, and extracted a surplus through rights to livestock.... Like the feudal lords and the monasteries before them, the collectives organized movement, single-species herds, and allocated pasture.”¹²⁹ In both Qing-era and socialist-era herding a high number of livestock was taken off for export, to mainland China and to the Soviet Union respectively.¹³⁰

In collectives, livestock was separated by type, age, and so forth, with specific herders assigned to specialized herding. Even so, the private livestock held by most herders in the collective meant that herders continued to pursue a style closer to the subsistence mode, with a variety of livestock.

Tim Ingold’s work on reindeer herders provides important terminology useful in conceptualizing Mongolian and other North Asian herding societies.¹³¹ He points to two types of relationships between herders, specifically between herd owners and their hired hands: assistantship and associateship herding. Assistantship herding has a herd owner who works their herds and hires a poor herder to help them. In contrast, associateship owners do not herd themselves at all and instead employ herders to work their herds, who then deliver products to the owner. David Sneath adopted and applied these distinctions to Inner Mongolia in *Changing Inner Mongolia*, and carried the influence into *End of Nomadism?*. Mongolian herding has both

¹²⁸ Humphrey and Sneath, *The End of Nomadism?*, 230.

¹²⁹ Humphrey and Sneath, *The End of Nomadism?*, 230.

¹³⁰ For a socialist-era history of resource extraction from Outer Mongolia during the Qing period see M. Sanjdorj, *Manchu Chinese Colonial Rule in Northern Mongolia* (London: C. Hurst, 1980).

¹³¹ Tim Ingold, *Hunters, Pastoralists, and Ranchers: Reindeer Economics and Their Transformations*, Cambridge Studies in Social Anthropology (Cambridge: Cambridge University Press, 1980), 190-191.

models, with associateship herding occurring more often with large scale institutions like nobility, monasteries, and later collectives, whereas assistantship tends to be found among well off commoners.¹³² Assistant and associateship herders are most often paid in livestock products. Socialist leaders condemned both assistantship and associateship herding as exploitative and herd owners that employed other herders as class enemies.¹³³

Mongolian Ecological Regions

Mongolia is ecologically diverse and includes mountains, forested mountain (*khangai*), steppe (*tal*), and semi-desert (*gobi*). These regions vary in average precipitation, amount and type of vegetation, wildlife, and climate. Herding strategies and livestock composition vary based on region; for example, there are more cattle, including yaks, in *khangai* regions and more camel and goats in *gobi* regions. Ivan Mikhailovich Maiskii, famous for his status as a Soviet diplomat, wrote an important pre-revolutionary source of Mongolia based on his travels in 1919 and 1920.¹³⁴ He also describes Mongolian geography, but not in the systematic way that Simukov did later.

Andrei Dmitriyevich Simukov, the noted Russian Mongolist who traveled the region in the 1920s and 1930s before his death in the Stalinist Purges, described regional patterns of mobility in Mongolia that became the standard in scholarly discussions in both Western language scholarship and Mongolian. Simukov proposed six ideal types of herding movements based on the environment: *khangai*-type, steppe-type, western-type, South Khangai-type, eastern-type, and *gobi*-type.¹³⁵

¹³² A contemporary example of this is found in Natasha Fijn's *Living with Herds*, though she does not label it as such. Fijn, *Living With Herds*, 12-13.

¹³³ Sneath, *Changing Inner Mongolia*, 40-41.

¹³⁴ Maiskii, *Mongoliia Nakanune Revoliutsii*; Maiskii, *Contemporary Mongolia*.

¹³⁵ A.D. Simukov, *Trudy o Mongolii i dlia Mongolii*, Senri Ethnological Reports 67 (Osaka: National Museum of Ethnology, 2007), 443-49.

As Simukov describes, the *khangai*-type movement has very low degree of mobility due to the high-production pasture in the moisture and grass rich *khangai* region. As such winter and summer camps are often only four to five miles apart. The steppe-type of migration has summer pastures in the open near water, with winter pastures sheltered by mountains or hills. The Western-type has summer camps in high elevations in the mountain, and with herders moving down the mountain in the fall and using the lower hills as protection from the wind in the summer. The South Khangai-type is similar, but instead of vis a vis a mountain, herders move north of a river, either the Orkhon or its tributaries, in the summer, and south in the winter. Eastern-type movements are like the South Khangai type in that they follow a river, in this case the Kherlen, from north in the summer to the south in the winter. Finally, *gobi*-type herders tend to move only a few miles between pastures in a regular year but will move over a hundred miles during a drought. Herders camp for the summer in flat open areas and move to the mountains in the winter, though herd composition plays a part, with camels preferring flatlands, while horses, sheep, and goats prefer mountains. Simukov makes clear that these are ideal types and herders within a region will pursue a variety of movement strategies based on their locale, wealth, labor availability, and personal preference. Although specialization of herd types is often pointed to as a particular result of collectivization, Simukov shows wealthy herders already engaged in herd specialization. It therefore appears likely that mixed herding is a result of the household-based herding found in contemporary Mongolia as opposed to an imagined default Mongolian type which was disrupted by socialism.

Simukov's divisions are used by both recent scholarship like Humphrey and Sneath in *End of Nomadism?* and Endicott in *A History of Land Use in Mongolia*.¹³⁶ Later socialist

¹³⁶ Humphrey and Sneath, *End of Nomadism?*, 221; Elizabeth Endicott, *A History of Land Use in Mongolia: Thirteenth Century to the Present*, (New York: Palgrave Macmillan, 2012), 27.

Mongolian scholarship cited Simukov and reproduced his classifications.¹³⁷ Tomasz Potkanski and Slawoj Szyrkiewicz focus on the *khangai/gobi* divide in their ethnographic research of herding based on field sites in Eastern Gobi and North Khangai provinces.¹³⁸ They provide excellent details on herding strategies in the two environments and as well as point out the differences in social structure in the regions.

Socialist leaders followed a similar, if simpler, categorization by focusing on three basic regions: *tal* (steppe), *khangai*, and *gobi*. In his 1956 *Advice for Herders (Malchidad ökh zöwlölgöö)*, J. Sambuu lists three regions: “1. *khangai* and *khangai* mountainous zone 2. steppe, eastern steppe, and mixed steppe zone 3. *gobi* steppe or *gobi* desert zone.”¹³⁹ Sambuu emphasizes that each zone has different environments, strategies, and herd composition. Jagwaral likewise describes regional differences, though he focuses primarily on *gobi* and *khangai* regions.¹⁴⁰ This reflects the evolution of socialist division of regions under Jagwaral’s leadership as Minister of Agriculture, in which laws governing the number of private livestock allowed in the collective were divided between the *gobi* and *khangai* regions. Despite the further simplification, this two-fold division shows the continued cognizance of the need to differentiate strategies in Mongolia’s diverse environments, and more elements of continuity in the pre-socialist period.

Sambuu states the knowledge of “our ancient ancestors” (*manai ertnii etseg öwög*), has been passed down the knowledge that the use four seasonal pastures maximizes food and water

¹³⁷ D. Bazargür, B. Chinbat, S. Shiirev-Ad’ia, *Bügd Naraimdakh Mongol Ard Ulsyn Herder’s Movement*, ” (Ulaanbaatar: Ulsyn Kheveleliin Gazar, 1989), 16.

¹³⁸ Tomasz Potkanski and Slawoj Szyrkiewicz, “The Social Context of Liberalisation of the Mongolian Pastoral Economy: Report of Anthropological Fieldwork,” PALD Research Report 4, 1993, 40–49.

¹³⁹ Zhamsrangijn Sambuu, *Malchdad ökh zöwlölgöö*, (Ulaanbaatar: Ulsyn Kheveleliin Gazar, 1956), 8–9.

¹⁴⁰ Zhagvaral, *Aratstvo i Aratskoe Khoziaistvo*, 61.

for livestock. Although Sambuu laments that in most places pasture, water, and livestock distribution is uneven, some locations still continue the ancient practices of seasonal movements. Sambuu and Jagwaral's emphasis on ancient knowledge reveals the narrow tightrope act that Mongolian leaders were walking between an emphasis on a restoration of ancient herding knowledge, which had been degraded in the current period, and the promise of new scientific socialist technologies. Socialist leaders advocated a strong connection and rational use of the land but divorced it from any idea of "spirituality" (or as they usually phrased it, "superstition"). Whether articulated in a scientific rational manner or a through animated spiritual landscape, both socialists and contemporary religious households wanted to use their available knowledge to utilize the land as best they could.

1930s Collectivization Campaign

The 1956 to 1960 collectivization campaign was not the first attempt at collectivization in the Mongolian People's Republic. Nor was collectivization the first experiment with socio-economic transformations. As Christopher Atwood explores, co-operatives were formed in the 1920s to combat foreign, mainly Chinese but also German, American, and British, dominated trading firms.¹⁴¹ By 1929 co-operatives replaced most foreign firms, but average herders continued to do business with Chinese merchants as they had better prices. Atwood argues that the co-operatives established the "fundamental ideology that saw commerce as a matter of patriotism and national strength" which was continued under collectivization.¹⁴²

From 1929 to 1932, the MPR attempted to follow the model of the USSR in collectivizing its herding economy. As in the Soviet Union large scale resistance, often violent,

¹⁴¹ Christopher P. Atwood, "The Mutual-Aid Co-Operatives and the Animal Products Trade in Mongolia, 1913–1928," *Inner Asia* 5, no. 1 (2003): 65–91.

¹⁴² Atwood, "The Mutual-Aid Co-Operatives and the Animal Products Trade in Mongolia," 73.

followed. This resulted in a civil war in 1932, which the MPR won thanks to Soviet assistance. After this, Stalin instructed MPRP leaders to put a hold on collectivization. The *History of the Mongolian People's Republic (Bügd Nairamdakh Mongol Ard Ulsyn Tüükh)*, the official history compiled by the USSR and MPR Academy of Sciences in 1966, formed the template for other socialist evaluations of the first round of collectivization.¹⁴³ It held that collectivization failed due to the “Leftist Deviation” (*zүүinii zawkhral*), which failed “to understand the true inner nature of the collective economic movement of the USSR, which had entirely different conditions from Mongolia.”¹⁴⁴ By the time that Bat-Ochir published *Ard Angi*, (literally *People's Class*, meaning the laborer's class¹⁴⁵) in 1986, the Leftist Deviation is described as “Leftists' mistakes and deviations” (*зүүнтний алдаа zawkhral*).¹⁴⁶

Some Western scholars replicated the socialist argument in their evaluation of the first round of collectivization, including Owen Lattimore, Daniel Rosenberg, and Ines Stolpe.¹⁴⁷ Irina Y. Morozova presents a less convincing argument, that it was based on Turco-Mongol militarism, rather than the obvious connection to the Soviet collectivization campaign. In fact, collectivization in Mongolia was only deemed flawed because it was a failure. Resistance was widespread in the Soviet Union, and took many of the same forms: violence, hiding or slaughtering livestock, and migration. As Charles Bawden argues, “the leftist deviation was a

¹⁴³ Shirendev et. al., *History of the Mongolian People's Republic*; Shirendev et. al., *Bügd Nairamdakh Mongol Ard Ulsyn Tüükh* 3, (Ulaanbaatar: Ulsyn Kheveleliin khereg erkhlekh khoroo, 1966), 264.

¹⁴⁴ Shirendev et. al., *History of the Mongolian People's Republic*, 268; Shirendev et. al., *Bügd Nairamdakh Mongol Ard Ulsyn Tüükh* 3, 284.

¹⁴⁵ *Ard* is in this case being used in the Russian use of the term *arat*, to mean commoner, usually a herder.

¹⁴⁶ Bat-Ochir, L. *Ard Angi: Bütets, öөрчлөлт, khorshoozhilt*, (Ulaanbaatar: Shinzhekh Ukhaany Akademiin Khevel. 1986), 91.

¹⁴⁷ Owen Lattimore, *Nomads and Commissars: Mongolia Revisited*, (New York: Oxford University Press, 1962), 127; Daniel Rosenberg, “The Collectivization of Mongolia's Pastoral Production,” *Commission on Nomadic Peoples* 9 (1981): 26; Ines Stope, “Display and Performance in Mongolian Cultural Campaigns,” in *Conflict and Social Order in Tibet and Inner Asia*, ed. Fernanda Pirie and Toni Huber (Boston: Brill, 2008), 63.

deviation only in the sense that things got out of hand.... It was the tempo of leftism, not the policies themselves, which was the mistake.”¹⁴⁸

Many of the leaders of the second round of collectivization had personal experience on the ground attempting to organize collectives in the first round. As a seventeen-year-old member of the youth league, Bazaryn Shirendev was assigned to a poorly run collective where a few quarrelsome leaders were said to “only discuss world matters and... look like people who have forgotten how to look after a few animals.”¹⁴⁹ During his time working in the collective he explains that in order to promote the collective “I wandered around the households for five or six days. Regardless of whether there were several *gers* or just a single *ger*, I would enter and say, ‘We are establishing socialism. You must join the collective.’”¹⁵⁰ J. Sambuu also participated in the first round of collectivization cataloguing and confiscating property owned by black (secular) and yellow (religious) feudal peoples as described in his autobiography *Along the Path of Life* (*Amidralyn zamnalaas*).¹⁵¹

The failed first round was held up as a counter example of how not to execute the second round. Socialist authors and leaders explained that unlike the first round, which was lacking in consent and popular support, the second round had the backing of the people. The *History of the Mongolian People's Republic*, continually stresses the voluntary nature of the second round of collectivization.¹⁵² The failure of the first round was so severe that the very name for collectives received new branding: in 1934, the terms *khoshoo*, co-operative, and *khamtral*, collective, were replaced by *negdel*, association.¹⁵³

¹⁴⁸ Bawden, *Modern History of Mongolia*, 327.

¹⁴⁹ Shirendev, *Dalain dawaalgaanaar*, 81; cf. Shirendev, *Through the Ocean Waves*, 53.

¹⁵⁰ Shirendev, *Dalain dawaalgaanaar*, 81; cf. Shirendev, *Through the Ocean Waves*, 53.

¹⁵¹ Sambuu, *Am'dralyn zamnalaas*. 130; cf. Sambuu, *Herdsmen to Statesman*, trans. Mary Rossabi, 86

¹⁵² Shirendev et. al., *History of the Mongolian People's Republic*, 566; Shirendev et. al., *Bügd Nairamdakh Mongol Ard Ulsyn Tүүkh*, 609.

¹⁵³ Atwood, *Encyclopedia of Mongolia and the Mongol Empire*, 115.

While the second campaign of collectivization was not violent, this fact should not be held up as a major point of contrast to collectivization in the Soviet Union and the People's Republic of China as a peaceful alternative, as has sometimes been the case in scholarship.¹⁵⁴ This was especially the case in official Mongolian materials, which contrasts the consensual collectivization of the second round with the conflict of the first round. The reason why the second collectivization campaign was nonviolent was because extreme violence already occurred in Mongolia. The first collectivization campaign caused a civil war, mirroring the mass rebellions found in many parts of the Soviet Union, including Buryatia.¹⁵⁵ After victory in 1932 with the help of the Soviet military, collectivization was put on pause, but mass violence did not end. The most extreme purges occurred in the late 1930s, targeting lamas, Buryats, intellectuals, and any other real or perceived threat to the government were imprisoned or killed.¹⁵⁶ By the mid-1950s most class enemies and people able to offer serious resistance had been killed. Because of the elimination of organizations independent of the state, this resistance was non-violent, but collectivization still retained a coercive element found in other countries.

The Second Round of Collectivization

After the first failed attempt at collectivization, livestock was primarily held by privately operating herders, though a few celebrated model collectives remained. Noise was periodically made about promoting collectives, but collectivization was put on the backburner due to first the Purges, then World War II, then the post-war recovery period. But in 1954, the plenum of the MPRP Central Committee passed "The Organization of the Herding Collectives and the

¹⁵⁴ Fernanda Pirie and Toni Huber, eds., *Conflict and Social Order in Tibet and Inner Asia*, Brill's Tibetan Studies Library, v. 21 (Leiden ; Boston: Brill, 2008), 3.

¹⁵⁵ D.L. Dorzhiev, *Krest'ianskie Vosstaniia i Miatezhi v Buriatii v 20-30 Gody: Khronika Iazykom Dokumenta*, (Ulan-Ude: Obshchestvenno-nauchnyi tsentr "Sibir", 1993), 65, 75.

¹⁵⁶ Kaplonski, *Lama Question*.

Strengthening of the Economy,” which laid out the plan to promote and create new collectives.¹⁵⁷ This directive was influenced by Nikita Khrushchev’s Virgin Lands Campaign, and Ts. Lookhuuz, the Director of State Farms, visited Kazakhstan to observe the ongoing Soviet campaign.¹⁵⁸ The level of taxes was also changed, with a greater emphasis on taxing the rich and procurement of livestock goods became mandatory in 1954. In 1955 new rules were drawn up for the collective including labor laws that mandated that everyone living in the collective above the age of 16 had to be collective members.¹⁵⁹

Collectivization truly started in earnest in 1956 a year of major transition and turmoil not just in the MPR but the whole socialist bloc. In 1956 Nikita Khrushchev gave his famous “Secret Speech” in which he criticized Stalin. The two leaders of the MPR at the time, the Yumjaagiin Tsedenbal and the Party General Secretary Dashiin Damba, followed the Soviet Union in de-Stalinization (and, by association, de-Choibalsanization) efforts. One of the tasks put before the various intellectuals who were asked to investigate was how to improve the herding economy and implement collectivization.

B. Shirendew, as First Deputy Prime Minister, was involved in collectivization, but according to him his support for a gradual collectivization was “distorted and made to look as if I was a defender of private herdsmen and petty capitalists. However, talk soon died down.”¹⁶⁰ This was not Shirendew’s last brush with controversy and Tsedenbal almost had him arrested as a spy in 1957 as retaliation for his role in de-Stalinization efforts, though he managed to escape this

¹⁵⁷ M.A.Kh. *Namyn töv khoroonь 1954 onь 4 дүгээр сарын бүгд хурлын илтгэл ба тогтоол*, (Ulaanbaatar: Ulsyn Khevl, 1954), 1.

¹⁵⁸ Yuki Konagaya and I. Lkhagvasüren, *XX зууны Монголчууд 2: Сотсалист Монголын улс төрийн ам’драл*, Senri Ethnological Reports 72, (Osaka, Japan: National Museum of Ethnology, 2007), 110; cf., Yuki Konagaya, I. Lkhagvasuren. *Socialist Devotees and Dissenters: Three Twentieth Century Mongolian Leaders*, trans. Mary Rossabi, ed. Morris Rossabi, Senri Ethnological Reports 107, (Osaka, Japan: National Museum of Ethnology, 2012), 108.

¹⁵⁹ Bat Ochir, *Ard анги*, 168.

¹⁶⁰ Shirendev, *Dalain davalgaanaar*, 240; cf. Shirendev, *Through the Ocean Waves*, 156.

fate with the help of Tsedenbal's rival co-leader Damba by preemptively conceding defeat and going to Moscow to earn a doctoral degree. The tug of war during the de-Stalinization period between tradition and innovation was mirrored in efforts to balance old and new herding strategies.

Herders within a collective were allowed to own some private livestock, in numbers far greater than that in neighboring Buryatia or Inner Mongolia. The laws allowing private livestock holding were divided between the two environmental extremes of Mongolia, *khangai* and *gobi*. Each had different limits of how many private livestock a collective member was allowed to keep. At first one hundred head of livestock were permitted in the *khangai*, while one hundred and fifty were permitted in the *gobi*. However, the laws also included restrictions of how many of each livestock animal were permitted, as seen in the table from Jagwaral.¹⁶¹

Table 1. Type of Private Livestock Permitted by Mongolian Environmental Regions

Livestock type	<i>Khangai</i> zone	<i>Gobi</i> zone
Large Horned Cattle	15	15
Cows	5	5
Horse	10	15
Camel	5	20
Sheep and Goat	70	100

According to Jagwaral, herders in the *khangai* were more likely to try and keep private cattle than herders in the *gobi*, where most of the cattle were held collectively. This reflects the common herd composition in the region, as cattle (including yak) are more numerous in the

¹⁶¹ Zhagvaral, *Aratstvo i Aratskoe Khoziaistvo*, 206.

khangai than in the *gobi*. He also states that southern regions were the most difficult to collectivize.¹⁶² He chalks this up partially to increased difficulty in establishing side industries such as farming, as well as greater distance from district centers. Furthermore, in the *gobi* herd composition and available labor was different than the steppe and *khangai*. It is not clear why a specific rule governing the private stock in the steppe (*tal*) was never formulated, despite it being often seen as the “default” of Mongolian pastures. There is likely an answer in the archives, and I hope one day to find it, but as of now I have not found the answer.

In August 1959, the Central Committee changed the number of private head of livestock each member could own, leading to 73.3 percent of livestock being collectively own, and 26.1 percent being privately owned.¹⁶³ One *bod*, consisted of “one horse, cattle, yak, mule, donkey, or reindeer... two camels, seven sheep, or fourteen goats.”¹⁶⁴ In 1959, the a report to the Central Committee recorded the following percentage of private livestock held by collective members.¹⁶⁵

Table 2. Percentage of Private Livestock Held by Collective Members

Number of Livestock	Percentage of Collective Members
No livestock	1.3
1–30 head of livestock	48.3
31–50	32
Higher than 51	18.4

Tsedenbal announced that collectivization was as important as the 1921 revolution.¹⁶⁶ In 1958, Tsedenbal declared

After Mongolia solves the problem of socialist transformation of agriculture which at present is being carried out throughout the country, she will enter a new period of her

¹⁶² Zhagvaral, *Aratstvo i Aratskoe Khoziaistvo*, 207.

¹⁶³ Bat Ochir, *Ard Angi*, 172.

¹⁶⁴ Bat-Ochir, *Ard Angi*, 67.

¹⁶⁵ UTNONBBA, kh 4, d 24, khn 191, pg. 10.

¹⁶⁶ Bat-Erdene Batbayar, *Twentieth Century Mongolia*, (Brill, 2021), 72.

development of socialist construction. It is not long before the Mongolian people will face the task of gradual transition to Communism.¹⁶⁷

This is similar to Khrushchev's announcement in 1961 that the Soviet Union would achieve Communism within twenty years.¹⁶⁸ In 1960, the same year that collectivization was completed, Mongolian leaders approved a new constitution.¹⁶⁹ While the journey of collectives was not over, the major step of collectivizing the herding economy was successfully completed.

Forming and Joining the Collective

Mongolian leaders deployed a carrot and stick method to incentivize herders to join the collective, as when collectivization began in 1956 participation was voluntary. Those outside of the collective were subject to regularly increasing taxes while those within were promised improved infrastructure, protection, and equality. Many Mongolians willingly joined collectives because of these attractive promises. For herders who were poor or of middling wealth, the collectives had obvious merits. However, collectives often ran into a problem when only poor herders joined the collective which resulted in not enough livestock to sustain a functioning collective.

Renchingiin Minjüür, who served as the head of the Mörön, later Bright Road, collective in the Ikh Tamir district in North Khangai for twenty-one years and was the recipient of the high honor of Labor Hero, was unequivocal in his assertion that collectivization was necessary to modernize and improve herding in Mongolia. In a post-socialist interview, he went into great detail about the rise and fall of collectives in Mongolia and often laments their dissolution. He did admit an early collectivization in 1954 was somewhat haphazard, and recalled,

If someone wished to establish a collective, the Party and Government said “Okay, okay!” so one person became the collective's boss, and 4–5 camps (*ail*) formed one

¹⁶⁷ Bawden, “Economic Advance in Mongolia,” 259–60.

¹⁶⁸ William Taubman, *Khrushchev: The Man and his Era*, (New York: W.W. Norton, 2003), 511.

¹⁶⁹ Bawden, “Economic Advance in Mongolia,” 259–60.

collective. In one valley, various people joined and formed one collective. In this way, 730 collectives were established.¹⁷⁰

The collective that Minjüür led, Bright Road, was originally three different collectives that were merged together. In a similar vein, one military veteran named Dambadoo criticized early collective efforts as largely being led by incompetent herders who couldn't take care of their livestock themselves.¹⁷¹ Before becoming the leader of the collective, Minjüür studied for a year at the Party school and "for seven to eight months took classes in Kazakhstan, and practiced for two months in Buryatia."¹⁷² This socialist internationalism highlights the strong influence that neighboring Soviet lands had on Mongolian collectivization campaigns.

Minjüür constantly comes back to the question of helping poor and confiscating wealth from the rich. He connects this to his own life, when he was a poor child and forced to herd for wealthy Mongolians who did not lift a finger when his mother became sick and died.¹⁷³ Minjüür states that "we oppressed the rich using our authority, and when then they joined the collective, the herds that they pastured became the collective's. We supported our poor people, so then their life became peaceful and good."¹⁷⁴ He also continually connects the pre-collective existence of wealthy herders to the post-1991 rise of wealth inequality. According to Minjüür, the Party worked hard to demonstrate to the people the positives of the collective and collective labor, as it was the only way that they would be willing to join.¹⁷⁵

¹⁷⁰ Lkhagvasüren, *XX zuuny Mongolchuud*, 32; cf. *A Herder, a Trader, and a Lawyer*, trans. Mary Rossabi, 45.

¹⁷¹ Dambadoo, *The Oral History of Twentieth Century Mongolia*, http://amantuuh.socanth.cam.ac.uk/search/view_person.php?Person=990089

¹⁷² Lkhagvasüren, *XX zuuny Mongolchuud*, 33; cf. *A Herder, a Trader, and a Lawyer*, trans. Mary Rossabi, 46.

¹⁷³ Lkhagvasüren, *XX zuuny Mongolchuud*, 33; cf. *A Herder, a Trader, and a Lawyer*, trans. Mary Rossabi, 46.

¹⁷⁴ Lkhagvasüren, *XX zuuny Mongolchuud*, 33; cf. *A Herder, a Trader, and a Lawyer*, trans. Mary Rossabi, 46.

¹⁷⁵ Lkhagvasüren, *XX zuuny Mongolchuud*, 34; cf. *A Herder, a Trader, and a Lawyer*, trans. Mary Rossabi, 47.

Minjüür detailed the process of joining a collective from the point of view of collective leadership. When joining a collective, the individual would write a letter listing their family, livestock, and wealth, and then appear in front of the collective's leaders, who then told them

Well, these are the rules of the cooperative. You keep fifty head of livestock and must give a hundred head of livestock to the cooperative! Now a twenty-fire *tögrög* tax will be collected. When you become a member of a collective, you will herd the collective's livestock. You can herd the livestock you like. If you want to milk a cow, you will be given at least 10 cows, and if you want to herd sheep, you will be given at least a hundred sheep and goats. If you want to herd horses, you will be given a stallion and horses, or about twenty horses. You will be paid a day's wages for herding the cooperative's livestock. You will be given a few grams of meat and a few grams of milk a day.¹⁷⁶

Minjüür explained collective leadership spent a great deal of time considering the best pastureland, who to assign to which herd, and other granular herding details. He took great pride in detailing livestock increase, and his role in promoting the dairy industry in Ikh Tamir. Minjüür also described his time implementing the “wool is gold” (*noos bol alt*) program, which called for an increase in production of wool.¹⁷⁷ Minjüür acknowledged later shortcomings of the collectives as well, although he places the blame on failed leadership or problems of individual herders rather than pointing to any flaw in the system itself. Minjüür concludes by stating that the Party knew that “collectivization was the exact way that the Mongolian state would develop,” and that “it was a requirement to gain a place among the states in the world.”¹⁷⁸

Ts. Lookhuuz's description of herding in collectives emphasizes the top-down nature and the collectives' control had over herding. He explained

The herders that herded the Agricultural Co-operatives' herds could not change pastures on their own initiative. Questions like when, where, by what form of transportation would they move, etc. were decided by the 'Negdel Council.' All the work was controlled by the state, which would determine the *negdel* herd's milking season, organize the breeding

¹⁷⁶ Lkhagvasüren, *XX zuuny Mongolchuud*, 41; cf. *A Herder, a Trader, and a Lawyer*, trans. Mary Rossabi, 53–54.

¹⁷⁷ Lkhagvasüren, *XX zuuny Mongolchuud*, 33; cf. *A Herder, a Trader, and a Lawyer*, trans. Mary Rossabi, 45.

¹⁷⁸ Lkhagvasüren, *XX zuuny Mongolchuud*, 33; cf. *A Herder, a Trader, and a Lawyer*, trans. Mary Rossabi, 45.

work, when to deliver the young, to shear the hair and wool, to move to other pastures (*otor khiikh*) etc. The herders could not make any of these decisions themselves.¹⁷⁹

According to Lookhuuz, “Mongolian nomad (*nüüdelch*) herders became collective members, and then they herded the collective’s animals. So, the word ‘nomad’ lost the real meaning.”¹⁸⁰

Lookhuuz’s description of nomadism flies in the face of socialist rhetoric, which emphasized the high degree of control that first nobles and monasteries, then wealthy commoner herders, had over their employed herders. It also conflicts with the historical reality, as Lookhuuz’s lament of the loss of nomad seems to recall an idealized, and as Sneath and Humphrey demonstrate, non-existent, free wandering Mongolian herder.¹⁸¹ Indeed, in socialist texts *malchin* (herder) is far more common than *nüüdelch* (nomad).

Lookhuuz’s fellow failed conspirator and exiled official, Baldandorjiin Nyambuu (1922-2008), retained none of the general acceptance of socialist modernity of Lookhuuz, much less the enthusiastic embrace of Minjüür. He recalls collectivization “was not a pleasant job for me. The act was a kind of ‘purge’ and was ‘ideologically prejudiced.’”¹⁸² He argues that “before joining the collective our herders had many livestock. Herders lived only through their livestock.” Although “many people” refused to join the collective, they were “forced to join through many pressures and coercion. As a result of this work a major crisis arose in the Mongolian herding economy. There was no one to watch the livestock confiscated by force. The people who joined the collective were forced to herd the livestock. The herders named the collective’s livestock ‘criminal livestock’ (*valtai mal*). Because the herder did not have the right to use a single one of

¹⁷⁹ Konagaya and Lkhagvasüren, *XX zuuny Mongolchuud 2*, 110; cf., *Socialist Devotees and Dissenters*, trans. Mary Rossabi, 108.

¹⁸⁰ Konagaya and Lkhagvasüren, *XX zuuny Mongolchuud 2*, 110; cf., *Socialist Devotees and Dissenters*, trans. Mary Rossabi, 108.

¹⁸¹ Humphrey and Sneath, *End of Nomadism?*, 305–06.

¹⁸² Konagaya, “Socialist Modernisation in Mongolia as Narrated after Socialism,” 18; Konagaya and Lkhagvasüren, *XX zuuny Mongolchuud 2*, 199; cf., *Socialist Devotees and Dissenters*, trans. Mary Rossabi, 184.

those livestock. Herders did not have the rights to use benefits of the livestock's products of meat, milk, and skins. They were required to give all the livestock's wool and hair to the collective. If a herder uses the collective's livestock meat or milk and not fulfill the plan and standards the herder was would be sent to jail."¹⁸³ He continued to criticize the collective life and argue that herders worked very hard for little reward, and as a result many started to behave dishonestly, and "by 1990 Mongolian herders all became beggars," and the entire country was dependent on the Soviet Union.¹⁸⁴

Konagaya characterizes Nyambuu's feelings towards collectivization as "disgust for socialist modernization. Although we cannot strictly state whether this disgust comes from the current situation where pastoral cooperatives have been broken down or not, he narrated that he felt disgust at that time. And now he still felt disgust. This means he talked as if he had never changed his mind."¹⁸⁵ It is likely that Nyambuu's opinion of socialism and collectives were heavily colored by his exile from the party to work in the countryside, similar to Lookhuuz's criticism of his time while herding. He is in the minority of his evaluation of collectives, and even most critics were able to find some positives in the socialist project. But his critique of economic flaws of the collective system echoes his and Lookhuuz's criticism of Tsedenbal in 1964.¹⁸⁶

The period of 1956 to 1964 was marked by various struggles over what exactly the post-Stalin and Choibalsan era meant for the MPR and had numerous conflicts over leadership and ideology as Tsedenbal moved to remove various rivals. Local collective leadership at times had

¹⁸³ Konagaya and Lkhagvasüren, *XX зууны Монголчууд 2*, 199; cf., *Socialist Devotees and Dissenters*, trans. Mary Rossabi, 184.

¹⁸⁴ Konagaya and Lkhagvasüren, *XX зууны Монголчууд 2*, 200; cf., *Socialist Devotees and Dissenters*, trans. Mary Rossabi, 185.

¹⁸⁵ Konagaya, "Socialist Modernisation in Mongolia as Narrated after Socialism," 18.

¹⁸⁶

similar conflicts, as seen in the case of Spark collective in Ölziit district in South Khangai. On September 25th, 1959, the collective boss Wandansangi was removed from his post for spurring on “petit bourgeois” actions and was replaced by Norowerenchin.¹⁸⁷

The above example of Tsodol and Yanjidulam were just one of many couples, and at times families, who joined the collective. Thankfully preserved in provincial archives, the documents signed by herders when they joined the collective offers an important snapshot into their lives during a pivotal decision. The collection of joining documents from the collective in Öndörönts sum in South Khangai in 1956 shows a range of herd size, age, and family dynamics. The most common dynamic was, like Tsodol and Yanjidulam, that of a husband and wife joining, usually with a small number of livestock. Other examples include a patriarch who signed for his family including his wife and children, but does not name them, merely stating “my family has five people, two of whom are workers.”¹⁸⁸ Within the document the age of the family members and whether they were able to work were listed, though often their names were not. These dynamics played out differently depending on the region, for example in the Gobi matrilineal families were and are common which certainly would have impacted the shape of family units joining the collectives.¹⁸⁹ How it did is not clear however, and would require further work in Gobi provincial archives.

Most herders who joined had a small number of livestock that they gave to the collective. Commonly held livestock was the main attraction of the collective; for a poorer herder it was worth it to give up their few livestock for a guaranteed livelihood. For example, Dawaa had

¹⁸⁷ AA Kh 30, khn 27, 50.

¹⁸⁸ AA kh 54 khn 1, pg 24.

¹⁸⁹ Tomasz Potkanski and Slavo J. Szykiewicz, “The Social Context of Liberalisation of the Mongolian Pastoral Economy: Report of Anthropological Fieldwork,” *PALD Research Report 4*, 1993, 29.

twenty-five head, with two camels, eight horses, seven sheep, and seven goats.¹⁹⁰ The poorest herder to join was one family that had only one camel and three horses.¹⁹¹ Joining a collective was often a practical decision, as the Mongolian government used taxes to incentivize herders to join the collective. This led to herders with a relatively large number of livestock joining, with one family having 164 head of livestock when they joined.¹⁹² Often times these families had more livestock the previous year, as with Dondow who had eight camels, thirteen horses, one cattle, 119 sheep, and 102 goats in 1955, but in 1956 had one camel, three horses, forty-four sheep and forty-four goats, for a total of ninety-two livestock.¹⁹³ This difference likely had two possible explanations. First, that disaster, either disease, climate, or predators, caused loss of livestock. The second possibility is that Dondow sold off most of his livestock before he joined. This was a common strategy of wealthier herders to maximize their monetary wealth right before joining the collective, which would also decrease their taxes. These people all joined the collective in 1956, just when collectivization was truly beginning to pick up steam, when joining was voluntary. Whether wealthy or poor, motivated by ideology or practicality, these herders all agreed to hand over their livestock for the promise of new and improved life in the collective.

As Minjüür mentioned in his recollections, the process of collectives led to wildly different sizes and compositions of collectives. A few examples of the wide variation of collective population and livestock numbers found in South Khangai *aimag* can be seen in the table below.

Table 3. South Khangai Collectives, Collective Members, and Livestock

District	Collective	Collective Members	Number of Livestock
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¹⁹⁰ AA kh 54 khn 1, pg 6.

¹⁹¹ AA kh 54 khn 1, pg 9.

¹⁹² AA kh 54 khn 1, pg 13.

¹⁹³ AA kh 54 khn 1, pg 4.

Batkhaan	New Road	37	1,208 ¹⁹⁴
Khairkhandulaan	New Victory	216	6,234 ¹⁹⁵
Khairkhandulaan	All Life	189	3,139 ¹⁹⁶
Olziit	Spark	718	21,073 ¹⁹⁷
Olziit	Glory	64	1,650 ¹⁹⁸

These numbers are from 1957, except for Batkhaan's New Road collective, which is from 1956.

The variation of collective population, human and livestock, is clear. The largest collective, Spark, has over eleven times the people and twelve times the livestock than the neighboring Glory collective, both in the Olziit district. Despite the size difference, the collectives do generally have the same ratio of human to livestock, between twenty-five to thirty livestock for one person. The outlier is Khairkhandulaan's All Life collective, with only sixteen livestock per person. The amount of livestock in a collective was heavily dependent on how many livestock the members joined with, and the collectives tended to attract the poorer herders first.

In addition to collective livestock in New Victory and All Life, the documents also provide the number of private livestock held by collective members: 3,996 and 3,914 respectively. The number of private livestock owned by members of the other collectives in other South Khangai collectives were not specified. This reflects the variable information collected in bookkeeping and reports to the provincial and central government during the early period of collectives. The slapdash formation strategy of collectives was tolerated in the early period of collectivization, but as time went on it was clear something had to be done about this problem.

¹⁹⁴ AA kh 59 d 1 khn 04, 1-5.

¹⁹⁵ AA kh d 1 khn 12, 3.

¹⁹⁶ AA kh 1 d 1 khn 12, 3.

¹⁹⁷ AA kh 51 d 1 khn 12, 3.

¹⁹⁸ AA kh 51 d 1 khn 12, 3.

“The Oral History of Twentieth Century Mongolia” includes many interviews of Mongolians reflecting on collectives and the process of joining often left a particularly strong impression. Doljinsüren, who was born in 1943, recalled many difficulties caused by the increased demands on private herders put in place by the five-year plan, noting that “at that time it was very difficult, and so we joined the collective. Before that it was very hard.”¹⁹⁹ Before joining the collective she wore a *deel* (robe) of woolen scraps, and according to her the life “was very difficult for the families with many children. Even those families that had many animals could not eat a lot of food. When we were trying to fulfill the five-year plan, we had a lot of trouble (*makhaa idekh*, literally “to eat one’s own meat”).”²⁰⁰ In contrast, after collectivization Doljinsüren and her siblings were happy because “when we joined the collective, it became nice.... we didn’t have such a large herd, so we were delighted (laughs), because we didn’t have to watch over many animals.”²⁰¹ Her mother was not as thrilled as her children and reprimanded them for celebrating their loss of livestock.²⁰²

According to Doljinsüren, the collective bosses would travel to herders and tell them “‘you should join the collective. If you do not join, it is difficult.’ They went like this and said ‘Join, join.’ Then they would go around again and again. Then we joined.”²⁰³ This agitation effort was similar to the arguments Shirendew employed during the first round of collectivization, with similarly blunt arguments. When asked about people’s reactions to joining the collective, Doljinsüren responds that “we became very happy. But the rich people were not

¹⁹⁹ Doljinsüren, *The Oral History of Twentieth Century Mongolia*, http://amantuu.h.socanth.cam.ac.uk/search/view_person.php?Person=990127

²⁰⁰ Doljinsüren, *The Oral History of Twentieth Century Mongolia*.

²⁰¹ Doljinsüren, *The Oral History of Twentieth Century Mongolia*.

²⁰² Doljinsüren, *The Oral History of Twentieth Century Mongolia*.

²⁰³ Doljinsüren, *The Oral History of Twentieth Century Mongolia*.

so happy. At that time, it looked like the rich people with large herds were watching for the final result,” and that the wealthy only joined reluctantly or when forced to do so.²⁰⁴

Doljinsüren cited cleanliness and cultural campaigns connected to collectivization as one of the main positives of the movement because “as we joined the collective, we became educated. Otherwise, when people did not join the collective, at that time we had an open fire, so it was very smoky, and their life was like this. Then they joined the collective, and they became cultured. The *gers* and so on became white, and they would receive a stovepipe and a stove. Then they became very cultured.”²⁰⁵ Cultural activities were very important in Doljinsüren’s memory of collectives, as “the leader of the farm organized public activities. People would listen to music, and read books, and the like. The people who did not know writing were taught, then usually dances and the like were organized. We were very cultured.... After milking the herds, there was singing and dancing. It was very nice.”²⁰⁶

Ines Stolpe provides a detailed study of the cultural campaigns mentioned by Doljinsüren and other interviewees.²⁰⁷ Cleanliness campaigns, both pertaining to personal hygiene and to homes and public spaces, closely followed collectivization campaigns, and clearly became connected to them in many people’s recollections. These activities were central in many people’s positive remembrance of collectives and stand in contrast to the defunding of centralized cultural activities after privatization.

In his interview, Gombo described his help in organizing the collective and his later rise to a leadership position.²⁰⁸ According to him, poor herders were the first to join the collective

²⁰⁴ Doljinsüren, *The Oral History of Twentieth Century Mongolia*..

²⁰⁵ Doljinsüren, *The Oral History of Twentieth Century Mongolia*..

²⁰⁶ Doljinsüren, *The Oral History of Twentieth Century Mongolia*..

²⁰⁷ Ines Stolpe, “Display and Performance in Mongolian Cultural Campaigns,” in *Conflict and Social Order in Tibet and Inner Asia* (Brill, 2008), 59–84.

²⁰⁸ Gombo, *The Oral History of Twentieth Century Mongolia*,

http://amantuuh.socanth.cam.ac.uk/search/view_summary.php?Interview=090325A&Person=990203

and wealthy herders would join only reluctantly. While activists carried out propaganda agitation and organized meetings to convince people to join, he claims “there wasn’t any compulsion to join the collective... at the beginning, you know, people were exempted from tax and other official livestock taxes, therefore people joined. But later people would not join it,” which is why it became mandatory to join the collective.²⁰⁹ After collectivization became mandatory, there were still forms of resistance. According to Gombo, “those people that were a little crafty, a little bright sold their herds and goods before they joined the collective and wasted it and fled to the city. They did just like that (laughs). Otherwise, if you stay in your homeland and herd your herds in your hollow, they would make you join the collective. You could not flee from the collective.”²¹⁰ Gombo recalled the collective in positive terms and stated, “usually the collective took care of us at that time.”²¹¹

Another man, Bataa, explains that in 1959 at the age of 19 he was involved in agitating among the local families to convince them to join the collective. During the collectivization campaign, “some families gave their herds to the collective, some families did not give their herds to the collective.”²¹² His account provides more of the arguments used to convince those to join. He would inform the families he visited

Well (za), now our collectivization campaign is on the rise. I said, Well what do people who join the collectie have to do? They need to live together. You need to herd your herds together and load and transport your hay together. My comrade, you and I need to enter into this beneficial and helpful place. So, you cannot go alone and follow a few herds. Now it is the Socialist period.... so as a rule you cannot be primitive. You have to labor together.”²¹³

²⁰⁹ Gombo, *The Oral History of Twentieth Century Mongolia*.

²¹⁰ Gombo, *The Oral History of Twentieth Century Mongolia*.

²¹¹ Gombo, *The Oral History of Twentieth Century Mongolia*.

²¹² Gombo, *The Oral History of Twentieth Century Mongolia*.

²¹³ Bataa, *The Oral History of Twentieth Century Mongolia*,
http://amantuu.socanth.cam.ac.uk/search/view_summary.php?Interview=090614A&Person=990223

Bataa acknowledges that many people resisted. He notes that when older people, particularly women, yelled at him and dismissed his arguments, he was often unsure how to respond.²¹⁴

Bataa cites popular culture to explain his own history, saying “some of our movies show us this. I forget which movie, but in it they brought their two five-year-old castrated steers (*shar*) and tied and hid them. A lot of things like this happened. Now some families were still driving their livestock. Some of them hid their animals in the mountains, and in the rocks.”²¹⁵

Bataa explained that Mongolia was following the Soviet model and that “this co-operative was Lenin’s theory. Our country was following them like that.”²¹⁶ Furthermore, “at that time Lenin *bagsh* (teacher) was worshiped. Oh and then after that it was Stalin, we worshiped Stalin *bagsh*.”²¹⁷ As with many other interviewees, Bataa states the importance of the concurrent cultural campaigns by saying that before collectivization “even soap was rare at that time.”²¹⁸ But by 1960, even those in the countryside had been subject to the cultural campaign and “everyone became civilized.”²¹⁹ He also notes the importance of the newspapers and magazines, like “Woodpecker” (*Tonshuul*), which would criticize those that lagged behind in their work. Bataa, like most of the other interviewees emphasize the importance of collectives in modernizing life in the countryside. Sodnomjav, who won numerous awards for his skills, stated “in the collective period the organization of joint work, moving to other pastures, and *otor* [distant moves for fattening] was very good. The services provided to the herdsman were also excellent.”²²⁰ To many herders, any resistance or negative aspects of the *negdels* were overshadowed by the positive aspects.

²¹⁴ Bataa, *The Oral History of Twentieth Century Mongolia*.

²¹⁵ Bataa, *The Oral History of Twentieth Century Mongolia*.

²¹⁶ Bataa, *The Oral History of Twentieth Century Mongolia*.

²¹⁷ Bataa, *The Oral History of Twentieth Century Mongolia*.

²¹⁸ Bataa, *The Oral History of Twentieth Century Mongolia*.

²¹⁹ Bataa, *The Oral History of Twentieth Century Mongolia*.

²²⁰ Humphrey and Sneath, *End of Nomadism?*, 39.

Some herders who worked in the collective were more critical than others. Osor, a former collective herder, provided one of the harshest criticism of collectives in the *Oral History Project*. He recalled that his family owned their own animals before collectivization and contrasted the ease of living today to life under socialism, saying “now our young people truly very live luxuriously. People of my era... life in the collective, was in truth very hard. If I was to put it bluntly, we were like prisoners.”²²¹ He was quite critical of how people behaved then, and explained, “Well, when the collective boss (*darga*) would arrive, then we were scared.... They would say fearfully ‘The boss has arrived. Well, the boss arrived from the province (i.e., the provincial capital). Oh, what do we do?’”²²² However, he then softened his criticism by saying “anyway, life in the collective was not that bad a life. I herded five hundred horses for the collective and in one year produced over ten thousand liters of fermented mare’s milk (*airag*). At that time, I was living a normal life with my wife.”²²³

Osor then continued to describe the socialist period in less negative terms than he had previously. However, this is framed entirely in contrast to the faults of Mongolia today. Osor gave the extremely rose-colored statement that during socialism, “well at that time in general people were very well behaved. I think that people in the socialist period were that way. People did not drink vodka and wine,” whereas today’s youth are constantly drunk.²²⁴ Alcoholism was in fact a serious issue in Mongolia during the socialist period, and was subject to numerous campaigns, but this idealized vision of the past is used to contrast the flaws found in

²²¹ Osor, *The Oral History of Twentieth Century Mongolia*, http://amantuuh.socanth.cam.ac.uk/search/view_summary.php?Interview=090744A&Person=990296

²²² Osor, *The Oral History of Twentieth Century Mongolia*.

²²³ Osor, *The Oral History of Twentieth Century Mongolia*.

²²⁴ Osor, *The Oral History of Twentieth Century Mongolia*.

contemporary society.²²⁵ A similar idea of decline was found in the socialist era when discussing contemporary herding.

He then explained the flaw of today's youths and says that "the young people that I see, in their case, they need to go back in the collective.... They generally do not do their private work well and are stuck up. They go bankrupt. So, I want to put them in this prison-like situation."²²⁶ Osor was therefore quite critical of socialism, while also claiming that it was in many ways better than life today. This reflects the general nostalgia for the socialist period, and speaks to the degree to which post-socialist interviews position the socialist era as opposed to the present day. That said, it is clear that collectives, despite their coercive nature, provided a steady life and many services and amenities that are simply not accessible to many herders in post-socialist Mongolia.

Literature Promoting Collectivization

Various literary works were produced in the fifties and sixties to promote the second round of collectivization. Some of these novels were set in the first failed round of collectivization, but still emphasized the importance of living in the collective. These works also take advantage of the increased openness of discussing the flaws of earlier socialist eras, while still ultimately coming down on the side of the socialist project. J. Byamba's *Steppe Flower* (*Talyn Tsetseg*) was a novel published in 1960 set during the first round of collectivization and follows the model of a working-class hero struggling against the wealthy. His hero, Bat, eventually realizes that his noble benefactor has been exploiting him and leaves to help the

²²⁵ Stolpe, "Display and Performance in Mongolian Cultural Campaigns," 64.

²²⁶ Osor, *The Oral History of Twentieth Century Mongolia*.

people.²²⁷ Ch. Lodoidamba's *Clear Tamir (Tungalag Tamir)* which was made into a film, also depicts the first round of collectivization.²²⁸

Other works were set in the contemporary period of collectivization such as D. Pürevdorj's poem, "Radiance in the Steppe" (*Talyn Tuyaa*).²²⁹ He lauds the spread of "red sparks," the collectives, along the steppe.²³⁰ The protagonist, Jamba, is an old herder who remembers the horrors of the old collectivization attempts and is frightened of losing his herd. His children urge him to join, as do his neighbors, but he resists. He simply states

My cattle are the basis for my life.
I'm not accustomed to share them
Even with relatives.
Much less with strangers or the neighbors.²³¹

Ultimately, he is convinced by the collective leader who argues

One tree is not a forest.
A man alone is not a man.
A cooperative flock of magpies
Is stronger than a lone snow leopard.
You know this better than the others.
Many together make a great power.
You for your comrades, they for you.
All together, for all.²³²

Similarly, B. Yawuukhulan's 1959 poem, "Mongolian Eastern Steppe" (*"Mongolyn Dornod Tal"*), contrasts the Dornod province steppe with his own homeland. While describing this land, he states that it was "truly peacefully united" (*üinen saikhan negdmel*).²³³ Later creative works

²²⁷ Gerasimovich, *History of Modern Mongolian Literature*, 258.

²²⁸ Ch. Lodoidamba, *Tungalag Tamir*, (Ulaanbaatar: Ulsyn Khevreliin Gazar, 1971).

²²⁹ Gerasimovich, *History of Modern Mongolian Literature*, 258.

²³⁰ Gerasimovich, *History of Modern Mongolian Literature*, 258.

²³¹ Gerasimovich, *History of Modern Mongolian Literature*, 182.

²³² Gerasimovich, *History of Modern Mongolian Literature*, 183.

²³³ Iavuukhulan, "Mongolyn dornod tal," in *Mongolyn Uran Zokhiolyn Deezhis* 108, ed. L. Tudev et al. (Ulaanbaatar: "Mongol Uran Zokhiol" khevreliin gazar", 1998), 174.

continued to depict collectivization, as seen in the 1970 film *Son in Law* (*Khürgen khüü*) which dramatizes the problems of wealthy herders trying to game the system of collectives and taxes.²³⁴

These literary works use the common motif of herders who are eventually convinced of the merits of collectivization and glory in working together to show that the majority of those resisting collectivization are not evil, but simply misguided and set in their ways. The wealthy herders were the bad element, but these works show that once separated from negative influence the working-class herders would come to realize the merits of the socialist system through their own free will.

Even when everyone joined a collective, collective leaders warned against lazy herders and work shirkers. Authors often discussed people who abused the system and served as counterexamples of a hard laboring socialist herder. Sengiin Erdene's "Solitude" (*Gantsaardal*) written in 1961, depicts a stubborn old man resisting the changes of collectivization.²³⁵ The story opens during beginning of the spring, when the collective brigade is moving to new pastures. The protagonist of the story, Old Man Dash, sits watching the other members of the collective prepare to move, while muttering "my poor homeland (*nutag*), my poor homeland."²³⁶ His (unnamed) wife, after feeding their "scruffy fat grey (*khökh*) puppy" named Snubnose (*Bankhar*),²³⁷ complains to Dash that everyone is leaving while they are just sitting there.²³⁸ Dash dismisses her, and says she is welcome to leave if she wants. His wife enters their home, muttering. Dash continues to watch, and out loud wonders,

²³⁴ *Khürgen khüü*, directed by Dejidiin Jigjid. (Mongolkino 1970).

²³⁵ Erdene Senge, "Solitude," trans. Kenneth Linden, *Words Without Borders*, October 2018; S. Erdene, "Gantsaardal," *Naran togoruu*, (Ulaanbaatar: Ulsyn Khevelelin Gazar, 1972), 111.

²³⁶ Although *nutag* is most commonly used to mean homeland, it is clear later in the story that Dash was not born in this region.

²³⁷ Though somewhat ambiguous, it appears the puppy's name is Bankhar, rather than it being of the bankhar breed, the Mongolian mastiff celebrated and held as the ideal Mongolian dog today.

²³⁸ Erdene, "Solitude," trans. Kenneth Linden; S. Erdene, "Gantsaardal," 111.

My poor homeland. What are they thinking, what kind of people would reject their homeland after living here for forty years? They say together we will settle, we will settle. The pasture's grass will not be enough, the animals will never graze well in the new pastureland, the cows will never give milk, and their summer milk quota will certainly be short. They say that we should live in one concentrated spot, in modern buildings with electricity. Where are these modern buildings? And what can I do . . . Even my dull wife seems to be talking nonsense as well.²³⁹

He managed to convince the older members of the collective to his way, until the younger members convinced them by promising various improvements, including electricity powered milking machines, in the new center. In the end everyone agreed to move, and Dash assented and declared "OK, OK. I will stay here and keep guarding my pastures. I will take care of my few personal head of livestock, and I won't make trouble for you. And I will survive somehow."²⁴⁰ Despite her misgivings and objections, Dash's wife stays with him as the rest of the collective moves from the pasture.

One day she goes to the collective center to purchase "flour, grains, tea, and tobacco," and

At the collective center, her former neighbors met her and took her to the settlement of their brigade. New wooden houses were there, built in rows, and she saw a corral for milking, a half-covered stall for the calves, and so on. She saw there was a place here where everything was orderly and unthinkably clean, and she was greatly awed and fascinated by what she saw. Her former neighbors urged her to join them.²⁴¹

Erdene shows the collective center as an almost utopian settlement which not only offers necessary supplies but perfectly ordered life with impressive infrastructure for livestock. As Humphrey and Sneath argue, collectives were the center of urbanism, and "which were the bearers of urban culture in the steppe: it was here one could see films, buy manufactured goods, hear news, make a phone call to the city, meet visitors and tourists from the capital."²⁴² Centers

²³⁹ Erdene, "Solitude," trans. Kenneth Linden; Erdene, "Gantsaardal," 112.

²⁴⁰ Erdene, "Solitude," trans. Kenneth Linden; Erdene, "Gantsaardal," 113.

²⁴¹ Erdene, "Solitude," trans. Kenneth Linden; Erdene, "Gantsaardal," 114.

²⁴² Humphrey and Sneath, *End of Nomadism?*, 209.

had provided all the promised modern amenities offered by socialism. While the livestock elements are discussed, there is far greater emphasis on quality of life and consumption.

Enchanted by the collective center, the old woman returns to try to convince her husband to join everyone else, to no avail. He cites possible challenges with herding livestock, wondering “would the cattle become fat when people are living in houses? When fall comes, the animals will be lost. They will experience this disaster, then they will all see.”²⁴³ A few nights later, Old Man Dash returns to his *ger* after being out in the mountains, and is surprised when first his puppy, then his wife does not come out to greet him. He realizes that they both left to join the rest of the collective and cries out “‘Damn it! What the hell is going on?’ And then, like someone who lost his strength, he sat down with a thud on the bed, breathing heavily, not knowing whether to be angry or to laugh.”²⁴⁴

Erdene depicts Old Man Dash as neither inherently anti-socialist nor anti-collective, but filled with anxiety that the new area, closer to the district center, will not offer the same quality of pasture for his animals. He has a close emotional connection to his homeland, which was not where he was born but where he lived most of his life. But resisting the collective, even for understandable reasons, leads to disaster. And while Old Man Dash is not a cartoonish villain and is somewhat sympathetic, he does mistreat both his wife and the puppy Bankhar. The unnamed old woman, like many women in socialist literature, is far more accepting of modern life than her husband. His stubbornness leads him to his wiser wife, along with the puppy, abandoning him to live in titular solitude.

²⁴³ Erdene Senge, “Solitude,” trans. Kenneth Linden, *Words Without Borders*, October 2018; S. Erdene, “Gantsaardal,” *Naran togoruu*, (Ulaanbaatar: Ulsyn Khevreliin Gazar, 1972), 114.

²⁴⁴ Erdene Senge, “Solitude,” trans. Kenneth Linden, *Words Without Borders*, October 2018; S. Erdene, “Gantsaardal,” *Naran togoruu*, (Ulaanbaatar: Ulsyn Khevreliin Gazar, 1972), 115.

Other works by Erdene take place in the collective and demonstrate the importance of cooperation, doing one's work and participating in the socialist society and economy. "In the Dust of the Herds" (*Malyn khöliin toos*) revolves around a single mother, Chantsal, who is infatuated by the charming Balbar who promises to take her away from the dust left kicked up by the herds.²⁴⁵ She hopes he will provide a good husband and a good father to her two children, the father of who is never mentioned. However, an old man reveals that Balbar is a corrupt man who let the collective animals become thin while his own grew fat. He "sells animals from the herd as if they were his own, he plots together with some of the executives and he receives fraudulent documents, money and praises. He has become greedy and mixes his own livestock with that of the state."²⁴⁶ Furthermore, Balbar keeps another woman in the city, and joked that he had one woman at home and another on the road. Erdene shows that those that shirk their work and abuse the collective are not merely bad for economic reasons, they are wicked people in other aspects of life. By showing a few flaws in collectives Erdene provides a look in the life collectives that is tinged with both realism and the promise for a better functioning system.

The gender dynamic of Erdene's work is an important aspect, as he often features women who embrace socialism earlier than men. This was a common socialist trope, the most famous Mongolian example being Ts. Damdinsüren's 1929 "The Rejected Girl" (*Gologdson khüükhen*), based on the life of various informants from his homeland, shows the suffering of a young woman in the old pre-socialist society before she discovers socialism, which frees her from oppression.²⁴⁷

²⁴⁵ S. Erdene, "In the Dust of the Herds," trans. D. Altangerel, *Some Short Stories From Mongolia*, (Ulan-Bator: State Publishing House, 1988), 183.

²⁴⁶ Erdene, "In the Dust of the Herds," 191.

²⁴⁷ Ts. Damdinsüren, "Gologdson khüükhen", *Tüüver Zokhiol*, (Ulaanbaatar: Ulsyn Khevel, 1956), 159; Ts. Damdinsüren, "The Rejected Girl," in *Selected Short Stories*, ed. Owen Lattimore, (Ulaanbaatar: State Pub. House, 1978), 5.

Class Enemies and Lazy Herders

One of the fundamental elements of any collectivization campaign was the identification and dispossessing of class enemies. The class enemies in the second collectivization campaign differed from those in the first campaign. In the first campaign, nobility and the clergy were the primary enemies and were defined by their hereditary and religious station as well as their large amount of wealth and livestock. Maiskii provides a detailed description of the pre-revolutionary class structures, which were dominated by nobility and member of the clergy.²⁴⁸

During the second campaign, the earlier disenfranchisement of nobles, civil war, and Stalinist era purge of lamas meant these previous class enemies were largely wiped out. Because of this, the focus turned to wealthy herders who were nevertheless commoners by birth. The definition of wealthy herders was based almost entirely on number of owned livestock and if they employed others. Using Ingold's terminology, this included associateship herding but more often consisted of assistantship herding.

The identity of class enemies was an important ideological and practical question. Jagwaral argues that herders were the working class from the Qing period, but that there were class distinctions within the herding class. He examines the herd size of different provinces, pre- and post-revolution.²⁴⁹ Jagwaral identifies three main divisions in the herding class, the poor, empty handed people (*gar khooson ard*), who have to work for others, middle class who have enough through subsistence herding, and wealthy people (*chineeleg ard*) who have "more money and livestock than necessary" and hire out others to do their work.²⁵⁰ He explains that they are now known as *bayan nudragan* (rich fist) after the Russian kulak, the classic wealthy peasant

²⁴⁸ Maiskii, *Mongoliia Nakanune Revoliutsii*, 37; Maiskii, *Contemporary Mongolia* (New Haven: Human Relations Area Files, 1956), 60.

²⁴⁹ Zhagvaral, *Aratstvo i Aratskoe Khoziaistvo*, 32.

²⁵⁰ Zhagvaral, *Aratstvo i Aratskoe Khoziaistvo*, 59.

model that was the primary enemy of Soviet collectivization. Jagwaral uses this to criticize “some of the intelligentsia in our country” who ask, “where are the kulaks?” and question their existence in Mongolia and herding societies.²⁵¹ He emphasizes that working alongside employees does not prevent one from being exploitative, though not all those who hire workers are kulaks. The distinction belongs largely to those who perpetuate “feudal modes” of labor and class relations.²⁵² By arguing that exploiters did not just belong to the noble or monastic class Jagwaral not only addresses the old debate over class distinctions in nomadic society, he also clearly shows the need to first heavily tax wealthy herders, and then force them to join collectives. That said, he draws a line between the push of wealthy herders into collectives and the punishment (beyond confiscation of wealth) of class enemies that was found in most other countries’ collectivization campaigns, as well as Mongolia’s first round of collectivization.

To support his arguments of the presence of wealthy herders, Jagwaral provides the numbers of livestock per household in 1954 collected in the official livestock census.

Table 4. 1954 Wealth of Households in Livestock²⁵³

Livestock Numbers	Households	Head of Cattle	% of Households	% of Head of Cattle
No Livestock	7077	0	3.4	0
1 to 10	22706	114308	10.8	0.5
11 to 20	16570	258195	7.8	1.2
21 to 50	43645	1520383	20.7	7.1
51 to 100	47440	3502141	22.5	16.3

²⁵¹ Zhagvaral, *Aratstvo i Aratskoe Khoziaistvo*, 59.

²⁵² Zhagvaral, *Aratstvo i Aratskoe Khoziaistvo*, 68.

²⁵³ Zhagvaral, *Aratstvo i Aratskoe Khoziaistvo*, 58–59.

101 to 150	27940	3439976	13.2	16
151 to 200	16732	2906154	7.9	13.5
201 to 300	16529	4019786	7.8	18.7
301 to 500	9599	3610433	4.5	16.8
501 to 700	2037	1181327	1	5.5
701 to 1000	669	548345	0.3	2.6
Over a 1000	265	380559	0.1	1.8
Total	211209	21481607	100	100

While all census numbers were subject to inaccuracies, the official numbers are the closest to reality historians can access. More importantly, these were that these numbers were the official numbers that the socialist leaders, including Jagwaral in his role in the Ministry of Agriculture, were working with as the basis to plan collectivization campaigns. This concentration of wealth was not as high as the pre-socialist or early socialist period but was still unacceptable for a modern socialist country in Jagwaral and other socialist leaders' view.

Socialist leaders and activists' antipathy towards the wealthy was often motivated not just by ideology, but also personal negative experiences. In his recollection of pressuring and forcing the wealthy to join the collective, Minjüür repeatedly mentioned having to work for rich people as a child, and how they did nothing to help him or his mother when she fell ill.²⁵⁴ These personal experiences would make it easy to justify and carry out disenfranchise wealthy people.

²⁵⁴ Lkhagvasüren, *XX зууны Монголчууд*, 33; cf. *A Herder, a Trader, and a Lawyer*, trans. Mary Rossabi, 46.

One woman, Nadmid, gave an interesting account from the perspective of a member of a wealthy herding family.²⁵⁵ Nadmid was a Zakhchin from Khowd, an ethnically diverse region in Western Mongolia. Her family was very wealthy as her grandfather and father both had a thousand head of livestock (*myangat malchin*). She acknowledges that “at that time, the households of herders with a thousand head were very rich. We had many sheep, and my father’s old man did as well. We had brightly colored cloth (*ereen daawuun*) covered *gers*, and buckets made of precious wood (*agir*).²⁵⁶ Our *ger* had a patterned design and was decorated with silver rams.”²⁵⁷ Their *ger* was decorated with *soyombos*, and they used it when celebrating Tsagaan Sar, which was banned. In the eyes of socialist activists this wealth was bad enough, yet perhaps even worse was the relationship they had herders they employed to watch their many livestock. Her family employed four Uriankhai families who lost their livestock due to raids by Kazakhs.

These families

were so poor, so they would frequently move to lands with food, herds and where people lived. After that, my family truly employed many people. Attracted by so many animals, they came and helped us to milk the animals, to tend them and to produce dairy products in order to fill their children’s bellies.... Thinking about it, there were a number of families. The Sharbaatar family came, the Balsan family came, alongside of our family there were always other families... who else? The Tünjin family, Manjuudai family. As far as I know, there were four families that would go around our place, and take turns coming down, and they were of great help. My poor things, they helped birth the livestock, and they divided up the herding. In the summer they milked the sheep that were lying down, milked, and then the children made food for themselves in their *gers*, and then occasionally in our *ger*. They were very helpful, and very kind.²⁵⁸

²⁵⁵ Nadmid, *The Oral History of Twentieth Century Mongolia*, http://amantuuh.socanth.cam.ac.uk/search/view_person.php?Person=990160

²⁵⁶ The Mongol word *agaru* is variously given as cypress, aloewood, or even sandalwood. The transcription of the interview has *agir*, however I think this is an Oirat dialectal variation. Bawden says that *agar* is the same as *agaruu*, “Cypress Family, Cupressaceae,” (pg. 5). He also lists *agar zandan* as “name of precious wood” (pg. 4). Tsewel’s dictionary also includes this definition (pg. 19). Hangin says that *agar* is cypress, but also that *agaruu* is a “large wooden vessel” (pg. 7). Kowalewski has *agaru* as “blagovonnœo derevo [fragrant wood/tree], aloe; agallochum (aquilaria agallocha, Rox.)” (pg. 133). Ramstedt, has ‘aloe-holz, sandelholz [aloe-wood, sandalwood]” and “xara ägr ‘buchbaum, buchholz [= beech]” (pg. 22). What is clear is from the context is that they owned fine wooden vessels. I am not confident which tree the buckets were made from, however.

²⁵⁷ Nadmid, *The Oral History of Twentieth Century Mongolia*.

²⁵⁸ Nadmid, *The Oral History of Twentieth Century Mongolia*.

Nadmid's family participated in what Ingold termed assistantship herding and provided a classic example of what socialists condemned as the wealthy oppressing the poor.

Nadmid recalled the increasing taxation that pushed them to join the collectives, that there "was indirect pressure, that behind it there were state policies."²⁵⁹ Because of this pressure her family joined the collective where they were made to give their herds and fine *ger* to the collective, and "they took everything and left us only three things, which were a silver dress ornament, the silver ram, and the precious wooden bucket."²⁶⁰ Still, she recalls that "the collective was very nice for a time. Things were plentiful, animals were cheaper than they are now, and goods were plentiful. After that one bad thing [i.e., the confiscation of livestock], life was very nice. After they established the collective, they planted grain crops and vegetables."²⁶¹

Nadmid's family history provides what in some ways is the ideal goal of collectives in relationship to wealthy herders by gradually forcing them through taxes to join the collective where their wealth and herds were confiscated. Then in the collectives they would become honest hard working socialist herders whose lives would be ultimately better than they were before. This reflects Jagwaral's focus on assimilating, rather than punishing, wealthy herders. Although Nadmid does not mention it, it is likely that the Uriyangkhai families joined the collectives before her family, as poor families were often the first to join.

When asked about collectivization in the 21st century, numerous former collective members would note the number of rich families in the region whose livestock were confiscated and were forced to join the collective. This common refrain suggests the party's propaganda on

²⁵⁹ Nadmid, *The Oral History of Twentieth Century Mongolia*.

²⁶⁰ Nadmid, *The Oral History of Twentieth Century Mongolia*.

²⁶¹ Nadmid, *The Oral History of Twentieth Century Mongolia*.

collectives enforcing equality was successful (as well as a general distaste towards the wealthy held by poorer and middle-class people).

Farms and Industrialization

At the same time collectives were being formed across the country, Mongolian leaders also promoted industrialization and intensification of farms and agriculture. State farms (*sangiin aj akhui*) were related to, but distinct from, the process of collectivization.²⁶² State farms had a higher concentration of farming and agricultural projects. These efforts, based on the Soviet model, intensified in large part due to Nikita Khrushchev's Virgin Land Campaigns.²⁶³ Tsogt-Ochiryn Lookhuuz, who served as the Director of State Farms in 1956, noted "the Virgin Land reclamation campaign was in our country directly under the influence of the USSR" and "in Mongolia, the ploughing of virgin land began at the same time as the collectives were established, and the herds were collectivized."²⁶⁴ Lookhuuz explained that one difference between collectives and state farms was that state farms were financed directly from the state whereas collectives were supposed to be self-sufficient in generating money.²⁶⁵ The main produce from state farms included corn, potatoes, grain, and hay. In addition, various fruits and vegetables were grown. State farms were not devoid of controversy, as seen by the changing of borders between North and South Khangai in the Kharkhorin state farm and at times collectives and state farms even engaged in boundary disputes.²⁶⁶

²⁶² For a complete list of the state farms, see Yuki Konagaya and Sampildondovyn Chuluun, *State-Run Farms in Mongolia*, (Osaka: National Museum of Ethnology, 2013).

²⁶³ B. Punsaldulam and Ts. Enkhjargal, "Gazar tarialan khödöö aj akhuin salbar bölön khögjsön n'," in *BNMAU-yn бүтээн байгуулалтын жилүүд ба Иү. Тседенбал*, (Ulaanbaatar: Erdem shinjilgenii khurlын emkhetgel, 2017), 71.

²⁶⁴ Konagaya and Lkhagvasüren, *XX зууны Монголчууд 2*, 69, 74; cf., *Socialist Devotees and Dissenters*, trans. Mary Rossabi, 84, 87.

²⁶⁵ Konagaya and Lkhagvasüren, *XX зууны Монголчууд 2*, 69; cf., *Socialist Devotees and Dissenters*, trans. Mary Rossabi, 84.

²⁶⁶ Zhagvaral, *Aratstvo i Aratskoe Khoziaistvo*, 215.

Minjüür contrasted the setup of state farms and collectives and claims that a major difference is the source of salary for the workers as state farmers were paid directly from the state as opposed to by the collective.²⁶⁷ Ts. Lookhuuz, who served as the head of the state farms, complained that after his expulsion from the party he was sent to work in a collective herding sheep and looking after pigs and chickens which “in terms of life was very difficult with a low salary.”²⁶⁸ Minjüür pointed out that state farms were far more engaged in agriculture than collectives.²⁶⁹ Farms also had higher levels of mechanization and warm barns for cattle and calves. Minjüür then launched into another lament of the post-collective period and the haphazard manner in which the farms were de-collectivized.

Industrialization through factories and mechanization of farming through tractors and trucks was overwhelmingly financed and supplied by the Soviet Union. This support was regularly heralded as one of many examples of the elder brother of the Soviet Union helping its younger brother Mongolia. State farms were also the center for innovation of improved and hybrid breed livestock as explored in chapter two. They also were the centers of livestock that did not belong to the traditional five snouts of livestock (*mal*) which were influenced from Soviet farming models. Poultry (*shuwuu*) were usually grouped together in plan documents, though this group included chickens, geese, and ducks. Pigs were also a major animal in state farms, and most breeds were imported from Siberia. State farms also were the recipients of most of the Soviet-imported mechanization and infrastructure.²⁷⁰ In 1957, state farms had 738 tractors, 210

²⁶⁷ Lkhagvasüren, *XX zuuny Mongolchuud*, 76; cf. *A Herder, a Trader, and a Lawyer*, trans. Mary Rossabi, 80.

²⁶⁸ Ts. Lookhuuz, *The Oral History of Twentieth Century Mongolia*, <https://amantuuh.socanth.cam.ac.uk/>

²⁶⁹ Lkhagvasüren, *XX zuuny Mongolchuud*, 76; cf. *A Herder, a Trader, and a Lawyer*, trans. Mary Rossabi, 80.

²⁷⁰ Punsaldulam and Enkhjargal, “Gazar tarialan khödöö aj akhuin salbar bөлөн khөгjsөн n’,” 76.

grain combines, 319 tractor ploughs, and 297 seeders.²⁷¹ The produce was processed in associated bakeries and distilleries.²⁷²

This period also saw new factories built in order to process the increasingly centralized livestock products. Early factories were built in Ulaanbaatar, and while other factories were later built, the majority of factories remained in the capital. Factories included meat packing, leather production, and milk processing. After three years of construction the first milk processing factory came online on December 31st, 1958, in Ulaanbaatar and was funded by the Soviet Union.²⁷³ This factory was designed to address the perennial problem of milk production in Mongolia: transportation, storage, transportation, and seasonal production.²⁷⁴ The opening of the milk factory was widely attended by Soviet and Mongolian leaders and lauded as proof of Mongolia's modern socialist development. At the opening, the factory was announced to be able to process 30,000 liters of milk a day and able to produce numerous milk products, including “processed milk, various types of creams, butter, yogurt, curd, ice cream, etc.”²⁷⁵ The *Ünen* newspaper article announcing the opening of the factory called nearby collectives and farms to increase milk production to match the high level of possible productivity. This call to action meant that despite the huge numbers of milk producing livestock in Mongolia, most milk ends up being wasted outside of the summer milking season.

Industrialization by its very nature transformed how Mongolians interacted with their animals and their environment. Pre-socialist Mongolians certainly had specialization of dealing with slaughtering, milking, and processing into clothing, but the mass processing of meat and

²⁷¹ Punsaldulam and Enkhjargal, “Gazar tarialan khödöö aj akhuin salbar bōlön khögjsön n’,” 76.

²⁷² Punsaldulam and Enkhjargal, “Gazar tarialan khödöö aj akhuin salbar bōlön khögjsön n’,” 78.

²⁷³ Dandarvaanchigiin Erdenebat, *Mongol Ulsad süünii salbar üüsch khögzhson tüükhen tovchoon*, (Mönkhiin Üseg, 2017), 251.

²⁷⁴ For a detailed history of milk production in modern Mongolia, see Dandarvaanchigiin Erdenebat, *Mongol Ulsad süünii salbar üüsch khögzhson tüükhen tovchoon*, (Mönkhiin Üseg, 2017).

²⁷⁵ Erdenebat, *Mongol Ulsad süünii salbar*, 254.

milk in factories created a level of alienation from animals not previously seen in Mongolia. Factories in the growing city created a class of people whose main relation to animals would be through their products, either meat, milk, or skin, rather than living animals. That said, the continued connection between city dwellers and their families in the countryside would no doubt have remained, albeit filtered through the constriction of internal movements imposed by the government.

Both mechanization and factories were heavily dependent on the Soviet Union, both for production and subsidizing cost. These were the largest departures from earlier methods of human-animal and environmental relations. Because of the reliance on the Soviet Union these innovations never spread as far as socialist leaders envisioned, and more importantly, quickly fell to the wayside when the Soviet Union dissolved.

Advice, Improvements, and Top Herders

Once herders were in the collective, the real work of transforming herding work and strategies could begin. The socialist drive to improve herding involved detailed study, documentation, and distribution of herders' strategies and knowledge of animals and their environment. The socialist government produced various herding guidebooks, ranging from general herding advice to specific topics such as breeding or types of livestock. Producing handbooks for sharing livestock knowledge was not a novel idea as there were various handbooks on livestock care that were produced before the socialist revolution.²⁷⁶ However, the socialist handbooks would have a larger circulation and intentionally removed references to various religious elements which were deemed backwards.

²⁷⁶ Ruth I. Meserve, "A Mongol Cure for the Rabid Horse," *Mongolian Studies* 10 (1986): 92.

J. Sambuu's (1895–1972) 1956 *Advice for Herders* (*Malchidad ökh zöwlölgöö*) includes important advice, but also serves as an advertisement for the socialist herding economy and the growing collectivization movement. The 1956 edition was an edited version of the 1945 edition, which was written with the help of the notable Mongolian intellectual B. Rinchen.²⁷⁷ The 1956 edition's first chapter covers basics of livestock and the environment of Mongolia. Jagwaral's *Herders and Herding Economy* was based on detailed research on the history of herding but was intended for an academic audience rather than a guidebook for average herders. This is in part largely because it is in Russian, rather than Mongolian, which would make it inaccessible to the majority of Mongolians. Their coverage of veterinary care is covered in Chapter 2.

Top herders regularly participated in conferences held at provincial, national, and even international levels. The 1956 South Khangai top herder conference focused on implementing call for collectivization in the second five-year plan as well as how to increase livestock, and how to convince other herders to join collectives.²⁷⁸ Many of the presenters focused on improving the quality of livestock, as seen in chapter two, and the construction of infrastructure to combat disasters, as discussed in chapter three. But most of the discussion was on the importance of increasing livestock numbers which could not private herders could not be relied on to carry out.

The presenters also agreed that the youth were “bad workers” and had to be taught by experienced herders like themselves.²⁷⁹ This is a regular refrain in socialist materials, and was particularly peculiar as many of the agitators for collectivization were members of the youth league. Such criticism could easily be transported to the 21st century when the herders who were

²⁷⁷ For a detailed study of Sambuu's works in Japanese, see Urenceceg, “Sambuu and His Book Advice to the Nomadic Herder: A Study of the Nomadic Life in Mongolia,” *Intercultural Studies*, no. 47 (March 2013): 221–58.

²⁷⁸ AA kh 1 d 1 khn 10, 1.

²⁷⁹ AA kh 1 d 1 khn 10, 94.

seen as ignorant youth, criticize young herders who grew up in the post-socialist period's lack of skills. Perhaps to address the alleged flaws of the young, in 1962 the Central Committee began to mandate students had to spend summers working in the countryside including in collectives and state farms.²⁸⁰

The criticism of young unskilled is more than simply “old people always criticize youth,” however. It reflects an attitude also found in Sambuu's handbook; that “our ancestors” had a greater knowledge of herding than most contemporary, particularly young, herders. This idea interestingly flies in the face of some of the other rhetoric around collectives; specifically that new technology and shared labor would create an improved new society. The tension between old and new appears again and again in the discussion of how best to herd in the new collective system.

Mongolian political leaders, collective bosses, veterinarians, and scholars traveled to conferences in the Soviet Union and other parts of the socialist bloc to participate in conferences on agriculture and collectivization. Conferences across the socialist world included trips to Moscow, Budapest, Berlin, Prague, and Beijing, where attendees' schedules and actions were monitored as well as topics of presentations.²⁸¹ In one such conference in 1955 in Budapest, Mongolians reported meeting a young György Kara, before he was known as Khar Dorj.²⁸² Buryatia was an especially important source of exchange and inspiration for aspects of collectivization and agriculture, including veterinary care. Although the region had, by the 1950s, been heavily colonized and Russified, Buryatia was still largely Mongolic-speaking, with a history of herding, so it was a site of particularly strong exchange of knowledge. This was

²⁸⁰ Bat Ochir, *Ard анги*, 184.

²⁸¹ TBA f 15 d 1 khn 762, 7.

²⁸² TBA f 15 d 1 khn 762, 43.

explicitly acknowledged during a conference in Buryatia, which held up Buryat veterinary science and hybrids as examples to be emulated.²⁸³ Inner Mongolia was a similar point of connection in the brief period of Sino-Soviet friendship in the mid-1950s with exchanges of various forms of agricultural knowledge as well as workers facilitated by their Mongolian identities.²⁸⁴ Other conferences were slightly less productive, such as a 1954 conference in China on collectivization where the Mongolian delegation understood the talks in Mongolian and Russian, but there was no Chinese to Mongolian translator, leaving them unable to understand many of the presentations.²⁸⁵ Despite these occasional linguistic difficulties, veterinary knowledge was part of shared socialist fraternal agricultural knowledge, even if it was at times more performative than practical.

To incentivize hard work and innovation, numerous awards were created to celebrate those who joined the *negdels* and performed well. In 1957, the Hero of Labor medal was given to numerous herders and veterinarians.²⁸⁶ Rare manufactured luxury items such as watches, sewing machines, bicycles, harmonicas, were given to herders as well.²⁸⁷ Socialist leaders heavily promoted the importance of a herder's individual work. Caroline Humphrey argues that in the first stages of collectivization,

rewards were given in prestige and honour rather than in money. Badges, certificates, speeches and honorific paragraphs in the newspaper were, and still are, used to celebrate people who have worked well in the collective interest. Similarly, observers may wonder why education for herdsmen concentrates more on moral and political matters than on professional and technical ones... all of this assumes that the herdsmen really know how to look after animals in harsh and difficult conditions; what is more doubtful, and needs to be carefully encouraged, is the motivation to work steadily to care for animals which are not their own property.²⁸⁸

²⁸³ TBA f 15 d1 khn 762, 11.

²⁸⁴ Sneath, *Changing Inner Mongolia*, 20.

²⁸⁵ TBA f 17 d 1 khn 511, 18.

²⁸⁶ Shirendev, *Dalain Davalgaanaar*, 238; Shirendev, *Through the Ocean Waves*, 155.

²⁸⁷ Zhagvaral, *Aratstvo i Aratskoe Khoziaistvo*, 47.

²⁸⁸ Caroline Humphrey, "The Role of Herdsmen's Collectives in the National Economy of Mongolia," *Development and Change* 9 (1978): 150.

Humphrey's point about the importance of rewards of merit and honor are extremely important, though her preface that accommodations were given rather than monetary and physical goods, "partly because nomadic people had no place to accommodate goods and were not used to acquisition," may be overlooking the importance of physical goods.²⁸⁹ First, it is possible and well attested historically for nomads to amass wealth.²⁹⁰ Second, the improvements to living conditions in *gers*, increased mechanization, and access to the *sum* center all should be understood as an increase in physical commodities. Many of the prizes did take the form of physical prizes, but were small and portable, such as a milk bucket or silver model of livestock. Today many older Mongolians wear their socialist-era medals with pride during the Tsagaan Sar and Naadam holidays.

Plans and Quotas

The Mongolian People's Republic adopted the Soviet style five-year plan in 1948 (after a failed attempt to implement one in 1931). The five-year plan was the backbone of a Soviet-style state socialist economy and detailed all the planned inputs and outputs of every sector of the economy. The second five-year plan drawn up in 1953 relied heavily on collectivization to implement its vision of a centralized state economy. Each year districts, provinces, and central state officials created tables listing the planned number, actual achievement, and percentage of the plan that was achieved to track the progress of the plan. A supplementary three-year plan was created from 1957 to 1960, and after that the five-year plan system continued until the end of state socialism in 1990.

²⁸⁹ Humphrey, "The Role of Herdsmen's Collectives in the National Economy of Mongolia," 150.

²⁹⁰ One of the many examples of this can be found in the detailed history of pearls in the Mongol Empire in Thomas Allsen's *The Steppe and the Sea*.

Socialist planners kept detailed numbers of livestock birth and death were kept assessing the progress of the plans. The plans were generally under fulfilled on a state level, though top herders, shock workers, and high achieving collectives would sometimes overachieve their plan. Workers who underachieved their goals were reprimanded and would hypothetically pay the difference in private livestock or cash, although punishments for underperforming tended to be light and a mere slap on the wrist. This leads to the classic capitalist complaint that collectives disincentivized collective workers from innovation and hard work. However, this critique ignores the many herders who not only worked hard during socialism but still proudly wear their socialist-era medals during holidays.

In his research on collectivization, Altantögs provides the 1959 law which detailed quotas of herders based on their wealth, region, and whether or not they were members in a collective.²⁹¹

Table 5. 1959 Livestock Product Quota

State Products Supply	3.1-4 <i>bod</i> in <i>khangai</i> or 3.6-6 <i>bod</i> in <i>gobi</i>	More than 4.1 <i>bod</i> in <i>khangai</i> or more than 6.1 <i>bod</i> in <i>gobi</i>	Private Herders
Cattle Meat	20 kg	24 kg	31 kg
Sheep Meat	4 kg	4.8 kg	6 kg
Goat Meat	3 kg	3.6 kg	4 kg
Sheep wool, 20% of which is short wool from lamb	1.25 kg	1.25 kg	1.25 kg
Camel Wool	4.8 kg	4.8 kg	4.8 kg
Goat Wool	0.2 kg	0.2 kg	0.2 kg
Goat Cashmere	0.23 kg	0.23 kg	0.23 kg
Cattle and Horse shed hair	0.25 kg	0.25 kg	0.25 kg
Horse hair	0.37 kg	0.37 kg	0.37 kg
Horse tail	0.1 kg	0.1 kg	0.1 kg
Yak wool and shed hair	0.4 kg	0.4 kg	0.4 kg

²⁹¹ N. Altantögs, “Khödöö aj akhuin negdliin mal aj akhuin tavaaryn бүтээгдэхүүний борлуулалты, khereglee (1960-1990 on),” *Historia Mongolarum* 8, 147–68.

Yak hair	0.43 kg	0.43 kg	0.43 kg
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In 1964, leaders issued new requirements for livestock goods, this time unified across the country.

Table 6 a. 1964 Quota for Livestock Products²⁹²

Wool cashmere, shed hair, hair	From one livestock (gram)
Sheep wool, 20% of which is short wool from lamb	1370
Camel Wool	5000
Goat Wool	215
Goat Cashmere	250
Cattle and Horse shed hair	310
Horse hair	410
Horse tail	110
Yak wool and shed hair	550
Yak hair	560

Table 6 b. 1964 Quota for Livestock Products²⁹³

Meat	Workers and officials	Other citizens
Cattle Meat	31 kg	24 kg
Sheep Meat	6.2 kg	4.8 kg
Goat Meat	4.1 kg	5 kg
Cow milk (from each cow)		100 liter

Note: In places without a milk factory 1 kg of fat may be delivered in place of 20 liters of milk. Workers and officials were exempt from milk requirements from the state.

Workers were exempt from the meat requirement if they had less than a certain number of livestock based on what sort of job they worked. However, this is an overall increase of required livestock goods and many are higher than the intentionally harsh taxes placed on the

²⁹² Erdenebat, *Mongol Ulsad süünii salbar üüsch khögzhön tүүkhөн товчоон*, 258.

²⁹³ Erdenebat, *Mongol Ulsad süünii salbar üüsch khögzhön tүүkhөн товчоон*, 258.

wealthy right before they were forced into collectives. In theory this should not be a problem as collectives were designed to increase production, therefore a slight increase of goods would be logical. However, collectivization was only complete for four years when these new increases were called for which was likely not enough to drastically increase production.

Foreign Observers

The writings of various foreign visitors to Mongolia during collectivization also provides useful contemporary sources on collectives from a different angle than Mongolian sources. A Russian visitor, S. Borzenko, published his experiences visiting Mongolia in 1954 in an article in *Pravda* entitled “Visiting the Arats.”²⁹⁴ This article gives an interesting look at the state of collectives and herding before the 1956 push for collectivization took off. Borzenko explains that “in Mongolia, a fierce (*zhestokii*) class struggle is continuing.”²⁹⁵ Borzenko describes attending a meeting between an agitator and herders, where after the agitator rebuked them for helping a lama, distributed various literature, increased livestock, and a resolution to shift the breeding season.²⁹⁶

Borzenko then met with Batmönkh, the chairman of the Labor collective. According to Batmönkh, “in 1950 seven poor families joined the cooperative, with only five heads of livestock.... Now 47 families work in our economic unit, and we possess 1,449 heads of livestock. In the past year we made 325,000 [*tögrögs*] in income.... We have built a Red Corner, a cattle barn, stables, five warm *khashaas* (a pen for livestock), equipped with a separating point, dug a well, bought seven hay harvesting machines, and a horse powered sowing machine.”²⁹⁷ After showing Borzenko various model members of the cooperative, Batmönkh concluded by

²⁹⁴ S. Borzenko, “V gostiakh u aratov,” *Pravda*, June 1, 1954, 3.

²⁹⁵ Borzenko, “V gostiakh u aratov,” 3.

²⁹⁶ Borzenko, “V gostiakh u aratov,” 3.

²⁹⁷ Borzenko, “V gostiakh u aratov,” 3.

saying that “I do not know how many years we will still roam (*kochevat*’) the steppes of our people, but the future of each *arat* is in the cooperative. All roads lead to them! One finger is nothing, but five fingers make a hand.”²⁹⁸ Borzenko not only shows the early efforts of collectivization, he also shows how this movement was shown off to their Soviet ‘elder brother.’ And around fifteen years after the mass murder of lamas they were still held up as a major class enemy who “prowl the steppe, like wolves!” As explored in chapter four, wolves were often cast as class enemies, especially lamas.

Owen Lattimore, a famous Mongolist who had been targeted by the infamous Joseph McCarthy for his alleged pro-socialist sympathies in 1950, visited Mongolia in 1961 immediately following the conclusion of the collectivization campaign. In his book *Nomads and Commissars*, Lattimore provides a history of Mongolia concluding with his visit to the MPR where he received tours of four *negdels*.²⁹⁹ Lattimore provides an experienced and highly sympathetic look at the new socialist form of herding. That said, at times he seems to be wearing rose colored glasses. After noting the policy of compulsory collectivization that was instated in 1958-1959, Lattimore undercuts this by asserting that “private herdsmen were more than ready to join.”³⁰⁰ Indeed, according to Lattimore, the rich herders had no more poor herders to work for them, so they desired to join the collective, but because they had so many excess animals mandatory collectivization was aimed not at forcing the wealthy to join, but to compel the collective to accept new members!³⁰¹ This twisted interpretation of collectivization clearly appealed to the highly sympathetic Lattimore.

²⁹⁸ Borzenko, “V gostiakh u aratov,” 3.

²⁹⁹ Lattimore, *Nomads and Commissars*, 178.

³⁰⁰ Lattimore, *Nomads and Commissars*, 185.

³⁰¹ Lattimore, *Nomads and Commissars* 186.

Lattimore was extremely interested in livestock and mobility and emphasizes the increased degree of specialization and that there were “two to four ‘big’ moves are made each year, depending on the type of country. This is as it was in the old days; but there is now more specialization and a much greater diversity of subsidiary activities.”³⁰² He then describes the division of herding between sheep and goats, which he states consist of 52 and 25 percent of the livestock respectively. He also describes the two kinds of dairy herds, the *ferm* (from Russian) of dairy cows, yaks, and yak-cattle hybrids (*khainag*), and milk mares. Lattimore also includes a picture of a number of posters in the *negdel* he visited, which includes the slogan “milk is gold” (*süü bol alt*) with figures for milk by animal per liter, another lists the increase of livestock births, while the final poster instructs the members of the *negdel* in proper gathering of wool.³⁰³ These posters are an important reminder of the official push for increased production. Lattimore embraces the collectives as the way forward to Mongolia and points to the many achievements in technology and standard of living during the socialist era while glossing over the atrocities of the purges.

Daniel Rosenberg’s research in the early 1970s in Ikh Tamir Bright Road collective is a valuable companion piece to Minjüür’s interview.³⁰⁴ Rosenberg met and interviewed Minjüür, who he describes as “a massive, charismatic, driven figure possessing great energy, an innovative mind, an ability to focus on detailed organizational matters, profound organizational competence, and great pride.”³⁰⁵ He provides Minjüür’s life story (the details of which

³⁰² Lattimore, *Nomads and Commissars* 186.

³⁰³ Lattimore, *Nomads and Commissars*, 135.

³⁰⁴ Daniel Mark Rosenberg, *Political Leadership in a Mongolian Nomadic Pastoralist Collective*, dissertation, (University of Minnesota, 1977); Daniel Rosenberg, “Leaders and Leadership Roles in a Mongolian Collective: Two Cases,” *Mongolian Studies*, 1981, 17–51; Daniel Rosenberg, “The Collectivization of Mongolia’s Pastoral Production,” *Nomadic Peoples*, 1981, 23–39; Daniel Rosenberg, “‘Negdel’ Development: A Socio-Cultural Perspective,” *Mongolian Studies*, 1974, 62–75.

³⁰⁵ Rosenberg, *Political Leadership in a Mongolian Nomadic Pastoralist Collective*, 178.

correspond to Minjüür's interview given decades later). According to Rosenberg, many collective members abused the *negdel* bosses, and "some of these directors were very sensitive, and thus they felt very disappointed and humiliated.... Menjuur (sic.) ignored the personal insults and simply pursued his goal of attempting to bring party and government policy into life. He didn't work to save his own face, he worked just to save party policy."³⁰⁶ This perspective of the bosses as persecuted by the common herders does not appear in other sources, even Minjüür's own late in life interview. This difference reflects the positive spin that Minjüür emphasizes in his accounting of collectives and socialism as a whole. It also shows that even a model collective that was selected to show a foreign scholar had conflicts over leadership.

Reorganization and Sedentarization

While Tsedenbal and other Mongolian leaders celebrated the complete collectivization of the herding economy in 1960, the project of collectivization was not entirely complete. Although independent Mongolia was distinct in the socialist herding world for retaining mobile herding, party leaders had made plans to increase sedentarization and settle most of the population. In a 1959 presentation to Central Committee, a strong case was made for sedentarization.³⁰⁷ A list of pros and cons were provided, with the ease of controlling and improving agriculture and distributing goods to a centralized population listed as largest pros, while the difficulty to maintain quality livestock herding featuring as a main flaw. They acknowledged that this would create pushback, but they argued critics' views were "too narrow" and sedentarization was best in the big picture. Foreign experts like Charles Bawden predicted a transition into a ranch-style livestock model, due to the push for sedentarization.³⁰⁸

³⁰⁶ Rosenberg, *Political Leadership in a Mongolian Nomadic Pastoralist Collective*, 200.

³⁰⁷ UTNONBBA, kh 4, d 24, khn 191, pg 89.

³⁰⁸ Charles Bawden, "Economic Advance in Mongolia," *The World Today* 16 (1960), 260.

Socialist leaders knew that native breeds in Mongolia were best served by mobile herding, and suggested that some shepherds would move in between fixed pastures especially in areas like the *gobi*. But as see in chapter two, many of the foreign and improved breeds, as well as non-*mal* livestock (primarily pigs and poultry) required relatively sedentary care. Although often criticized in contemporary scholarship, this was not a problem since all of herding was intended to become more settled, with an increase of infrastructure to provide fodder and wells to accommodate.

Ultimately, Mongolian leadership decided to merge *negdel* and *sum* (district) capitals, which Altantögs argues was one of the most important results of collectivization.³⁰⁹ Before these mergers occurred, there were various administrative conflicts. Jagwaral clearly lays out the fundamental problem of the dual administrative nature and cites examples where the separate district and province government came into conflict with the collective leadership.³¹⁰ Jagwaral condemns this as both weakening the collective and the party and calls for the district to be entrusted with some of the collective's governance. This suggestion was eventually put into practice.

Minjüür pointed to the increased centralization around the district center as a major improvement in life, in everything from education, quality of life, and increased care of livestock.³¹¹ Old folks, pregnant women, and children all benefited from the sedentary lifestyle. Minjüür again contrasts this with the post-collective socio-economic situation and calls for a movement back to centralized collective life. Sengiin Erdene's *Solitude* depicts the resistance of an old man to the relocation of the collective to be centered around the district center, though

³⁰⁹ Altantögs, in an as yet to be published conference presentation.

³¹⁰ Zhagvaral, *Aratstvo i Aratskoe Khoziaistvo*, 210.

³¹¹ Lkhagvasüren, *XX zuuny Mongolchuud*, 62; cf. Lkhagvasüren, *A Herder, a Trader, and a Lawyer*, trans. Mary Rossabi, 69.

Erdene makes it clear he is wrong to resist as the new center is brimming with modern amenities.³¹² Lattimore notes the move towards merging the *negdel* and *sum* administration during his visit, which he acknowledges as an important development in administrative structure of the *negdel*.³¹³ The reorganization of the *sum-negdel* resulted in a close interconnection of family life with the *sum* center.³¹⁴ Collectives were also merged together, and the number of collectives fell from 354 in 1960 to 272 in 1970.³¹⁵

When leaders merged the district and collective this made life revolved around the district center. Pro-sedenterization leaders likely decided it was enough to create a central hub of the district. This sort of half measure, and gradual decrease of investment in the herding economy foreshadowed the decrease investment in the agricultural sector. Perhaps foreseeing future lack of investment in collectives, Jagwaral concludes his book by arguing for increased investment and payment for collectives and collective members.³¹⁶

Ts. Namkhainyambuu, Labor Hero

Tserendashiin Namkhainyambuu, a highly decorated Labor Hero from Zawkhan province, was in many ways the ideal collective herder. He finished his autobiography in 1989, though it was not published until 1993, and the book reflects the increased openness of the late socialist period. His work shows the dual nature of socialist herding, as he emphasizes both the importance of learning from older established herders, first his mentors, and then from himself, as well as celebrates the innovations of improvements created by the socialist state. As an older

³¹² Erdene, "Solitude" trans. Kenneth Linden; Erdene, "Gantsaardal," 114.

³¹³ Senge, "Solitude," trans. Kenneth Linden; S. Erdene, "Gantsaardal," 180.

³¹⁴ Slawoj Szynkiwicz, "The Role of the Herdsmen's Co-operatives in Modernizing the Country Life in Mongolia," in *Poland at the 8th International Congress of Anthropological and Ethnological Sciences*, 195–210, (Wroclaw: Publishing House of the Polish Academy of Sciences, 1968), 199.

³¹⁵ *Narodnoe khoziaistvo MNR za 60 let iubileinyi statisticheskii sbornik*, (Ulan-Bator: Tsentr. Stat. upr. MNR, 1984), 85.

³¹⁶ Zhagvaral, *Aratstvo i Aratskoe Khoziaistvo*, 209.

decorated herder, his autobiography includes numerous lessons on herding, and is in large part intended to pass his knowledge onto a younger generation. His herding knowledge was gleaned entirely during the socialist era, but he learned from herders who came of age in the pre-collective period, and he intended to instruct post-socialist herders. In many ways, an experienced herder's wisdom transcended economic regimes.

Namkhainyambuu's life and autobiography demonstrates many of the important transformations of Mongolian society and herding through collectivization. He was literally the ideal herder – held up as an international example of Mongolian herding, he provided advice to herders through newspapers and radio interviews, conference presentations, and his book. He dedicated his life to herding, specifically herding sheep, which reflects the specialization of the collective period compared to post-collective independent herding households.

Namkhainyambuu's hard labor also shows that the capitalist-inspired idea that collectives did not create individual innovation does not hold water. He was not the norm, but he demonstrates that some herders did work long and hard and thought of their own strategies and methods to perfect herding, and that these innovators were well rewarded for their efforts. To herders like Namkhainyambuu, collectives, despite some flaws, fostered a meaningful and fulfilling life of herding which helped their family, community, and country.

Although too young to participate in collectivization, his autobiography provides a deeply personal source of someone growing up in the collective who was convinced of the strengths of collective herding and was highly motivated by the system of socialist rewards.

Namkhainyambuu specialized in herding sheep, especially Sartuul breed sheep, hence the title of his autobiography *Khoniny khishig (Bounty from Sheep)* and his autobiography combines personal history with herding advice accumulated from his decades of experience. He was

educated in the *sum* center as part of the increased push to educate children, which further integrated collective families' lives with the district center. However, at the age of 13 in 1961 quit school 4 to focus on herding, which at the time was frowned upon but permitted.³¹⁷

At first, he worked alongside families doing chores and watching nearby livestock, but in 1965 at his insistence he started participating in long term herding under the tutorship of an experienced herder named Lkhasüren with whom he drove herds to North Khangai, Bulgan and Ulaanbaatar to fulfill the collective's quotas. In 1967 he increased the sheep herd he was responsible for to 400 head and was recognized by the collective leader at the collective meeting for exceeding the planned herd growth for which he received an award and a harmonica.³¹⁸ His fellow collective members called on him to play the harmonica but Namkhainyambuu didn't know how to play, so on the advice of other members he saved it for his future son. He followed his accomplishments in his youth by becoming a deputy to the Great Khural at the age of twenty-seven, but he continued to herd with the added responsibility of answering questions about herding from various reporters and from other herders through the mail.³¹⁹ Namkhainyambuu's list of accolades are too long to list but include "Champion Herder," "Top Herder," "Order of the Polar Star," and "Labor Hero."

Namkhainyambuu wrote glowingly of the government efforts to improve the herding economy through plans and infrastructure, as well as his and other's individual efforts to exceed the state plans. He relates that in in the 1970s "we had 469-59 young from 486-590 female sheep and goats at the start of six years or at the end of five years, or 3363 young from 2907 mothers or

³¹⁷ Ts. Namkhainyambuu, *Khoniny Khishig* (Ulaanbaatar: "Esön Erdene" BBKhK, 1993), 30; cf. Ts. Namkhainyambuu, *Bounty From the Sheep: Autobiography of a Herdsman*, trans. Mary Rossabi, Inner Asia Book Series, no. 1 (Cambridge: White Horse, 2000), 50.

³¹⁸ *Aman khuur*, which can mean either harmonica or jaw harp. I feel confident that this was in fact a harmonica, given its importance as a modern socialist instrument.

³¹⁹ Namkhainyambuu, *Khoniny Khishig*, 40; cf. Rossabi, *Bounty From the Sheep*; 57.

356 young,” which overachieved the plan by a third.³²⁰ He was visited by reporters and received various letters asking for advice, though he acknowledges that now he sees there was censorship and people were afraid of going against their superiors.

Namkhainyambuu poses the question as to how he received the title of champion thrice at the district level and twice at the provincial level, to which he answers with a long discussion of the importance of long-distance mobility (*otor*), which he identifies as belonging to three types: “putting out to graze to restore, to fatten, and to maintain gained fatness.”³²¹ The first type, putting out to graze to restore, occurs in the spring when livestock is weakened from the winter, and should be fed on the gullies of the southern or eastern slopes of the mountain. Moving to fatten occurs in the summer, after shearing and milking. Again, he provides detailed advice to how to best select summer pastures, depending on if one lives in the *gobi* or the *khangai*. He also advises the reader to observe sheep because a good herder can tell how well a sheep is eating, and the fatter a sheep, the more awkward it will look. Finally, maintaining the fat occurs in the fall when the livestock need to get used to the cold and be prepared for the winter. Again, he provides different advice for the *khangai* and the *gobi*, though he emphasizes that this is general advice rather than concrete rules.

Namkhainyambuu places great importance on mobility, as seen when he instructs the reader “If possible, do not fence sheep!”³²² He argues that sheep raised exposed to the cold will be better conditioned to resist extreme temperatures. The fact that many of the sheep he took care of were the Sartuul breed shows that hybrids were far from shelter-locked burdens, as seen in

³²⁰ Namkhainiambuu, *Khoniny Khishig*, 40; cf. Rossabi, *Bounty From the Sheep*, 57.

³²¹ Namkhainiambuu, *Khoniny Khishig*, 45; cf. Rossabi, *Bounty From the Sheep*, 59. *Otor* is most often used to describe long distance mobility due to disaster, but in this case Namkhainyambuu clearly uses it to refer to seasonal migration.

³²² Namkhainiambuu, *Khoniny Khishig*, 50; cf. Rossabi, *Bounty from the Sheep*, 63.

more detail in chapter two. He details the process of moving livestock to various seasonal camps, including the winter camp on Songino known as “Hollow” (*Khongilt*). His emphasis on mobility provides support to Humphrey and Sneath’s argument that mobility was higher in collectives compared to post-collective herding.³²³

Despite his copious advice for herding, which included responding to letters sent in asking for advice and giving interviews for various news articles, he emphasized that herding must be learned in the field. Still, the book mostly concerns herding, with sections on his parents and his personal life interspersed throughout, with only a short section on his wife Jargal and their eight children.³²⁴ Jargal was also a highly decorated herder, and her hard work in and out of the home reflects the emphasis placed during the socialist period that women ought to be both highly skilled workers and mothers. And while it is clear he takes great pride in his and Jargal’s herding achievements and wants others to follow in their footsteps, he insists “herding livestock is not an easy path.”³²⁵ Namkhainyambuu relates the difficulty of the severe 1968 *zud*, and admits that he despaired, wondering why he stayed in the countryside when he could have become educated and moved to town like his peers. Perhaps reflecting this crisis of faith, in a 1987 conference on how to improve the struggling herding economy he points to the common occurrence of children and youth going to the city.³²⁶ He suggests an increased investment in district and provincial towns to combat this. Tragically, a few years from when he gave this advice the level of investment in the countryside would plummet even more due to de-collectivization. This criticism of older experienced herders that the youth have been seduced by

³²³ Humphrey and Sneath, *End of Nomadism?*, 268.

³²⁴ Namkhainiambuu, *Khoniny Khishig*, 54-57; cf. Rossabi, *Bounty from the Sheep*, 66-69.

³²⁵ Namkhainiambuu, *Khoniny khishig*, 33; cf. Rossabi, *Bounty from the Sheep*, 52.

³²⁶ Namkhainiambuu, *Khoniny khishig*, 64-65; cf. Rossabi, *Bounty from the Sheep*, 73-75.

city life was and is common. Again, the knowledge of elders is prized regardless of the political or economic situation.

Conclusion

Mongolian human-animal and environmental relations were changed by the socio-economic transformations of collectivization. However, the changes often focused more on cultural and economic changes rather than actual herding strategies. Leaders like Sambuu and Jagwaral highlighted numerous elements of herding as productive and compatible with socialism while other elements, particularly those related to religion and spiritualism, were officially discouraged (though certainly would have continued in private). At a center of herding knowledge was the importance of experienced older herders. Herding was increasingly professionalized, through the codification of strategies by top herders in conferences, handbooks, radio programs, and write in newspaper columns. Herding was also specialized with herders working with one type of livestock rather than having many different kinds as was the norm in the private ownership period and the post-collective period. Decisions of who would herd which animal, pasture selection, and other important herding matters were decided centrally, though there was collaboration with herders depending on the collective as seen in the case of Namkhainyambuu. Still, this often resulted in herders having to move from their traditional pastures, which, as seen in Erdene's "Solitude," was cast as a necessary sacrifice for socialist modernity. Industrialization and centralization occurred, but sedentarization was never fully implemented.

Mongolian leaders set out to reorganize Mongolian herding, society, and culture through collectivization, and they succeeded. From the outset, leaders and activists were clear in their goals: eliminate inequality and improve herding through collectively ownership as part of a

centrally planned economy. In their minds this Soviet-inspired model was the only way to achieve a modern state. Collectives used a carrot and stick approach to convince herders to join, promising new infrastructure, protection from poverty and disaster, and a new life in the collective. It is likely one or a combination of these promises that convinced Tsodol and Yanjidulam and many like them to join collectives. Ever-increasing taxes incentivized those unconvinced, especially the wealthy, to join the collective until the government forced the remaining holdouts to join. This coercion never escalated to violence, but this was because of the previous extreme violence carried out by the state against tens of thousands of Mongolians. The dispossession of wealthy herders was one of the primary goals of socialist leaders and they were successful. Herders from poorer families, both socialist leaders and average herders, cited this dispossession as one of the many positive features of collectivization.

Collectives revolutionized herding by increasing concentrating the herds into centrally owned and controlled institutions. Humphrey and Sneath emphasize the similarities between pre-socialist noble and monastic herding and collective herding and while there were many similarities the Qing era institutions never had the degree of concentration held by collectives. Herding families were able to keep fifty or seventy-five head of livestock, and in total private livestock made up twenty five percent of the total livestock in the country. This degree of private wealth was higher than that in other socialist states, but most livestock was state owned.

The massive increase of livestock that Mongolian leaders planned for never occurred. A lack of investment in plagued collectives until the end of the socialist era which, along with a very high offtake for export to the Soviet Union, was one of the reasons livestock numbers never increased. Despite this, it cannot be denied that Mongolian herding and society was fundamentally reorganized because of collectivization. There were certainly people who suffered

and lost property and wealth during collectivization. However, many Mongolians who lived through it cite the positives, rather than dwell on the negatives. Centrally owned livestock, along with major programs to protect against loss and disaster, was viewed positively by Mongolians, especially in contrast to the lack of these programs following de-collectivization.

Chapter 2

International Veterinary Science

Introduction

The introduction and professionalization of veterinary science (*shinjlekh ukhaany mal emneleg*) was one of the key components in collectivization campaigns and the socialist revolution of Mongolian herding. Once livestock were within a collective, they would (or were supposed to) receive veterinary care, from treatment of injuries to the administration of vaccines. Professionally trained veterinarians would also monitor livestock breeding, and new improved hybrid breeds created by Mongolian zootechnicians would be introduced into the collectives. The role of the veterinarian was so vital that they were among the main leaders of the collective. Veterinary science served as an incentive for herders to join collectives. Furthermore, like other aspects of collectivization, veterinary care would address the alleged backwardness of herding and achieve the planned constant increase of livestock deemed necessary to build a modern socialist state.

Veterinary science in the Mongolian People's Republic was most heavily influenced by the Soviet Union. Early on, Soviet veterinarians came to Mongolia to spread knowledge and establish veterinary stations. However, Mongolian veterinary science was not simply an outside imposition, as soon Mongolian veterinarians (*malyn emch*) and zootechnicians (*zootekhnich*) traveled to Soviet universities to learn their trade, and eventually set up their own schools in Ulaanbaatar. Mongolian veterinarians traveled across the socialist world, and in rare cases beyond, to learn and share veterinary scientific knowledge, from topics including vaccines and hybrid breeds. By doing so, Mongolians engaged in the global trend of using veterinary science to increase livestock production yields, as well as increase the integration of the state in livestock

economies. Nevertheless, Mongolian veterinarians and zootechnicians worked to adapt veterinary science to the Mongolian environment and livestock.

Although veterinary science was a method of overcoming limitations imposed on livestock by nature, veterinarians and leaders tried to strike a balance between introducing these new methods with the realities of the Mongolian environment. While all elements of collectivization balanced traditional and new elements, veterinary science had by far the newest elements. Scientific advancement was a key element of the modern elements of socialism, and its utopian vision of the future. Socialist thinkers acknowledged the long history of herding, which included veterinary care, but argued that advances like veterinary science would bring Mongolian into the modern socialist world. Popular culture, both outside and inside of Mongolia, portrays nomadism as an ancient and timeless way of life. However, collectivization in socialist Mongolia was one of the major transformations of Mongolian herding society and one of the most concrete changes in the lives of herders and their animals was the introduction of veterinary scientific medicine.

Veterinary science in Mongolia had three major elements, the first of which was the training and dissemination of veterinarians and veterinary assistants through the country. The training of these professionals and placement in collectives were a major concern, and the promise of consistent veterinary care was promoted as a strength of the collectives. The second was combating the large number of common livestock diseases in Mongolia through vaccinations. Mongolia has and continues to be plagued by many diseases which target livestock which could easily devastate entire herds. The final aspect of veterinary science was the importation of improved breeds and the spread and creation of new hybrid livestock breeds. Improved high yield breeds were not as mobile and required more resources than native breeds,

which led to efforts to create hybrids between improved and native breeds. Hybrids were still not as hardy as native breeds, but socialist leaders were well aware of the problems posed by these breeds and had plans in place to address them. It was when planned infrastructure was not constructed these problems became evident. All the elements of veterinary science indeed improved the health and quality of livestock even if it never led to the exponential increase socialist leaders called for.

Historiography

There is a common criticism of Western-style veterinary science in scholarship of Mongolian herding. Telenged and Fijn criticize socialist veterinary care for ignoring traditional knowledge in preference for outsider knowledge.³²⁷ Telenged argues that socialist zootechnicians bred improved breeds without concern for the environment and that the spread of veterinary science and artificial insemination replaced traditional knowledge.³²⁸ Fijn dismisses the veterinarians as Russian trained and improved breeds as Russian and ill-suited to the environment. According to her, improved breeds were happily discarded by Mongolian herders after socialism.³²⁹ These claims do not hold up to historical study, as most veterinarians in the 1950s were in fact Mongolians and many later improved breeds were also created by Mongolians. There is no doubt that some aspects of this campaign helped herders and that new veterinary science could be more effective than aspects of traditional knowledge. The arguments also tend to imply that the base state of Mongolian herding is based on small households with

³²⁷ B. Telenged, "Livestock Breeding in Mongolia Past and Present: The Advantages and Disadvantages of Traditional and Modern Animal Breeding Practices," in *Culture and Environment in Inner Asia*, ed. Caroline Humphrey and David Sneath (Cambridge: White Horse Press, 1996), 161–88; Fijn, *Living With Herds*, 30–31.

³²⁸ Telenged, "Livestock Breeding in Mongolia Past and Present," 161–88. Strangely, B. Telenged refers to the Orkhon breed sheep as "Orion." Although unproven, it is very likely that this was an issue stemming from the Latin transcription system used which represents the Cyrillic "x" with "h." All of the information provided clearly lines up with that of the Orkhon sheep.

³²⁹ Fijn, *Living with Herd*, 30–31.

low infrastructure and that the socialist model is an inherent disruption of this model, a claim contested by Sneath and Humphrey.³³⁰ Furthermore, the dichotomy between traditional and Western knowledge is overly simplistic. As shown in this dissertation, all aspects of the socialist transformation of the herding economy involved a melding of old and new techniques and technologies.

Veterinary science was by far the aspect of socialist herding that involved the most innovations and technological care, and professionalized veterinary care certainly displaced traditional livestock doctors. However, pre-existing traditional knowledge was not completely erased. In the 1950s and 1960s there appears to be a common view that there was value in documenting and picking and choosing the best parts of traditional knowledge. These folk (*ard*) methods are preserved and replicated in various scholarly works, as well as handbooks. Sambuu's 1956 *Advice for Herders* and Jagwaral's book *The Herder and the Herder's Husbandry* (*Arat i aratskoe khoziaistvo*) written in 1957 provides detailed history of these folk methods. Although Jagwaral emphasizes that new veterinary knowledge is superior, he makes it clear that traditional cattle breeding was still utilized, with different regions having different sizes and types of each livestock.³³¹ This book was not published until 1974 and is in Russian, so it was not available to most Mongolians. However, it does show that Jagwaral, who was the head of the Ministry of Agriculture from 1957 to 1961, was interested in the history and preservation of folk methods rather than their erasure. As an orphan of a herder's family in East Gobi, he almost certainly grew up using traditional methods.

The preservation of certain folk methods should not be interpreted as evidence of an ahistorical inherent Mongolian connection to their environment and livestock. While some

³³⁰ Humphrey and Sneath, *End of Nomadism?*.

³³¹ Zhagvaral, *Aratstvo i Aratskoe Khoziaistvo*, 161.

physical methods of folk veterinary care were preserved, the religious and spiritual aspects of traditional veterinary care were discarded. These spiritual protections certainly played a large part of pre-revolutionary livestock protection but had no place in the new socialist herding. At all times it was clear that the new modern socialist methods were superior. Folk methods were positioned as inferior to new Soviet inspired knowledge, but were still an important part of Mongolian history of livestock herding and still of some use. Just as traditional strategies of mobility would supplement superior modern strategies to scientifically locate the most rational pasture use, the traditional remedies and knowledge would supplement modern veterinary knowledge.

A more persuasive common criticism is that the socialist-era improved and hybrid breeds in Mongolia are ill-suited to the Mongolian environment as they require far more fodder, shelter, and water, while being unable to migrate like native breeds.³³² However, the argument that hybrids or improved breeds were ill-suited to the harsh climate of Mongolia is an oversimplification. These problems were seen across the globe in bringing high yield breeds to new environments, from cows in England to pigs in China.³³³ Socialist Mongolian zootechnicians and leaders were very aware of the difficulty Mongolian environments presented to improved breeds which led to the mission of hybridizing improved foreign breeds with local breeds. While Orkhon sheep and other new hybrids were more resource intensive than pre-existing Mongol breeds, they were designed to be better suited to Mongolia than many purebreds, as shown below. Therefore, the story of improved breeds and hybrids struggling in

³³² Humphrey and Sneath, *End of Nomadism?*, 12-14; Telenged, "Livestock Breeding in Mongolia Past and Present; Sneath, *Changing Inner Mongolia*, 84.

³³³ For numerous examples of global veterinary science, see Karen Brown and Daniel Gilfoyle, ed. *Healing the Herds: Disease, Livestock Economies, and the Globalization of Veterinary Medicine*, (Ohio University Press, 2010).

new environments is not just a Mongolian story but part of a worldwide environmental and animal history.

Global Context and Mongolia

As explored in Brown and Gilfoyle's *Healing the Herds*, professionalization of veterinary science was often part of state building in the 19th and 20th century around the world.³³⁴ The same model is seen in Mongolia where veterinary services were a clear part of the state apparatus and the reorganization of society and economy that was collectivization. Capitalist and socialist countries implemented similar policies in the goal to increase livestock numbers and yield. One of the major diseases combatted around the globe was rinderpest, or cattle plague.³³⁵ Increasing the production of livestock goods first required decreasing livestock loss. The second step was increasing the number of products that livestock would produce. Improved and hybrid breeds promised increased quality and quantity of meat, wool, milk, skin, or other products. However, the various improved breeds popular in America and Europe did not fare well in the Mongolian environment.

Hybridizing improved breeds with local breeds adapted to harsh environments was a common challenge in the 19th and 20th century and by no means was unique to Mongolia. Most of these experiences were from outsiders attempting to improve allegedly inferior local breeds in order to maximize production and profits. The balancing act between native and improved breeds is a worldwide one with a contested history. Rebecca Woods explores the history of livestock breeds in the British Empire in *The Herds Shot Round the World*.³³⁶ In the early 18th century,

³³⁴ Karen Brown and Daniel Gilfoyle, *Healing the Herds: Disease, Livestock Economies, and the Globalization of Veterinary Medicine* (Ohio University Press, 2010), 3.

³³⁵ Clive Spinage, *Cattle Plague: A History*, (Boston, MA: Springer, 2013).

³³⁶ Rebecca J. H. Woods, *The Herds Shot Round the World: Native Breeds and the British Empire, 1800–1900* (The University of North Carolina Press, 2017), 4.

British horse, cattle, and sheep breeds were selectively bred to increase productivity, and these breeds were exported across the British Empire, replacing local breeds. But British breeds were supplanted by higher-yield Continental European breeds like the Merino sheep, to such an extent that the British breeds were considered to be endangered native breeds in need of conservation. In the United States, during the New Deal government officials replaced local the Navajo *churra* sheep breed with improved breeds which were targeted to American wool markets, but whose wool was not as suited to the traditional household production by women of rugs and blankets.³³⁷ For once responding to needs of Navajo women, in 1936 a breeding station was established to create a hybrid well-suited to the environment whose wool would appeal both to commercial markets and Navajo women weavers. This project was deemed unsuccessful and abandoned in 1949.³³⁸ Adaptation to local condition and acceptance by the actual locals was a common problem in designing hybrid livestock.

Mongolia's neighbors also struggled balancing veterinary science and local conditions. In Japanese-controlled Manchuria and Inner Mongolia, imperial modernization projects tried similar policies and wrestled with the same problems in a different part of the Mongolian plateau.³³⁹ They combatted the same diseases and struggled to introduce improved breeds, even but never established major hybrids as in the Mongolian People's Republic. Clunies Ross, an Australian expert that visited Manchukuo, argues local mobile herding was the most productive method of livestock rearing, and that improved breeds "are incapable of surviving under natural grazing conditions and require intensive handfeeding and housing for at least five to six months

³³⁷ Marsha L. Weisiger, *Dreaming of Sheep in Navajo Country*, Weyerhaeuser Environmental Books (Seattle: University of Washington Press, 2009), 191-192.

³³⁸ Weisiger, *Dreaming of Sheep in Navajo Country*, 193.

³³⁹ Robert John Perrins, "Holding Water in Bamboo Buckets: Agricultural Science, Livestock Breeding, and Veterinary Medicine in Colonial Manchuria," in Karen Brown and Daniel Gilfoyle, *Healing the Herds: Disease, Livestock Economies, and the Globalization of Veterinary Medicine* (Ohio University Press, 2010), 195.

of the year.”³⁴⁰ Sigrid Schmalzer examines the Chinese Republican efforts of hybridizing American with local Chinese breeds to adapt them to local conditions in Dingxian, Hebei.³⁴¹ Despite various issues, local farmers continued to raise them through the Japanese invasion and into the People’s Republic.³⁴² Later in the People’s Republic of China breeding stations continued to work to improve pigs, as along with other scientific agricultural policies.³⁴³ As in Mongolia these international veterinary practices were closely linked with the socialist transformation of agriculture.

Soviet veterinary medicine, which was the primary source of veterinary science in the Mongolian People’s Republic, was introduced throughout its republics and regions, including to livestock herding regions such as Buryatia and reindeer herding Siberian and Arctic regions. In Chukotka collectivization also brought Soviet veterinary science from vaccines against anthrax to handbooks on selective breeding to increase reindeer size and yield.³⁴⁴ In Buryatia, as in Mongolia, veterinarians played a role in the leadership of the collectives.³⁴⁵ A series of books on livestock breeds and breeding were translated from Russian into Mongolian, with the studies on horse and cattle published in 1960 and 1961.³⁴⁶ These texts focus on Soviet breeds rather than Mongolian but given the large number of non-native breeds in Mongolia at the time they were still no doubt of use to specialists. Many of the improved breeds introduced in Mongolia

³⁴⁰ Kungtu C. Sun and Ralph W. Huenemann, *The Economic Development of Manchuria in the First Half of the Twentieth Century* (Cambridge: Harvard University Press, 1974), 49-50.

³⁴¹ Sigrid Schmalzer, “Breeding a Better China: Pigs, Practices, and Place in a Chinese County, 1929-1937,” *Geographical Review* 92, no. 1 (2002): 1.

³⁴² Schmalzer, “Breeding a Better China, 19.

³⁴³ Sigrid Schmalzer, *Red Revolution, Green Revolution: Scientific Farming in Socialist China* (Chicago ; London: University Of Chicago Press, 2016), 149.

³⁴⁴ Bathsheba Demuth, *Floating Coast: An Environmental History of the Bering Strait*, (New York: W. W. Norton & Company, 2019), 185-186.

³⁴⁵ Caroline Humphrey, *Marx Went Away--but Karl Stayed Behind* (Ann Arbor: University of Michigan Press, 1998), 105.

³⁴⁶ B. V. Fandeev, *Ükhriin Sudlal*, (Ulaanbaatar: Mongol Ulsyn Khevllel, 1960);

originated from Soviet Central Asia and Siberia, which makes it clear that Mongolian and Soviet veterinarians and zootechnicians were aware of the issues the Mongolian environment posed and did not merely import Russian or Western improved breeds without any thought.

International conferences on agriculture were an important site of exchange of veterinary science for Mongolia, as well as related ideas on collectivization, livestock, and other agricultural aspects. Mongolian political leaders, collective bosses, veterinarians, and scholars traveled to conferences in the Soviet Union and other parts of the socialist bloc to participate in conferences on agriculture and collectivization. As discussed in chapter one, conferences across the socialist world included trips to Moscow, Budapest, Berlin, Prague, and Beijing, where attendees' schedules and actions were monitored as well as topics of presentations.³⁴⁷ Buryatia was an especially important source of exchange and inspiration for aspects of collectivization and agriculture including veterinary care. Because Buryatia is a Mongol-speaking region with a history of herding, albeit one heavily colonized and Russified by the 1950s, it was a site of particularly strong exchange of knowledge. This was explicitly acknowledged during a conference in Buryatia which held up Buryat veterinary science and hybrids as examples to be emulated.³⁴⁸

Diseases and Early Veterinary Care

Veterinarians and veterinary science were extremely important in a livestock based economy like Mongolia. Mongolian livestock suffered from many diseases and ailments including cattle plague or rinderpest (*myalzan*), anthrax (*boom*), hoof and mouth disease (*shuls/shülkhii*), brucellosis (*brutsellioz*, a clear borrowing from Russian), strangles (*yam*), glanders (*sakhuu*), cowpox (*tsetseg öwchin*), mange (*khamuu*), the staggers (*ergüü*), calf

³⁴⁷ TBA f 15 d 1 khn 762, 7.

³⁴⁸ TBA f 15 d 1 khn 762, 11.

paratyphoid (*tugalyñ ij balnad*), scours (*töliin tsagaan chatsga*), black leg (*duut khawdar*), worms (*khorkhoi*), ruminal tympany or bloat, esophageal obstruction or choke, eating poisonous food, vitamin deficiency, burns, frostbite, broken bones, bot flies, and other parasites. In the socialist era professional veterinarians treated these ailments, vaccines were produced, and handbooks were distributed to herders so they could recognize and treat the various ailments. Combating livestock disease was an important incentive and justification for collectives as well as an internal measure of success.

Before the import of international veterinary science from Russia, Mongolian and Tibetan-style methods were practiced. While these can be framed as traditional, i.e. pre-socialist, their presence across Eurasia shows that the socialist era was not new in introducing long distance connections in livestock care. Prayers and praise songs for rock cairns (*owoo*) entreated protection from diseases, along with other causes of livestock loss.³⁴⁹ Texts and sutras were also written on how to care for livestock using physical and supernatural means. Ruth Meserve translated and examined a Qing era Inner Mongolian Chakhar text “The Methods of Curing Diseases of Horses and Camels,” focusing on the treatment of rabies in horses.³⁵⁰ The text included magical rituals as well as treatment advice which usually involved bloodletting, cauterization, and amputation. These texts show that veterinary care and knowledge was spread before the introduction of Western influenced veterinary science albeit of a different variety.

D. Maidar’s 1962 history of veterinary science from 1921 to 1956 provides a harsh assessment of pre-revolutionary veterinary care, dismissing it as backwards and insufficient in

³⁴⁹ C. R. Bawden, “Two Mongol Texts Concerning Obo-Worship,” *Oriens Extremus* 5, no. 1 (1958): 38-39; Walther Heissig, *The Religions of Mongolia* (Berkeley: University of California Press, 1980), 86, 94.

³⁵⁰ Ruth I. Meserve, “A Mongol Cure for the Rabid Horse,” *Mongolian Studies* 10 (1986): 91-92.

stopping diseases from ravaging Mongolian livestock.³⁵¹ Generally speaking, socialists evaluating of the Mongolian historical economy had three options: pre-socialist herding was backward and flawed, pre-socialist herders were skilled and well adapted but held back by superstition and an exploitative feudal system with socialism offering the perfection of previous methods through modernization, or a combination of the two. In contrast to most histories of herding, which played the middle ground, or hunting, which emphasized its long history, veterinarians emphasized the break in tradition in order to celebrate their accomplishments with veterinary science. To Maidar, pre-socialist veterinary care was tainted with Buddhist “superstitions” and led by amateurs, rather than scientific professionals.³⁵² Maidar emphasizes previous backwardness in order to then emphasize the vast improvement under socialism.

Maidar and his colleagues were part of a new highly educated profession whose predecessors were largely laypeople, and veterinary writings heavily integrated religious rituals. The emphasis on religious rituals meant that veterinarians could not connect with their predecessors as their methods included many elements that were disapproved of by socialist policies and ideology. Jagwaral’s desire to preserve traditional methods “while discarding everything mystical and backward and selecting all the best and valuable,” would leave less veterinary knowledge to preserve than herding or hunting.³⁵³ And the more functional methods of care could easily be included in the professional international care of livestock.

In the early 20th century before the socialist revolution veterinary care was primarily the purview of non-professional animal doctors. According to the Diluwa Khutugtu, an incarnate

³⁵¹ D. Maidar, *Mongolyn shinzhlekhi ukhaany mal emneleg, 1921-1956* (Ulaanbaatar: BNMAU Shinjlekh ukhaany akademi, 1962).

³⁵² Naidar, *Mongolyn shinzhlekhi ukhaany mal emneleg*, 3-5.

³⁵³ N. Zhagvaral, *Aratstvo i Aratskoe Khoziaistvo* (Ulan-Bator: Akademiia Nauk Mongol’skoi Narodnoi Respubliki, 1974), 188. Though written in 1957, the book was not published in Mongolian and was only published in Russian in 1974, which made the book available only to a certain educated class of Mongolians. As such it reflects Jagwaral’s academic studies and internal justifications of collectivization more than other public facing documents.

lama, the veterinary care in his monastic estate was done by skilled but non-professional parishioner herders.³⁵⁴ They would sometimes use Chinese or Russian medicine, reflecting an early form of the transition to biomedical veterinary science, but largely relied on their own knowledge to treat diseases. They and other specialists were paid in trade and relied on their own herds for their livelihood rather than income from their work. It is notable that veterinary care was performed by herders rather than monks even in a monastic community, as lamas provided medical care for humans. According to Gombojab Hangin the situation in Chakhar Inner Mongolia was similar with veterinary services provided by skilled specialist herders, all of which were men.³⁵⁵ Like Khalkha livestock doctors, they sometimes used Chinese medicine (Russian medicine being unavailable due to distance). According to Hangin many communities did not have veterinarians or other specialists. This patchwork system clearly left holes in care for livestock both in coverage and efficacy of treatment. But it is clear that veterinary specialists existed, even when they were not professionals.

Creating a Socialist Veterinary Corps

To deal with the various diseases and injuries of livestock, the Mongolian People's Republic needed to cultivate a professional veterinary service. There were three main types of veterinary specialists in Mongolia: veterinarians (*ikh malyn emch*, lit. great livestock doctor), veterinary assistant (*baga malyn emch*, lit. little livestock doctor), and zootechnician, a college or university-trained specialist in breeding of livestock. By the period of collectivization in the 1950s some veterinarians were trained in the Soviet Union or the greater socialist bloc, but the majority of veterinarians were trained in Mongolia. Books were produced to instruct Mongolian veterinarians on treatment of diseases for example a book instructing veterinary assistants how to

³⁵⁴ Herbert Harold Vreeland, *Mongol Community and Kinship Structure*, (New Haven: HRAF Press, 1962), 51.

³⁵⁵ Herbert Harold Vreeland, *Mongol Community and Kinship Structure*, (New Haven: HRAF Press, 1962), 150.

care for mange.³⁵⁶ Although part of the international veterinary scientific movement during the second collectivization campaign Mongolian, veterinarians were mostly Mongolians trained in Mongolia.

The introduction of professionalized international veterinary care in independent Mongolia was originally performed by Russian specialists stationed in the capital, today's Ulaanbaatar, at the time Ikh Khüree. Tseween Zhamtsarano published in his newspaper *New Mirror (Shine Toli)* an article in 1914 in which he celebrates the achievements of Russian veterinarians and rebukes the herders who were hesitant to work with them.³⁵⁷ Russian produced newspapers published veterinary articles, as in the previously mentioned article on rinderpest, in Mongolian although again the degree of distribution is unknown. Russian citizens were the primary providers of professional veterinary knowledge in the theocratic period under Bogda Khan's theocratic government and early on after the 1921 Revolution. In 1923 the fledgling socialist government established a central veterinary service, again relying at first on Russian specialists.³⁵⁸

The revolution of Western-style veterinary care was similar to the socialist change in human healthcare. Introduction of vaccines and Western-style doctors played an important role in legitimizing and spreading control of the socialist government. Western science, from the globe to electricity to vaccines, were potent symbols and arguments used by socialists. One of the most important method of combating diseases, livestock or human, are vaccines. This is not only because of their efficacy, but because they were a strong argument for the importance of modernization, whether of the socialist or capitalist variety. If the government can eradicate

³⁵⁶ G. Dashnjam, *Malyn khamuu övchnii tukhai malyn бага эмч нарт зориулал*, (Ulaanbaatar: Ulsyn Khevlél, 1954).

³⁵⁷ Ts. Zhamtsarano e.d., "Mal-iyar bayalig boltugai," *Sin-e toli* no. 17 (July 15, 1914).

³⁵⁸ Zhagvaral, *Aratstvo i Aratskoe Khoziaistvo*, 39.

virulent diseases, clearly the government knows what it is doing. As such vaccines were a potent weapon in socialist propaganda, especially early on when it was important to contrast the success of Western medicine with the traditional Tibetan-style Buddhist remedies. The literary hero Natsugdorji wrote poems explaining the existence of germs and the damages of syphilis, and belittling attempts at treatment by monks.³⁵⁹ Cultural campaigns towards the end of collectivization in 1959 focused on human cleanliness, from new iron stoves in tents to washing sheets.³⁶⁰ Collectives could transform not only the way that people herded, but also how they washed their hands.

During the 1930-1932 failed attempt at collectivization veterinary service was promoted as part of the package of collectivization, but with the subsequent civil war and failure to collectivize veterinary care was not implemented across the country. However, there was a gradual increase over the 30s and 40s. In 1930 there were 24 veterinary branches with 67 veterinary workers. Ten years later there were 238 branches, with 716 workers.³⁶¹ Veterinary centers went from treating 49,136 head of livestock in 1931 to 1,060,895 in 1938.³⁶² This increase, however, still left a large hole in the care of countrywide livestock care. And as with almost most other aspects of Mongolian life, World War II was a disruption of veterinary efforts.

Combating livestock diseases, especially with vaccines, was one of the most important advances brought by veterinary science. One early success in veterinary care was combatting and largely eradicating rinderpest, or cattle plague (*myalzan*).³⁶³ This pernicious disease was a major problem in herding regions across the world with a long history of combatting it, until vaccines

³⁵⁹ D. Natsagdorzh, *Zokhioluud*, (Ulaanbaatar: Ulsyn Khevreliin Khereg erkhlekh khoroo, 1961), 155, 171; Charles Bawden, trans., *Mongolian Traditional Literature: An Anthology*, (New York: Kegan Paul, 2003), 735-736.

³⁶⁰ Stolpe, "Display and Performance in Mongolian Cultural Campaigns," 63-64.

³⁶¹ Bat-Ochir, *Ard angi*, 79.

³⁶² Bat-Ochir, *Ard angi*, 79.

³⁶³ R. Sodnomdarjaa, Sh Tserendorj, and J. Bekhochir, "History of Rinderpest Control and Eradication in Mongolia," *Mongolian Journal of Agricultural Sciences* 11, no. 2 (November 25, 2014): 172.

spread in the 20th century.³⁶⁴ In 1916, a Russian edited newspaper based in the capital of Khüree published a two-part examination of the causes of rinderpest.³⁶⁵ With first Russian Imperial, and then Soviet assistance, Mongolia constructed vaccine production facilities and distributed vaccines for use on exposed livestock as well as for preventative measure. By the time of collectivization in the mid-50s, cattle plague outbreaks were greatly reduced to the point where cattle were no longer immunized after 1963.³⁶⁶ It is notable that the Sambuu's 1956 handbook does not mention rinderpest, whereas the 1945 version does.³⁶⁷ This shows that it was no longer a concern to herders, or at least no longer seen as a concern to herders by Sambuu and the publishers. While prevention from disease were certainly a feature of collectives, rinderpest was so important that it was largely eliminated before the second collectivization campaign. This achievement convinced herders of the viability of veterinarians and was celebrated by socialist activists and leaders like Jagwaral.³⁶⁸

As seen in Figure table five, collected from officially published statistics, the numbers of veterinarians and veterinary assistants were extremely low, which obviously would create a difficulty in spreading veterinarians across the country.

Tale 7. Number of Veterinarians and Veterinary Assistants in the MPR, 1952-1960³⁶⁹

Year	Veterinarians	Veterinary Assistants	Total
1952	121	1,158	1,279
1953	150	1,258	1,408
1954	162	1,448	1,610

³⁶⁴ Clive Spillage, *Cattle Plague: A History*, 2003 edition (Boston, MA: Springer, 2013).

³⁶⁵ A.P. Khionin, ed. "Üker-ün miljan kemekü ebedčin-ü učir-a," *Neyislel Küriyen-ü sonin bičig*, nos. 25-26, (July 20, 1916).

³⁶⁶ R. Sodnomdarjaa, Sh Tserendorj, and J. Bekhochir, "History of Rinderpest Control and Eradication in Mongolia," *Mongolian Journal of Agricultural Sciences* 11, no. 2 (November 25, 2014): 177.

³⁶⁷ Sambuu, *Malchdad ökh zövlölgöö*.

³⁶⁸ Zhagvaral, *Aratstvo i Aratskoe Khoziaistvo*, 161.

³⁶⁹ *BNMAU-yn uls ardyn azh akhui 1962 ond: statistikiin emkhtgel*, (Ulaanbaatar: Ulsyn Khevelelin Gazar, 1963), 61 ; D. Batsükh, ed., *BNMAU-yn 1921-1958 onuudyn uls ardyn azh akhui soëlyn khögzhilt: statistikiin emkhetgel* (Ulaanbaatar khot: Said naryn Zövlöliin Too Bürtgeliin Ulsyn Töv Gazar, 1960), 67. 1955 and 1959 are missing from the sources.

1956	229	1,904	2,133
1957	259	1,813	2,072
1958	274	1,220	1,494
1960	393	1,961	2,354

The number of full veterinarians more than tripled between 1952 and 1960, but the increase of veterinary assistants was slower. There is also a strange dip in the number of veterinary assistants in 1958, perhaps due to reorganization or increased training in the final phase of collectivization. By the end of the collectivization campaign in 1960, 2,354 veterinarians of both ranks had to care for the approximately 23 million livestock in the country³⁷⁰, around a 9,770 animals per veterinarian or veterinary assistant, and 58,524 head per full veterinarian. And these veterinarians were not equally distributed, instead largely concentrated in the state farms and longer established collectives. As a point of comparison, David Sneath records that in 1961 Inner Mongolia had 1,040 veterinarians.³⁷¹ It is not clear if this reflects the same distinction between the two ranks of veterinarians in the MPR.

There was a continued worry that there were not enough trained veterinarians in the collectives, and recruitment and education of veterinarians was an important mission. In the South Khangai collective members meeting in 1967 the same promises of veterinary science are reiterated that were made a decade earlier. Speakers emphasized that soon they would eradicate diseases and introduce hybrid breeds and they lament that there are not enough people working as veterinarians and zootechnicians.³⁷²

When collectives did receive newly trained veterinarians, they were often extremely young. Yunden, born 1942 in South Khangai, started working in the Golden Spring collective as

³⁷⁰ *BNMAU-yn uls ardyn azh akhui 197 ond: statistikiin emkhtgel*, (Ulaanbaatar: Ulsyn Khevrelelin Gazar, 1975), 61

³⁷¹ Sneath, *Changing Inner Mongolia*, 84.

³⁷² AA f 74 d 1 khn 11, pg 62, 65, 70.

a veterinary assistant in 1958 when he was 18.³⁷³ In 1962 he transferred to the Kharkhorin state farm, also in South Khangai. The young age and transfer between different collectives and state farms was a relatively regular occurrence for veterinarians. Although she started working over a decade later in 1971, Nanjid also began to work at 18 as a veterinarian, and she also was transferred between multiple collectives.³⁷⁴ The youth of veterinarians bucked the trend of prizing the experience of older herders seen in chapter one, and of older hunters in chapter four. In the case of veterinary science, scientific training in higher education was prized above experience, at least in the official context. Still, as seen in Jagwaral's preservation of folk methods for veterinary care, old methods were still reckoned to be important.

In addition to serving as a highly trained group specialists who offered a vital service, veterinarians served as an important cadre of socialist advocates and agents of the Mongolian socialist state building endeavor. Mongolian veterinarians fulfilled the same role of their counterparts across the globe in the 19th and 20th centuries of spreading state control into the countryside and agrarian economies.³⁷⁵ Herders had to be integrated into the state economic system for them to access improved veterinary care through collectivization.

Collectivization and Veterinary Care

Veterinary care and collectivization went hand in hand and activists and agitators promoted it as a major incentive for herders. Joining a collective would protect against disease in two ways. First, as with all major causes of livestock death, a major loss would not destroy the life of an individual herder because all livestock would be held in common. Second, collectives

³⁷³ Yunden, *The Oral History of Twentieth Century Mongolia*,
http://amantuuh.socanth.cam.ac.uk/search/view_person.php?Person=990165

³⁷⁴ Nanjid, *The Oral History of Twentieth Century Mongolia*,
http://amantuuh.socanth.cam.ac.uk/search/view_person.php?Person=990070

³⁷⁵ Karen Brown and Daniel Gilfoyle, *Healing the Herds*.

would include veterinarians to treat diseases and oversee breeding and care of livestock. In the South Khangai top herders conference numerous speakers emphasize the importance of veterinary care and improved breeds.³⁷⁶ One of the presenters was Chimedtseren, a forty-two-year-old who worked as a veterinarian for the last ten years.³⁷⁷ He notes that when the plan called for the vaccination of 2,000 livestock against anthrax, he managed to vaccinate 5,630. He also vaccinated 1,000 livestock from cowpox and treated 1,750 livestock for various infections. A country wide conference of top herders in 1958 called for an extermination of diseases in state farms and collectives from 1959-1960.³⁷⁸ This shows the importance of veterinary care as one of the methods to promote collectivization and create modern socialist herding. Veterinary science was also an important internal measure of success. Numbers of veterinarians, vaccines, improved breeds, and livestock killed by diseases were closely monitored in internal state and party documents and plans.

In theory each collective would have a veterinarian, and perhaps a zootechnician, who would be part of the collective leadership.³⁷⁹ In the collective veterinarians were part of the commission to verify the livestock and goods taken to fulfill plans were of proper quality, in order to ensure that no diseased or otherwise flawed livestock were submitted to the state. In 1959, the Spark collective in South Khangai province established a livestock commission which included a veterinarian named Namkhaidorj as one of the seven members.³⁸⁰ When selecting new pastureland veterinarians and zootechnicians were to be consulted by collective bosses.³⁸¹

³⁷⁶ AA, kh 1 d 1 khn10, pg 33.

³⁷⁷ AA, kh 1 d 1 khn10, pg 121.

³⁷⁸ UTNONBBA, kh 4 d1 khn 24, pg 98.

³⁷⁹ S. Badamkhatan, ed., *Etnografiin Sudlal* (Ulaanbaatar: Shinzhlekh Ukhaany Akademiin khevllel, 1972), 143.

³⁸⁰ AA f 30, d 1 khn 27, 25.

³⁸¹ S. Badamkhatan, ed., *Etnografiin Sudlal* (Ulaanbaatar: Shinzhlekh Ukhaany Akademiin khevllel, 1972), 148.

Livestock death by disease were closely monitored by the collective's leadership. The Spark Collective leadership detailed the number and kind of livestock killed by brigade by disease.

Table 8. April 1961 Spark Collective Livestock Loss from Disease³⁸²

	Horse	Cattle	Yak	Camel	Sheep	Goat	Total
Brigade 1	356	43	7	0	151	43	600
Brigade 2	5	0	0	4	92	47	148
Brigade 3	5	0	0	30	16	12	63

The huge number of livestock loss in the first brigade compared to the second and third brigades shows the devastation brought by untreated disease. By closely monitoring livestock deaths, leaders of the collective would not only know how many livestock were lost, they also knew when they ought to respond by quarantining (*khöl khorikh*) and treating afflicted herds.

Veterinarians and collective bosses had to ensure that these livestock were in fact killed by disease, rather than some other reason. Caroline Humphrey observed in Buryatia the common practice of obscuring the reason for the death of the livestock, including claiming it died by disease, in order to use the collective's livestock for one's own uses, such as slaughtering for food.³⁸³ Closely monitoring which animals died by disease was at least partially intended to prevent such practices from occurring.

As with other aspects of collectivization the veterinary care often slowly arrived. In an interview, collective boss and later Labor Hero R. Minjüür lists veterinarians and zootechnicians as a reason for why collectivization was necessary.³⁸⁴ He somewhat undercuts this by explaining that when the collective was first established there were no veterinarians so as the collective leader he was responsible for veterinary care along with most other duties.³⁸⁵ Given Minjüür's

³⁸² AA f 30 d 1 khn 29, 117, 21.

³⁸³ Humphrey, *Marx Went Away--but Karl Stayed Behind*, 136.

³⁸⁴ Lkhagvasüren, *XX Zuuny Mongolchuud*, 40; cf. *A Herder, a Trader, and a Lawyer*, trans. Mary Rossabi, 51.

³⁸⁵ Lkhagvasüren, *XX Zuuny Mongolchuud*, 47; cf. *A Herder, a Trader, and a Lawyer*, trans. Mary Rossabi, 57.

high rank and continued clear positive opinion of collectivization after the end of the socialist era, this is not a condemnation of the collectives, but a description of the early kinks that had to be worked out. And Minjüür made his feelings clear when he said that there were no veterinarians at the time, just like there are no veterinarians today.³⁸⁶ As in other cases, Minjüür exaggerated the post-socialist situation in order to make his point clearer about the strengths of the socialist system. Eventually Minjüür's Bright Road collective did receive a veterinarian as well as a zootechnician.³⁸⁷

Veterinary knowledge and the importance of new strategies were promoted and disseminated through radio, magazines, and handbooks. J. Sambuu's *Advice for Herders*, mentioned in chapter one, emphasized the importance of new international veterinary science.³⁸⁸ The 1956 handbook, in part intended to promote collectivization, includes chapters on combating diseases and promoting improved breeds. In the chapter on disease Sambuu provides an overview of the importance of combating diseases and vaccinations and various diseases are listed along with their symptoms and possible treatments.³⁸⁹ To convince herders of the merits of improved breeds, Sambuu goes through and lists each new breed one by one, emphasizing the new yields made possible by these new kinds of livestock.³⁹⁰ This handbook both gives useful information as to what a herders could do themselves as well as emphasizes the importance of international veterinary care and its role in the new socialist herding economy.

Handbooks continued to be produced after collectivization. Smaller handbooks on specific subjects were also produced such as the 1963 "Instructions on Rearing Livestock

³⁸⁶ Lkhagvasüren, *XX Zuuny Mongolchuud*, 47; cf. *A Herder, a Trader, and a Lawyer*, trans. Mary Rossabi, 57.

³⁸⁷ ³⁸⁷ Lkhagvasüren, *XX Zuuny Mongolchuud*, 42; cf. *A Herder, a Trader, and a Lawyer*, trans. Mary Rossabi., 53.

³⁸⁸ Zh Sambuu and Rincin, *Mal aju aqui deger-e-Ben yagakiju ajillaqu tuqai arad-tu ögkü sanagulg-a surgal* (Ulaganbagatur: Bügüde Naiiramdaqu Monggol Arad Ulus-un Keblel, 1945); Zh. Sambuu and Rincin, *Mal azh akhui deeree iaazh azhillakh tukhai ardad ögökh samuulga surgaal* (Ulaanbaatar: [ZhEMR Khevelelin gazar, 2001).

³⁸⁹ Sambuu, *Malchdad ökh zövlölgöö*, 277.

³⁹⁰ Sambuu, *Malchdad ökh zövlölgöö*, 185.

Young” (*Malyn töliig boijuulakh zaavar*).³⁹¹ It was designed for the use of collective members with a publication of 5,000 copies, but it is not clear how many people actually used the book.³⁹² Released soon after collectivization was complete the booklet that includes sections on each of the five livestock, with basic veterinary topics such as insemination and various diseases commonly found among young livestock. It also has a small section on hybrid and improved breeds, which emphasizes that they have different gestation and growth timing than Mongolian sheep, and herders in collectives need to learn these as well.³⁹³ This handbook was for herders who were not zootechnicians but who were presumably still expected to birth and care for young livestock. These sorts of handbooks were one method of spreading veterinary knowledge. N. Otgon’s 1965 *Herders’ Handbook* (*Malchdyn garyn awlaga*) is intended for “herders, workers in herds, brigade, or farms, and anyone interested in methods of livestock labor.”³⁹⁴ Despite the generic name of the book, Otgon was a veterinarian, and the book is primarily devoted to veterinary care and science. Because it is written by a veterinarian it conveys more advanced and specialized knowledge than is found in Sambuu. The handbook includes basic care of injuries, recognizing and knowledge of diseases, and care of birth and young livestock.

Namkhainyambuu, the Labor Hero profiled in the first chapter, emphasizes the importance of veterinary care in both his autobiography and unpublished handbook of herding advice. He is especially insistent on the collaboration between herders and veterinarians in the case of livestock births.³⁹⁵ Namkhainyambuu’s strategies and advice combines the best of traditional and modern herding strategies, and he is very clear on the importance of veterinary

³⁹¹ Ia. Badarch, ed., *Malyn Töliig Boijuulakh Zaavar*, (Ulaanbaatar: BNMAU Ulsyn khödöö aj akhuin iam, 1963), 1.

³⁹² The copy in my possession includes annotations of livestock births in pencil so it was deemed useful by at least one individual.

³⁹³ Ia. Badarch, ed., *Malyn töliig boijuulakh zaavar*, (Ulaanbaatar: BNMAU Ulsyn khödöö aj akhuin iam, 1963), 16-17.

³⁹⁴ N. Otgon, *Malchdyn garyn awlaga* (Ulaanbaatar: Ulsyn Khevelelin Khreeg Erkhlekh Khoroo, 1965), 2.

³⁹⁵ Namkhainyambuu, *Khoniny khishig*, 72, c.f. Namkhainyambuu, *Bounty from the Sheep*, 84.

science. Though he advocates for individual herders' close connection and knowledge of sheep, veterinarians were necessary for both treatment of disease and especially rational planning and execution of breeding. At no point does he suggest, as Fijn's informants did, that veterinarians were ill suited to the job or unwelcome, much less some sort of disruption to "real" herding knowledge.

Veterinary science was the most prevalent in state farms (*sangiin aj akhui*). They received the most funding and were the locations of experiments with breeding. State farms also had the most cultivated land, and non-*mal* livestock³⁹⁶: pigs, poultry, and rabbits.³⁹⁷ All of these elements, including veterinary science, were intended to spread out into the various collectives after their perfection in the state farm. When the Kharkhorin state farm was formed in 1956, it had five veterinary assistants, three secondary educated zootechnicians, and two agrotechnicians.³⁹⁸ The next year they had added a full veterinarian to the staff.³⁹⁹ While state farms were farther along with implementing veterinary science than collectives, they still struggled with numerous problems. According to a 1960 Ministry of Agriculture report, despite progress in fighting diseases, anthrax, black leg, cowpox, mange, intestinal worms, and more were found in state farm livestock, and in 1960 80% of the deaths of state farm livestock were because of diseases.⁴⁰⁰

³⁹⁶ *Mal* is the Mongolian word for livestock, but exclusively for the five snouts: horse, camel, cattle, sheep, and goat. I will make this clear at the start of the dissertation, but I want to make it clear here.

³⁹⁷ Yuki Konagaya and I. Lkhagvasüren, *XX зууны Монголчууд 2: Сотсиалист Монголын улс төрийн ам'драл*, Senri Ethnological Reports 72, (Osaka, Japan: National Museum of Ethnology, 2007), 78; cf., Yuki Konagaya, I. Lkhagvasüren. *Socialist Devotees and Dissenters: Three Twentieth Century Mongolian Leaders*, trans. Mary Rossabi, ed. Morris Rossabi, Senri Ethnological Reports 107, (Osaka, Japan: National Museum of Ethnology, 2012), 91.

³⁹⁸ AA, kh 72 d 1 khn 101, pg 1.

³⁹⁹ AA, kh 72 d 1 khn 02, pg 92.

⁴⁰⁰ TBA, f 15 d 1 khn 963, pg 20.

Improved and Hybrid Breeds

Increasing the production of livestock goods first required decreasing livestock loss. The second step was increasing the number of products that livestock produce. Improved and hybrid breeds promised increased meat, wool, milk, skin, and other products. Hybridization is an important aspect of livestock breeding in and out of Mongolia. In Mongolian the term for hybrid (*erliiz*) is borrowed from Chinese (*erleizi*). In English language scholarship the most prominent use of *erliiz* is by Uradyn Bulag's *Nationalism and Hybridity in Mongolia*, who frames his research around the idea of *erliiz*.⁴⁰¹ In this case the hybrid is used as a slur against mixed race people. As an Inner Mongolian, he himself is identified as an *erliiz* because of the assumed idea of Inner Mongolians being Chinese, rather than the "pure" Khalkha majority of independent Mongolia.⁴⁰² Bulag points out that in terms of livestock, *erliiz* is a positive term, and hybrids are said to be of superior quality.⁴⁰³

However, the story is a bit more complicated than 'livestock *erliiz* are good, human *erliiz* are bad.' It is true that in the socialist era *erliiz* are precious commodities and presented and counted as indicators of success. However, it is still clear that they are "other," distinct from native Mongolian breeds (*Mongol nutgiin üülder*). There is also the term purebred (*tsewer üülder*) which is rarely used and only for foreign improved breeds primarily in works specifically on veterinary science and zootechnicians and rarely in government or archival documents from the time which instead focus on improved breeds. Livestock *erliiz* may be stronger and more

⁴⁰¹ Uradyn Erden Bulag, *Nationalism and Hybridity in Mongolia*, Oxford Studies in Social and Cultural Anthropology (Oxford: Oxford University Press, 1998), 2.

⁴⁰² Bulag, *Nationalism and Hybridity in Mongolia* 7-8.

⁴⁰³ Bulag, *Nationalism and Hybridity in Mongolia*, 140.

productive, but like the wolf-dog hybrids discussed in Chapter four and human hybrids, they are still not part of the natural order.⁴⁰⁴

As discussed above, it is a common narrative that improved and hybrid breeds are not suited to the Mongolian environment. This is generally true as improved breeds are less adapted to Mongolian environment and are ill suited to movement. Early efforts of importing improved breeds in Mongolia did not fare well. There is a 1940 report which claims that in 1880 a small number of Merino sheep were imported but they fared poorly compared to the native sheep.⁴⁰⁵ Improved breeds, especially Merino sheep and Simmental and Holstein-Frisian cattle, as well as some horses, were periodically imported in the early 20th century. In the 1920s Simmental cattle and ten Australian Merino sheep were imported but ended up dying from mange.⁴⁰⁶ By all reports, these breeds struggled and did indeed require an exorbitant amount of resources to survive.

By the period of the second collectivization campaign attitudes and importation of improved breeds were better planned and thought out. In the 1950s there was a clear shift towards more regionally appropriate Soviet improved breeds, most which were largely from Siberia and Central Asia, as seen below. Even the pig breeds, not one of the five traditional livestock raised in Mongolia, were primarily of the Siberian variety. Buryat work on improved breeds were especially important, given both the shared culture and similar environmental concerns. In 1954 the Soviet Union donated Sychev, Alatau, and Kazakh white-headed cattle,

⁴⁰⁴ One method of hybridization is quite common and is still widely practiced in the *khangai* (hilly forested steppe region) region of Mongolia, crossing cattle (*ükher*) and yak (*sarlag*). The first-generation hybrid, *khainag*, is more common than the next generation, *ortoom*. In socialist literature on breeds *erliiz* is usually referred to hybrids between different breeds of the same species of livestock, rather than cross-species hybrids like *khainag*.

⁴⁰⁵ D. Tseveenzhav, *BNMAU-Yn Zootekhnikiin Alba, Shinzhlekh Ukhaany Khögzhilt* (Ulaanbaatar: Ulsyn Kheveleliin Gazar, 1983), 23.

⁴⁰⁶ Konagaya and Lkhagvasüren, *XX zuuny Mongolchuud* 2, 68; cf., *Socialist Devotees and Dissenters*, trans. Mary Rossabi, 84.

Altai, Tsigai, and Karakul sheep, and Don goats. In a conference in Buryatia, the Tsigai sheep were celebrated as well suited to both Buryatia and Mongolia. By September 1959 1,200 improved breed cattle, 200,000 improved and hybrid sheep, and 1,000 improved breed of goats were claimed to be in the collectives, excluding those in the state farms.⁴⁰⁷ Kazakh white headed cattle were held up as an example of improved livestock which were well suited to native environment.⁴⁰⁸ Between 1958-1960 the Soviet Union donated, along with tractors, combines, and other machines, ten million sheep and a million cattle.⁴⁰⁹ These sheep and cattle are almost certainly of the various Soviet created improved breeds. Between ten thousand and twenty thousand Karakul sheep were bred in the state farms to export their high-quality skins as well as for internal use for the military and high-ranking officials.⁴¹⁰ It seems that by the 1950s Mongolian leaders and veterinarians learned from their mistakes. These improved breeds were still primarily located the state farms and required more resources. But they certainly could survive in Mongolia with proper care.

In the 1959 Central Committee discussion on post-collectivization plans for sedentarization leaders were aware of the stationary nature of improved breeds but they framed this as a positive, rather than negative. According to the discussants, native breeds' required movement were in fact limitations. In contrast, non-*mal* livestock like pigs, poultry, and bees did not have to move and improved breeds lived in a shelter with fodder, and "have no need to move."⁴¹¹ This turns the now typical formulation on its head; instead of improved breeds being problems for not moving native breeds are problems because they have to move. While these

⁴⁰⁷ UTNONBBA, kh 4 d 1 khn 24, pg 77.

⁴⁰⁸ D Altangerel, D Gonchig, and Ch Khüleg, *Mal ürzhüüleg*, ed. Sh Sengee (Ulaanbaatar: BNMAU Ardyn Bolovsrolyn Iaamny Surakh Bichig, Setgüüliin Negdsen Redaktsyn Gazar, 1988), 264.

⁴⁰⁹ Bat-Ochir, *Ard angi*, 176.

⁴¹⁰ Konagaya and Lkhagvasüren, *XX zuuny Mongolchuud* 2, 124; cf., *Socialist Devotees and Dissenters*, 123.

⁴¹¹ UTNONBBA, kh 4 d 1 khn 24, pg 101.

plans were quietly put aside, seemingly due to the cost, the plan for increased fodder, shelter, water, and improved breeds continued.

A 1960 Ministry of Agriculture report on the 1957-1960 three-year plan approved by the head of the ministry Jagwaral primarily focused on the state of veterinary science.⁴¹² The report emphasizes the importance of state farms and the promotion and spread of improved breeds from the state farms to the collectives. From 1957 to 1960 the number of improved and hybrid breeds in state farms increased, with the number of cattle going from seven to fourteen percent and sheep increasing from thirty one to forty nine percent.⁴¹³ It makes clear the importance of the Soviet Union and other socialist states in importing improved breeds and states that in 1960 the Soviet Union donated 104 Altai rams and 712 Altai ewes, 100 Tsigai ewes, 497 Karakul rams and 1106 Karakul ewes, and 100 improved bulls and cows.⁴¹⁴ The various improved breed's yields of wool, milk, and meat are compared favorably against native breeds. However, the report found that "serious deficiencies were found in respect to livestock breeding in state farms."⁴¹⁵ The pace of breeding was too slow, and the warm buildings and fodder necessary for improved breeds were not adequately provided. With these problems facing even the state farms, which were supposed to be the highest quality of care, it is unsurprising that collectives could not have received large scale veterinary care or improved breeds right after collectivization in 1960. These documents show that ministry of agriculture and the leaders of the state farms were aware of the challenges facing improved breeds but saw the increased cost as worth the tradeoff of for the improved yields. Improved breeds were primarily located in the state farms but were planned to be spread to the collectives as well.

⁴¹² TBA, kh 15 d 1 khn 963, pg 1.

⁴¹³ TBA, f 15 d 1 khn 963, pg 10.

⁴¹⁴ TBA, f 15 d 1 khn 963, pg 10.

⁴¹⁵ TBA, f 15 d 1 khn 963, pg 19.

Hybridization was the solution to the problem of improved breeds' high resource requirements and inability to migrate, as well as the lower than planned placement of infrastructure. The creation of hybrid livestock consisted of mixing native breeds with improved breeds so that they could thrive in the Mongolian environment. This was not a "one and done" deal as different strains and mixes of hybrids continued to be produced. The most prominent example of the move towards improved breeds during the collectivization campaign is the Orkhon breed sheep which was the first official successful hybrid sheep bred in Mongolia. Other examples include the "Gobi Gurwan Saikhan" goat breed, the creation of which began in 1958 and consisted of hybridizing the Don goat with Mongolian.⁴¹⁶ Numerous other improved breeds were produced long after the socialist period ended but the Orkhon sheep is the first and most famous example.

The primary architect of the Orkhon sheep was T. Ayuurzana, one of the first zootechnicians in Mongolia. Ayuurzana started writing on improved breeds with the 1944 journal article "Wool is Gold," the same name of a famous campaign at the same time to improve wool production.⁴¹⁷ The following year he also produced a work on winter disasters, showing again the close connection between the projects to improve livestock. Work to create the breed began in 1947 in the Orkhon state farm in Selenge. In 1953 and 1954 Tsigai sheep from Saratov oblast along with eleven rams and nineteen female lambs of the Altai breed from Altai oblast were imported.⁴¹⁸ These sheep were the most popular Soviet breeds to import, with 500 Tsigai ewes arriving in 1956, and from 1955-1956 400 female lambs of the Altai breed.⁴¹⁹ From 1955 to 1959 these breeds were mixed with Pr  coce, Merino, and Mongolian sheep to

⁴¹⁶ Altangerel, Gonchig, and Kh  leg, *Mal   rzh  leg*, 269.

⁴¹⁷ Ts. Arvii, *Orkhon uuldriin khon'* (Ulaanbaatar: Ulsyn Khevreliin Gazar, 1978), 8.

⁴¹⁸ Arvii, *Orkhon uuldriin khon'*, 14.

⁴¹⁹ Arvii, *Orkhon uuldriin khon'*, 26.

ultimately make the Orkhon sheep. In 1961 this breed was officially recognized and named Orkhon breed sheep.

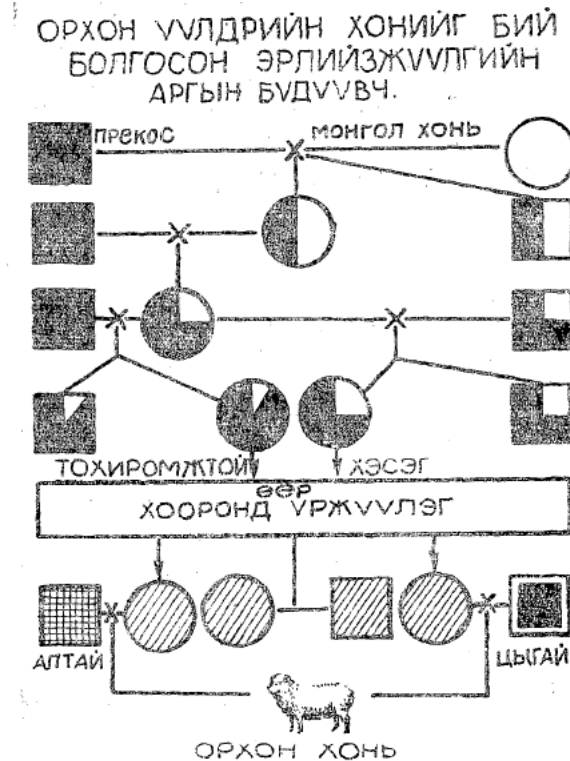
At the time as well as in later works Orkhon sheep are praised at being well suited to the Mongolian environment and possessing both native breed's hardiness with the meat and wool of improved breeds.⁴²⁰ Owen Lattimore was impressed by this breed during his visit in 1961 and states that they have superior meat and wool as well as being well suited to the environment.⁴²¹ After the creation of the breed, Ayuurzana traveled to the Soviet Union, as well as Brazil and Australia (a famously sheep heavy country) to lecture on his work on the Orkhon sheep which again demonstrates the international nature of the hybridization mission.⁴²² Ayuurzana was a prominent example of a Mongolian in the "driver's seat" of building new socialist Mongolian breed. Hybrids were not a foreign imposition, but rather a Mongolian led initiative that engaged with global trends. Ayuurzana also serves as a prominent example of the first generation of Mongolian veterinary scientists.

⁴²⁰ Arvii, *Orkhon uuldriin khon*’, 59 ; D. Tseveenzhav, *BNMAU-Yn Zootekhnikiin Alba, Shinzhlekh Ukhaany Khögzhilt* (Ulaanbaatar: Ulsyn Kheveleliin Gazar, 1983), 119.

⁴²¹ Owen Lattimore, *Nomads and Commissars: Mongolia Revisited* (New York: Oxford University Press, 1962), 45.

⁴²² Arvii, *Orkhon uuldriin khon*’, 11.

Fig. 1 Orkhon Sheep Hybrid Graph⁴²³



The above picture, from the 1988 Mongolian text *Livestock Breeding (Mal үрzhүүleg)* by D. Altangerel, D. Gonchig, and Ch. Khüleg, shows the detailed crossing of breeds that produced the Orkhon breed sheep. At the top, the Précoc breed was bred with native Mongolian sheep, and then eventually over the generations combined with Altai and Tsigai breeds to create the Orkhon sheep at the bottom. The presence of this table shows the importance of the Orkhon sheep as a flagship hybrid breed twenty-eight years after the completion of the breed.

Ts. Lookhuuz, the director of state farms from 1956 to 1962, goes into great detail of the program on improved breeds, especially the Orkhon sheep, in his interview with Yuki Konagaya and I. Lkhagwasüren.⁴²⁴ In 1963 Lookhuuz was removed from power and sent into the

⁴²³ Altangerel, Gonchig, and Khüleg, *Mal үрzhүүleg*, 267.

⁴²⁴ Konagaya and Lkhagvasüren, *XX зууны Монголчууд* 2, 68; cf., *Socialist Devotees and Dissenters*, trans. Mary Rossabi, 84.

countryside for challenging Tsedenbal's authority.⁴²⁵ It is therefore no surprise that Lookhuuz appears nowhere in the history of the Orkhon sheep published in 1978.⁴²⁶ Lookhuuz discusses at length the increased requirements for foreign breeds and explains that while Mongolian breeds can move and graze, foreign breeds cannot and require shelters during the winter.⁴²⁷ His evaluation fits with the general agreement that foreign breeds are more expensive to keep than Mongolian breeds.

Lookhuuz oversaw work on the creation of hybrid breeds as the director of state farms. Improved breeds had finer wool than Mongolian sheep and he stated "it was possible in state farms to provide constant fodder and warm shelters" for these improved breeds and that eventually collectives would be able to as well.⁴²⁸ The crowning achievement of these efforts was the Orkhon sheep but in one instance it did not get the reaction they hoped for. Lookhuuz recalls that there was a large celebration and ceremony to honor Ayuurzana and the other zootechnicians that worked on the Orkhon sheep. As the Chairman of the Presidium J. Sambuu was presented with a boiled Orkhon sheep in the celebration, even though the Orkhon sheep's primary purpose was fine wool rather than high quality meat.⁴²⁹ After two bites Sambuu stopped and asked, "is this dog-tailed sheep meat?"⁴³⁰ Lookhuuz points out that the Orkhon sheep's tail is shaped like a dog's tail, unlike the Mongolian sheep's tail which are round and fat and a beloved food item. Lookhuuz opines that the meat of Mongolian sheep is better than hybrid sheep

⁴²⁵ Konagaya and Lkhagvasüren, *XX zuuny Mongolchuud* 2, 128; cf. Rossabi, *Socialist Devotees and Dissenters*, 125-126.

⁴²⁶ Ts. Arvii, *Orkhon uuldriin khon'* (Ulaanbaatar: Ulsyn Kheveliin Gazar, 1978).

⁴²⁷ Konagaya and Lkhagvasüren, *XX zuuny Mongolchuud* 2, 128; cf. Rossabi, *Socialist Devotees and Dissenters*, 125-126.

⁴²⁸ Konagaya and I. Lkhagvasüren, *XX zuuny Mongolchuud* 2, 88; cf. Rossabi, *Socialist Devotees and Dissenters*, 98.

⁴²⁹ Konagaya and I. Lkhagvasüren, *XX zuuny Mongolchuud* 2, 120; cf. Rossabi, *Socialist Devotees and Dissenters*, 121.

⁴³⁰ Konagaya and I. Lkhagvasüren, *XX zuuny Mongolchuud* 2, 120; cf. Rossabi, *Socialist Devotees and Dissenters*, 121.

because Mongolian sheep grew used to their environment over thousands of years. Despite this explanation, Lookhuuz says he was “greatly upset” for many days by the “very unfortunate thoughtless words” because of the years of work poured into the hybrid sheep by him and many specialists.⁴³¹ This anecdote does not only show the question of quality of hybrid livestock, but it is also evidence that hybrids are “other.” Real native Mongolian sheep have fat tails; sheep that does not have a fat tail is not just strange, it is not a real sheep. Dog eater is also an insult hurled against Chinese people by Mongolians.⁴³² The fact that this is coming from Sambuu, who advocated so strongly for improved and hybrid breeds in his handbook, makes the story even more notable. This is perhaps explained by that like B. Rinchen as the co-author of the previous 1945 edition of *Advice*, a similar ghost or co-writer was employed in the 1956 edition, though in this case they were uncredited.⁴³³ It also shows that despite the progressive mission of socialism, socialist leaders still had some deeply held conservative views about livestock and proper food.

By contrast, Namkhainyambuu, the highly decorated sheep herder discussed in chapter one, spoke very highly of hybrid breeds, in particular his homeland’s Sartuul breed which was created from 1968 to 1971.⁴³⁴ He sang the praises of Sartuul sheep in his national question and answer newspaper column, and asserted that “our “Sartuul sheep” is suited to our homeland’s water and pasture, the flocks are selected and adapted.”⁴³⁵ As a highly trained and decorated herder, Namkhainyambuu certainly was well situated to evaluate the quality of the breed. One

⁴³¹ Konagaya and I. Lkhagvasüren, *XX zuuny Mongolchuud* 2, 121; cf. Rossabi, *Socialist Devotees and Dissenters*, 121.

⁴³² For discussions of Mongolian attitudes towards Chinese foods, see Uradyn Erden Bulag, *Nationalism and Hybridity in Mongolia*, Oxford Studies in Social and Cultural Anthropology (New York: Oxford University Press, 1998) and Franck Billé, *Sinophobia: Anxiety, Violence, and the Making of Mongolian Identity* (Honolulu: University of Hawai‘i Press, 2015).

⁴³³ For a detailed recounting of Sambuu and his contribution to the 1945 volume, see (in Japanese) Urenceceg. “Sambuu and His Book Advice to the Nomadic Herder : A Study of the Nomadic Life in Mongolia.” *Intercultural Studies*, no. 47 (March 2013): 221–58.

⁴³⁴ Namkhainiambuu, *Khoniny Khishig*, 67, c.f. Namkhainiambuu, *Bounty From the Sheep*, 75.

⁴³⁵ Namkhainiambuu, *Khoniny Khishig*, 67, c.f. Namkhainiambuu, *Bounty From the Sheep*, 75.

could dismiss his words as mere propaganda, but given his praise of the breed in his autobiography that was published after socialism, and his general enthusiasm for the socialist project, it is fair to assume that this reflected his experience and opinion. The Sartuul breed continues to be a popular one in its Zawkhan province homeland, further proof of that Namkhainyambuu's assertion of its suitability is accurate.

Zootechnicians were responsible for breeding improved and new hybrid breeds of livestock. Although connected, zootechnicians and veterinarians were ranked differently, and ultimately had different missions. Veterinarians were there to treat existing flocks, while zootechnicians intended to create better flocks. State farms had the largest concentration of improved and hybrid breeds, so that is where most zootechnicians were located. Some collectives did have zootechnicians, but this was rare especially in the early days of the collectives. D. Tsedew was the first Mongolian trained to be a zootechnician in 1946.⁴³⁶ The first congress of zootechnicians was held in 1957 during the period of increased emphasis on hybrids and improved breeds.⁴³⁷

Table 8. Working Zootechnicians in Mongolia⁴³⁸

Year	Higher Education	Secondary Education	All
1940	N/A	8	8
1945	N/A	60	60
1950	35	135	170
1955	85	151	236
1960	102	225	327
1965	355	419	774
1970	522	521	1043
1975	622	864	1486

⁴³⁶ D. Tseveenzhav, *BNMAU-yn Zootekhnikiiin Alba, Shinzhlekh Ukhaany Khögzhilt* (Ulaanbaatar: Ulsyn Kheveleliin Gazar, 1983), 86.

⁴³⁷ D. Tseveenzhav, *BNMAU-yn Zootekhnikiiin Alba, Shinzhlekh Ukhaany Khögzhilt* (Ulaanbaatar: Ulsyn Kheveleliin Gazar, 1983), 97.

⁴³⁸ D. Tseveenzhav, *BNMAU-yn Zootekhnikiiin Alba, Shinzhlekh Ukhaany Khögzhilt* (Ulaanbaatar: Ulsyn Kheveleliin Gazar, 1983), 195.

1980	757	987	1744
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In addition to breeding and designing new livestock types, zootechnicians were responsible for artificial insemination. The period of collectivization appears to be the height of artificial insemination, after 1965 the numbers of artificial inseminations dropped significantly. The one exception was goats, perhaps reflecting the increased importance of cashmere.

Table 9. Number of Artificial Inseminations in Mongolia⁴³⁹

Year	Cow	Sheep	Goat	All
1954	1,800	34,200	N/A	36,00
1960	23,700	713,200	16,800	753,700
1965	77,400	1,382,100	44,400	1,503,900
1970	37,700	707,600	24,800	770,100
1975	27,000	652,700	106,300	786,000
1980	45,000	705,300	149,600	900,300

The reason for this is unclear, though there is a correlation with decreased budget allocation in the national budget towards agricultural and rural spending. This, like the walk away from plans to heavily sedentarize, points to a retreat from the utopian view of the start of collectivization. Zootechnicians remained largely concentrated in state farms along with their improved and hybrid breeds, but some collectives eventually received some. Like veterinarians they were highly ranked members of the collective leadership.

Despite often being an object of ridicule, as in the anecdote about Sambuu's dismissal of the Orkhon sheep as dog tailed, and held as one of the major examples of the flaws of socialist herding in Greater Mongolia, improved and hybrid breeds were not a quixotic or foolish experiment blindly following in the model of the Soviet Union. By the time of the second

⁴³⁹ D. Tseveenzhav, *BNMAU-yn Zootekhnikiin Alba, Shinzhlekh Ukhaany Khögzhilt* (Ulaanbaatar: Ulsyn Khevelelin Gazar, 1983), 202.

collectivization campaign the attitude towards improved and hybrid breeds were clear headed and were bred to be adapted to the Mongolian environment. These efforts were part of the larger global movement of increasing livestock yields by breeding better animals. Although improved and hybrid breeds required more water, feed, and shelter, this was seen by Mongolian agricultural planners an acceptable tradeoff for increased yields. And hybrids, despite their otherness and perhaps inferior taste, were held up as the key to maximizing yields in a livestock-based economy, the necessary step to achieve socialism.

Conclusion

It is common to criticize the introduction of international scientific breeding techniques as impositions that erased Mongolian knowledge. But the historical evidence does not support this claim. First and foremost, the people implementing these techniques were Mongolians, in contrast to other regions in Greater Mongolia such as Buryatia and Inner Mongolia. Furthermore, it does not seem that local knowledge was truly discarded. Both high level officials such as Sambuu and Jagwaral worked to preserve aspects of traditional knowledge on breeding and disease, while melding these techniques with scientific veterinary care. And high-ranking herders like Namkhainyambuu emphasized both the in the field, close connection to livestock as well as the importance of having a trained corps of veterinarians. Veteran herders in at the time of collectivization lamented the decrease of traditional herding skills amongst the young and unskilled herders, identical contemporary complaints must be taken in the context of the long history of lamenting the decline of herding knowledge, rather than at face value.

Veterinary medicine was one of the major tools and measures of success for collectivization campaigns. Mongolia was part of a worldwide struggle to adapt improved breeds to local conditions was not unique to Mongolia, and should not be understood solely as a story of

Mongolian exceptionalism, nor socialist folly. While Mongolia's environment is certainly harsh to non-native livestock, the history of modern veterinary science is filled with similar examples around the world.

Veterinarians were an important cadre of socialist professionals who promoted the greater integration of the countryside with the state. Collective leaders and handbooks promoted collectives as offering superior veterinary care. Veterinarians would heal livestock when injured, and vaccines would prevent livestock from getting one of the many diseases that plagued Mongolian herds. These efforts did lead to eradicating cattle plague and decreasing the number of disease outbreaks. But newly formed collectives often lacked veterinarians and even after the end of collectivization veterinary care was often lacking.

Although often vilified as one of the major flaws of socialist livestock improved and hybrid breeds do not seem to be as useless as commonly thought. In the 1950s and 60s Mongolian leaders and veterinarians recognized the limitations the Mongolian environment places on livestock. Because plans called for a constant increase of fodder, shelters, and wells, the additional need of improved breeds and hybrids were less of an issue. It is only when the promised infrastructure never arrived or with the dissolution of infrastructure with de-collectivization that the limits of the various improved breeds became a major problem.

Hybrids were also not tossed out after the socialist era. The Orkhon sheep continues to be raised in Mongolia, with a dedicated and passionate social media presence on Facebook and Twitter.⁴⁴⁰ Charlotte Marchina points out that not only are there new breeds of hybrids, but that the majority of officially recognized livestock breeds were recognized after 1990.⁴⁴¹ She argues

⁴⁴⁰ Orkhon khoni, *Facebook*, <https://www.facebook.com/orkhonsheep>

⁴⁴¹ Charlotte Marchina, *Nomad's land: Éleveurs, animaux et paysage chez les peuples mongols*, (Zones Sensibles, 2019), 182-183.

that the specific livestock breed is seen to be far less important than the distinction of “Mongol” livestock and non-Mongol livestock. In contrast in Aga Buryatia there is far more emphasis on improved and hybrid breeds and their ability to adapt to local pastures which corresponds more with Mongolian socialist era rhetoric.⁴⁴²

With the dissolution of collectives after socialism funding for veterinary care was greatly decreased. There are still veterinarians including those that worked in collectives during the socialist period, however there are fewer serving a larger number of livestock. Some of these veterinarians were trained during the socialist era and lament the current state of veterinary care.⁴⁴³ Socialist veterinary care was not perfect, but it is hard to argue with the efficacy of vaccines against diseases.⁴⁴⁴ While I was in Mongolia there were numerous outbreaks of disease, especially hoof and mouth disease, and districts and regions were quarantined because of these outbreaks. But these quarantines were easy to circumvent because of the lack of central roads in the countryside. The lack of regular wide scale vaccinations obviously contributed to these outbreaks. Even cattle plague returned after socialism, though it was officially blamed on Tuvan and Buryat livestock crossing the border.⁴⁴⁵

Increased reliance on advanced veterinary care only became a major problem when the infrastructure of collectives that housed and spread Western-style techniques dissolved. As shown by Kathryn Verdery’s studies *Peasants Under Siege* (co-authored with Gail Kligman) and

⁴⁴² Charlotte Marchina, *Nomad’s land: Éleveurs, animaux et paysage chez les peuples mongols*, (Zones Sensibles, 2019), 184-186.

⁴⁴³ Nanjid, *The Oral History of Twentieth Century Mongolia*, http://amantuuh.socanth.cam.ac.uk/search/view_person.php?Person=990070 ; Norjmoo, *The Oral History of Twentieth Century Mongolia*, http://www.amantuuh.socanth.cam.ac.uk/search/view_person.php?Person=990247 ; Batbaatar ; *The Oral History of Twentieth Century Mongolia*, http://amantuuh.socanth.cam.ac.uk/search/view_person.php?Person=990417.

⁴⁴⁴ Despite what certain contemporary Americans may claim.

⁴⁴⁵ R. Sodnomdarjaa, Sh Tserendorj, and J. Bekhochir, “History of Rinderpest Control and Eradication in Mongolia,” *Mongolian Journal of Agricultural Sciences* 11, no. 2 (November 25, 2014): 178-179

The Vanishing Hectare, both the formation of the collective and their dissolution were disastrous to people in the countryside.⁴⁴⁶ Centralization and control creates suffering among herders and farmers, but the loss of the infrastructure that is created by those institutions also caused suffering. Veterinary science was a clear tool for building collectives, was far from perfect, and never reached the heights promised by socialist leaders. However, aspects like widespread vaccines and basic veterinary care made it one of the most successful aspects of collectivization.

⁴⁴⁶ Kligman and Verdery, *Peasants under Siege*; Verdery, *The Vanishing Hectare*.

Chapter 3

Zud, Drought, and Infrastructure

Introduction

Interviews of collective members, socialist publications, and archival documents show that *zud* (winter disaster) and *gan* (drought) were one of the major threats to livestock that leaders intended to address through collectivization. The socialist government's attempt to change the way Mongolians interacted with animals and the environment included making the livestock economy no longer subject to the worst elements of the Mongolian environment. Climatic disasters exist at the intersection between humans, livestock, and the environment which leaders aimed to transform through collectivization. As environmental historians like Christof Mauch and Christian Pfister argue, disasters must be understood as a social as well as environmental phenomena.⁴⁴⁷ This is true of winter disasters and drought in Mongolia as well. *Zuds* and droughts were traumatic events that became a standard way to date one's place in Mongolian history. Scholars, herders, and policy makers continue to debate the role and best response to *zuds* and droughts in contemporary Mongolia. To many Mongolians, the degree to which the government could contend with a disaster was a measure of success of that government.

There are multiple fundamental issues when discussing climatic disasters which the socialist government and leaders, as well as their neoliberal successors, had to wrestle with. First, there was the basic issue of definition: what counted as a winter disaster, and what counted as a drought? Second, what was the cause of death of the livestock in question? Was it truly because of the disaster, or for another reason? And perhaps most importantly, when a disaster occurred,

⁴⁴⁷ Christof Mauch and Christian Pfister, *Natural Disasters, Cultural Responses: Case Studies Toward a Global Environmental History* (Lexington Books, 2009).

who was to blame? Was it the herder who didn't work hard enough to protect their livestock?

The government for not having a robust safety net in place to mitigate loss from disaster? Or the government for simply allowing the disaster to occur in the first place? These questions were debated throughout the socialist era, as well as today, though it is almost always in implicit terms.

Disasters threatened the goal to maximize livestock production. Like diseases and wolves, disasters threatened the number of livestock. Unlike the move to create improved breeds, disaster preparedness was intended to protect existing livestock, rather than move to increase the quality of future livestock. Disasters were also a greater threat than the others to human life, though casualties from winter disasters were relatively rare. Socialist leaders agreed that natural disasters were a major problem and made it clear to herders that the government and the collective was the best way to protect from disasters, and planned to address disasters through a mixture of supportive policy and infrastructure. Hay collection for when fodder was not easily available, warm and covered *khashaa* (pens or shelters) for the winter, and wells for water during droughts were all integral elements of the collectivization effort. The government at every level was also supposed to work together to alleviate disasters, though this was easier said than done.

Disasters also often created or emphasized class divisions, which collectivization aimed to erase. In pre-socialist Mongolian society, those that lost their livestock in disaster would end up as hired help for more wealthy herders.⁴⁴⁸ First and foremost, holding livestock collectively would prevent any one family from losing all their livestock in a disaster. As Tim Ingold argues, the possibility of disaster causes mass accumulation in pastoral economies, which certainly plays out in the case of Mongolia, where one of the main methods of combating climatic disaster was

⁴⁴⁸ Vreeland, *Mongol Community and Kinship Structure*, 90.

large scale accumulation of livestock.⁴⁴⁹ Once within the collective, *zud* was one of the only acceptable reasons for loss of livestock. Even then a herder often had to prove that it was not due to their negligence. Various disasters occurred during and immediately after collectivization, which tested the newly established system's efficacy. Combating disasters remains one of the most celebrated aspects of collectives.

Zud and Gan

Zud is a winter disaster that kills livestock, often by freezing pasture cover, and is known by a variation of the same Turco-Mongol word across Central Eurasia.⁴⁵⁰ Many Eurasian pre-modern and modern governments, including those in Central Eurasia, assumed responsibility for responding to weather disasters.⁴⁵¹ Thus, like all Central Eurasian countries, socialist Mongolia would have to deal with *zud* and *gan* one way or another—and be seen to be doing so. Opportunities to display this concern were not lacking; the country was plagued by multiple *zuds* and droughts, before and after collectivization.

There are a variety of *zuds*, including white *zud*, which features a great deal of snow, and black *zud*, which is defined by refrozen ice and a lack of snow. Common wisdom holds that a drought (*gan*) in the summer precedes a *zud* in the winter or spring. Troy Sternberg claims that this is a myth and deploys meteorological evidence to argue that *zud* and drought are in fact usually not linked.⁴⁵² However, *zud* and drought must be understood as a complex relationship

⁴⁴⁹ Tim Ingold, *Hunters, Pastoralists, and Ranchers: Reindeer Economics and Their Transformations*, Cambridge Studies in Social Anthropology (New York: Cambridge University Press, 1980), 202-203.

⁴⁵⁰ Charles R. Bawden, *Mongolian-English Dictionary*, (London ; New York : New York: K. Paul International ; Distributed by Columbia University, 1997), 180; Joseph Étienne Kowalewski, *Dictionnaire Mongol-Russe-Française*, (Kasan, 1844), 2385; Ia. Tsevel, *Mongol khelnii tovch tailbar tol': 30 000 Orchim üg*, ed. Kh Luvsanbaldan (Ulaanbaatar: Ulsyn khevleliin khereg erkhekh khoroo, 1966), 281.

⁴⁵¹ Andrea Janku, "'Heaven-Sent Disasters' in Late Imperial China: The Scope of the State and Beyond," ed. Christof Mauch and Christian Pfister (Lanham: Lexington Books, 2009), 233–64.

⁴⁵² Troy Sternberg, "Investigating the Presumed Causal Links between Drought and Dzud in Mongolia," *Natural Hazards* 92, no. 1 (November 1, 2018): 27.

between climate, pasture, livestock, and humans. A *zud* is only a *zud* if large amounts of livestock die across multiple provinces, and a drought is only a drought if it causes problems for watering and feeding livestock. Livestock poorly watered and fed in the summer are more likely to be vulnerable to snow and ice in the winter. Scientific data are important, but disasters are ultimately defined by the impact on herders and their livestock, not objective numbers of precipitation and temperature. If herders say that droughts precede *zud*, then there is clearly a strong correlation between them.

Another issue in the definition of *zud* is an official reluctance to use term during the later socialist era. As a rule, large scale, multi-*aimag* disasters were *zuds*, whereas more localized livestock loss were merely severe snowstorms. As discussed below provincial and party documents list thousands of livestock killed, but with the assurance that it was not a *zud*, but a snowstorm that killed the livestock. In a 1975 MPRP directive, Tsedenbal restricted the use of *zud* and *gan*, and justified this by claiming it ignored the fault of herders who allowed their livestock to die.⁴⁵³ This redefinition neatly removes government responsibility of disaster to place it solely on the individual, which played into a debate that occurred throughout the socialist period and continues today.

The word *zud* (Classical Mongolian *jud*) has a long history in Turco-Mongol languages. Otto Farkas and B. Kempf provide a history of the term, as well as a table of the Turco-Mongol (and Tajik) cognates for *zud*, demonstrating the term's wide use and stability of meaning of "winter disaster" over time.⁴⁵⁴ The earliest example *zud* in Mongolia is found in on the Türk

⁴⁵³ Farkas and Kempf, "Reinventing the 'Dzud,'" 144.

⁴⁵⁴ Otto Farkas and B. Kempf, "Reinventing the 'Dzud': Livestock Famine in 21st Century Mongolia: On the Contribution of the Altaic Civilization to the Glossary of International Humanitarian Assistance," *Continuity and Change in Central and Inner Asia*, 2002, 127–59.

ruler Bilge Qaghan's 735 C.E. stele along the Orkhon River.⁴⁵⁵ It is found in Mahmud Kashgari's 11th century compendium as *yut* as a winter disaster that kills livestock, almost identical to the modern definition of *zud*.⁴⁵⁶ As laid out by Farkas and Kempf, early mentions of the *zud* in the Mongolian Empire include a clear description of a winter disaster during Easter in Qaraqorum by William of Rubruck, indirect mentions in discussions of Mongol Imperial disaster relief by various sources including Marco Polo, while the first Mongolian language appearance in Chosgi-Odsir's Mongolian language commentary of *Bodhicaryavatara* printed in 1312.⁴⁵⁷ After the Mongol Empire, *zud* appears in various Middle Mongolian chronicles, including Saghang Sechen's *Precious Summary (Erdeni-yin Tobchi)* and Lubsang-Danzin's *Golden Summary (Altan Tobchi)*, in which *zud* always appears as the compound word *jud turqan* (*turkhan* means thin or emaciated).⁴⁵⁸

Droughts are a severe problem in Mongolia, though they often receive less attention than *zuds*. Loss of livestock due to *zud* or severe winter storm was closely monitored by provincial and district leaders in archival documents produced for consumption by the ministry of agriculture and party leaders, but the same was not true of droughts, in part because it was far easier to calculate the damage and loss of livestock caused by *zuds*. Droughts cause livestock

⁴⁵⁵ Otto Farkas and B. Kempf, "Reinventing the 'Dzud': Livestock Famine in 21st Century Mongolia: On the Contribution of the Altaic Civilization to the Glossary of International Humanitarian Assistance," *Continuity and Change in Central and Inner Asia*, 2002, 129.

⁴⁵⁶ Mahmūd al-Kāṣṣarī, *Compendium of the Turkic Dialects (Türk Şiveleri Lügati)*, vol. 2, edited and Translated by Robert Dankoff and James Kelly," (Cambridge: Harvard University 1982), 220; Gerhard Doerfer, *Türkische Und Mongolische Elemente Im Neupersischen: Unter Besonderer Berücksichtigung Älterer Neupersischer Geschichtsquellen, Vor Allem Der Mongolen- Und Timuridenzeit* vol 4., Akademie Der Wissenschaften Und Der Literatur. Veröffentlichungen Der Orientalischen Kommission, Bd. 16, etc (Wiesbaden: F. Steiner, 1963), entry 1191; Gerard Clauson, *An Etymological Dictionary of Pre-Thirteenth-Century Turkish* (Clarendon Press, 1972), 883.

⁴⁵⁷ Farkas and Kempf, "Reinventing the 'Dzud'," 130; Marco Polo and Sharon Kinoshita, *The Description of the World* (Indianapolis: Hackett Publishing Company, Inc, 2016), 90.

⁴⁵⁸ Farkas and Kempf, "Reinventing the 'Dzud'," 130; Sagan Setsen et al., *Erdeniin tovch* (Ulaanbaatar: Soyombo Printing, 2006), 30, 119; Charles R. Bawden, ed., *The Mongol Chronicle Altan Tobči*, Göttinger Asiatische Forschungen, Bd. 5 (Wiesbaden: O. Harrassowitz, 1955), 57, 85.

death but it is harder to pinpoint the exact cause of death. Nevertheless, socialist herders and planners were still acutely aware of the damage that droughts caused and promoted the collection of fodder and construction of wells to combat droughts.

Historically, weather was a tool that could be manipulated by certain people. Ádám Molnár's *Weather Magic in Inner Asia* provides a detailed history of the intentional manipulation of weather through various magical methods, most often through weather stones, among Turco-Mongolic peoples.⁴⁵⁹ He then provides more recent accounts in the 19th and 20th centuries, including Buryats, Oirats, Monguors, and Ordos Mongols.⁴⁶⁰ Though this list includes Oirats in Mongolia proper, Molnár does not include stories of Khalkha Mongol weather manipulation. The magical ill weather is known in Mongolian as *zad* (Classical *jada*), connected to the Turkic word as well.⁴⁶¹ Tibetan lamas, who were in close contact with Mongolian lamas, wrote texts explaining how to use weather magic during the Qing Empire.⁴⁶² When weather is a controllable element, it makes sense that the quality of a state would influence the weather. This idea was found in other neighboring societies that influenced and were influenced by Mongolia, like China.⁴⁶³

Recent studies of Mongolian climate history, usually utilizing dendrochronology, provides greater understanding of *zud* and drought history. The nineteenth century was an especially dry period with multiple severe droughts. These conditions caused multiple extreme

⁴⁵⁹ Ádám Molnár, *Weather-Magic in Inner Asia* (Indiana University, Research Institute for Inner Asian studies, 1994).

⁴⁶⁰ Molnár, *Weather-Magic in Inner Asia*, 96-103.

⁴⁶¹ Molnár, *Weather-Magic in Inner Asia*, 104.

⁴⁶² Hanung Kim, "Rainmakers for the Cosmopolitan Empire: A Historical and Religious Study of 18th Century Tibetan Rainmaking Rituals in the Qing Dynasty," *Religions* 11, no. 12 (2020): 630.

⁴⁶³ Andrea Janku, "'Heaven-Sent Disasters' in Late Imperial China: The Scope of the State and Beyond," ed. Christof Mauch and Christian Pfister (Lanham: Lexington Books, 2009), 233-64.

disasters which led to mass livestock loss.⁴⁶⁴ In comparison the 20th century saw increased precipitation in Mongolia, especially after the severe drought and *zud* of 1944-1945, though droughts were still a severe and common danger.⁴⁶⁵ As is the case with much of the world, the end of the 20th century and beginning of the 21st century has seen marked warming in Mongolia, exacerbating the impact of droughts and subsequent *zuds* in post-socialist Mongolia.⁴⁶⁶

In the mid-19th and early 20th century, local governments played an important role in disaster relief. According to the Diluwa Khutugtu, part of the responsibility of the monastery included disaster relief for the local *shaw*i (parishioners), as well as providing religious services designed to prevent and combat disasters.⁴⁶⁷ Ritual prayers (*magtaal* or *yörööl*) to rock cairns (*owoo*) often concerned with preventing calamity, which in many specifically includes *zud* and drought. Charles R. Bawden translates Buddhist rituals from the mid-19th century collected by Mergen Diyanchi Lama which were performed at an *owoo* for long life and rain, as well as to provide protection from demons, plagues, and to “avert evils of the type of wolves attacking the flocks, thieves and brigands stirring abroad, hail, drought or cattle-pest occurring.”⁴⁶⁸ Walther Heissig records multiple blessing prayers in his *The Religions of Mongolia*. The prayer to the black standard (*sülde*) of Chinggis Khan pleads

For the five kinds of herd-animal outside
No misfortune and no wild anger, drought or famine,
No great alarms,
No danger from wolf or dog, no danger from the evil enemy, thieves and brigands.⁴⁶⁹

⁴⁶⁴ N. K. Davi et al., “Extension of Drought Records for Central Asia Using Tree Rings: West-Central Mongolia,” *Journal of Climate* 19, no. 2 (January 2006): 296.

⁴⁶⁵ Gordon Jacoby et al., “Temperature and Precipitation in Mongolla Based on Dendroclimatic Investigations,” *IWA Journal* 20, no. 3 (1999): 346.

⁴⁶⁶ Nicole K. Davi et al., “A Long-Term Context (931–2005 CE) for Rapid Warming over Central Asia,” *Quaternary Science Reviews* 121 (2015): 89–97.

⁴⁶⁷ Herbert Harold Vreeland, *Mongol Community and Kinship Structure*, (Westport, Conn: Greenwood Press, 1973), 178.

⁴⁶⁸ C. R. Bawden, “Two Mongol Texts Concerning Obo-Worship,” *Oriens Extremus* 5, no. 1 (1958): 38-39.

⁴⁶⁹ Walther Heissig, *The Religions of Mongolia*, (Berkeley: University of California Press, 1980), 86, 94.

Other texts translated by Heissig include a fire ritual that has a “request to keep illnesses at a distance, to preserve from slippery ice and hunger, to prevent wolves and thieves from coming near, to protect from cattle-plague.”⁴⁷⁰ Socialist combinations of threats to society were common as well, as seen in the saying recorded by Tsewel, “the dog gets fat when there is a *zud*, the lama gets fat when there is suffering.”⁴⁷¹ This saying pairs classic socialist anti-religious sentiment with more practical herding concerns, and almost certainly refers to the fact that dogs would eat dead livestock, which would increase the problem of feral dogs, as discussed in chapter 4.

Inner Mongolia suffered from the same natural disasters as independent Mongolia. During the Qing empire, the imperial government often had to deal with disasters in Inner and Outer Mongolia. David Bello argues that disaster relief efforts by the Qing government to combat *zuds* and droughts in Inner Mongolia “in the form of grain and silver, as the main form of state disaster relief and debt recovery for continuously stricken Mongol herds unintentionally alienated people from their livestock.”⁴⁷² However, similar relief efforts were carried out in Khalkha Mongolia and were not unique to Inner Mongolia with its partial transition to farming. According to John Gombojab Hangin when wolves, weather, bandits, or disease threatened, Chakhar Inner Mongolians would hold special religious ceremonies to address these evils, likely similar to the owoo texts mentioned above.⁴⁷³ After the formation of the PRC, the communist government continued to deal with the same problems. Inner Mongolia suffered from a severe winter in 1957-1958 that might qualify as *zud*.⁴⁷⁴ In addition, the sudden 1964 February blizzard

⁴⁷⁰ Heissig, *The Religions of Mongolia*, 75.

⁴⁷¹ Ia. Tsevel, *Mongol khelnii tovch tailbar tol': 30 000 orchim üg*, ed. Kh Luvsanbaldan (Ulaanbaatar: Ulsyn Khevreliin Khereg erkhlekh khoroo, 1966), 281.

⁴⁷² David Anthony Bello, *Across Forest, Steppe and Mountain: Environment, Identity and Empire in Qing China's Borderlands*, Studies in Environment and History (New York: Cambridge University Press, 2016), 14.

⁴⁷³ Herbert Harold Vreeland, *Mongol Community and Kinship Structure* (Westport, Conn: Greenwood Press, 1973), 127.

⁴⁷⁴ David Sneath, *Changing Inner Mongolia: Pastoral Mongolian Society and the Chinese State*, Oxford Studies in Social and Cultural Anthropology (Oxford: Oxford University Press, 2000), 82.

that features in the Inner Mongolian political parable “Little Heroic Sisters of the Grassland” examined by Uradyn Bulag, can perhaps be placed on the continuum of *zud*.⁴⁷⁵ However, as *zud* is a social construction, it is very possible these examples were simply “severe snowstorms.” As in the PRC, MPRP leaders sometimes positioned climatic disasters as an obstacle that could be easily overcome with enough labor, as in the “Little Heroic Sisters of the Grassland.”⁴⁷⁶

In the Soviet Union, neighboring Turkic and Mongol herding lands also contended with *zud* and drought. S. I. Vainshtein discusses climate disaster in Tuva, and highlights a lack of fodder to combat winter disaster, and mentions a notable winter disaster between 1933-1934 which caused 100,000 livestock deaths, between 15-17 percent of the total livestock.⁴⁷⁷ However, the date of this disaster right after the Soviet collectivization campaign must be noted, so the loss of livestock was almost certainly a combination of climatic and human disaster. Again, there is a strong parallel in Mongolia, as the 1944-1945 drought and *zud* is often held up as among the worst examples of climatic disaster, but it was greatly exacerbated by the large amount of supplies sent to the Soviet Union to support their efforts in World War II.

The Kazakh *zhūt* has received some attention by scholars, in particular Ian Campbell and Sarah Cameron. Campbell explores the Russian Imperial efforts to create disaster relief in the conquered Kazakh steppe⁴⁷⁸ Campbell argues that before the conquest Kazakhs suffered less from *zhūt* thanks to the ability to migrate large distances, the equivalent of the Mongolian *otor*, to find food, and that the Russian conquests limited the amount that they could move to new

⁴⁷⁵ Uradyn Bulag, *The Mongols at China's Edge: History and the Politics of National Unity*, World Social Change (Lanham: Rowman & Littlefield Publishers, 2002), 183.

⁴⁷⁶ Bulag, *The Mongols at China's Edge*, 183.

⁴⁷⁷ S. I. (Sev'ian Izrailevich) Vainshtein, *Nomads of South Siberia: The Pastoral Economies of Tuva*, Cambridge Studies in Social Anthropology; 25. (Cambridge: Cambridge Univ. Press, 1980), 80.

⁴⁷⁸ Ian Campbell, ““The Scourge of Stock Raising’: Zhūt, Limiting Environments, and the Economic Transformation of the Kazakh Steppe” in *Eurasian Environments: Nature and Ecology in Imperial Russian and Soviet History*, ed. Nicholas B. Breyfogle, Pitt Series in Russian and East European Studies (Pittsburgh: University of Pittsburgh Press, 2018), 60.

pastures. To many Russian bureaucrats, sedentarization and agriculture was the best way to proactively address disasters, as well as societal problems among the Kazakhs. In contrast others argued reform of pastoralism was needed, by creating policies to address major livestock loss such as *zhūt*, drought, wolves, and disease, the same problems collectivization were to address, with similar methods including hay collection.⁴⁷⁹

Sarah Cameron shows that while some early Soviet Kazakh leaders tried to defend nomadism, by 1930 Soviet thinkers instead declared nomadism was a backward and inefficient lifestyle, and cited the vulnerability to drought, *zhūt*, and disease as proof.⁴⁸⁰ According to mainstream Soviet thought, herding was at the mercy of climatic disasters, whereas settled socialist society would overcome it. Kazakh collectivization and *zhūt* contributed to the migration from Kazakhstan to Xinjiang to western Mongolia. As in Tuva at the same time, a winter disaster conveniently shifts blame from the disastrous government policy. Soviet efforts at farming on the steppe, most notably the Virgin Land Campaigns, often encountered droughts and other climatic disasters, which caused a great deal of debate between Soviet scholars over the role of humans and the environment in disasters.⁴⁸¹ Central Eurasian governments, whether imperial or socialist, have had to deal with winter disasters and drought one way or another.

***Zud*, and Numbers of Livestock Deaths**

After a *zud* occurs, one of the government's major responsibilities was to count the number of livestock killed during the disaster. Although at first glance this would appear to be an objective fact, and the government portrayed it as such, in fact the contradictory numbers

⁴⁷⁹ Campbell, "'The Scourge of Stock Raising,'" 70

⁴⁸⁰ Sarah Cameron, *The Hungry Steppe: Famine, Violence, and the Making of Soviet Kazakhstan* (Ithaca New York: Cornell University Press, 2018), 65; Alun Thomas, *Nomads and Soviet Rule: Central Asia under Lenin and Stalin* (Bloomsbury Publishing, 2018), 35-36.

⁴⁸¹ Marc Ellie, "'Desiccated Steppes: Droughts and Climate Change in the USSR, 1960s-1980s'" in *Eurasian Environments: Nature and Ecology in Imperial Russian and Soviet History*, ed. Nicholas B. Breyfogle, Pitt Series in Russian and East European Studies (Pittsburgh: University of Pittsburgh Press, 2018), 75.

provided in publications demonstrate that number of livestock deaths are subjective. One of the difficulties in evaluating livestock loss is that would certainly be in the interest of herders to have as many head of livestock counted as lost from *zud* in order to maximize government support they would receive, while governments would want as low a count as possible. While exact numbers of livestock death differ based on the source, the trends are the same.

Farkas and Kempf provide detailed information about *zuds* in modern Mongolia, including the coverage of *zuds*, adult and young livestock loss, and the percentage of total livestock loss. Their numbers derive from the Mongolian governmental resolution detailing the loss from *zud* over the years. Farkas and Kempf's numbers also include separate numbers of young livestock killed, which are especially at risk from *zuds*. This follows a common trend in documenting loss livestock, often include separate numbers of adult and young livestock.

Table 11. Losses to livestock due to *zud* and drought⁴⁸²

Year	Type of Disaster	Number of Provinces Impacted	Animal Mortality			
			Adult Stock		Young stock	
			# (mil.)	%	# (mil)	%
1944/1945	Drought and <i>zud</i>	9	8.1	33.2	1.1	17
1954/1955	<i>zud</i>	9	1.9	8.2	0.3	4
1956/1957	<i>zud</i>	11	1.5	6.2	0.9	12
1967/1968	Drought and <i>zud</i>	13	2.7	11.9	1.7	21.6
1976/1977	<i>zud</i>	15	2	8.6	1.6	10.7
1986/1987	<i>zud</i>	1	0.8	3.6	0.9	9
1993/1994	<i>zud</i>	3	1.6	6.4	1.2	13
1996/1997	<i>zud</i>	11	0.6	2.1	0.5	5.4
1999/2000	Drought and <i>zud</i>	12	3	3	1.2	12.1

⁴⁸² Farkas and Kempf, "Reinventing the 'Dzud,'" 143.

These figures are contradicted by figures from the Mongolian National Statistics Office found in Maria Fernández-Giménez’s World Bank sponsored “Lessons from the Dzud” publication, which are repeated in Middleton et al.⁴⁸³

Table 12. Recorded Major Disasters

Year	Type	Livestock Deaths (mil.)
1944/1945	Drought and <i>zud</i>	8.6
1954/1955	<i>zud</i>	1.8
1956/1957	<i>zud</i>	1
1967/1968	Drought and <i>zud</i>	3.8
1976/1977	<i>zud</i>	4.1
1986/1987	<i>zud</i>	0.8
1993/1994	<i>zud</i>	0.8
1996/1997	<i>zud</i>	0.7
1999/2000	Drought and <i>zud</i>	2.6
2000/2001	Drought and <i>zud</i>	4.8
2001/2002	Drought and <i>zud</i>	3.4
2009/2010	Drought and <i>zud</i>	10.3

The difference in numbers is because Fernández-Giménez’s figures come from the Mongolian National Statistics Office, while Farkas and Kempf’s comes from a separate Mongolian governmental resolution detailing the loss from *zud* over the years.⁴⁸⁴

Yet another set of numbers are found in Töwdiin Semchin’s *Mal aj akhui, ediin zasag* in a series of tables.⁴⁸⁵ In these tables he notes which 12-year animal cycle the *zud* took place. This is in part because there is a saying that monkey years are especially bad for *zuds*, and indeed the 1944, 1956, and 1967 *zuds* all fell on monkey years.

⁴⁸³ Maria E. Fernández-Giménez, Batbuyan Batjav, and Batkhishig Baival, “Lessons from the Dzud : Adaptation and Resilience in Mongolian Pastoral Social-Ecological Systems” (The World Bank, August 1, 2012), 19; Nick Middleton et al., “Explaining Spatial Variations in Climate Hazard Impacts in Western Mongolia,” *Landscape Ecology* 30, no. 1 (2015): 94.

⁴⁸⁴ Fernández-Giménez, et al., “Lessons from the Dzud” 19; Farkas and B. Kempf, “Reinventing the ‘Dzud,’” 143.

⁴⁸⁵ Tövdiiin Semchin, *Mongolyn mal azh akhui, ediin zasag* (Ulaanbaatar: “Tod bichig” KhKhK ekhiig beltgezkh kevlev, 2017), 427-433

Table 13. Loss of Livestock in *zud* (per thousand head) ⁴⁸⁶

	1944-1945 Monkey Year	1967-1968 Monkey Year	1976-1977 Dragon Year	2009-2010 Cow Year
Large Livestock Loss	7543.3	1736	1960	10319.9
Young Livestock Loss	10940	1659	1600	3441.9
Pregnant Loss	581	823.9	790	1904.8
All	9218.3	4218.9	4350	15666.6

While Semchin does not provide numbers for as many *zuds* as the other sources, he provides other information, such as the temperature during the *zud*, number of *aimags* impacted, loss in *tögrögs*, and length of time to recovery. He also includes a separate table of loss of livestock from 2000-2010 from disasters. The greater information from the 21st century certainly is in part because more granular information was easily available. It also suggests that Semchin, like many 21st century Mongolians, sees the socialist period as having a higher standard of living and higher quality of livestock care than the post-socialist period. Semchin's book is filled with advice from award winning socialist-era herders, rather than post-socialist herders. This attitude that older, more experienced herders have greater insight than younger herders was present in the socialist era as well. The sense of declining quality of herding knowledge seems to be pervasive through the 20th and 21st century.

Table 14. 2000-2010 Livestock number loss from disaster (per thousand head) ⁴⁸⁷

Year	Total	Camel	Horse	Cattle	Sheep	Goat

⁴⁸⁶ Semchin, *Mongolyn mal azh akhui, ediin zasag*, 430.

⁴⁸⁷ Semchin, *Mongolyn mal azh akhui, ediin zasag*, 432-433

2000	2719.6	79	214	585.9	1158.5	682.2
2001	1840.7	63	261.1	299.4	704.7	512.5
2002	1630.2	12.4	97.9	82.9	655.9	781.1
2003	643.3	1.1	65.9	107.6	267.9	200.9
2004	39.6	0.2	3.4	4.6	17.3	14.2
2005	123.5	0.4	5.1	10.4	48.6	59.1
2006	73	0.5	5	5.2	29	33.3
2007	43.8	0.2	2.9	3.8	20.1	16.8
2008	695.1	1.2	50.8	52.5	285.2	305.4
2009	1597.8	2.6	55.8	94.9	624.9	819.6
2010	10167.9	16.5	364.2	561.4	4299.5	4926.3
Average (2001-2010)	1778.5	15.1	102.4	164.4	737.4	759.2

Certain trends can be seen from the statistics. Most years in which a *zud* occurred a drought proceeded it, reflecting the common wisdom of Mongolian herders. The number of livestock deaths reveal that the pre-collective 1944-1945 drought and *zud* was indeed one of the deadliest *zuds*, although the lack of earlier disaster numbers and the increased difficulties and loss from World War II does not make it a normal *zud*, if such a thing could be said to exist. The differing numbers speak both to the difficulty in counting livestock loss from disaster, as well as whether or not the kinds of livestock should be differentiated when calculating loss. The low number of livestock death in the 1960s and 1970s should be accepted with caution, as the policy during that time was to minimize the role of *zud*. Perhaps the numbers would have been higher if different policies were in place. That said, socialist leaders were interested in knowing how many

livestock died, which is likely why *zuds* were still acknowledged and monitored, even if their severity and importance were downplayed.

Combating Disasters Before the Revolution

Pre-revolutionary Mongolians made efforts to prepare for disaster by creating infrastructure, like later socialists. Hay was collected, shelters for livestock were constructed, and wells were dug. Wells required the most amount of cooperation and labor, in contrast to hay collection and pen construction which could be carried out by individuals. The wells that did exist in pre-socialist Mongolia were often located in summer pastures, for example those in the highlands.⁴⁸⁸ Many of these infrastructural improvements would have been improved the rearing of improved breeds as well. Despite the common image of a pure wandering herder relying on pastureland, hay collection pre-dated socialist Mongolia. “Busybody” Sharaw’s famous painting “One Day in Mongolia” depicts hay mowing among its daily activities.⁴⁸⁹

Pre-revolutionary Mongolians in Outer and Inner Mongolia collected hay in different amounts depending on the region. In the Diluwa Khutugtu’s monastic holding Narobanchin in modern Zaw Khan, poorer Mongols often harvested hay to sell for better off herders.⁴⁹⁰ According to John Gombojaw Hangin, herders in his homeland of Taibas in Chakhar Inner Mongolia relied heavily on hay collection for every type of livestock.⁴⁹¹ Family members and hired hands cut hay, usually in August, with larger herds requiring the most amount of fodder. Families made claim on customary use on hay pastures to harvest, which according to Hangin often led to conflict both between both insiders and outsiders. Similarly, Vainshtein shows

⁴⁸⁸ Vreeland, *Mongol Community and Kinship Structure*, 43.

⁴⁸⁹ Uranchimeg Tsultemin, “Cartographic Anxieties in Mongolia: The Bogd Khan’s Picture-Map,” *Cross-Currents: East Asian History and Culture Review* 1, no. 21 (2016), 66-88.

⁴⁹⁰ Herbert Harold Vreeland, *Mongol Community and Kinship Structure* (Westport, Conn: Greenwood Press, 1973), 141.

⁴⁹¹ Vreeland, *Mongol Community and Kinship Structure*, 145.

before socialism Tuvans collected hay in preparation from disasters and strongly refutes common claims to the contrary.⁴⁹² Vainshtein's work reveals a major tension within socialist historiography: pre-socialist (and in the Tuvan case, pre-Russian) society was backwards, and advanced infrastructure was a socialist innovation. The tricky balancing act of acknowledging the existence of pre-socialist disaster mitigation at the same time as the clear superiority of the socialist system's creation of infrastructure was walked by socialist Mongolian activists and historians as well.

Pre-socialist Mongolians utilized various forms of fences and stalls. Community leaders organized construction of fences, sometimes with corvée labor.⁴⁹³ Wealthy Mongols in Khalkha and Chakhar Inner Mongolia were more likely to own fences and stalls and served as major markers of wealth along with the most basic form of livestock wealth.⁴⁹⁴ Corrals were most commonly used for sheep, rather than larger livestock, with the sheep grazing in the pasture during the day and herded back into the corral during the night. In the Diluwa Khutugtu's lands, corrals were often permanent in winter pastures, which also served as claim markers of ownership.⁴⁹⁵ This did not completely prevent conflict, and camps would claim and repair unmarked fences for their own use.⁴⁹⁶ Permanent winter corrals limited winter movement, in contrast to the fenceless summer pastures.⁴⁹⁷ Chakhar corrals were wooden, in contrast to the stone *gobi* corrals, with high walls to protect from wolf predation. Wealthy herders had private corrals versus the poorer communal corrals, where sheep were kept during the night.⁴⁹⁸

⁴⁹² Vainshtein, *Nomads of South Siberia*, 80, 82.

⁴⁹³ Vreeland, *Mongol Community and Kinship Structure*, 192.

⁴⁹⁴ Vreeland, *Mongol Community and Kinship Structure*, 31.

⁴⁹⁵ Vreeland, *Mongol Community and Kinship Structure*, 34.

⁴⁹⁶ Vreeland, *Mongol Community and Kinship Structure*, 44.

⁴⁹⁷ Vreeland, *Mongol Community and Kinship Structure*, 43.

⁴⁹⁸ Vreeland, *Mongol Community and Kinship Structure*, 146.

Vainshtein shows that Tuva followed the same trends, with fences and covered stalls created before the socialist era.⁴⁹⁹

The 1944-1945 Disasters

Historical records for socialist-era *zuds* tend to start with the major disasters in 1944 and 1945, but there were devastating disasters in previous decades. On September 17th, 1935, Simukov was told by the governor of South Gobi province that they were suffering from a long-lasting drought which affected sixty percent of the province.⁵⁰⁰ To prevent starvation, Ulaanbaatar sent 1,000 camels to transport flour and millet which Simukov attributes to the difficulty in traveling via truck from the capital. Rather than using the Mongolian word *gan* for drought, Simukov uses *zud* (*tszud*) which he translates as drought (*zasukha*). Given the conversation is occurring in September, the disaster in question was certainly a drought. The reason for this apparent error is unclear; perhaps in the Russian translation style at the time *zud* was defined as any type of climatic disaster, or the governor was using a term he knew would be understood as disaster by his audience.

In 1944 and 1945, there was an extreme drought followed by a *zud*. Ten years later during the collectivization campaign it was referenced both as an important example of the Mongolian People's Republic's response to disaster before collectivization and as a rallying cry for why collectivization was desperately needed. According to Jagwaral the disaster killed a fifth of the country's livestock, whereas Farkas and Kempf reports that 33.2% of the livestock was lost, but they express skepticism at the number.⁵⁰¹ To address this disaster 19,143 sheep, 1,900

⁴⁹⁹ Vainshtein, *Nomads of South Siberia*, 80, 82.

⁵⁰⁰ A. D. Simukov et al., *Trudy o Mongolii i dlia Mongolii*, vol 3 part 1, Senri Ethnological Reports 74 (Osaka: The National Museum of Ethnology, 2008), 506.

⁵⁰¹ N. Zhagvaral, *Aratstvo i aratskoe khoziaistvo* (Ulan-Bator: Akademiia Nauk Mongol'skoi Narodnoi Respubliki, 1974), 48; Farkas and B. Kempf, "Reinventing the 'Dzud,'" 143.

horses, 808 cows, and 621 goats, in total 22,473 livestock, were allocated to help people impacted by the *zud* across Middle Gobi, Sükhbaatar, Khentii, Gobi-Altai, Bayankhongor, and South Khangai provinces.⁵⁰² In Bayankhongor and Sükhbaatar alone, 540 camps (*ail*) in eight districts (*sum*) received over 15,700 head of livestock between October 1945 and February 1946. These livestock were lent for zero interest and had to be repaid in ten years for the small livestock, and fifteen years for the large livestock.⁵⁰³ The high number of livestock allocated to Bayankhongor and Sükhbaatar, 15,700 out of 22,473, meant that there would be only be 6,773 animals left for Middle Gobi, Khentii, Gobi-Altai, and South Khangai, which hardly seems adequate to alleviate the loss of livestock.

Many older Mongolians interviewed by *The Oral History of Twentieth Century Mongolia* mention the 1944/45 *zud* when recounting their youth. The severity of the *zud*, and its occurrence at the same time as World War II, means it is a major date in most people's lives. Some of the interviewees misremembered the exact Gregorian year that the *zud* occurred but they did recall it was a monkey year, in reference to the accepted relation between the monkey year and severe *zuds*.⁵⁰⁴ Dulamjav from Khovd province's family lost most of their livestock and "people's quality of life sharply declined" after the *zud*.⁵⁰⁵ Tarajaw dated his time in school as during "the monkey year *zud*," at the same time as World War II, and described it as a "terrible *zud*" which interrupted his studies.⁵⁰⁶ Lkhagwaa recalled the difficulties of the first five-year plan and the threats to livestock, including wolf predation and *zud*. Lkhagwaa says that he was 13 in the *zud* of 1942 (almost certainly misremembering the *zud* of 1944/45), when their livestock was

⁵⁰² L. Bat-Ochir, *Ard angi: бүтэц, өөрчлөлт, хоршоохилт : XX зууны екһнеес zharaad on*, ed. M. Sanzhdorzh (Ulaanbaatar: Shinzhlekh Ukhaany Akademiin Khevllel, 1986), 123.

⁵⁰³ Bat-Ochir, *Ard angi*, 123.

⁵⁰⁴ Multiple interviewees have *bichin*, rather than the standard *michin* (monkey) in transcriptions of the interviews.

⁵⁰⁵ Dulamjav, *The Oral History of Twentieth Century Mongolia*, <https://amantuuh.socanth.cam.ac.uk/>

⁵⁰⁶ Tarajav, *The Oral History of Twentieth Century Mongolia*, <https://amantuuh.socanth.cam.ac.uk/>

devastated.⁵⁰⁷ In his homeland, a camp (*ail*) that had 200 or 300 head of livestock had only 70 or 80 surviving after the disaster. He then recalled that during collectivization when a *zud* occurred and the summer pasture was in poor condition hay was brought in. He contrasted this to post-socialism's lack of fodder in the winter during *zuds*. Lkhagwaa, like Minjüür, frames the quality of government as their ability to take care of people during disasters.

However, the loss of livestock from *zud* is only half of the story of difficulty in the countryside from 1944 to 1945. This was a period when the Mongolian People's Republic was supplying heavy support for the Soviet Union during World War II, most of which was in the form of livestock products and live livestock. Jagwaral, in his discussion of why Mongolians needed government support referenced the dual pressures of countryside life at the time by saying that in 1945, "if not for the MPRP and the people's government, there would have been a terrible ruin and famine, especially since this natural disaster befell the country during World War II."⁵⁰⁸ Jagwaral frames World War II as much as a "natural disaster" as a *zud* or drought, a difficult, trying event which occurred outside of anyone's control. In reality the war was manmade, as was the extreme pressure that it put on Mongolians in the countryside. As bad as the 1944-1945 drought into *zud* was, the extraordinarily high livestock death count of over eight million livestock deaths was in part due to heavy pressure exerted on the countryside by the government to provide livestock and livestock goods to support the Soviet war effort.

Socialist rhetoric held up the response to 1944-1945 *zud* both as a success of socialist governance and as a reason why collectivization was necessary. The logic went that it would have been far worse without the government, but not been nearly as bad if everyone had been in

⁵⁰⁷ Lkhagvaa, *The Oral History of Twentieth Century Mongolia*, <https://amantuu.h.socanth.cam.ac.uk/>

⁵⁰⁸ N. Zhagvaral, *Aratstvo i aratskoe khoziaistvo* (Ulan-Bator: Akademiia Nauk Mongol'skoi Narodnoi Respubliki, 1974), 48.

a collective. This period also provides further proof of the social construction of *zud*, from the memory of the monkey year to government policies exacerbating the cost of climatic disasters.

Combating Disaster in Collectives

Collectives had multiple methods to combat disaster, but the most fundamental was the system of collectively held livestock. Scholars and organizers emphasized that when livestock was held individually, a single disaster could impoverish a family, whereas in a collective people would still have livestock and a support system. Collectives also would organize *otor*, long distance migration in response to a disaster. As Christopher Atwood argues, pre-revolutionary Mongolian society was organized into appanage communities, in which territorial boundaries were enforced to prevent outsiders from taking advantage of the local resources.⁵⁰⁹ Mongolians recognize that during an *otor* boundaries needed to be relaxed to alleviate disaster, but they were also hostile to outsiders seeking to use their pastures due to disaster for fear that they would not leave and return home after the disaster was over.

J. Sambuu's *Advice for Herders*, issued in 1956 in Cyrillic script, with an earlier version in vertical script in 1945, gave a great deal of advice for dealing with disaster, both *zuds* and drought. Sambuu argues that the government and collectives were important for the proper coordination of *otor* which would be carried out based on environmental and scientific data, and that strangers would need to share pastures when necessary.⁵¹⁰ Sambuu also highlights the collection of fodder and construction of wells and pens, and again that these efforts were best carried out through collectives and state farms, rather than through privately held herds.⁵¹¹ The

⁵⁰⁹ Christopher Atwood, "Banner, Otog, Thousand: Appanage Communities as the Basic Unit of Traditional Mongolian Society," *Mongolian Studies* 34 (2012): 37.

⁵¹⁰ Zhamsrangijn Sambuu, *Malchdad ökh zöwlölgöö* (Ulaanbaatar: Ulsyn Khewlelijin Gazar, 1956), 74-76, 79.

⁵¹¹ Sambuu, *Malchdad ökh zöwlölgöö*, 105.

1945 edition of the handbook discusses similar infrastructural changes, though the push for collectives was not as prevalent.

In an interview Minjüür, the Labor Hero and leader of the Ikh Tamir Bright Road collective, extolled the virtues of the collective in combating *zuds* as far superior to both pre-collective and post-collective systems. In his list of why collectivization was necessary, Minjüür prominently emphasized livestock loss from *zuds* which impoverished families.⁵¹² Minjüür explained that in the 1956-1957 *zud* four million livestock died it was because collectives were not properly established yet just like the four million livestock that died in 1999 because of the dissolution of collectives.⁵¹³ He continued that after the collectives were formed there were others disasters, but only 2.8 million livestock died because of the efforts of the collectives. During a *zud* his Bright Road collective provided “fodder, bran, mixed feed, warm *khashaas* where livestock did not get cold” in addition to wells, going on *otor*, and tractors and trucks to bring in needed hay.⁵¹⁴ By Minjüür’s reckoning there were seven to eight major *zuds* post-collectivization, but estimated that the death toll was usually 800,000, 1.8 or 2 million per *zud*, in contrast to the four thousand deaths of pre- and post-collectivization disasters. After citing these numbers, he concludes that “thus, the collectives were truly superior.”⁵¹⁵ Minjüür’s explanation is heavily rose tinted, as official numbers have the 1956 *zud* as lower mortality than he states, and he glosses over the severe *zud* of 1967/1968. However, the exact details are irrelevant; all of

⁵¹² I. Lkhagvasüren, *XX Zuuny Mongolchuud*, Senri Ethnological Reports 42 (Osaka: National Museum of Ethnology, 2003), 40. cf. I. Lkhagvasüren, *A Herder, a Trader, and a Lawyer: Three Twentieth Century Mongolian Leaders*, trans. Mary Rossabi, ed. Morris Rossabi, Senri Ethnological Reports 107, (Osaka, Japan: National Museum of Ethnology, 2012), 51.

⁵¹³ Lkhagvasüren, *XX Zuuny Mongolchuud*, , 86. cf. I. Lkhagvasüren, *A Herder, a Trader, and a Lawyer*, (Osaka, Japan: National Museum of Ethnology, 2012), 88.

⁵¹⁴ Lkhagvasüren, *XX Zuuny Mongolchuud*, , 86. cf. I. Lkhagvasüren, *A Herder, a Trader, and a Lawyer*, (Osaka, Japan: National Museum of Ethnology, 2012), 88.

⁵¹⁵ Lkhagvasüren, *XX Zuuny Mongolchuud*, , 86. cf. I. Lkhagvasüren, *A Herder, a Trader, and a Lawyer*, (Osaka, Japan: National Museum of Ethnology, 2012), 88.

them depend on the same supposition: that a metric of good governance is the ability to protect from and alleviate destruction from disasters. This was certainly true during the socialist era and the push for collectives, but also found in pre-modern Central Eurasian governments as well. Good governments do not allow disasters to occur, and if they slip through, then the government makes sure the people suffer as little as possible.

As with other forms of livestock death, livestock loss from *zuds* were collected in internal state and party documents. An example of this is seen in the Mongolian People's Revolutionary Party materials on collectivization from 1956, Choibalsan province (*aimag*) list of the cause of death of livestock from 1952 to 1955 in the "people's economy," meaning the non-collectivized livestock in the province.⁵¹⁶ The tale shows the cause of death, the percentage of total livestock that died from that cause, and then the total loss numbers.

Table 15. People's Economy in Choibalsan Province

Cause	1952	1953	1954	1955	All
Died from <i>zud</i>	185	9359	27910	na ⁵¹⁷	37454
Percent	0.01	0.09	3.1	na	na
Died from Disease	13552	15234	41539	64597	134922
Percent	1.3	1.3	4.6	9.4	na
Eaten by Wolves	2639	1576	4046	8261	na
Percent	0.2	0.1	0.4	na	na
Livestock Killed for Private Need	190649	187660	167156	140514	685979
Percent	17.9	17.5	18.5	20.6	na
All above Amount	207025	213829	240651	205111	866616
Percent	19.3	19.9	26.6	30	na
State Supply	114188	121306	141500	99997	476991
Percent	16.7	11.3	15.8	14.6	na
Total Livestock number from Census Period	1067660	1073546	397362	683538	na
Total Loss Numbers	321213	335135	382151	na	na

⁵¹⁶ UTNONBBA, kh 4 d1 khn 23, pg 16.

⁵¹⁷ Na denotes that the section was left blank in the archives.

This table seems to suggest that a *zud* occurred every year, which is not the normal understanding of *zud*. In fact, later reports emphasized that even when livestock died during the winter, it was not from *zud*, simply a bad winter storm. This suggests that definition of *zud* was in a state of flux and contested during the socialist period which culminated with Tsedenbal's 1975 condemnation of the term.

The MPRP collected reports on winter conditions in each *aimag*. In 1958, in North Khangai, "the livestock generally overwintered well. Most pastures (*nutguud*) had nearly no snow, thus the livestock had deficient water. In Urd Tamir, Öndör sant *sum* had snow, unlike others."⁵¹⁸ This report is an important reminder that while extreme snow was a problem, so was lack of snow, as livestock relied on snow for enough water. In the same year, in Gobi Altai, Sükhbaatar, and Middle Gobi, there were snow storms, but not enough of a hay stockpile and lack of necessary trucks.⁵¹⁹ Despite the snow, the reports emphasized that although there was snow, it was not a *zud* (*tsastai bolowch zudgüi*). In the assessment of the plan to increase livestock numbers from 1958 to 1959, hay and shelters had to be increased to protect livestock during winter and spring.⁵²⁰ The Party also noted that because the Gobi had many droughts and *zuds*, this called for greater movement and the construction of stalls and stone pens, depending on the degree of movement and settlement.⁵²¹ In contrast, Mongolians in wooded areas like the *khangai* were more likely to use wooden pens.

Herders at conferences routinely emphasized the importance of protection from disaster. A 1955 conference had speeches on the importance of hay collection in the summer, distribution

⁵¹⁸ UTNONBBA, kh 4 d 1 khn 24, pg 46.

⁵¹⁹ UTNONBBA, kh 4 d 1 khn 24, pg 47-49.

⁵²⁰ UTNONBBA, kh 4 d 1 khn 24, pg 97.

⁵²¹ UTNONBBA, kh 4 d 1 khn 24, pg 157.

of fodder and warm pens in the winter, and *otor* in response to disasters.⁵²² Presentations at the 1956 South Khangai top herder conference were very concerned with combating disasters, as emphasized in the opening remarks, in large part because it took place during an extreme *zud* that was killing livestock at the time.⁵²³ Presenters discussed the importance of collectives, hay, and shelters to protect livestock. However, some herders disagreed on the best response to the *zud*. One presenter argued that the problem with *zuds* is not environmental, and while infrastructure and organization is well and good, the best response to a *zud* is just hard work.⁵²⁴ And everyone agreed that the youth just were not working hard enough, a common refrain for herders during collectivization, as well as today. The idea that good hard socialist labor is the answer to solving disaster is same as that which can be found in the “Little Heroic Sisters of the Grassland.”⁵²⁵

In interviews, former collective members regularly mention the role of collectives in protecting against loss during *zuds*. Nanjid, who worked as a veterinarian, noted that collectives organized emergency migrations during *zuds*.⁵²⁶ Furthermore, she explained that as a veterinarian she was a member of the livestock commission and part of her job was verifying the actual cause of death to exonerate the herder from fault, with disasters and diseases being one of the accepted reasons to lose livestock. Tserennadmid included *zud*, along with dogs and wolves, in the common threats to livestock that impacted the ability to fulfill the five-year plans.⁵²⁷ Many herders mentioned the most disastrous *zud* at the time, for Tserennadmid this was a *zud* in 1950 which devastated her home pasture. Sodnomjaw, who was interviewed by the Cambridge

⁵²² UTNONBBA, kh 15 d 1 khn 726, pg 199.

⁵²³ AA kh 1 d1 khn 10, pg 1.

⁵²⁴ AA kh 1 d1 khn 10, pg 96.

⁵²⁵ Uradyn Bulag, *The Mongols at China's Edge: History and the Politics of National Unity*, World Social Change (Lanham: Rowman & Littlefield Publishers, 2002), 183.

⁵²⁶ Nanjid, *The Oral History of Twentieth Century Mongolia*, <http://amantuuh.socanth.cam.ac.uk/>

⁵²⁷ Tserennadmid, *The Oral History of Twentieth Century Mongolia*, <https://amantuuh.socanth.cam.ac.uk/>

research group project that resulted in *The End of Nomadism?*, praised the collectives for organizing *otor*, collection of hay, and construction of *khashaas*, all of which was centrally planned.⁵²⁸ However, he criticized the socialist system of herding as leading to the loss of personal motivation and initiative, and that because of the reliance on infrastructure and collective instructions, post-collectivization herders did not know how to deal with these problems on their own. This seeming contradiction again shows the debate over whether individuals, the climate, or governments are at fault for disasters.

Once herders belonged in a collective, *zuds* turned from a reason to join to one of the few excusable reasons to lose livestock. However, collectives were sometimes reluctant to forgive herders for allowing their livestock to die. This is connected to the question of who or what was responsible for livestock deaths from disaster, and if labor is enough to stop livestock loss. As mentioned by Nanjid, livestock commission members and veterinarians had to verify the cause of death before excusing the herder in question. The number of livestock which died was not only counted, but the remains were attempted to be salvaged to see what skins and other goods could be saved. Because extraction of livestock goods and plans to do so were a basic element of collectives, it should not be surprising that there was a great deal of concern about the amount of goods lost in disasters, as well as what could be salvaged.

Although smaller scale, local snowstorms could still be extremely dangerous, as seen in the example of 1962 snowstorm in South Khangai. From May 5th to the 7th, a severe snowstorm swept across the majority of South Khangai, impacting a total of seventeen *sums*. Despite seeming to fit the criteria for a *zud*, including the late spring date, all of the archival documents specifically only refer to it as a severe snowstorm, rather than a *zud*, which again emphasizes the

⁵²⁸ Humphrey and Sneath, *The End of Nomadism?*, 39-40.

social and governmental role in defining what officially counts as a *zud*. That it was not officially a *zud* did not make it any less disastrous as it caused a great deal of damage. Nine people died across six sums, one man and eight women, and 46 people were injured, while winds damaged or destroyed 10 buildings and 93 *gers*.⁵²⁹ A total of 142,429 livestock were killed across the entire province. The report on the death included a detailed breakdown of livestock deaths, divided into different age groups.

Table 16. 1962 South Khangai May 5-7th Livestock Deaths

Adult Livestock Loss⁵³⁰

Sum Name	All	Camel	Horse	Cattle	Sheep	Goat
Bayanöndör	16103	91	899	406	8778	5930
Büрд	1524	3	105	128	313	975
Batölzii	59	0	4	1	40	14
Z.B. Ulaan	13744	102	1088	392	8907	3255
Bayangol	12733	138	614	230	5612	6129
Guchin	778	7	24	0	231	515
Delgerekh	8728	13	882	565	5183	2085
Züil	11114	94	350	281	6605	3784
Ölziit	12863	83	286	112	8196	4186
Nariinteel	211	1	13	27	39	131
Sant	13768	119	357	168	7998	5126
Targat	7313	5	743	357	4369	1839
Tögrög	1728	53	38	3	318	1316
Uyanga	3153	36	881	646	975	615
Khowd	662	40	0	0	19	603
Khairkhandulaan	1924	10	237	261	748	668
Khujirt	639	0	90	102	283	164
Kharkhorin	312	0	64	14	232	2
All	107356	805	6674	3694	58846	37337

Young Livestock Loss⁵³¹

Sum Name	All	Camel	Horse	Cattle	Sheep	Goat
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⁵²⁹ AA, kh 43, d1 khn 12, pg 31.

⁵³⁰ Arwaikheer, kh 43, d1 khn 12, pg 36.

⁵³¹ Arwaikheer, kh 43, d1 khn 12, pg 37.

Bayanöndör	2,817	67	329	12	1,528	881
Büрд	594	4	62	1	309	198
Batölzii	40	0	0	3	34	3
Z.B. Ulaan	3,652	14	185	44	2,593	816
Bayangol	5,086	126	234	9	3,544	1,173
Guchin	364	4	1	0	189	170
Delgerekh	3,018	4	177	15	2,338	484
Züil	3,853	41	160	52	2,378	1,222
Ölziit	4,890	22	118	1	3,329	1,429
Nariinteel	88	0	3	0	21	53
Sant	3,986	113	118	10	2,812	933
Targat	2,984	0	110	30	2,382	462
Tögrög	385	97	21	0	138	129
Uyanga	1,449	2	152	12	1,096	187
Khowd	490	0	0	0	21	469
Khairkhandulaan	578	0	70	16	372	120
Khujirt	399	0	100	15	211	73
Kharkhorin	400	0	55	0	342	2
All	35,073	494	1916	220	23,637	8,806

These numbers, collected by collective, district, and provincial leaders, detail how loss was distributed amongst livestock type and age of livestock. As shown by the existence of a separate table, young livestock are especially vulnerable to *zud*. Furthermore, small livestock (sheep and goat) are far more likely to die from *zud* than large livestock (cattle, horse, and camel), although there are larger number of them in total. While the collective itself was intended to help protect against large scale loss from disaster, it also came with the construction of important infrastructure. To fight climatic disasters, party and collective leaders emphasized three infrastructural elements: hay, stalls, and wells.

Hay

Producing and collecting fodder is one of the most common and important methods of combating disaster. When pastureland does not produce enough feed for livestock due to either *zud* or drought, collected hay and feed is necessary. Hay collection occurred at multiple levels;

those of private herders, collectives, state farms, and hay stations. Jagwaral and other socialist leaders argued that one could not rely on private herders to prepare and provide their own hay. Jagwaral criticizes private herders because “many herders harvest hay much less than they need and possibly, motivating them with the fact that if there is a drought or *zud*, they will still have to migrate to another place, leaving harvested hay.”⁵³² Jagwaral argues for converting some pastureland to hay production and that more feed would decrease the degree to which seasonal migration was required.⁵³³ Sambuu devotes a chapter to fodder collection in both the 1945 and 1956 edition in which he emphasizes the need for preparing hay for the winter and placing it near winter pastures.⁵³⁴ Despite Jagwaral’s insistence of the inadequacy of relying on private hay collection, up until the start of collectivization in 1956 private hay collection far outnumbered those in hays and collectives, as seen in the table below.

Table 17. Hay Collected per Thousand ton⁵³⁵

Sector Name	1940	1950	1955	1956
State Farm	21.9	15.2	49.8	58.6
Collective	0.5 ⁵³⁶	8.5	176.5	295.9
Private Herder	39.8	924.6	1092	1241.5
Total	62.2	948.3	1318.3	1596

⁵³² Zhagvaral, *Aratstvo i Aratskoe Khoziaistvo*, 130.

⁵³³ Zhagvaral, *Aratstvo i Aratskoe Khoziaistvo*, 131.

⁵³⁴ J. Sambuu and Rincin, *Mal Aju Aquí Deger-e-Ben Yagakiju Ajillaqu Tuqai Arad-Tu Ögkü Sanagulg-a Surgal* (Ulaganbagatur: Būgūde Naiiramdaqu Monggol Arad Ulus-un Keblel, 1945), 230; Zhamsrangijn Sambuu, *Malchdad ökh zöwlölgöö*. (Ulaanbaatar: Ulsyn Khewlelijn Gazar, 1956), 110.

⁵³⁵ UTNONBBA, Kh 8 d 1 khn 142, pg 110.

⁵³⁶ The table notes that the number of hay collected in 1940 in collectives was unknown, so they used the 1941 numbers.

Hay stations were established to provide fodder during *zud* and drought. Although connected to collectivization, the stations themselves were separate from collectives and state farms, and collectives and state farms had their own separate efforts to grow and collect hay. Hay production was also necessary to feed improved breeds, which required more fodder than native breeds. However, as Bat-Ochir explains, the primary purpose for hay stations was to produce hay for herders to feed their livestock during *zuds*.⁵³⁷ Cultivation of hay was closely linked with the increase of farming, which was heavily promoted, especially in state farms, as part of the future of socialist agriculture.⁵³⁸ The increase of farming was accompanied by the import of large number of tractors and trucks from the Soviet Union.⁵³⁹

Table 18. 1956 Collective Hay Final Fulfillment⁵⁴⁰

Collected Hay	Thousands of Tons				
Province	1955 ⁵⁴¹		1956		1955-1956
	Fulfillment	Plan	Fulfillment	Plan	Increase
North Khangai	17.2	38.9	24.9	64	144.8
Bayan-Ölgii	2.2	5.6	6.6	117.9	300
Bayan Khongor	8.6	16.4	20.2	123.2	234.9
Bulgan	37.1	44.4	65.8	148.2	177.8
Gobi Altai	1.6	2.1	3.2	152.4	200
East Gobi	0.6	0.6	0.8	133.8	133

⁵³⁷ Bat-Ochir, *Ard angi*, 137.

⁵³⁸ B Punsaldulam, *Mongolyn gazar tarialangiin tüükh 1900-1958 on*, vol. 1 (Ulaanbaatar: “Bembi san” KhKhK, 2017).

⁵³⁹ Bat-Ochir, *Ard angi*, 137.

⁵⁴⁰ UTNONBBA, kh 15 d 1 khn 75, pg 13.

⁵⁴¹ The document incorrectly states 1956.

Middle Gobi	0.6	1	2.4	240	400
Zawkhan	3.1	8.6	12.6	146.5	406.4
South Khangai	7.8	9.4	10.4	110.6	133.3
South Gobi	0.4	1.3	0.7	53.8	175
Sükhbaatar	3.3	3.6	5.9	163.9	178.8
Central	20	26.1	24.8	95	122.8
Uws	7.7	11.7	10.7	91.5	139
Khowd	10.9	16.8	17.1	101.8	157.9
Khöwsgöl	23.6	30.5	50.2	164.6	212.7
Khentii	14.5	13.2	20.4	154.5	140.7
Choibalsan	17.1	23.8	32.6	137	190.6
Ulaanbaatar	0	0	0.4	0	0
All	176.5	254	309.7	121.9	175.5

There was clearly a balance that had to be struck between preserving pasture and converting land to hay or farm production. This was seen in two other Mongolian lands. Buryatia was often held as an example for collectivization and the future of herding in socialist Mongolia. However, Buryatia had severe problems with hay production. Caroline Humphrey explains that cultivation of hay and fodder in Buryatia used to be higher, but Khrushchev's Virgin Land Campaigns redirected a great deal of infrastructure and land from growing hay to growing corn, resulting in Russia a fall from 64 tons of hay in 1953 to 47 million tons in 1965.⁵⁴² Despite

⁵⁴² Caroline Humphrey, *Marx Went Away--but Karl Stayed Behind* (Ann Arbor: University of Michigan Press, 1998), 173.

devoting more land to cultivate, in the 1960s fodder did not keep up with the needs for livestock with only 40% of the necessary fodder being produced, and in the Buryatia was importing fodder, including from Mongolia. Inner Mongolia had a similar trajectory of increase and then decrease of hay production. Collectivization included the same sort of increased infrastructure promoted in independent Mongolia, including hay making.⁵⁴³ Collective members were paid extra for hay collection because the hay fields were far away from the pastures, and the work was intensive.⁵⁴⁴ With de-collectivization in the 1980s, hay fields and machinery were put into individual hands, largely those of collective leaders and party members. Sneath cites an example of the winter of 1983-1984 a third of livestock loss in Hulun Buir, while in Bayan Gol one herder lost half his livestock, one lost all of his livestock, while the Party member with the hay collecting machines and established shelters lost no livestock.⁵⁴⁵ Mongolia's post-collectivization efforts also led to a loss infrastructure formed in the collective, including hay, wells, and stalls.

Khashaa

Khashaa is a broad term which includes anything from a simple wooden fence enclosure to insulated covered stalls. Socialist plans called for large scale construction of various *khashaas*, including basic pens, milking sheds, covered, and warm shelters. Building materials varied based on region, *khashaas* in the *gobi* and other lightly wooded areas were made of stone while in areas like the *khangai* and *taiga* fences were built from wood. The purpose of *khashaas* varied, from simply keeping livestock together at night, to protecting from the extreme weather during winter and *zuds*. While *khashaas* are not nearly as labor and technology intensive as hay collection or

⁵⁴³ Sneath, *Changing Inner Mongolia*, 82.

⁵⁴⁴ Sneath, *Changing Inner Mongolia*, 93.

⁵⁴⁵ Sneath, *Changing Inner Mongolia*, 158.

well construction, they were nevertheless cited as an incentive to join collectives, and the number of *khashaas* built were closely monitored by the government as part of the effort to reach the ever-important goal of increasing livestock.

The push for *khashaa* construction embodies some of the major tensions in the collectivization campaign. First, *khashaas* by their nature anchor livestock to specific seasonal pastures, and are not compatible with unplanned wandering. While wandering was never a strategy practiced by Mongolian herders, the presence of *khashaas* mean that even slight variations in pasture selection are less likely to occur. *Khashaas* are also a strong pre-socialist herding element promoted by the socialist project. There was not a great deal of new technologies or strategies involved in building fences; instead collectives promised the organization of the labor necessary to build the infrastructure.

Sambuu includes a chapter for *khashaas* with a focus on insulated warm stalls.⁵⁴⁶ Though he extolls their virtues, Sambuu does warn that vermin like mice, rats, and insects can congregate in stalls.⁵⁴⁷ Herders were responsible for keeping fences and shelters in good repair and clean condition. As in pre-socialist Mongolia, fences were often for sheep and goats to keep shelter in at night, especially during the winter where the pressed together bodies kept them warm.⁵⁴⁸ Sambuu argues that one of the most important steps to modernize Mongolian livestock is the creation of warm shelters.⁵⁴⁹ During extreme snow and *zud*, livestock would suffer without proper shelters.

⁵⁴⁶ J. Sambuu and Rincin, *Mal Aju Aquí Deger-e-Ben Yagakiju Ajillaqu Tuqai Arad-Tu Ögkü Sanagulg-a Surgal* (Ulaganbagatur: Būgūde Naiiramdaqu Monggol Arad Ulus-un Keblel, 1945), 216; Zhamsrangiin Sambuu, *Malchdad ökh zöwlölgöö*. (Ulaanbaatar: Ulsyn Khewlelijin Gazar, 1956), 128.

⁵⁴⁷ Zh. Sambuu, *Malchdad ökh zöwlölgöö*, 28.

⁵⁴⁸ Zh. Sambuu, *Malchdad ökh zöwlölgöö*, 79.

⁵⁴⁹ Zh. Sambuu, *Malchdad ökh zöwlölgöö*, 129.

The table of the completed stalls in 1956 shows some of the types of *khashaa* constructed during collectivization, including roofed stalls, non-roofed stalls, and sheds for livestock. Other varieties not listed include fences, corrals, and sheds specifically for milking.

Table 19. 1956 *Khashaa* Construction State Plan Achievement⁵⁵⁰

<i>All Khashaas</i>					
	1955	1956			1955- 1956
	Achieved	Planned	Achieved	percent	Percent
State	- ⁵⁵¹	146	-	-	-
Farm					
Collective	2020	3360	5173	158.9	256.1
People's	16537	21065	20572	97.7	124.4
Economy					
All	18557	24571	25745	104.8	138.7

Note: The state economy built five cattle buildings, 6 pig and poultry buildings out of 17 planned.

Table 20. 1956 Roofed and Unroofed *Khashaa* Construction State Plan Achievement⁵⁵²

Roofed	Without Roof

⁵⁵⁰ UTNONBBA, kh15 d1 khn 75 pg 35.

⁵⁵¹ Left blank in the document.

⁵⁵² UTNONBBA, kh15 d1 khn 75 pg 35.

1956			1956		
Planned	Achieved	Percent	Planned	Achieved	Percent
126	-	-	-	-	-
1770	2065	116.7	420	1504	358
6985	8068	114.1	853-	5874	68.9
881	10133	114.1	8950	7378	82.4

Table 21. 1956 Shed for Young Livestock Construction State Plan Achievement⁵⁵³

1956		
Planned	Achieved	Percent
3	-	-
1170	1604	137.1
5550	6629	119.4
6728	8233	122.2

Table 22. Roofed Pens for Large Livestock 2nd Five Year Plan⁵⁵⁴

	1954	1955			1956			1957		
Province	Plann ed	Plann ed	Achie ved	Perc ent	Plann ed	Achie ved	Perc ent	Plann ed	Achie ved	Perc ent

⁵⁵³ UTNONBBA, kh15 d1 khn 75 pg 35.

⁵⁵⁴ UTNONBBA, kh15 d1 khn 75, pg 169.

North Khangai	20	50	96	192	60	80	133. 3	60	84	140
Bayan Ölgii	5	5	5	100	5	0	0	5	20	400
Bayankho ngor	5	10	25	250	30	34	133. 8	35	107	304. 7
Bulgan	10	30	48	160	60	208	346. 7	80	250	312. 5
Gobi Altai	10	15	20	133. 3	20	22	110	25	25	104
North Gobi	2	1	0	0	1	4	400	1	4	400
Middle Gobi	2	5	4	80	10	4	40	13	12	92.8
Zawkhan	5	10	50	500	20	39	195	25	40	160
South Khangai	8	15	18	120	17	20	117. 6	20	30	150
South Gobi	2	1	3	300	1	17	1700	1	4	400
Sükhbaata r	5	5	1	20	5	7	140	5	9	180
Central	26	50	26	52	74	57	77	90	116	128. 9

Uws	5	20	0	0	30	35	116. 7	45	54	120
Khowd	5	20	69	245	45	22	48.9	50	66	132
Khöwsgöl	10	50	94	188	100	320	320	120	0	0
Khentii	10	45	8	17.8	55	0	0	60	80	133. 3
Choibalsan	10	45	8	17.8	55	58	105. 5	60	47	78.3
Ulaanbaatar	0	0	0	0	0	0	0	0	0	0
Total	140	377	475	125	588	927	157. 6	695	949	136. 5

The reports show that regions with forests had higher number of *khashaas* constructed. A large portion of this is due to the availability of construction materials.

Fence and pen construction, like herding knowledge and other forms of infrastructure were not completely new or foreign to Mongolia. However, the socialist government was able to mobilize more labor and technology in order protect the health and safety of livestock.

Wells

Wells are time, labor, and technology intensive to dig, and are less likely than hay or stalls to be constructed in a private economy, as the amount of of technology and labor required is higher. Wells are especially important in the *gobi*, where water is often scarce. While wells are most associated with droughts, and thus summer and fall, water shortage can also occur in the

winter and spring when there is not enough snow to provide drinking water for livestock. Well construction was monitored by socialist leaders as part of central plans and in party documents and the concern of lack of water in the *gobi* was a common topic of discussion.⁵⁵⁵ There were multiple wells constructed during the socialist period, though most were shaft (dug by hand) or bore (created by a drilling machine).

Sambuu again devotes a chapter to the construction of wells, another instance of advertisement for collectivization.⁵⁵⁶ Herders had to keep wells covered and clean, to prevent contaminated water, or even small or young livestock from falling in.⁵⁵⁷ Throughout Sambuu emphasizes the importance of keeping in mind the local environmental conditions, as *gobi* regions needed more wells than other regions. Sambuu explains that wells can expand the use of pastures and locals should be consulted when building wells so they are in the optimum location.⁵⁵⁸ Sambuu acknowledges the importance of old wells, but argues that they need to be renovated, drained, and reinforced to insure they are up to modern standards.⁵⁵⁹ Herders already knew that wells are important, but they needed to be spread (through collectives).⁵⁶⁰

In almost direct contrast to the earlier call to keep in mind local conditions, Sambuu almost off handedly throws out the possibility of a mass Soviet-inspired megaproject to bring more water to the Gobi. Sambuu explains that Mongolia can irrigate and water the Gobi just as the Soviet Union irrigated deserts including the Karakum in Turkmenistan, which the locals now used to grow hay and other crops.⁵⁶¹ Sambuu was referring to the Karakum Canal, which began

⁵⁵⁵UTNONBBA, kh 15 d1 khn 795, 30.

⁵⁵⁶ Sambuu and Rincin, *Mal Aju Deger-e-Ben Yagakiju Ajillaqu Tuqai Arad-Tu Ögkü Sanagulg-a Surgal*, 140; Sambuu, *Malchdad ökh zöwlölgöö*, 117.

⁵⁵⁷ Sambuu, *Malchdad ökh zöwlölgöö*, 121.

⁵⁵⁸ Sambuu, *Malchdad ökh zöwlölgöö*, 123.

⁵⁵⁹ Sambuu, *Malchdad ökh zöwlölgöö*, 124.

⁵⁶⁰ Sambuu, *Malchdad ökh zöwlölgöö*, 126.

⁵⁶¹ Sambuu, *Malchdad ökh zöwlölgöö*, 125.

in 1954, which was a major example of the socialist megaproject. It also was one of the main causes of the disappearance of the Aral Sea.⁵⁶² This large-scale proposal is one example in which Sambuu's modestly titled *Advice for Herders* promotes the large-scale transformation of Mongolia through socialism.

Table 23. 1956 Carried out Planned Well Construction⁵⁶³

	All Wells			Bore Wells			Shaft Wells			Other Types of Wells		
	Planned	Achieved	%	Planned	Achieved	%	Planned	Achieved	%	Planned	Achieved	%
State Farm	9	6	66.7	2	2	100	7	4	57.1	"	"	"
Collectives	214	655	31	6	7	116.7	8	14	175	200	634	317
People's Economy	3889	2900	74.6	12	13	108.3	17	12	70.6	3860	2875	74.5
All	4112	3561	86.6	20	22	110	32	30	93.7	4060	3509	86.4

The various infrastructural improvements aimed to combat disaster fared poorly in the post-socialist privatization period.⁵⁶⁴ It is far easier to divide livestock amongst collective members than it is to divide a well. Certainly, herders continue to use fences and stalls, or to harvest hay, but without the centralized efforts found previously.

Post-Socialist Disasters

Most of the Western scholarly literature on climatic disasters in Mongolia are almost all examinations of 21st century occurrences and are most concerned with *zuds*. These works almost always focus on two aspects related to disasters: climate change and the neoliberal policies of post-socialist Mongolia. This again shows the heated debate over who is responsible for

⁵⁶² Julia Obertreis, "Soviet Irrigation Policies under Fire: Ecological Critique in Central Asia, 1970s-1991," *Eurasian Environments: Nature and Ecology in Imperial Russian and Soviet History*, ed. Nicholas B. Breyfogle, Pitt Series in Russian and East European Studies (Pittsburgh: University of Pittsburgh Press, 2018), 116.

⁵⁶³ UTNONBBA kh 15 d1 khn 773, pg 44.

⁵⁶⁴ Humphrey and Sneath, *The End of Nomadism?*, 56.

livestock loss of *zud* is wrapped up in views about government and personal responsibility. Most works also argue that climate change has exacerbated the intensity and frequency of disasters.⁵⁶⁵ Craig R. Janes and Oyuntsetseg Chuluundorj argue that that disasters are worse because of the lack of infrastructure and safety net of post-socialist neoliberal Mongolia.⁵⁶⁶ A few works instead take the point of view that with the end of collectives herders are more incentivized to work to protect their herds.⁵⁶⁷ Annika Ericksen explores this trope of the lazy herder that blames a herder's lack of initiative, born by decades of socialist coddling, for their loss of livestock during disaster.⁵⁶⁸ She argues that the trope of the lazy herder being responsible for loss of livestock is descended from the socialist period, when socialist leaders also said poorly performing herders were responsible for livestock loss. This was especially the case post-collectivization, as seen in Tsedenbal's 1975 proclamation. After the especially severe 2009/2010 *zud* some panicked observers even declared that herding could no longer play a role in Mongolia's economic future. The importance of *zud* in modern Mongolia is such that NPR ran a number of articles about *zud* and its role in modern Mongolia in 2019, a relatively rare spotlight on Mongolia in a prominent English language news source.⁵⁶⁹

Disasters have increased in severity and frequency due to climate change which is supported by both climatic data and interviews with Mongolians. Interviewees often contrast the

⁵⁶⁵ María E. Fernández-Giménez et al., "Lessons from the Dzud: Community-Based Rangeland Management Increases the Adaptive Capacity of Mongolian Herders to Winter Disasters," *World Development* 68 (April 2015): 48–65.

⁵⁶⁶ Craig R. Janes and Oyuntsetseg Chuluundorj, *Making Disasters: Climate Change, Neoliberal Governance, and Livelihood Insecurity on the Mongolian Steppe*, First edition, Resident Scholar Series / School for Advanced Research (Santa Fe, New Mexico: School for Advanced Research Press, 2015).

⁵⁶⁷ Mukund Palat Rao et al., "Dzuds, Droughts, and Livestock Mortality in Mongolia," *Environmental Research Letters* 10, no. 7 (2015): 10.

⁵⁶⁸ Annika Ericksen, "Depend on Each Other and Don't Just Sit: The Socialist Legacy, Responsibility, and Winter Risk among Mongolian Herders," *Human Organization* 73, no. 1 (2014): 38–49.

⁵⁶⁹ "The Deadly Winters That Have Transformed Life For Herders In Mongolia : NPR," accessed November 20, 2019, <https://www.npr.org/2019/07/29/737990796/the-deadly-winters-that-have-transformed-life-for-herders-in-mongolia>.

current environmental dangers with that of the past. Charlotte Marchina records examples of how contemporary herders dealt with *zud* and drought, including migrating to new regions, and that herders agree that *zud* and drought are getting more frequent with greater severity.⁵⁷⁰ This supports the common consensus as climate change increases, the degree and severity of disasters increase. Some Mongolians, like Dambadoo, were forced to move from his native Middle Gobi to Ulaanbaatar after a disastrous *zud* wiped out his livestock, a common experience and reaction to disaster in contemporary Mongolia.⁵⁷¹ Similarly, in 2000 Tsedensodnom in Khöwsgöl lost his over hundred head of livestock, and was forced to move to Mörön, the province center.⁵⁷² Unfortunately, disasters will increase, although the definition of these disasters and how the government and society responds can still be decided by Mongolians.

Conclusion

Mongolians' understanding of winter disasters and droughts was formulated through a social process in response to extreme environmental conditions. Governments and scholars do their best to contain a *zud* in a neat row of numbers, but it is much more in the mind of people. It was, and is, most notably a measure of success of an individual or government. To people like Minjüür, the degree to which the socialist government was successful in combating disaster is one of the key metrics of a government's success. In his point of view, the Mongolian People's Republic kept their promise and prevented mass death through collectives and its successor did not. Of the three major threats to livestock socialists targeted, disease, disaster, and wolves, disaster is arguably the hardest to combat and was the deadliest to both livestock and people. To

⁵⁷⁰ Charlotte Marchina, *Nomad's land: Éleveurs, animaux et paysage chez les peuples mongols* (Zones Sensibles, 2019), 48, 54.

⁵⁷¹ Dambadoo, *The Oral History of Twentieth Century Mongolia*, <https://amantuuh.socanth.cam.ac.uk/>

⁵⁷² Tsedensodnom, *The Oral History of Twentieth Century Mongolia*, <https://amantuuh.socanth.cam.ac.uk/>

protect livestock from disasters, collectives implemented a shared pool of livestock, constructed infrastructure such as hay stations, wells, and stalls, and criticized herders who let livestock die during disasters. Socialists agreed that it was not only within the realm of possibility to control the impact of *zud* and *gan*, but it was also the obligation of individuals and/or governments to do so.

During my time in Mongolia, *zud* and drought were common topics of conversation. While traveling along the Orkhon River in 2015, I encountered a local governmental official who was preparing an *owoo* (rock cairn) for a ritual to appease the river spirit (*lus*) to alleviate the drought. Earlier in the summer I observed the brown, dusty steppe of Central province, and knew it was due to drought, which was later confirmed by talking with herders celebrating the summer holiday (*Naadam*). But to my eye the land by the Orkhon was green and healthy, an example of the variability of what constitutes a disaster in different regions in Mongolia. The *owoo* ritual had pre-modern antecedents but was still a modern response to the same problems that troubled socialist and pre-socialist governments. It was just one example of how disasters are defined by the people on the ground rather than amount of precipitation.

Chapter 4

Wolf Extermination

Introduction

Wolves (*Canis lupus*) are a widespread apex predator and were throughout pre-modern history found in most of the Northern Hemisphere.⁵⁷³ This led to conflict with the most widespread apex predator: humans. The Eurasian grey wolf (*Canis lupus lupus*) is endemic to modern Mongolia, the larger Mongolian plateau, and surrounding lands of Inner Asia and Siberia.⁵⁷⁴ Mongolian wolves, *chono*, are found throughout Mongolia with areas like the *khangai* and taiga having the largest population of wolves, while the *gobi* has the lowest, with many wolves living in the steppe regions. Domesticated animals are usually far easier prey for wolves than wild prey, and as such wolves often choose to prey on the five snouts (*khoshuu*) of Mongolian livestock. Wolf extermination (*ustgakh*) was closely related to collectivization campaigns as one of the main goals of collectivization was removing causes of loss of livestock to increase livestock numbers. The promise of wolf extermination served as an incentive for herders to join collectives, and success in killing wolves was an internal measure of success.

Socialist Mongolian writers, hunters, and government officials saw wolves as dangerous threats to livestock and by extension the socialist project. Mongolian socialist authors and hunters engaged with pre-existing themes in which wolves were portrayed primarily as dangerous beasts and wolves and undesirable people were connected. Mongolian wolf hunters were highly organized and articulated their work as a form of Marxist labor, key to building

⁵⁷³ L. David Mech and Luigi Boitani, eds., *Wolves: Behavior, Ecology, and Conservation* (Chicago: University of Chicago Press, 2003).

⁵⁷⁴ N Batsaikhan et al., *A Field Guide to the Mammals of Mongolia [Mongol orny khökh-tön am'tan tanikh garyn avlaga]*, 2nd ed. (London: Zoological Society of London, 2014), 226; Jigmiddorji, Urta, and Nongnaiijab, *Amitan-u jirugtu toli*, 1. keb (Kökeqota: Öbör Monggol-un Surgan Kümüjil-ün Keblel-ün Qoriy-a, 1986), 1550.

socialism. By integrating modern methods with pre-socialist sentiments, socialist Mongolian intellectuals, hunters, herders, and officials sought to solve a perennial predation problem facing Mongolian herders, one shared by many other herders across the world. The few pro-wolf voices in socialist Mongolia reacted against the common rhetoric of wolves as enemies. The socialist-era widescale persecution of wolves calls into question the common narrative that contemporary Mongolians revere wolves, or in earlier periods.

Scholars of animal history have increasingly emphasized the agency of non-human animals, and wolves are certainly no exception.⁵⁷⁵ By studying the reintroduction of wolves in Yellowstone National Park biologists found that wolves shape their environment through predation by a process known as trophic cascade.⁵⁷⁶ Wolves in Mongolia certainly shaped their environment through predation of wild and domesticated animals in the same manner. Archival materials, which almost always focus on livestock losses or wolves killed, rarely provide a clear window into understanding of agency of wolf packs or individuals, much less their emotional and personal lives. However, socialist Mongolians themselves ascribed agency to wolves, most often as dangerous threats to livestock and socialism itself though, to some, wolves were persecuted victims. Similarly, the reactions of livestock to wolves were discussed, especially the ability of stallions and bulls to protect herds from wolves.

Although wolf extermination was part of the socialist modernization program in Mongolia, it was not a clear break from pre-socialist Mongolian attitudes towards wolves. Instead, socialist hunting and attitudes towards wolves represented an increase of magnitude, regularity, and professionalism from previous periods. Human-wolf conflict has been the norm

⁵⁷⁵ Baratay, "Building an Animal History," 3–14.

⁵⁷⁶ William J. Ripple and Robert L. Beschta, "Trophic Cascades in Yellowstone: The First 15 Years after Wolf Reintroduction," *Biological Conservation* 145, no. 1 (January 2012): 205–13.

since the beginning of recorded Mongolian history and continues to be the primary way that Mongolian herders and hunters interact with wolves.

Global Context

Mongolia was one of the many countries across the world that carried out extermination campaigns against wolves in the modern era. John F. Richards argues that widespread persecution of large animals, especially predators, is one of the four environmental transformations in the early modern era. He cautions against seeing this solely as evidence of human cruelty and destruction of the natural, as “graziers and ranchers did not kill wolves or lions solely for pleasure. They were acting to defend their stock beset by a myriad of threats.”⁵⁷⁷ The history of wolf hunting in America is a rich sub-section of human-animal history, and provides insight into long history of persecution and, in many places, eventual extermination of wolves.⁵⁷⁸ Wolf extermination was a global movement that Mongolia was engaged in, similar to the global movement of veterinary science discussed in chapter two.

Closer geographically to Mongolia, Brett Walker examines the history and the extermination of the wolf in Japan and shows that while wolves played an important role in Japanese and Ainu religion, conflict with wolves intensified in times and places where Japanese herded horses and then during modern attempts to transform Hokkaido into cattle ranching territory, which eventually led to the complete extermination of wolves throughout Japan.⁵⁷⁹ Although as a primarily herding people, Mongolians did not experience the positive impact of wolves eating herbivores that threatened their crops the way that Japanese farmers did, both

⁵⁷⁷ John F. Richards, *Unending Frontier : An Environmental History of the Early Modern World*, (Berkeley: University of California Press, 2003), 9.

⁵⁷⁸ Barry Holstun Lopez, *Of Wolves and Men* (New York: Scribner, 1978); Bruce Hampton, *The Great American Wolf*, (New York: Henry Holt and Company, 1997), Jon T. Coleman, *Vicious : Wolves and Men in America*, (New Haven, CT, USA: Yale University Press, 2004).

⁵⁷⁹ Brett L. Walker, *The Lost Wolves of Japan*, Weyerhaeuser Environmental Books (Seattle: University of Washington Press, 2005).

Mongolia and Japan are North Asian countries with complex religious connection with wolves that still embarked on mass wolf hunting in the quest for modernization.

Mongolia's model, the Soviet Union, embarked on widescale extermination campaigns against wolves in order to protect livestock, and campaigns in neighboring Mongol lands of Inner Mongolia (China) and Buryatia (Russia) often shared the same rhetoric as Mongolia.⁵⁸⁰ Soviet Siberian and Arctic reindeer herding regions had similar wolf extermination programs, with Soviet leaders implementing wolf extermination policies to protect Chukchi reindeer herds, and according to post-socialist anthropological studies both Ewen herders and Yukaghir hunters have negative attitudes towards wolves, and often see wolves as greedy competitors.⁵⁸¹ These regions all suffered from the same array of threats of livestock (wolf, disease, disaster) as Mongolia and framed the issues of wolves in similar ways.

Tim Ingold offers an important methodological framework to understand pastoralists' relation with animals, including wolves, by arguing that pastoralism introduces deep insecurity over the possibility of disasters, including predators, which menace pastoral accumulation. While wolves would target wild reindeer in a relatively rational way by killing the sick and old, after domestication, reindeer lose their natural defense mechanism against wolves, who then kill domesticated animals in far greater numbers than they can consume. Ingold points out that this means the herder has to devote even more time protecting his livestock, thus "the more the herds

⁵⁸⁰ M. P. Pavlov, *Volk* (Moscow: Agropromizdat Publ., 1990), 303; David Sneath, *Changing Inner Mongolia: Pastoral Mongolian Society and the Chinese State*, Oxford Studies in Social and Cultural Anthropology (Oxford: Oxford University Press, 2000), 86.

⁵⁸¹ Bathsheba Demuth, *Floating Coast: An Environmental History of the Bering Strait*, 1 edition (New York: W. W. Norton & Company, 2019), 180-181; Piers Vitebsky, *Reindeer People : Living with Animals and Spirits in Siberia*, (London : HarperCollins, 2005), 270-275; Rane Willerslev, *Soul Hunters: Hunting, Animism, and Personhood Among the Siberian Yukaghirs*, (Berkeley: University of California Press, 2007), 76, 91-93; S. I. (Sev'ian Izrailevich) Vainshtein, *Nomads of South Siberia: The Pastoral Economies of Tuva*, (New York: Cambridge Univ. Press, 1980), 80, 180.

are protected, the more they *have* to be.”⁵⁸² Ingold’s study clearly draws the important connection between the pastoralist and the wolf, and the motivations of pastoralists’ fear towards wolves. Like Walker, Ingold emphasizes that humans and wolves are two competing apex predators. Ingold’s conclusions are clearly seen in Mongolia and help explain the common trope of the ravenous wolf that devastates livestock. As such herders killing predators was an important and common economic activity, especially for herders, across the world, and intensified, rather than being invented, in the modern era.

Wolves in Mongolia

The Eurasian grey wolf (*Canis lupus lupus*) is endemic to modern Mongolia, the larger Mongolian plateau, and surrounding lands of Inner Asia and Siberia.⁵⁸³ Areas like forested mountains (*khangai*) and taiga have the largest population of wolves, while the *gobi* (semi-arid or inhabitable desert) has the lowest, with many wolves in the steppe regions as well.⁵⁸⁴ As such the economic role of wolves, as threat to livestock and source of furs, varies across Mongolia. During the Manchu Empire peoples on the edges of Mongolia, like the Tannu Uriankhai, harvested furs, including wolf pelts, to pay their taxes.⁵⁸⁵ There are no clear historical or contemporary population numbers of wolves in Mongolia, and the best source of population numbers are the official government numbers of wolves killed. Gantulga, a Mongolian biologist

⁵⁸² Ingold, *Hunters, Pastoralists, and Ranchers*, 52-53.

⁵⁸³ The Asiatic wild dog or dhole (*Cuon alpinus*) (Mongolian *tsöwör chono*, *sharnad tsöwör*) is often referred to in English and Mongolian as a red wolf (*ulaan chono*) but is a separate species, a confusion that is found in English translations of works from pre-Mongol Inner Asia, and while native to Mongolia is almost certainly extinct in modern Mongolia. Jens Wilkens, “Der Asiatische Rothund (Cuon Alpinus) Im Alttürkischen – Zur Identifikation von Altuigurisch / Karahanidisch Ar Böri,” *Türk Dilleri Arastirmalari* 25/2 (2015), 239; Edward H. Schafer, “Brief Note: The Chinese Dhole,” *Asia Major* 4, no. 1 (1991): 1; Ts. Shiirevdamba et. al., *Mongol Ulsyn Ulaan Nom = Mongolian Red Book*, (Ulaanbaatar: Baigal Orchin Aialal Juulchlalyn Iam, 2016), 43-44.

⁵⁸⁴ N. Batsaikhan et. al., *Mongol orny khökhötön am’tad : tanikh garyn avlaga* (London: Zoological Society of London, 2014), 226; Jigmiddorji, Urta, and Nongnaijab. *Amitan-u jirugtu toli*. 1. keb., Kökeqota: Öbör Monggol-un Surgan Kümüjil-ün Keblel-ün Qoriy-a, 1986, 1550.

⁵⁸⁵ Schlesinger, *A World Trimmed with Fur*, 129.

researching wolves, is currently working to understand historical population numbers using governmental archival data, and contemporary numbers with methods such as camera traps.⁵⁸⁶

The Mongolian word for wolf is *chono* (Classical Mongolian *chino* 'a, Middle Mongol *chino* and *china*), along with many nicknames or taboo names, used to avoid inviting bad luck and the wolf preying on one's livestock.⁵⁸⁷ These nicknames include Blue Wolf (*khökh chono*), Steppe Animal (*kheeriin amitan*), Creeping Gray (*mölkhöö bor*), Gray (*orog*), Stumpy (*shodgor*), and *bookhoi*. These names can be combined and modified, as in the example of Dүgersүren, a Khalkha herder from Zawkhan born in 1951, who was interviewed for *The Oral History of Twentieth Century Mongolia* project, who refers to wolves using three names together, "*kheeriin bookhoi chono*."⁵⁸⁸ Other nicknames for wolves are derived from Buddhist clergy, including Luwsan the Monk, Creeping Luwsan, and Reverend Oidow.⁵⁸⁹ These names were used by socialist authors to compare greedy wolves with greedy lamas.

It is also common to substitute dog (*nokhoi*) for wolf, or use dog in some combination of nicknames, like Steppe Dog, Khangai Dog, Country Dog, and so on. This is similar to Japan, where Walker explains there was a great deal of overlap in the various terms and definitions between dog and wolves, which sparked debates in in pre-modern and modern Japan over the exact distinction between wolves and dogs.⁵⁹⁰ This was exacerbated by the history of hybridization between wolves and dogs and the subsequent Western-influenced need to clearly

⁵⁸⁶ Personal correspondence.

⁵⁸⁷ Nicholas Poppe, "On Some Mongolian Names of Wild Beasts," *Central Asiatic Journal* 9, no. 3 (1964): 164.

⁵⁸⁸ Dүgersүren, *The Oral History of Twentieth Century Mongolia*, http://amantuuh.socanth.cam.ac.uk/search/view_person.php?Person=990013

⁵⁸⁹ J. Damdin, *Buural Anchny Temdeglel*, (Ulaanbaatar: Ulsyn Kheveleliin Khereeeg Erkhlekh Khoroo, 1963), 62; Charles R. Bawden, *Mongolian-English Dictionary* (New York: Columbia University, 1997), 204, 216, 255

⁵⁹⁰ Brett L. Walker, *The Lost Wolves of Japan*, Weyerhaeuser Environmental Books (Seattle: University of Washington Press, 2005), 24.

delineate between the two species.⁵⁹¹ Wolf-dog hybrids appear to occur in Mongolia as well, and there are numerous stories of wolf-dog hybrids which are hard to verify, but of the very belief in their existence is important. These hybrids (*erliiz*), like livestock hybrids in chapter two, are often said to be bigger and better than the sum of their parts, but as with human *erliiz* explored by Uradyn Bulag they are clearly other and do not really belong.⁵⁹² Hybrid wolf-dogs are another close connection between wolves and feral dogs.

Although wolves were and are hunted many ways in Mongolia, one method was so pervasive that it became a term solely associated with killing wolves. The usual term for hunting is *an* (Classical Mongolian *ang*).⁵⁹³ However, the word that is today used exclusively for hunting wolves, *aw* (Classical Mongolian *aba*) was historically the word used for a battue or circle hunt.⁵⁹⁴ These large-scale hunts in which hunters would form a circle, at times miles long, and slowly advance to constrict every living thing into a small area, where they would be slaughtered. Khohchahar E. Chuluu has researched the circle hunt, and detailed its military importance in the Manchu Qing period, and regional variations of the circle hunt.⁵⁹⁵

Circle hunts, or battue, are famously attested throughout the Mongol Empire, through the early modern period in Mongolia.⁵⁹⁶ In the Imperial period, the circle hunt was a major indicator of social status, with an early oath given to Chinggis promised to execute the circle hunt for him,

⁵⁹¹ Aaron Herald Skabelund, *Empire of Dogs : Canines, Japan, and the Making of the Modern Imperial World* (Ithaca, NY, USA: Cornell University Press, 2011), 8.

⁵⁹² Bulag, *Nationalism and Hybridity in Mongolia*, 140.

⁵⁹³ Bawden, *Mongolian-English Dictionary*, 20; Tsevel, *Mongol Khelnii Tovch Tailbar Tol'*, 42.

⁵⁹⁴ Bawden, *Mongolian-English Dictionary*, 2; Tsevel, *Mongol Khelnii Tovch Tailbar Tol'*, 14.

⁵⁹⁵ Khohchahar E. Chuluu, "The Formation and Regulations of the Military Hunt in Qing Mongolia," *Inner Asia* 20, no. 1 (2018): 5–25; Khohchahar E. Chuluu, "The Encircling Hunt of Mongolia: Institutional Structures and Socio-Political Implications," *Tōyō Bunka Kenkyūjo Kiyō [Memoirs of the Institute for Advanced Studies on Asia]*, 2017, 25–58.

⁵⁹⁶ Allsen argues that the circle hunt was part of the larger history of the royal Eurasian hunt. He also provides other names in Mongolian for the circle hunt: qomorgha, jerge, and nerge. Thomas T. Allsen, *The Royal Hunt in Eurasian History*, (Philadelphia: University of Pennsylvania Press, 2006), 26.

providing him the various game they killed.⁵⁹⁷ Later, one of the rights awarded to the *darqan* Badai, Kishiliq, and Sorqan Shira is keeping animals they killed in the circle hunt.⁵⁹⁸ The hunting circle's importance in the Mongol elite is shown in many contemporary histories written in the Mongol Empire, such as Juvaini's *History of the World Conqueror*.⁵⁹⁹ This is also documented extensively by travelers to the Mongol empire, as the Song Chinese emissary Zhao Gong and later Peng Daya and Xu Ting give clear descriptions of the circle hunt and its importance to Mongolian society, and clearly differentiate between the circle hunt and individual hunts.⁶⁰⁰ Marco Polo also provides detailed information of circle hunts and other various hunting styles through the Empire, especially Qubilai Qa'an's grand hunts.⁶⁰¹ Post-Imperial hunts were nowhere near as large, but the basic principal of a wide scale organized circle hunt remained.

It is not clear when *aw* became associated with hunting wolves, but the connection is that one nobility's expected jobs included killing predators, which was most often in the circle hunt. The lupine protagonist of Sangdag's "What the Wolf Encircled by the Hunt Said," (*Awyn khomorgond orson chonyn khelsen ni*) shows the clear correlation between wolves and circle hunts in the early 19th century.⁶⁰² After stealing livestock, the local lord organizes a hunt, with the wolf explaining that

When the Lord of the Banner
Leading his troops like a wedge,

⁵⁹⁷ Igor de Rachewiltz, trans., *The Secret History of the Mongols: A Mongolian Epic Chronicle of the Thirteenth Century*, Brill's Inner Asian Library, v. 7 (Leiden ; Boston: Brill, 2004), §123

⁵⁹⁸ de Rachewiltz, *The Secret History of the Mongols*: §187, 219.

⁵⁹⁹ 'Alā' al-Dīn 'Aṭā Malik Juvaynī, trans. John Andrew Boyle, *Genghis Khan: The History of the World Conqueror* (Seattle: University of Washington Press, 1997), 27-30.

⁶⁰⁰ Christopher P. Atwood, trans., *The Rise of the Mongols: Five Chinese Sources* (Cambridge: Hackett Publishing Company, Inc., 2021).

⁶⁰¹ Marco Polo and Sharon Kinoshita, *The Description of the World* (Indianapolis: Hackett Publishing Company, Inc, 2016), § 91-94.

⁶⁰² Charles R. Bawden, ed., *Mongolian Traditional Literature: An Anthology*, (London ; New York : New York: Kegan Paul ; Distributed by Columbia University Press, 2003), 726-727; Ce. Damdinsürüng, ed., *Monggol Uran Jokiyal-Un Degeji Jagun Bilig Orusibai*, (Ulaganbagatur: Būgūde Naiiramdaqu Monggol Arad Ulus-un Sinjileküi Uqagan ba Degedü Bolbasural-un Kūriyeleng-ün Keblel, 1959), 432; ᠲᠤᠰ Damdinsüren and D. Tsolmon, eds., *Mongolyn Uran Zokhilyn Deezh Zuun Bileg Orshiv* v. 3 (Ulaanbaatar: Bembi San Khevelelin Gazar, 2000), 198.

Riding their good, swift horses,
Chased me like a whirlwind and caught me up.⁶⁰³

A very similar text, “Conversation between the Wolf and the Noble” (*Chono noyon khoyoryn yaria*) the noble organizes the circle hunt to slay the wolf at the request of his subjects (*albat*).⁶⁰⁴ As discussed below, this anonymous piece and Sangdag flip the convention on its head by asking pity for the wolf, but the role of the noble in organizing the hunt for the wolf is clearly established.

James Gilmour, a Christian missionary in Mongolia in the 1870s, describes the process of hunting wolves with a pole lasso. Although he does not frame it as a battue or circle hunt, he explains that on the smaller end, of a “couple of horsemen, one to hunt, and one to head off, can be pretty sure of killing their game.”⁶⁰⁵ On the larger scale he witnessed a wealthy Mongolian who upon hearing about a nearby wolf “ordered his men to mount and pursue the beast. This order made every face radiant with joyous excitement; and in a few moments the retainers were galloping over the plain.”⁶⁰⁶ The hunt was a failure, which angered the wealthy Mongol and disappointing his servants. It is not clear from Gilmour’s description whether this wealthy Mongol was actually of noble or aristocratic status, but the large-scale organization of the circle hunt by the upper class is evident. The importance of the circle hunt in Mongolian social status, and its close association with hunting wolves shows the importance of organizing the killing of wolves by Mongolian authorities well before the socialist era.

⁶⁰³ Bawden, ed., *Mongolian Traditional Literature*, 726-727; Damdinsürüng, ed., *Monggol Uran Jokiyal-Un Degeji Jagun Bilig Orusibai*, 432; Damdinsüren and Tsolmon, eds., *Mongolyn Uran Zokhiolyn Deezh Zuun Bileg Orshiv*, 198.

⁶⁰⁴ “Chono noyon khoyoryn yaria” XIV 2756/96, National Library of Mongolia; L. Tüdev et al., eds., *Mongolyn Uran Zokhiolyn Deezhis* vol. 9 (Ulaanbaatar: “Mongol Uran Zokhiol” khevleliin gazar, 1995), 286.

⁶⁰⁵ James Gilmour, *Among the Mongols*, (New York, N.Y.; Washington D.C; London: Praeger, 1970), 353.

⁶⁰⁶ Gilmour, *Among the Mongols*, 353.

Contemporary anthropological studies by Natasha Fijn focus on Mongolian's spiritual relationship with animals, including wolves, and contrast Mongolian attitudes with Western anti-wolf viewpoints.⁶⁰⁷ Fijn's informants explained that wolves are more likely to attack a misbehaving herder, and Fijn states "in the countryside, however, herders do not usually kill wolves for sport; they kill them to prevent them from encroaching into the co-domestic sphere where they pose a threat to the herd animals."⁶⁰⁸ Her informants included prolific wolf hunters who stated that wolf convey luck or *khiimori* when killed. Similarly, Bernard Charlier's *Faces of the Wolf* uses the wolf as a framing device to explain how the contemporary Mongolians he stayed with saw the world through interconnected animated environments and animals.⁶⁰⁹ Some scholars even argue that the reason wolves are not yet extinct in Mongolia is because of their religious and cultural importance to Mongolians.⁶¹⁰ The extreme end of this trope is seen in Jiang Rong's popular novel *Wolf Totem*, also adapted into a film, which compares the loss of Inner Mongolian culture during the Chinese Cultural Revolution with extermination campaigns of the wolf and features colonialist imagery of the Han Chinese bringing modernity to a foreign and backwards Mongolian culture.⁶¹¹

Wolves certainly play an important role in the Mongolian spiritual world, and they are notable as one of three beings, along with horses and humans, which possess *khiimori* (spirit, or good fortune) in Mongolian Buddhism. By killing the wolf, one takes the *khiimori* for oneself as a hunter named Norow explained in an interview in the "Oral History Project of Twentieth

⁶⁰⁷ Fijn, *Living with Herds*, 208.

⁶⁰⁸ Fijn, *Living with Herds*, 209.

⁶⁰⁹ Bernard Charlier, *Faces of the Wolf: Managing the Human, Non-Human Boundary in Mongolia*, Inner Asia Book Series, volume 10 (Leiden, The Netherlands: Brill, 2015), 10.

⁶¹⁰ J.R. Wingard and P. Zahler, *Silent Steppe: The Illegal Wildlife Trade Crisis in Mongolia*, Mongolia Discussion Papers, East Asia and Pacific Environment and Social Development Department. (Washington D.C.: Washington D.C.: World Bank., 2006), 99; Renée Worringer, "Shepherd's Enemy or Aşina, Böri, Börte Činō, and Bozkurt?: Wolf as Menace, Wolf as Mythical," *Society & Animals* 24, no. 6 (2016): 557-558.

⁶¹¹ Rong Jiang, *Wolf Totem*, trans. Howard Goldblatt (New York: Penguin Press, 2008).

Century Mongolia.”⁶¹² Examples of killing animals while having great respect or love for them has been highlighted in ethnographic and historical scholarship.⁶¹³ However, archival materials, oral history, folklore, and literary sources from the socialist period, as well as materials from pre-modern and post-socialist Mongolia show that this was not the most common attitude towards wolves. Instead, wolves were most often seen with antipathy in modern and pre-modern Mongolia.

Wolves in pre-modern Mongolia

Many pre-modern sources on wolves in Mongolia have similar depictions to socialist era depictions of the wolf as a dangerous beast which plays a fundamental threat to life and livelihood. The wolf shows up a number of times in *The Secret History of the Mongols*, the mid-13th century historical chronicle of Chinggis Khan’s family and rise to power.⁶¹⁴ When discussing the importance of the wolf in Mongolia, many point to the first legendary ancestor of Chinggis Khan, Grey (or Blue-Grey) Wolf (*Börte Chino’a*) and his wife Fallow Doe (*Ghu’a Maral*). It is often said, as in Igor de Rachewiltz’s translation, that Blue-Grey Wolf is a wolf, therefore Chinggis is descended from a wolf.⁶¹⁵ Some scholars, as well as some Mongolians, misinterpret this to claim that *all* Mongolians were held to be descended from the wolf, despite the genealogy in the *Secret History* explicitly being that of the Borjigid noble lineage, not that of all Mongolians.

However, according to some versions of this same legend Grey Wolf was simply the personal name of a human ancestor of Chinggis Khan. The Persian historian Rashid al-Din

⁶¹² Norow, *The Oral History of Twentieth Century Mongolia*, <http://amantuuh.socanth.cam.ac.uk/>

⁶¹³ Hilda Kean, *The Great Cat and Dog Massacre: The Real Story of World War Two’s Unknown Tragedy* (Chicago: University of Chicago Press, 2017); Rane Willerslev, *Soul Hunters: Hunting, Animism, and Personhood Among the Siberian Yukaghirs* (Berkeley: University of California Press, 2007).

⁶¹⁴ Igor de Rachewiltz, trans., *The Secret History of the Mongols: A Mongolian Epic Chronicle of the Thirteenth Century*, Brill’s Inner Asian Library, v. 7 (Leiden ; Boston: Brill, 2004), § 1.

⁶¹⁵ de Rachewiltz, *The Secret History of the Mongols*; § 1.

describes Blue-Grey Wolf as a human ancestor of Chinggis Khan.⁶¹⁶ The *Golden Summary* (*Altan tobchi*), a mid-17th century Mongolian chronicle by Lubsang-Danzin that includes elements from a variety of sources including the *Secret History*, also portrays Grey Wolf and his wife Fallow Doe as human ancestors of Chinggis.⁶¹⁷ Later in the *Golden Summary*, their animal counterparts appear in a circle hunt and are spared by Chinggis Khan.⁶¹⁸ De Rachewiltz discusses the controversy in his commentary and lists the various sources supporting each interpretation, but does not explain how he came to his conclusion that Grey Wolf is in fact a wolf and interpretation of the pair as human is a later invention.⁶¹⁹ The possible lupine ancestry of the Mongols is similar to that found among Turks and other steppe peoples who traced their ancestry to wolves, which Christopher Beckwith also connects to the Romulus and Remus myth.⁶²⁰

Another one of Chinggis' ancestors, Alan the Beautiful was impregnated by a golden being that left her *ger* in the form of a golden dog, another possible reference to a wolf given the common interchange of terms.⁶²¹ In addition, one of the Mongolic peoples mentioned in the *Secret History* are the Wolves (*Chinos*).⁶²² Wolves are also used in a variety of metaphors and aphorisms in the *Secret History*. When Alan's son Bodonchar the Fool was abandoned by his brothers, he survived by hunting with his hawk, and "when he had nothing to eat, he stalked the wild game which wolves had penned in on the cliffs," and scavenging the remains left behind by

⁶¹⁶ Rashid al-Din Ṭabib, *Rashiduddin Fazlullah's Jami'u't-Tawarikh: Compendium of Chronicles*, trans. W. M. Thackston, (Cambridge, Mass.: Harvard University, Dept. of Near Eastern Languages and Civilizations, 1998), 114.

⁶¹⁷ Charles R. Bawden, ed., *The Mongol Chronicle Altan Tobči*, Göttinger Asiatische Forschungen, Bd. 5 (Wiesbaden: O. Harrassowitz, 1955), § 4.

⁶¹⁸ Bawden, *Altan Tobči*, § 39.

⁶¹⁹ de Rachewiltz, trans., *The Secret History of the Mongols*, § 224-225.

⁶²⁰ Peter B. Golden, "Wolves, Dogs, and Qipcaq Religion," *Acta Orientalia Academiae Scientiarum Hungaricae* 50, no. 1/3 (1997): 87-97; Christopher I. Beckwith, *Empires of the Silk Road: A History of Central Eurasia from the Bronze Age to the Present* (Princeton University Press, 2009), 4-10.

⁶²¹ de Rachewiltz, *The Secret History of the Mongols*, § 21.

⁶²² de Rachewiltz, *The Secret History of the Mongols*, § 129, 207.

wolves.⁶²³ Bodonchar's taming of a hawk represents the establishment of the long history of falconry Mongolia and the rest of Eurasia, while scavenging the remains of wolf kills is a clear indicator of the lowest point in his struggle to survive.⁶²⁴

Although the importance of wolves in early Mongol culture is clear, the majority of references to wolves in the *Secret History* are negative. After Temüjin, the future Chinggis Khan, kills his half-brother Bekter, his mother curses him and compares him a number of dangerous and foul animals, including a “wolf stalking its prey under cover of a blizzard.”⁶²⁵ Chinggis Khan named his generals Jebe, Qubilai, Jelme, and Sübe'edei his Four Dogs, a likely euphemism for a wolf given the common interchanging of terms.⁶²⁶ When confronted by the Four Dogs, the Naiman ruler fearfully referred to them as “like wolves that come chasing a flock of sheep and pursuing them at the sheep-pen.”⁶²⁷ Chinggis' one time companion Jamuqa reinforced this fearful imagery by adding that Chinggis fed his Four Dogs human flesh and restrained them with iron chains, only to be released upon his enemies. Wolves in the *Secret History* are both feared beasts and admirable ancestors (or at least namesakes of ancestors), but as in other cases in Mongolian history, they are just as often sources of danger and ruin.

There are a number of religious and folkloric text on wolves from Qing-era Mongolia, though some are harder to date. Wolves appear in a famous example of Buddhist didactic literature, “The Turquoise Key” (*Oyun tülkigür*), one version of which councils the ruler that “if

⁶²³ de Rachewiltz, *The Secret History of the Mongols*, § 26.

⁶²⁴ de Rachewiltz, *The Secret History of the Mongols*, § 209.

⁶²⁵ de Rachewiltz, *The Secret History of the Mongols*, § 78.

⁶²⁶ de Rachewiltz, *The Secret History of the Mongols*, § 265, 406, 521

⁶²⁷ de Rachewiltz, *The Secret History of the Mongols*, § 195.

you do not have a steady and good disposition,/You will be offensive like a menacing wolf.”⁶²⁸

Another reads “[This shastra] is like a pure-minded [man] watering/a wolf and a sheep in one trough.”⁶²⁹ This phrasing clearly represents the wolf and sheep in opposition only able to exist through religious achievement, similar to the lamb and the lion in Biblical imagery.

One anonymous story, “The Story of the Mountain Goat” features a mother goat whose kids Bambai and Chambai are tricked and devoured by a “cruel wolf, destroyer of all creatures.”⁶³⁰ Finally in despair, she goes to a woodcutter, offering to give him dairy and wool for the rest of his days if he will help her kill the wicked wolf, and protect her descendants. The man tricks the wolf, which allows the goat to kill it, and Bambai and Chambai come out of his stomach, still alive. The story gives a folkloric explanation of domestication and emphasizes the importance of people in protecting their livestock from wolves. As Ingold argues, humans protect their herds from wolves but once they do so, the animals lose the ability to do so themselves.

Dorji Meyiren (1878-1943)’s “The Story of the Hare, The Hogget, and the Wolf” which depicts a hare and sheep pretending to be Manchu officials who put a wolf on trial.⁶³¹ They declare the wolf is a sinful beast, and that it is “deplorable that when they rob and steal the beasts owned by humans, they do not pay attention to merely satisfying themselves, but, however many there are, they destroy them utterly, with greedy intent.”⁶³² The wolf manages to escape before

⁶²⁸ Charles R. Bawden, ed., *Mongolian Traditional Literature: An Anthology*, (London ; New York : New York: Kegan Paul ; Distributed by Columbia University Press, 2003), 115. For a discussion of why it is to be read as “Turquoise Key” rather than “Key to Wisdom,” see G. Kara, review of *Review of An Anthology of Mongolian Traditional Literature*, by Charles R. Bawden, *Mongolian Studies* 26 (2003): 94.

⁶²⁹ N.S. Yakhontova, “The ‘Oyun Tülkigür’ or ‘Key to Wisdom’: Text and Translation Based on the MSS in the Institute for Oriental Studies at St. Petersburg,” *Mongolian Studies* 23 (2000): § 108.

⁶³⁰ Charles R. Bawden, ed., *Mongolian Traditional Literature: An Anthology*, (London ; New York : New York: Kegan Paul ; Distributed by Columbia University Press, 2003), 510.

⁶³¹ Bawden, *Mongolian Traditional Literature*, 193.

⁶³² Bawden, *Mongolian Traditional Literature*, 194.

they execute him, but the story clearly puts the clever hare and the sheep on the side of right, while the wolf is an easily fooled villain.

Supernatural methods were often called upon to combat the wolf. Hunting rituals such as those collected by B. Rinchen and translated by Charles Bawden were used to target wolves as well as other game animals.⁶³³ Damdin the Grizzled Hunter, a well decorated hunter and author of the 1963 *Notes of a Grizzled Hunter*, also provides hunting rituals in the appendices, which he insists are backwards and provided for only scholarly purposes.⁶³⁴ Many of these texts are prayers addressed to Manaqan, ruler of wild beasts to allow the hunter to kill a number of animals.⁶³⁵ Wolves are named explicitly in a number of these offerings, including blue wolves (*khökh chono*), and may be included in some of the metaphorical references of “long-tailed carnivores,” and almost certainly are the “blue dogs” referenced in one text.⁶³⁶ Diluwa Khutugtu, an incarnate lama, relates a story of the infamous Ja Lama, an early 20th century Kalmyk adventurer in Western Mongolia the who was said to have magic powers, particularly focused around his gun.⁶³⁷ One of the stories of Ja Lama’s gun magic relates how one night a wolf raided a flock of sheep, in which Ja Lama fired his gun from the entrance in his *ger* into the night, and the next morning the wolf was found dead from Ja Lama’s bullet next to the flock of sheep.⁶³⁸

⁶³³ Charles R. Bawden, “Mongols Notes: II. Some ‘Shamanist’ Hunting Rituals from Mongolia,” *Central Asiatic Journal* 12, no. 2 (1968): 101.

⁶³⁴ J. Damdin, *Buural Anchny Temdeglel* (Ulaanbaatar: Ulsyn Khevreliin Khreeg Erkhlekh Khoroo, 1963), 111.

⁶³⁵ Bawden, “Mongols Notes: II. Some ‘Shamanist’ Hunting Rituals from Mongolia,” 111.

⁶³⁶ Bawden, “Mongols Notes: II. Some ‘Shamanist’ Hunting Rituals from Mongolia,” 126, 127, 128, 131, 136; Damdin, *Buural anchny temdeglel*, 112.

⁶³⁷ Owen Lattimore and Fujiko Isono, trans., *The Diluv Khutagt: Memoirs and Autobiography of a Mongol Buddhist Reincarnation in Religion and Revolution*, Asiatische Forschungen, Band 74, (Wiesbaden: Harrassowitz, 1982), 163.

⁶³⁸ Lattimore and Fujiko Isono, trans., *The Diluv Khutagt*, 164.

Prayers and rituals were used defensively against wolves as well, as in an incantation to provide protection from a wolf that is preying on the herd translated by Bawden. The text calls for placing salt, iron, and nine black stones on the head (Bawden suggests that this is likely a model, rather than a literal head), wrapping it in cloth and burying it under the threshold.⁶³⁹ The text then calls for repeating the incantation three times. The spell begins

I cast a spell till I nail down the mad wolf of the rocks.
I cast a spell, making you bite salt in your gaping mouth.
I cast a spell that my foals and colts may be safe.
I cast a spell that my sheep and lambs may be safe.
Smash apart the scapulas.
Shoot him, spear him.⁶⁴⁰

The text continues to curse the wolf, interspersed with Buddhist prayers.⁶⁴¹

Manuscripts of Oirat amulets from the 19th or early 20th century offer protection from the wolf.⁶⁴² Illustrations with Tibetan and Oirat clear script text depict wolves being chained and shot at with flaming arrow with Oirat language curses reading “trap the dangerous wolf” and “bind the wolf’s mouth,” while the Tibetan text on the amulets include onomatopoeia and Buddhist prayers. The spells echo the curses collected by Bawden, suggesting a common formulation. The same model of protective charm, with similar iconography, in this case a vajra and swastika, was found in Khalkha lands in the 1960s, though they lack the written prayers, which demonstrates the strong continuity of such amulets, even across different Mongol people and periods.⁶⁴³

⁶³⁹ Bawden, “Mongols Notes: II. Some ‘Shamanist’ Hunting Rituals from Mongolia,” 118.

⁶⁴⁰ Bawden, “Mongols Notes: II. Some ‘Shamanist’ Hunting Rituals from Mongolia,” 119.

⁶⁴¹ Bawden, “Mongols Notes: II. Some ‘Shamanist’ Hunting Rituals from Mongolia,” 120.

⁶⁴² From an untitled manuscript of amulets written in Oirat-Tibetan. f.35a; f.35b; f. 55a., György Kara’s private collection.

⁶⁴³ S. Chuluun et al., *Mongolyn ugsaatny züin kheeriin sudalgaany ekh khereglegdekhüün* v.7 (Ulaanbaatar: Soembo Printing, 2011), 149-150.

Protection from wolves is also found in various Buddhist texts related to the *owoo* (rock cairn). These ritual prayers are often concerned with preventing calamity, which in many specifically includes wolves. Bawden translates Buddhist rituals from the mid-19th century collected by Mergen Diyanchi Lama which were performed at an *owoo*. These are prayers for long life and rain, as well as protection from demons, plagues, and to “avert evils of the type of wolves attacking the flocks, thieves and brigands stirring abroad, hail, drought or cattle-pest occurring.”⁶⁴⁴ Wolves are in the same category as every other threat towards livestock, the same issues later addressed by collectivization.

Walther Heissig records multiple praise prayers in his *The Religions of Mongolia*.

The prayer to the black standard (*sülde*) of Chinggis Khan pleads

For the five kinds of herd-animal outside
No misfortune and no wild anger, drought or famine,
No great alarms,
No danger from wolf or dog, no danger from the evil enemy, thieves and brigands.⁶⁴⁵

This prayer also shows the close connection between wolves and feral dogs. Both are threats to livestock, and it shows that socialist dog anti-dog campaigns have a long history as well. Other texts translated by Heissig include a prayer to Gesar that references wolves and predators, while a fire ritual has a “request to keep illnesses at a distance, to preserve from slippery ice and hunger, to prevent wolves and thieves from coming near, to protect from cattle-plague.”⁶⁴⁶

⁶⁴⁴ C. R. Bawden, “Two Mongol Texts Concerning Obo-Worship,” *Oriens Extremus* 5, no. 1 (1958): 38-39.

⁶⁴⁵ Walther Heissig, *The Religions of Mongolia*, (Berkeley: University of California Press, 1980), 86, 94.

⁶⁴⁶ Heissig, *The Religions of Mongolia*, 75.

According to John Gombojab Hangin when wolves, weather, bandits, or disease were especially rife, Chakhar Mongols would hold special religious ceremonies to address these evils, likely similar to the *owoo* prayers in Khalkha Mongolia.⁶⁴⁷

The use of religion to combat wolves was not limited to Buddhism or shamanism. Joseph Kler, who lived in the Scheut Mission in Ordos for a number of years, describes the Mongolian hunting culture in the early 20th century.⁶⁴⁸ He writes that “the Mongol is very much afraid of wolves because they are a real danger for his flocks.”⁶⁴⁹ In a custom parallel to the Buddhist prayers against wolves, Kler notes that “our Christian Mongols at times ask that Masses be said in order that flocks may be protected against the wolves, who when they are hungry and running in packs are rapacious.”⁶⁵⁰

Not all Mongolians were hostile to wolves; there was a continued genre of wolf apologia. The poems of the Khalkha prince Tsogtu Taiji (1581–1637), the story “What the Wolf Encircled by the Hunt Said” by the nineteenth century satirist Sangdag the Storyteller, and the anonymous “Conversation Between the Wolf and the Noble” frame the wolf as similar to thieves, but then the authors argue using Buddhist rhetoric that the wolf in fact deserved pity (*khöörkhii*). This is because the wolf has no choice but to steal, just like a starving thief, and that the wolf was ultimately doomed for the amount of sin it accumulated in its lifetime. Tsogtu Taiji connects wolves and thieves in one of his many rock poems, and implies that both of them steal because they are starving.

Although different are the apparent bodily forms
Of a thief who robs you from near or from afar
And a wolf prowling the edge of camp,

⁶⁴⁷ Herbert Harold Vreeland, *Mongol Community and Kinship Structure* (Westport, Conn: Greenwood Press, 1973), 127.

⁶⁴⁸ Joseph Kler, “Hunting Customs of the Ordos Mongols,” *Primitive Man* 14, no. 3 (1941): 38.

⁶⁴⁹ Kler, “Hunting Customs of the Ordos Mongols,” 44.

⁶⁵⁰ Kler, “Hunting Customs of the Ordos Mongols,” 44.

In air of hunger for sustenance, they are one and the same.⁶⁵¹

The most famous and most explicit of the trope of the sympathy for the wolf as thief was by the great nineteenth century satirist Sangdag the Storyteller, whose various works take the point of view of an animal or plant, using its plight to comment on the situation of the Gobi people.⁶⁵² His works are well documented in Mongolian and in English translations, particularly by Charles Bawden. In “What the Wolf Encircled by the Hunt Said” (*Awyn khomorgond orson chonyn khelsen ni*), a doomed wolf pleads for his life from a noble.⁶⁵³ Sangdag depicts the wolf as a pitiful, sinful beast that is guilty of stealing baby animals, but did so only to survive, and like Tsogtu Taiji, Sangdag is explicit in his comparison. After lamenting his situation hunted by the local lord, the wolf declares

As for my mortal body, it is a beggar's.
As for the thoughts I think, they are a thief's.
Wherever I go is hell.⁶⁵⁴

The wolf is a guilty of being a thief, but he is a pitiful creature that is oppressed by the nobles and his men in the battue circle hunt. The wolf describes his sinful existence and explains the difficulties of his life, and is filled with regret for stealing baby animals, but insists he had no

⁶⁵¹ Brian Baumann, “The Stone Inscription of Tsogt Taij (Čoytu Tayiji),” *Sources of Mongolian Buddhism*, 2020, 3–5; Zhigzhidiin Boldbaatar and Ch. Dagvadorzh, *Mongol tumnii sod khumuus. Dotgoor bot*, (Ulaanbaatar: Soembo Printing KhKhK, 2014), 127, 106.

⁶⁵² Charles R. Bawden, ed., *Mongolian Traditional Literature: An Anthology*, (London ; New York : New York: Kegan Paul ; Distributed by Columbia University Press, 2003), xi, 726-727; Ce. Damdinsürüng, ed., *Monggol Uran Jokiyal-Un Degeji Jagun Bilig Orusibai*, ([Ulaganbagatur: Būgūde Naiiramdaqu Monggol Arad Ulus-un Sinjileküi Uqagan ba Degedü Bolbasural-un Kūriyeleng-ün Keblel, 1959), 432; T̂S Damdinsüren and D. T̂Solmon, eds., *Mongolyn Uran Zokhilyn Deezh Zuun Bileg Orshiv* v. 3 (Ulaanbaatar: Bembi San Kheveleliin Gazar, 2000), 198.

⁶⁵³ Bawden, *Mongolian Traditional Literature*, 726-727; Ce. Damdinsürüng, ed., *Monggol Uran Jokiyal-Un Degeji Jagun Bilig Orusibai*, ([Ulaganbagatur: Būgūde Naiiramdaqu Monggol Arad Ulus-un Sinjileküi Uqagan ba Degedü Bolbasural-un Kūriyeleng-ün Keblel, 1959), 432; T̂S Damdinsüren and D. T̂Solmon, eds., *Mongolyn Uran Zokhilyn Deezh Zuun Bileg Orshiv* v. 3 (Ulaanbaatar: Bembi San Kheveleliin Gazar, 2000), 198.

⁶⁵⁴ ⁶⁵⁴ Bawden, *Mongolian Traditional Literature*, 726-727; Ce. Damdinsürüng, ed., *Monggol Uran Jokiyal-Un Degeji Jagun Bilig Orusibai*, ([Ulaganbagatur: Būgūde Naiiramdaqu Monggol Arad Ulus-un Sinjileküi Uqagan ba Degedü Bolbasural-un Kūriyeleng-ün Keblel, 1959), 432; T̂S Damdinsüren and D. T̂Solmon, eds., *Mongolyn Uran Zokhilyn Deezh Zuun Bileg Orshiv* v. 3 (Ulaanbaatar: Bembi San Kheveleliin Gazar, 2000), 198.

other choice. Sangdag concludes with the wolf pleading the prince for mercy. The wolf's fate is ambiguous but is unlikely to be positive.

Although Sangdag's work is the most famous example of the theme of pity for the wolf as thief, it is not the only one. The "Conversation Between the Wolf and the Noble" (*Chono noyon khoyoryn yaria*) offers a longer detailed depiction of this theme. Unlike Sangdag's version, it features a debate between the wolf and noble, rather than a monologue by the wolf. The author and date are unknown, but copies exist both in the National Library of Mongolia and Saint Petersburg.⁶⁵⁵ The noble organizes a large circle hunt because of the large wolf population preying upon his people's livestock. After slaughtering many wolves, he is stopped by one who can speak human tongue. The wolf engages the noble in a debate over his life, and the level of sin he committed. In the end the noble sees the merits of the wolf's argument and agrees that one should pity and show mercy to the wolf-thief. In contrast, Sangdag provides no response from the noble and implies that the wolf will die in the end. This negative portrayal of the noble fits with Sangdag's style of satire and criticism of society. The two stories agree, however, that the wolf should not be hated and blamed for preying on young animals and livestock, just like the thief should not be blamed for stealing. These depictions are clearly reactions against common portrayals of the wolf as a thief, and must be read as counter arguments to the pervasive anti-wolf narrative.

The defense of the wolf as a pitiful creature continued to be cited in the 20th century. According to Sechin Jagchid, in the 1930s the Panchen Lama, a major leader in Tibetan and Mongolian Buddhism, urged Mongolians not to hunt wolves, and instead called for pity of the

⁶⁵⁵ "Chono noen khoeryn yaria" National Library of Mongolia 2 296 56/96; L. Tüdev et al., eds., *Mongolyn Uran Zokhiolyn Deezhis* v. 9 (Ulaanbaatar: "Mongol Uran Zokhiol" khevleliin gazar, 1995), 286-290.

wolf for its sins accumulated through eating animals.⁶⁵⁶ In contrast, the Inner Mongolian Prince Demchungdongrub, or De Wang, told his followers to not hunt the wolf, but “emulate its firm will and determination.”⁶⁵⁷ Meanwhile the Young Mongol intellectuals derided these pro-wolf messages as superstitious nonsense, while average Mongols paid little attention and continued to hunt as usual.⁶⁵⁸

Foreign Observers

In 1919, immediately before the socialist period, the Russian diplomat Ivan Mikhailovich Maiskii describes wolves as a “scourge,” and causes the “loss of tens and hundreds of thousands” of livestock, especially during winter. He claims that Mongolians did not do anything about wolves because of their “characteristic Mongolian passiveness.” Instead, they see them “as a natural calamity, like storms, snows, plagues, and earthquakes, something to be regretted, but something utterly futile to struggle against.” Elsewhere, Maiskii laments that despite the richness of fur bearing animals, Mongols do little hunting in part because of “the influence of religion, which does not approve of the destruction of living things.”⁶⁵⁹ These claims are orientalist and an example of the slippery slope of relying on common religious tropes to understand an entire people. And, as Johann Elverskog argues, the idea of an inherently environmentalist Buddhism is pervasive but little basis in reality.⁶⁶⁰ The alleged contrast between European and Mongolian attitudes mixed with stereotypes of harmonious Mongolian environmentalism unfortunately has a surprisingly long life.

⁶⁵⁶ Sechin Jagchid and Paul Hyer, *Mongolia's Culture and Society*, (Boulder, Colo: Westview Press, 1979), 146.

⁶⁵⁷ Jagchid and Hyer, *Mongolia's Culture and Society*, 36.

⁶⁵⁸ Jagchid and Hyer, *Mongolia's Culture and Society*, 36.

⁶⁵⁹ Maiskii, *Mongoliia nakanune revoliutsii*, 122; Maiskii, *Contemporary Mongolia*, 282-283.

⁶⁶⁰ Elverskog, *The Buddha's Footprint*.

A.D. Simukov provides a much more grounded portrayal of Mongolians and wolves. Simukov found wolves in all the regions he visited as part of a 1925-1926 Russian biological expedition. Some locals complained about the large numbers of wolves and Simukov writes “both the wolf and the fox are the target of zealous persecution by local Mongolian hunters,” in stark contrast to Maiskii’s claims.⁶⁶¹ According to Simukov, most of the wolves were killed with iron and steel traps imported from Russia and he suggests the Mongolian word for trap (*khawkh*) is from the Russian *kapkan*, which demonstrates the importance of Russian imported traps. Simukov reported that one Torgut man who owned fifty traps caught fifteen wolves, fifty foxes, and many cats over one winter. The price of a Russian trap was fifteen to eighteen *rubles* so a man with fifty traps would be quite wealthy.⁶⁶² The American traveller Roy Chapman Andrews’ 1921 account also emphasizes the importance of the fur trade in Mongolia, though his account is far more interested in his own hunting exploits than those of the local Mongolians.⁶⁶³ These early reports on the fur trade show both the importance of wolf hunting, and a stereotyped, inaccurate view of Mongolians that, despite being easily disproven, is often long lived.

Wolves as Metaphor: Kulaks, Lamas, and Wolves

Collectivization included identifying and removing class enemies: those wealthy classes and individuals who held large amount of wealth and livestock and exploited working herders. Enemies like nobles, wealthy herders, and Buddhist lamas, were compared to wolves by socialist Mongolians, who referenced centuries of comparisons between wolves and dangerous people. As Harriet Ritvo argues, “embodying the lower classes or alien groups as dangerous wild animals emphasized the need for their masters to exercise strict discipline and to defend against

⁶⁶¹ Simukov, *Trudy o Mongolii i dlia Mongolii*, 27.

⁶⁶² Simukov, *Trudy o Mongolii i dlia Mongolii*, 29.

⁶⁶³ Roy Chapman Andrews, *Across Mongolian Plains; A Naturalist’s Account of China’s “Great Northwest,”* (New York,: D. Appleton and Company, 1921), 178.

depredations.”⁶⁶⁴ Attacking these targets provided livestock and wealth to build the collective, promoted the stated goal of equality, and punished or eliminated those who leaders perceived to be threats to the state.

Songs collected by the Russian Mongolist Nicholas Poppe in collectives in the Selenge region of Soviet Buryatia in 1930 during collectivization often used animals and environmental metaphors and imagery. One song compared kulaks, rich peasants who were the primary enemy during Soviet collectivization, to wolves.

In the forest on the western mountain
There will be no ever-present wolves.
All of us will form a commune;
There will be no rich kulaks.⁶⁶⁵

It is extremely likely that similar songs existed at the same time in independent Mongolia, as Mongolia was implementing collectivization at the same time when Poppe traveled among the Buryats with similar songs and poems created by Mongolian intellectuals to promote these campaigns. Furthermore, the Selenge Buryats’ dialect is extremely similar to the dominant Khalkha Mongolian dialect.

The other main class enemy in Mongolia during the 1930s were lamas, who were often compared to wolves. This connection is seen in metaphors, stories, and nicknames for wolves and was cited by both socialist critics of lamas and supporters of lamas. Mongolian leaders wrestled with solving “the lama problem” through the 1920s and 1930s, until Choibalsan and other socialist leaders purged lamas and destroyed monasteries during the Great Purges of the

⁶⁶⁴ Harriet Ritvo, *The Animal Estate: The English and Other Creatures in the Victorian Age* (Cambridge, MA: Harvard University Press, 1987), 16.

⁶⁶⁵ Nicholas Poppe, *Tsongol Folklore: Translation of the Collection the Language and Collective Farm Poetry of the Buriat Mongols of the Selenga Region*, (Wiesbaden: Harrassowitz, 1978), 70; N.N. Poppe, *Iazyk i kolkhoznaia poeziia Buriat-Mongolov Selenginskogo aimaka*, (London: Gregg International Publishers Limited, 1972), 63.

late 1930s.⁶⁶⁶ Indeed, the same word, *ustgakh* “exterminate,” was used for both lamas and wolves. The professional hunter Damdin explains that among the many nicknames of the wolf, clergy related nicknames such as “Luwsan the Monk,” “Creeping Luwsan,” and “Reverend Oidow” were due to the exploitative nature of the lamas, whose actions were like the wolf.⁶⁶⁷ S. Borzenko, a Soviet visitor to Mongolia, recorded that a Mongolian activist told him “uprooted, the lamas threw away and replaced their yellow robes and, masquerading as herders, prowl the steppe, like wolves!”⁶⁶⁸ Both lamas and wolves had to be exterminated, and the existence of both were a threat to socialism.

Wolves were also a potent political symbol in Inner Mongolia, as seen in a political cartoon produced in 1968 during the Cultural Revolution that accuses the leader Ulaankhüü of nationalism and sympathy for wealthy herders. It depicts the leader in Mongolian dress playing a horse head fiddle to an audience of wolf headed Mongolians, clearly representing wealthy herders. The image is labelled “Ulaankhüü Promoting Class Reconciliation,” with a poem in the corner that reads

The sky is blue, and the grassland is vast;
the wind blows down the grass,
revealing the cattle and sheep.
Sheep are everywhere.
There is no more wolf on the grassland.⁶⁶⁹

The poem contrasts with the illustration of the wolf headed Mongolians and the accusation against Ulaankhüü of downplaying class conflict. The similarity between the Buryat song and the Inner Mongolian poster shows the pan-Mongolian socialist themes of wolves as class enemies. In

⁶⁶⁶ Kaplonski, *Lama Question*.

⁶⁶⁷ J. Damdin, *Buural anchny temdeglel*, (Ulaanbaatar: Ulsyn Khevreliin Khereeeg Erkhlekh Khoroo, 1963), 62.

⁶⁶⁸ S. Borzenko, “V gostiakh u aratov,” *Pravda*, June 1, 1954, 3.

⁶⁶⁹ Uradyn Erden Bulag, *The Mongols at China's Edge: History and the Politics of National Unity*, World Social Change (Lanham: Rowman & Littlefield Publishers, 2002), 128.

these propaganda wolves, like wicked people, use their free will to commit evils. Collectives were supposed to eliminate both wolves and wealthy people, but if one persisted, the other would not be far behind.

Collectivization in the 1950s-60s: Anxieties and Promises

In the early part of the second round of collectivization, joining collectives was voluntary so leaders and activists spent a great deal of effort publicizing the merits of collectivization. Activists included wolves high on the list of reasons to join the collective as wolves caused major loss to Mongolian herders. Guarding against wolves is an onerous task, as herders must stay up all night, especially during birthing season. Shirendew recalls in his autobiography his time as a youth herding wealthy herder's livestock, when he occasionally failed to protect their flocks from wolves. One rich herder yelled at him and called him a dog, while another family prepared a ritual using sutras, fire, and milk to expel the bad luck from him which drew in the wolves.⁶⁷⁰ Shirendew uses the difficulty of his life as a youth in his autobiography to articulate the need for socialist revolution, and his wolf stories also serve this purpose. Alleviating this type of labor would be an attractive prospect, especially to poorer herders who found collectives the most appealing.

In South Khangai province a top herder named Yondon stated in a 1956 herding conference that the most important contributions of collectives were roofed sheds, collection of fodder, and protection from and hunting of wolves. He received five state sponsored bounties for having killed wolves, and during 1956 twenty to thirty wolves were killed in the province.⁶⁷¹ Yondon and other herders participating in the conference were already part of collectives and their speeches were a celebration of the strengths of collectivization.

⁶⁷⁰ Shirendev, *Dalain davalgaanaar*, 45-46, 62; Shirendev, *Through the Ocean Waves*, 26-27, 38.

⁶⁷¹ AA kh1 d1 khn10: 173

Despite the rhetoric that collectivization would solve wolf predation and other sources of livestock loss, herders were held responsible for wolf predation once they were in the collective. In his explanation of the herder's salary system, Minjüür noted that "if livestock greatly decreased, if livestock was eaten by wolves or dogs, or other improper loss of livestock, the person that lost the livestock's salary was cut."⁶⁷² In a separate interview, Badarch, who worked in the Bright Road collective under Minjüür, used the same words to explain merit-based rewards in the collective.⁶⁷³ This appears to be a stock phrase in the Bright Road collective and was likely found in other collectives to explain the responsibility of herders in protecting livestock. The warning for collective members to remain vigilant is also seen in R. Saijaa's short story "Wolves." The story has an old woman telling a visitor about pre-collectivization deprivation by wolves in the winter of 1945 while warning "we can't let up our vigilance. Wolves are capable of anything, they are such terrible creatures!"⁶⁷⁴ As discussed in the previous chapter, Mongolian leaders often invoked the natural disasters of 1944-1945, which were exacerbated by the shortages caused by World War II, as justification to carry out collectivization. Saijaa neatly ties together the reason for collectivization while reminding his reader that the struggle against wolves was not yet over. Collectivization promised protection from wolves but despite heavy persecution wolves persisted as a threat to livestock.

By the Numbers: State Plans and Pelts

Socialist planners in the central government produced detailed documentation of plans of production of goods, as well as causes of livestock loss, both of which included numbers on

⁶⁷² Lkhagvasüren, *XX зууны Монголчууд*, 92; cf. *A Herder, a Trader, and a Lawyer*, trans. Mary Rossabi, 92.

⁶⁷³ Badarch, *The Oral History of Twentieth Century Mongolia*, http://amantuuh.socanth.cam.ac.uk/search/view_person.php?Person=990409

⁶⁷⁴ Henry G. Schwarz, *Mongolian Short Stories* (Center for East Asian Studies, Western Washington University, 1974), 97.

wolves. These numbers were provided by collective leaders, who would have been at times motivated to inflate the numbers of livestock killed by wolves in order to obscure improper use of livestock. As seen in internal documents killing wolves and decreasing loss by predation were important metrics of success to party leaders. In the Mongolian People's Revolutionary Party materials on collectivization from 1956, a report from Choibalsan province lists the three main causes of death of livestock from 1952 to 1955 that collectivization was intended to solve: natural disaster, disease, and wolves. Livestock killed by wolves were in the thousands but were not as prolific killers as disease or disaster.⁶⁷⁵

Development plans drawn up by the Ministry of Agriculture listed livestock killed by wolves alongside wolf pelts collected with other targeted quotas related to collectivization. Plans for wolf and other animal pelts were created alongside plans for dairy, wool, and skins. Almost every fur bearing animal was targeted for government quotas, continuing the long history of the fur trade in Mongolia. Some of these pelts were used in the domestic fur clothing market, but most were exported to Soviet Union.

The 1956 agricultural development plan shows that wolves killed by livestock and wolf pelts collected were closely linked. The first part of the 1956 wolf extermination plan lists the large (horse, cattle, camel) and small (sheep, goat) livestock killed in 1953 and 1954.⁶⁷⁶

Table 24. 1956 Wolf Extermination Plan: Livestock Killed

Livestock Killed by Wolves		
	Large Livestock	Sheep and Goat

⁶⁷⁵ UTNONBBA, kh 4 d 1 khn 23, pg 16.

⁶⁷⁶ TBA, kh 15 d 1 khn 772, pg 88.

Province	1953	1954	1953	1954
North Khangai	1332	1017	878	800
Bayan Ölgii	328	580	1423	1378
Bayankhongor	1060	792	1116	934
Bulgan	1577	1557	1800	1675
Gobi Altai	1500	1290	979	1130
North Gobi	578	955	1672	1788
Middle Gobi	47	32	712	352
Zawkhan	1086	1195	1547	1787
South Khangai	933	755	1292	911
South Gobi	273	555	1043	799
Sükhbaatar	121	178	623	806
Selenge	908	687	490	238
Töw	1663	1551	3003	2588
Uws	682	689	1242	1515
Khowd	685	772	1075	1179
Khöwsgöl	1987	1981	1087	1262
Khentii	1492	1266	1649	1473
Choibalsan	515	888	1061	3159
Ulaanbaatar	6	24	25	54
Total	16773	16764	22717	23772

The next section shows the number of wolves killed. It lists wolves killed in 1953 and 1954, the plan, number carried out, and percentage in 1955, and the plan of wolves killed in 1956.

Table 25. 1956 Wolf Extermination Plan: Wolves Killed

Wolves Killed				
	1953	1954	1955	1956

Province	Carried Out	Carried Out	Plan	Carried Out	Percent	Plan
North Khangai	1430	1296	2600	1139	43.8	2600
Bayan Ölgii	371	342	2000	293	14.7	2000
Bayankhongor	1222	651	2500	822	32.8	2500
Bulgan	1306	1102	4000	956	23.9	4000
Gobi Altai	573	335	2450	320	13	2450
North Gobi	1659	1378	2000	1032	51.6	2000
Middle Gobi	59	89	1000	71	7.1	1000
Zawkhan	740	391	4000	474	11.7	4000
South Khangai	679	619	2500	506	24.2	2500
South Gobi	217	203	750	182	24.2	750
Sükhbaatar	1927	1420	2000	1696	84.8	2000
Selenge	68	416	2500	498	19.9	2500
Töw	1525	1443	5000	1179	23.5	5000
Uws	688	400	4000	350	8.7	4000
Khowd	302	252	2000	288	14.4	2000
Khöwsgöl	1069	981	4000	878	21.9	4000
Khentii	1731	1303	3500	904	25.8	3500
Choibalsan	1684	N/A	3000	178	5.9	3000
Ulaanbaatar	N/A	N/A	200	N/A	N/A	200
Total	17250	12628	50000	11766	23.5	50000

These tables show the large variation *aimag* by *aimag* of wolf population, as the *gobi* regions of Mongolia had by far the lowest concentration of wolves, where the *khangai* had the highest concentration. There was some knowledge of wolf population numbers based on livestock killed and skins collected, but this did not always translate into policy. In 1955 only 71 of a quota of 1000 wolves in Middle Gobi were killed.⁶⁷⁷

⁶⁷⁷ TBA, fl5 d1 khn 772, pg 88.

Despite this dismal result, the next year 1000 wolf skins were again called for. On the one hand the data suggests that the wolf population was not high enough to kill such a large number of wolves, but the numbers of livestock killed by wolves still list 273 large livestock killed in 1953 and 555 killed in 1954, while 1043 sheep and goats were killed in 1953, and 799 small livestock were killed in 1954, which shows the high damage even small numbers of wolves can do to herds. Other provinces also came nowhere near the planned numbers, though not by so stark a gap, and similarly no change in the plans were made.

The next year the fulfillment of the 1956 wolf skin plan was evaluated and compared to the results of 1955.⁶⁷⁸

Table 26. Fulfilment of 1956 Wolf Extermination Plan

Province	1955 Fulfillment	1956 Plan	1956 Fulfillment	1956 Percent	Percent of increase of wolves killed from 1955-1956
North Khangai	1177	2600	915	35.2	77.8
Bayan Ölgii	293	2500	283	11.3	96.6
Bayankhongor	1094	2000	817	40.9	74.7
Bulgan	956	4000	677	16.9	70.8
Gobi Altai	320	2450	264	10.8	82.6
North Gobi	1032	2000	965	48.8	93.6
Middle Gobi	71	1000	62	6.2	87.4
Zawkhan	504	4000	341	8.5	67.7
South Khangai	585	2500	518	20.7	88.6
South Gobi	184	750	148	19.7	80.4
Sükhbaatar	1971	2000	1972	98.6	100.1
Töw	1677	7500	1152	15.4	58.7
Uws	441	4000	328	8.2	74.4
Khowd	334	2000	239	12	71.6
Khöwsgöl	989	4000	755	18.9	76.3
Khentii	1078	3500	897	25.6	83.3
Choibalsan	1260	3000	905	30.2	71.8
Ulaanbaatar	86	200	156	78	181.4

⁶⁷⁸ TBA, kh 15 d 1 khn 773, pg 75.

Total	14052	50000	11394	22.8	81.1

Some of the 1955 numbers are not the same as those reported in the previous plan. This is likely updated based on later counts submitted by hunters and provincial leaders, though this is not explicit. Despite the new plan, wolf kills were lower in 1955-1956 in every case except for Sükhbaatar, which had one more wolf killed in 1956 than the previous year, and Ulaanbaatar, with seventy more wolves killed. Out of a planned 50,000 wolf pelts in 1956, only 11,394 were collected, a decrease of 2,658 total wolves killed from the previous year.

Wolf kills were also tracked at the provincial, district, and collective level. In 1960 wolves were a small portion of skins collected in South Khangai. Each of the twenty-five collectives in the province had a planned number of rabbit, fox, marmot, wolf, badger, antelope, ground squirrel, *manuul* (Pallas's Cat), corsac fox, squirrel, lynx, and steppe polecat furs to be delivered.⁶⁷⁹ The number of wolf skins compared to the other skins is miniscule. The Strong Life collective had the largest number of wolf skins in the province at eighteen, in comparison to a quota of 4,900 marmots and 2,220 squirrels.⁶⁸⁰ In total one hundred and two wolves were planned to be killed, with the only animal called for in lower numbers were badger and lynx. The high numbers of 29,700 marmots and 22,600 ground squirrels shows that other fur bearing animals were targeted in greater numbers than wolves, but wolves number far less than their small rodent prey and are more difficult to hunt. As both a threat to livestock and a prestige trophy for hunters, wolves received far more attention among hunters, herders, and socialist

⁶⁷⁹ AA kh 74 d 1 khn 06, 12.

⁶⁸⁰ AA kh 74 khn 06, 12.

planners than other game animals, despite the difference in total number of pelts, as seen in the following section.

Hunting as Marxist Labor

Professional hunters who worked at the district, provincial, or state level often wrote handbooks which are an important source for the history of wolves which were also a common tool in wolf hunting in the United States and other countries.⁶⁸¹ Socialist wolf hunting shared motivations, methods, and ideas with Soviet and other socialist countries in addition to other major wolf hunting cultures. Mongolian hunters regularly participated in international hunting conferences and referenced other country's hunting methods and attitudes in their work while celebrating Mongolia's hunting history. This mix of international modernization and preservation of traditional strategies was the defining feature of the socialist Mongolian human-animal and environmental relations.

J. Damdin begins his handbook, *Notes of a Grizzled Hunter*, with a discussion of Mongolian hunting history starting with prehistory, through the Mongol Empire (13-14th centuries), up to the time he was writing.⁶⁸² He provides this history to argue that in Mongolia labour (*khödölmör*) was divided between hunters and herders. Damdin uses this Marxist interpretation to explore the positive impact hunters played in developing the economy, and the MPRP's promotion and regulation of hunting. By placing hunting under Marxist approved labour, he frames hunting as important not only to Mongolian but all human history, a different interpretation of Marx's original theory in which hunting societies were the earliest in the evolutionary schema of production.

⁶⁸¹ Coleman, *Vicious*, 12.

⁶⁸² Damdin, *Buural anchny temdeglel*, 3-10.

Damdin provides a great deal of information gained from personal experience on how to kill a wolf and provides details such as the common colours of the wolf based on woods, steppe, and *gobi* areas. According to Damdin, the wolf “is the ultimate predator, and eats all kinds of livestock, deer, antelopes, pigs, and so on.” He argues that because there are many wolves in the *khangai*, and it is very difficult to hunt a wolf in the forest, therefore new methods must be developed, because “the work exterminating the enemy wolf is very important.”⁶⁸³ He references the common slaughter of livestock by wolves, although notes that at times a stallion or bull can protect the herd which shows the importance of livestock in defending wolves. Damdin concludes by celebrating that at the time of his writing more wolves than ever were being killed and names a Lutyn Demberel who killed at least 20 in a year; though Damdin explains that now with cars people can kill over a hundred wolves a year.⁶⁸⁴

The genre of hunting handbooks continued through the socialist period. S. Luwsan’s *Mongolian Hunter’s Notes* was published in 1986 and provides a short history of hunting in Mongolia, methods of hunting, a list of animals and their behavior month by month, and his advice on hunting. Luwsan’s advice includes the directions that “hunters must not drink vodka (*arkhi*) or smoke tobacco.” He also advises that hunters should target wolves from mid-February to March during wolves’ mating season as it makes them easy to kill. Luwsan writes how to spot a sleeping wolf and warns that there is usually a guard that is not asleep. Luwsan writes this vigilance is because wolves are a “very bad intentioned, darkly suspicious animal,” thereby ascribing inner lives, motivations, and emotions to wolves, even if they are wicked beings that

⁶⁸³ Damdin, *Buural anchny temdeglel*, 62-63.

⁶⁸⁴ Damdin, *Buural anchny temdeglel*, 3-10, 62-63, 66.

need to be killed. Luwsan decries the great damage to livestock from wolf predation and lauds the increased efforts by hunters in his conclusion.⁶⁸⁵

The professionalization of hunting was also evident in hunting conferences which were organized in a similar manner to conferences of herders. It must be noted that hunting is a male gendered activity and, though there were socialist attempts of gender integration in herding, there does not seem to be a similar movement for hunting. The materials for the annual South Khangai hunting conference included various ethnographic materials from around the province, including hunting songs, trophies, museum pieces, and interviews with old hunters. These materials, like Damdin's hunting history, served to establish a long and proud lineage of hunting labour on the local and state level. 1162 hunters in nineteen brigades participated in South Khangai's first annual hunters conference in 1969.⁶⁸⁶ Hunters discussed all matter of game but consistently emphasized the importance of wolf hunting with one presenter announcing that "hostile animal (*daisagnagch amitan*) wolf" had to be exterminated to improve the environment and protect livestock from predation and disease.⁶⁸⁷

Veteran hunters, like veteran herders, agreed that the youth of the day were a problem as they lacked in skill and motivation, and that veteran hunters had to pass on their knowledge in forums such as conferences and handbooks. This is in contrast with earlier methods of passing hunting knowledge from father to son and demonstrates the transition to professional rather than folk methods of instruction. The emphasis on the wisdom of elder hunters, like elder herders, reflects the continued contention between new and old in collectivization and broader socialist reorganizations of herding. Leaders celebrated hunters for numbers of hunted animals while

⁶⁸⁵ Sonomyn Luvsan, *Mongol Anchny Temdeglel* (Ulaanbaatar: Ulsyn Kheveleliin Gazar, 1986), 1, 26, 64-65, 148.

⁶⁸⁶ AA, kh 70 d 1 khn 1, pg 20.

⁶⁸⁷ AA, kh 30 d 1 khn 1, pg 20.

criticizing the low number of wolves killed and declared that “the failure to achieve the wolf hunting plan is a serious shortcoming.”⁶⁸⁸ In time the wolf kills did increase, and a mass hunt in 1982 resulted in sixty-two pups caught and 118 wolves killed.⁶⁸⁹ Even so, socialist leaders, hunters, and herders remained concerned as wolves were never completely exterminated. This was likely due to the high number of wolves in the country, and the overall decreased investment in the herding economy which also caused the lack of major increase of livestock numbers.

Hunting Techniques: Continuity, Change, and Variety

There are numerous methods of killing wolves some of which are particular to Mongolia while others were used globally. In his handbook Damdin calls upon the use of all possible methods to kill the wolf and presents a long list of methods: hunting with a gun, traps, hunting with dogs, eagles, horses, digging out dens, pouring water into dens, poison, hunting from cars, and even mimicking wolf howls to trick them into the open.⁶⁹⁰ Luvsan also provides advice on how to kill a wolf, including traps, poison, and hunting by horse.⁶⁹¹ Hunters mounted on horses often used pole-lassoes (*uurga*), which are primarily used for herding livestock.⁶⁹² Decorated herder Ts. Namkhainyambuu writes in his autobiography “not long ago, there were many wolves and dogs,” and during his youth a man spotted a wolf’s tracks and chased it down with his horse and caught it with his pole-lasso and returned with its corpse. This implies a herder rather than a professional hunter, as well as demonstrates dangers of feral dogs as well as wolves in the opinion of a top herder.⁶⁹³ Various traps were deployed to kill wolves, with the quality of traps

⁶⁸⁸ AA kh30 d1 khn2, pg 12.

⁶⁸⁹ AA kh70 d1 khn15, pg 35.

⁶⁹⁰ Damdin, *Buural anchny temdeglel*, 85.

⁶⁹¹ Luvsan, *Mongol anchny temdeglel*, 63.

⁶⁹² Gotovyn Akim, *Tengeriin nokhoy: Khökh Mongolyn khökh chonyn tukhai ünen ba domog* (Ulaanbaatar: Chölööt Khevllel San, 2000), 31; Gotovyn Akim, *Dog of Heaven: Truths and Myths of Blue Mongolia’s Blue Wolf*, (Ulaanbaatar: EDO Publishing, 2008); 42.

⁶⁹³ Namkhainyambuu, *Khoniny Khishig*, 15; cf. Rossabi *Bounty from the Sheep*, 38.

increasing in the 20th century with wooden traps and snares replaced by metal traps to the point of adopting the Russian word for trap, as observed by Simukov.⁶⁹⁴

Methods for killing wolves were also published in popular journals and magazines. “Methods of Wolf Hunting” by L. Baatar and A. Nyamdorj was published in 1978 in *Countryside Economy*, a widespread journal with a variety of topics from veterinary to farming advice. The article begins with a celebration of the success and methods of wolf hunting in the Soviet Union, specifically Siberia and Kazakhstan. They then turn to Mongolia’s 1974 pronouncement which called for increased wolf hunting and the continuation of holidays designated for wolf hunting.⁶⁹⁵ The same L. Baatar is the subject of the book *The Great Call* by his son, on his father’s experiences hunting wolves. Despite his expertise, Baatar was not a professional hunter, but a highly decorated herder; nevertheless, he was skilled with a gun and a prolific hunter of wolves and other game.⁶⁹⁶ While many wolves were killed by professional hunters, others were also killed by herders and sportsmen especially during national holidays designated for wolf hunts. Two wolf hunting holidays occurred on the first day of December and in the second week of May, with another on the Sunday of the third week of February around the Lunar New Year, Tsagaan Sar.⁶⁹⁷ As a religious holiday, Tsagaan Sar was a common target through the socialist era, with numerous intellectuals, including the famous Natsugdorji, arrested for celebrating Tsagaan Sar in 1932 and, after periodic attacks on the holiday, in 1960 leaders rebranded it as “Collective Herder’s Day.” In an interview recalling her family’s clandestine Buddhist practices Nöröwsüren explains wolf hunts were organized during Tsagaan Sar to

⁶⁹⁴ Simukov, *Trudy o Mongolii i dlia Mongolii*, 27, 29.

⁶⁹⁵ L. Baatar and A. Niamdorzh, “Chono avlakh arga,” *Khödöö azh akhui* 1 (1978): 60.

⁶⁹⁶ B. Lundaa and L. Baatar, *Ikh duudlaga* (Ulaanbaatar: BIT Press, 2014).

⁶⁹⁷ Baatar and Niamdorzh, “Chono avlakh arga,” 62.

prevent public observation of the holiday.⁶⁹⁸ Even when not explicitly compared to religious figures, wolves were used to oppress religious activities, a major goal of the socialist state.

Perhaps the most effective and brutal methods of wolf hunting is “denning,” in which hunters follow a wolf to an active wolf den and either kill the pups or use them to draw out the mother before slaughtering them all, though occasionally hunters take the pups alive.⁶⁹⁹ In his post-socialist book in defence of wolves, Gotowyn Akim records many collected interviews which describe denning where all the interviewees emphasize the brutality of the practice.⁷⁰⁰ This gruesome hunting method is rarely addressed when discussing the man on beast single combat valorised in descriptions of gathering *khiimori*. Wolf hunting strategies like denning are very well documented in America, as well as Japan, further evidence of the shared wolf hunting culture and its place in the global movement of modernization.⁷⁰¹

The Bounty System and its Discontents

Hunters were awarded in various ways for their work including awards for meritorious labor, medals, and accolades in addition to a regular salary. There was also a bounty system where hunters were paid by the pelt based on the age and gender of the slain wolf. In 1969 South Khangai offered twenty-five tögrögs for male and non-pregnant female wolves while pregnant wolves were worth forty tögrögs.⁷⁰² In 1978 the countrywide bounty was the same save that wolf pups were worth thirty-five tögrögs.⁷⁰³ Not all districts had an equal bounty system, as seen in an

⁶⁹⁸ Norovsüren, *The Oral History of Twentieth Century Mongolia*, http://amantuuh.socanth.cam.ac.uk/search/view_person.php?Person=990572

⁶⁹⁹ Damdin, *Buural anchny temdeglel*, 85.

⁷⁰⁰ Akim, *Tengeriin nokhoi*, 71; Akim, *Dog of Heaven*, 88.

⁷⁰¹ Lopez, *Of Wolves and Men*, 191; Coleman, *Vicious*, 70; Walker, *The Lost Wolves of Japan*, 168.

⁷⁰² AA kh 30 d 1 khn 1, 20

⁷⁰³ Baatar and Niamdorzh, “Chono avlakh arga,” 62.

incident South Khangai in 1969 when a hunter complained that he only received six tögrögs for a pelt in Khujirt district.⁷⁰⁴

Wolf bounties were also sometimes paid in livestock rather than in cash as in the case of a 1961 declaration from the Spark collective in South Khangai awarding D. Gankhawkhad four female sheep for bringing in eight live wolf pups.⁷⁰⁵ These pups were acquired by denning during which the pups' mother was killed. Wolf pups are often used as playthings before growing too large and aggressive, when they are usually killed. State law allowed hunters, like herders, to keep a small number of private livestock, thus additional personal livestock was an attractive award. Guns were also awarded to top hunters like Dambadoo who was born in Middle Gobi province in 1925 and, as was the case in many hunting families, learned to hunt from his father. Dambadoo served as a sharpshooter in the army during World War II and afterwards in 1950 helped form a collective in Bayanjargalan district. He used his marksmanship cultivated during the war to hunt and regularly brought in a large number of game, including wolves, to fulfil state contracts. For his efforts he received cash bounties as well as a high-quality carbine.⁷⁰⁶ Guns were less often given as rewards than money or livestock which reflects Dambadoo's achievements and status.

Top hunters and planners criticized the patchwork of bounty systems found across the country and even within a single province and noted that some hunters would bring the pelt to a different district to receive livestock rather than cash, of which youth were allegedly often guilty. To prevent this, at hunting conferences provincial hunters proposed a standardized province-wide cash bounty, and detailed logging of individuals turning in bounties to prevent people from

⁷⁰⁴ AA kh 70 d 1 khn 1, 31

⁷⁰⁵ AA kh 30 d 1 khn 29. 138

⁷⁰⁶ Dambadoo, *The Oral History of Twentieth Century Mongolia*,
http://amantuuh.socanth.cam.ac.uk/search/view_transcript.php?Interview=081209A&Person=990066

moving between districts, or worst of all, coming in from a different province.⁷⁰⁷ Hunters worked hard to standardize and monitor compensation for their profession and increase its standing.

Socialism and Dogs

Dogs were closely connected with wolf hunting campaigns, and while dogs were used as guards against wolves as well as companion hunting animals, they were often targeted for extermination in the same breath as wolves. In the 1950s-1960s, dogs were targeted for extermination and hunting along with wolves, for the same reasons: predation of livestock, carrying disease, and for harvesting of skins. This was contested by some Mongolian herders who argued that they were useful as livestock guardians and occurred at the same time as an increase of the Soviet influenced phenomenon of pet dogs in the capital. As in the case of wolf hunting, anti-dog sentiment pre-dated the socialist era.

Most domestic dogs in Mongolia are guard dogs, the best of which are said to be able to fight off wolves; hunting dogs are rarer but also present. There are a few works on dogs in Mongolia in English. Terbish provides an examination of the Mongolian dog and argues that both the dog and wolf hold important spiritual roles in Mongolian cosmology, and that both are treated in seemingly contradictory ways.⁷⁰⁸ Dogs play a close role in Mongolian day to day life but are considered to be polluted and forbidden to enter a home. They are widely mistreated, especially female dogs who are seen as inferior guard dogs.⁷⁰⁹ He explores the various cultural and spiritual interpretations of dogs, such as their near status of humans in the cycle of incarnation, and negative effects of mistreating

⁷⁰⁷ AA, kh 70 d 1 khn 1, pg 30.

⁷⁰⁸ Baasanjav Terbish, "The Mongolian Dog as an Intimate 'Other,'" *Inner Asia* 17, no. 1 (April 21, 2015): 141.

⁷⁰⁹ Terbish, "The Mongolian Dog as an Intimate 'Other,'" 148-149.

dogs on their owners.⁷¹⁰ Dogs with brown spots above their eyes, known as four eyed dogs (*dörwön nüdtei nokhoi*) can see ghosts. The most notable Mongolian dog is the *bankhar*, a large Tibetan mastiff like dog which is today held in high regard as a symbol of Mongolian pride and as a livestock guardian against predators.⁷¹¹

Early socialist Mongolia had a sizeable population of feral dogs in the countryside. According to Simukov, these feral dogs often crossed with wolves, further connecting the threat of wolves and dogs. He states that “it is a very reliable fact that wolves frequently cross with stray dogs here.” He did not himself see any, but he reports other sightings, including a Mongolian hunter that accompanied him who saw “a stray dog (in heat) in company with a wolf and a hybrid.”⁷¹² These hybrids are similar to other *erliiz* (hybrids) in Mongolia, in that like livestock they are stronger than the sum of their parts but are clearly not part of the natural order. Simukov describes them as black furred, “very large, strong, and bold,” and as proof mentions that one dragged a heavy trap thirty *versts*.⁷¹³ The hybrids are targeted by hunters, and their furs fetch the same cost as wolves. Simukov’s account is second hand, like most other accounts of wolf-dog hybrids, but reinforces the connection between feral dogs and wolves, metaphorically and biologically.

In 1962, Mongolist Owen Lattimore explains the anti-dog element of a 1956 campaign with the slogan “Down with dogs and burn the books” by claiming that guard dogs are no longer truly needed due to the “near-extermination of wolves.”⁷¹⁴ This explanation does not hold water given the continued emphasis on hunting wolves during and after this period, not to mention

⁷¹⁰ Terbish, “The Mongolian Dog as an Intimate ‘Other,’” 144-145.

⁷¹¹ Terbish, “The Mongolian Dog as an Intimate ‘Other,’” 141, 148-149, 144-145, 150.

⁷¹² Simukov *Trudy o Mongolii i dlia Mongolii*, 28.

⁷¹³ Simukov *Trudy o Mongolii i dlia Mongolii*, 28.

⁷¹⁴ Owen Lattimore, *Nomads and Commissars: Mongolia Revisited*, (New York: Oxford University Press, 1962), 140.

today's apparently sizeable wolf population. Instead, it was likely an extension of anti-feral dog campaigns, along with acquisition of cheap pelts. These extermination campaigns are closely related to collectivization as well, as canine diseases, such as rabies, can infect livestock as well as humans, and stray dogs can attack livestock. J. Sambuu's *Advice for Herders* called for killing dogs for similar reasons to wolves, such as disease and threats to livestock.⁷¹⁵ In 1958, a meeting on collectivization mentioned livestock killed by wolves and dogs along with those killed by disease and cold.⁷¹⁶ This echoed the formulation from Ikh Tamir stated by Minjüür and Badarch, who listed wolf and dog kills together with killed by disaster. 1957 agricultural plans called for dog products as well as various wild animals. These plans called not just for dog skins (*aris*), but also hair (*khöwör*).⁷¹⁷ When there is a bounty for a dog skin, it is a great deal easier to target a neighbor's guard dog than to go out hunting for feral dogs. In contemporary Ulaanbaatar, there are rumors that dog hunters target pet dogs as well.⁷¹⁸ It is logical to assume similar situations occurred in the past.

However, dog extermination proved to be controversial, at least among some experienced herders as dogs could protect against strangers, and ideally wolves. During the conference of top herders of South Khangai in 1956 run of the mill presentations of the importance of labor devolved into pointed back and forth between presenters argued over the merits of dogs.⁷¹⁹ Jamsran warned that dogs had diseases, so most needed to be exterminated. He allowed that "we need to protect the good dogs and exterminate the bad dogs," with guard dogs (*khotoch nokhoi*) as the good dogs. Guard dogs would wear colorful collars or scarfs to note their official role.

⁷¹⁵ Sambuu, *Malchdad ökh zöwlgöö*, 284, 294.

⁷¹⁶ UTNONBBA kh 4 d 1 khn 24, pg 97.

⁷¹⁷ TBA, kh 17 d1 khn 572, pg 37, 49, 68.

⁷¹⁸ Personal communication.

⁷¹⁹ AA, kh 1 d 1 khn 105, pg 94.

Later Dolgor read a presentation that emphasized multiple times that he and his father would never have been successful herders without their guard dogs, and that some guard dogs have been killed in the anti-dog campaigns.⁷²⁰ After taking only a brief detour from this point to complain about the youth, Dolgor returned to the importance of dogs. In yet another example of the importance of veteran pre-socialist knowledge, despite the arguments over dogs, both presenters, and other herders, agreed that the youth were poor herders.

Dogs were used for hunting as well. D. Damba, a hunter who worked during the socialist era, opens his 2014 *Old Hunter's Notes* with a section on dogs, and describes the difference between hunting, guard, and pet dogs.⁷²¹ He explains that pairs of dogs are best suited to fight off wolves. The rest of the section consists of a list of the various dogs he and his family owned over the years, with a brief conclusion on famous dogs like Laika and Balto. He relates various stories of his dogs Snowcock, Lion, Tiger, Tiger Cub, Bear, Basar (a dog from a Mongolian folktale), Gonjoon, White Forehead Patch (*Khalzan*), Brightly Colored (*Ereen*), Fast, and Bankhar. He relates various stories and fond memories of the dogs, as well as noteworthy hunting episodes, some of which were against wolves.

Furthermore, Mongolians dogs could also be loving animal companions. Literary works also sometimes depicted positive attitudes towards dogs. S. Erdene's "Solitude" (*Gantsaardal*) the old couple has a "scruffy fat grey (*khökh*, lit. blue) puppy" named Snubnose (*Bankhar*).⁷²² As an example of Dash's ill temper, Erdene writes "after he finished scarfing down the food from his dish, Snubnose came over to Dash, tail wagging, but Dash kicked the dog with his roebuck

⁷²⁰ AA, kh 1 d 1 khn 105, pg 135.

⁷²¹ D. Damba, *Övgön Anchny Temdeglel*, (Ulaanbaatar, 2014), 8.

⁷²² Erdene Seng, "Solitude," trans. Kenneth Linden, *Words Without Borders*, October 2018, <https://www.wordswithoutborders.org/article/october-2018-dalit-writing-solitude-erdene-seng-kenneth-linden>; S. Erdene, "Gantsaardal," *Naran togoruu*, (Ulaanbaatar: Ulsyn Khevreliin Gazar, 1972), 111.

winter boots. Snubnose, offended, fled his owner's temper with a plaintive yelp.”⁷²³ Dash's mistreatment of the dog, and subsequent abandonment by the puppy along with his wife, make it clear that soon despite anti-dog campaigns puppies were still objects of sympathy. At the same time as the extermination campaigns, pet dogs (*khaw nokhoi*) and other personal pet dogs became popular due to Russian influence.⁷²⁴ These companion dogs were allowed inside, kissed, and treated with more intimacy than was previously common.⁷²⁵ Choijamts relates a moving recollection of his childhood dog, which he got as a puppy in 1939.⁷²⁶ A “very good, very cute” black and white spotted dog, he was a “genuine (*jinkhene*) Mongol bankhar.” Choijamts spent his childhood watching sheep together and playing with the dog. Sadly, his neighbor disliked the dog, and poisoned him. This depressing story shows the two extremes of human treatment of dogs.

Re-valuing the Wild – At the Expense of Wolves

While Mongolians primarily killed wolves to protect livestock and collect pelts, they also targeted wolves to protect wildlife. R.A. Hibbert, who was the British Chargé d’Affaires from 1964-1966 and wrote multiple articles on wildlife in Mongolia, writes Mongolians “are preoccupied by the hard labour (sic.) of creating a modern economy-building socialism as they express it. They are not inclined to view with much sympathy the unqualified enthusiasm which

⁷²³ Seng, “Solitude,” trans. Kenneth Linden; Erdene, “Gantsaardal,” 111.

⁷²⁴ Caroline Humphrey, “Some Notes on the Role of Dogs in the Life of Mongolian Herdsmen,” *Journal of the Anglo-Mongolian Society* 3, no. 2 (1976): 14-15.

⁷²⁵ Humphrey also records an anecdote which emphasizes the widespread antipathy towards cats in Mongolia. According to Humphrey, there is folk saying about house dogs that they will wake three times in the night to ensure their owner is still alive, in contrast to a cat which will wake three times in the night to see if their owner is dead and is glad if that is the case, and if they get tired of waiting, they will kill the person themselves.

⁷²⁶ Choijamts, *The Oral History of Twentieth Century Mongolia*, http://amantuuh.socanth.cam.ac.uk/search/view_person.php?Person=990901

western visitors often show for Mongolia's wilder beauties and its wealth of game” and that “the main menace to rare wildlife may prove to be the wolf.”⁷²⁷

Although Hibbert’s comments reflect the focus on wildlife as game found in Mongolia at the time, the 1960s also marked a time when Mongolians increasingly valued wildlife as part of the country’s national heritage. In 1962, certain endangered, and in the case of the *takhi* (Przewalski’s horse) extinct in the wild, animals were placed under protection.⁷²⁸ Hunters were cautioned against killing endangered species and to abide by state regulations, with violators named and fined.⁷²⁹ These species became endangered due to human hunting and competition with livestock, yet a focus on wolf predation distracted from human culpability.

To socialist biologists and intellectuals, wolves were not part of the natural world to be celebrated, instead they were enemies of nature and the economy. One wildlife handbook states “the wolf is commonly occurring in our country and is the most dreadful enemy of the agricultural economy and game animals.”⁷³⁰ In Khaidav and Chagnaadorj’s *MPRP’s Game Animals* wolves were vilified in entries on various herbivores which listed dates and numbers when large numbers of wildlife were killed by wolves. In the entry on wolves, they declare “the wolf eats our country’s precious wildlife and livestock and causes immeasurable harm to our national economy.” After some basic biological information, they celebrate the extermination of wolves in Europe, America, and most of Western Russia as examples to be emulated and conclude that “the extermination of the wolf is of national importance.” They also list the various advanced methods employed by the Soviet Union to kill wolves, including helicopters, sleds,

⁷²⁷ R.A. Hibbert, “Wildlife of Mongolia,” *Journal of the Royal Central Asian Society* 54 (1967), 57, 62.

⁷²⁸ T. Khaidav, B. Chagnaadorzh, *BNMAU-Yn an Am'tad*, (Ulaanbaatar: Ulsyn khevleliin gazar, 1969), 17.

⁷²⁹ AA kh 70 d 1 khn1, 19.

⁷³⁰ A. Dulmaa, O. Shagdarsüren, eds., *BNMAU-yn agnuuryn am'tad ba an khamgaalal* (Ulaanbaatar: ShUAKh, 1972), 159.

guns, and poisons such as barium fluoride acetate, and praise the import of these methods into Mongolia. Illustrations of various animals are uniformly cute, even major carnivores; for example, a she-bear rolls around with her cubs. The one exception is the wolf, which snarls while scavenging a rotting carcass.⁷³¹ That celebration of Mongolia's role in an international wolf hunting culture even appeared in a handbook for wildlife demonstrates its pervasive nature.

Sympathy for Class Enemies and the Wolf

Some victims of the socialist government used the plight of wolves to symbolize their own persecution, which echoed earlier sympathetic depictions of wolves. D. Namdag's "Howl of the Old Wolf" is a mid-1960s novella that was banned for its perceived subversive message. The novella, similar Jack London's *White Fang*, is the story of the history and emotional life of a wolf navigating the world.⁷³² The story follows a wise and clever old three-legged wolf who lost his leg in a trap and now lives with his daughter and her mate. After the young male feeds on sheep against the old wolf's advice, the humans call in wolf hunter named Tserenchimed who kills the old wolf's daughter and her foolish mate. At the end, the old wolf howls for his companions in dismay "but there was no sound in response, no sound at all."⁷³³ Namdag, like many other socialist-era writers, showed wolves as active agents though in this case their actions are not wicked but sympathetic and necessary for survival. The grizzled patriarch is likely an avatar for Namdag himself, who was imprisoned twice by his own government, first was in 1932 alongside the noted author Natsugdorji and a number of other intellectuals for celebrating the Lunar New Year, the second in 1941 for alleged Nazi ties due to his education in Germany,

⁷³¹ Khaidav, B. Chagnaadorzh, *BNMAU-Yn an Am'tad*, 70.

⁷³² Jack London's books are quite popular today in Mongolia and made their way early to Mongolia via Russian translation. It is not clear if Namdag was directly influenced by London, however. Jack London, *White Fang* (New York: Open Road Media, 2016).

⁷³³ D. Namdag, *Khögshin chono ul'san n' : tuuzh* (Ulaanbaatar: Admon, 2009), 39,

though he survived the purges in which many of his contemporaries were killed.⁷³⁴ Namdag's obvious connection to the titular old wolf emphasizes the suffering and persecution of both author and lupine protagonist.

Gotowyn Akim recorded multiple post-socialist stories of how lamas escaped execution by staying with wolves.⁷³⁵ One story features a lama who stays in a wolf den and feeds on meat brought to him by the wolf. When the local herders chase down the wolf, the lama protects the wolf and explains it was only killing to help him survive, thereby ameliorating the herders. This story is a further example of repressed individuals being connected to or identified as wolves.

These fantastical stories turn the socialist rhetoric of wolves as lamas and other class enemies on its head while continuing their close association. Centuries of Mongolian stories share a theme which connect wolves to thieves and refugees; with often sympathetic portrayals of wolves revolving around its persecuted life, rather than a celebration of a grand predator with *khiimori*.

Socialist Nostalgia

Many Mongolian interviewees speak fondly of the socialist era and collective herding, and many Mongolian's views toward socialist wolf hunting programs are similarly filled with strong nostalgia. Jawzan, a Khalkha woman from Khowd *aimag* who was born in 1927, came from a family of hunters. Her father, father-in-law, and brother all hunted though as a woman she was excluded from the familial hunting tradition. In her interview she contrasted the socialist hunting system with contemporary hunting and argued it was far better under socialism. When asked about the contemporary hunting situation, she lamented it is “bad, bad” and because there

⁷³⁴Zhigzhidiin Boldbaatar and Ch. Dagvadorzh, *Mongol tūmnii sod khümüüs. Dötgöör bot*, (Ulaanbaatar: “Soёмbo Printing” KhKhK, 2014), 275.

⁷³⁵ Akim, *Tengeriin Nokhoi*, 36; Akim, *Dog of Heaven*, 48.

are less hunters “now wolves are plentiful. There are no deer. In the past wolves and the like (*chono mono*) were hunted with contracts. Hunters were given contracts by the state.”⁷³⁶ Hunters killed wolves and badgers along with other animals like rabbits and argali. This lamentation follows the socialist idea that wolves are apart from, and enemies of, nature as well as the increase of wolves is due to a decline of professional hunters.

B. Manduhai and Charlotte Marchina, scholars of post-socialist Mongolia, write that contemporary Mongolians bemoan the lack of regular wolf hunts, and the expense and labor of having to hunt wolves themselves.⁷³⁷ According to Manduhai, herders stayed up all night to watch the herds, but “a bullet almost equaled the price of a sheep, so many herdsmen could not afford to shoot the attackers regularly.”⁷³⁸ With the increase of risk in herding after socialism wolves became more of a concern. To many Mongolian herders, the socialist promise of killing wolves was positive and relatively successful. As in the case of many Mongolians’ memories of socialist herding, socialist wolf hunting may not have been perfect, but it was far better than the precarious situation that followed.

Impact of Hunting on Wolves

Hunting reshaped wolves’ lives, decimated their packs, and changed their diet. Due to the lack of extensive scientific study, the exact impact of hunting on wolves in Mongolia is difficult to ascertain. However, assumptions can be made based on available information and detailed studies of wolves in other parts of the world. Perhaps most importantly, hunting shatters the normal composition of a wolf packs, which are expansive family units that form the core of

⁷³⁶ Javzan, *The Oral History of Twentieth Century Mongolia*, http://amantuuh.socanth.cam.ac.uk/search/view_person.php?Person=990587.

⁷³⁷ Manduhai Buyandelger, *Tragic Spirits: Shamanism, Memory, and Gender in Contemporary Mongolia* (Chicago ; London: The University of Chicago Press, 2013), 115; Charlotte Marchina, *Nomad’s land: Éleveurs, animaux et paysage chez les peuples mongols* (Zones Sensibles, 2019), 124.

⁷³⁸ Buyandelger, *Tragic Spirits*, 115.

wolves' social world.⁷³⁹ As depicted by Namdag in “Howl of the Old Wolf,” in popular imagination the old and skilled wolves survived when younger and more foolish individuals died. Mongolians told stories about skilled wolves who evaded hunters with names including Split-Paws, Shred-Foot, Ash Grey, Old Yellow, and Swift White Wolf, each of whom were said to specialize in eating particular types of livestock.⁷⁴⁰ Similar tales of “outlaw wolves” were found in America with tales of canny wolves like “Old Whitey, Old Three-Toes, Old Lefty, and Old Rags the Digger.”⁷⁴¹ Japan had a similar preponderance of tales of single wolves who evaded capture until finally bested by professional hunters.⁷⁴² Whether in Mongolia, America, or Japan, these single wolves were both vilified for mass livestock slaughter and grudgingly admired for their ability to evade hunters.

Wolves were also heavily impacted by the large-scale hunting of their natural prey. With thousands of marmots, squirrels, antelope, and other species killed per year across the country, wolves ate even more livestock. Studies have generally shown that wolves in Mongolia, like other wolves, will generally choose to eat wild game when presented with the opportunity but turn to the easier to kill livestock when their natural prey are in low supply.⁷⁴³ Wolves that were not killed by hunters were still fundamentally transformed by widespread hunting through the shattering of their social life and forcing them to change their diet to one that would encourage further persecution by humans.

⁷³⁹ Mech and Boitani, eds., *Wolves: Behavior, Ecology, and Conservation*, 27-28.

⁷⁴⁰ Akim, *Tengeriin nokhoi*, 47; Akim, *Dog of Heaven*, 63.

⁷⁴¹ Coleman, *Vicious*, 164-165.

⁷⁴² Walker, *Lost Wolves of Japan*, 196.

⁷⁴³ Caroline van Duyne et al., “Wolf Predation among Reintroduced Przewalski Horses in Hustai National Park, Mongolia,” *The Journal of Wildlife Management* 73, no. 6 (2009): 836–43.

Conclusion

Wolves in Mongolia survived the extermination campaigns during socialism and today are seen by some as figures of nationalist pride and others as vicious pests. In 1980 Mongolian scientists estimated there were 30,000 wolves in the country.⁷⁴⁴ However, there are no official wolf population numbers from much of the socialist era or today, though it seems that the wolf population has steadily decreased.⁷⁴⁵ Most contemporary works on Mongolian wolf biology in English focus on predation in protected zones of endangered species and provides only small data points for wolf population numbers.⁷⁴⁶ Hunters who kill wolves without licenses are subject to fines, but wolves are still targeted by both professional and amateur hunters to fuel the fur trade as well as the Chinese and Mongolian traditional medicine markets.⁷⁴⁷

Human-wolf conflict remains strong due to the increase of human population, decrease of prey animals, and, perhaps most importantly, the ballooning of livestock numbers after socialism. Private wolf hunts continue, and province wide wolf hunts are occasionally organized utilizing a bounty system very reminiscent of socialist era hunts. Wolves are blamed for multiple ills, from attacking children, to rabies, to eating endangered species.⁷⁴⁸ The anthropomorphic wolf persists in the post-socialist era, as observed by Mette High in Uyanga, a booming gold

⁷⁴⁴ E. L. Clark et al., "Mongolian Red List of Mammals. Zoological Society of London, London," *English and Mongolian*, 2006, 98.

⁷⁴⁵ G. Gantulga, a Mongolian biologist researching wolves, is currently working to understand historical population numbers using governmental archival data, and contemporary numbers with methods such as camera traps.

⁷⁴⁶ Hannah S. Davie et al., "Measuring and Mapping the Influence of Landscape Factors on Livestock Predation by Wolves in Mongolia," *Journal of Arid Environments* 103 (April 2014): 85–91; Hannah S. Davie et al., "Herders and Wolves in Post-Soviet Society: An Ethnographic Study in Mongolia's Ikh Nart Nature Reserve," *Human Dimensions of Wildlife* 19, no. 4 (July 4, 2014): 319–33; Caroline van Duyn et al., "Wolf Predation among Reintroduced Przewalski Horses in Hustai National Park, Mongolia," *The Journal of Wildlife Management* 73, no. 6 (2009): 836–43; Petra Kaczensky et al., "The Great Gobi B Strictly Protected Area in Mongolia - Refuge or Sink for Wolves *Canis Lupus* in the Gobi," *Wildlife Biology* 14, no. 4 (December 1, 2008): 444–56;

⁷⁴⁷ G. Süld-Erdene, ed., *Mongol Nüüdelchdiin Tailbar Tol'*, Ankhny khevel, vol. 2 (Ulaanbaatar: "MONSUDAR" Kheveliin Gazar : Mongol Khel, Soëlyn Khurelen, 2015).

⁷⁴⁸ Mongolian National Broadcaster (2019, January 7). "Galzuu chono khün notsjee," <http://www.mnb.mn/i/161914>; Richard P. Reading et al., "The Commercial Harvest of Wildlife in Dornod Aimag, Mongolia," *The Journal of Wildlife Management* 62, no. 1 (1998): 59–71, <https://doi.org/10.2307/3802264>.

mining region. Locals explained that pollution (spiritual and physical) of the gold rush creates wolf-people who are marked by their physical characteristics as well as deviant behaviour such as stealing and preying on their fellow humans and are cursed to die alone.⁷⁴⁹ (High 2016).

Widely available books focus on wolves and include both hunting handbooks and Western-style environmentalist revisionist pro-wolf works.⁷⁵⁰ Meanwhile, Mongolian social media groups like Mongolian National Geography use Western-style environmentalist arguments to advocate for wolves and point to the mass extermination of wolves in North America and other countries as a cautionary tale whereas earlier it was a model to be followed.⁷⁵¹ By calling on Western, specifically American, environmentalist theories and attitudes, these Mongolians continue the tradition of an international wolf culture, albeit one that advocates for the protection, rather than killing, of wolves. This is part of a shift that sees the US, rather than the USSR, as the primary example of modernity. Pro-wolf advocates are one of many Mongolian voices arguing over the past and future of wolves in Mongolia.

Socialist Mongolia attempted to exterminate wolves using methods like those found in other countries. In their efforts to combat the wolf, socialists called upon centuries of anti-wolf sentiment found in Mongolia, fueled by the fundamental threat of wolf predation of livestock. Socialist extermination campaigns allowed Mongolians to imagine a wolf-free world, as in the American and Japanese models. Furthermore, when Mongolia transitioned to a capitalist society,

⁷⁴⁹ Mette M. High, “Human Predation and Animal Sociality: The Transformational Agency of ‘Wolf People’ in Mongolia,” in *Anthropology and Cryptozoology* (Routledge, 2016), 107–19.

⁷⁵⁰ D. Damba, *Övgön Anchny Temdeglel* (Ulaanbaatar, 2014); B. Lundaa and L. Baatar, *Ikh Duudlaga* (Ulaanbaatar: BIT Press, 2014); R. Batzhargal, *Zöwkhön chonyn av: chono avlakh tügeemel arguud*, Ulaanbaatar, 2006); Kh. Choizhilzhav, *Mor', nokhoi, chono gurav*, 2017; Kh. Choizhilzhav, *Mor', nokhoi, chono gurav*, 2017; T. Narankhüü, *Mongol nutgiin chono* (Ulaanbaatar: Amja Printing, 2000); D. Eregdenedagva, *Mongol Orny Chono* (Ulaanbaatar: Soyombo Printing, 2010).

⁷⁵¹ “Sain saikhan бүкхииг уриалгааia. - National Geography of Mongolia,” accessed January 23, 2016, <https://www.facebook.com/NatGeoMongolia/photos/a.504310816315113.1073741840.186735384739326/532789780133883/?type=3&theater>. Accessed January 7, 2019.

wolf hunting decreased rather than increased, further proof that capitalist societies do not have a monopoly on conflict with nature. Socialist Mongolian hunting shows the prevalence of predator extermination culture in societies where herding is dominant. It also shows that while hunting was always prevalent in history, it intensifies during periods of modernization.

Only by historicizing Mongolian attitudes towards wolves can we supplant stereotypical assumptions which all too often ascribe a monolithic view to Mongolians, and numerous other peoples. The socialist project in Mongolia promised to exterminate the wolf as one part of the larger movement to change how Mongolians interacted with animals and their environment. Despite claims of exceptionalism, socialist Mongolian modernization programs operated within both a Mongolian and international framework to eliminate wolves. Government planners monitored numbers of livestock killed by wolves at local and state levels and called for wolf extermination to protect livestock and gather pelts. Government employed hunters had quotas of wolves to kill, and some hunters wrote books offering advice of how to hunt wolves and framed hunting as Marxist labor. Wolves were often described by socialist Mongolian writers as having free will and agency but chose to inflict evil. Sympathetic examples like the protagonists of Namdag's short story were subversions of these tropes, but still operated in the Mongolian socialist framework of human-wolf relations.

As with other aspects of collectivization, the promise of wolf extermination was never fully realized, but this was not for lack of trying. Despite five-year plans, bounties, holidays, brigades, and new and improved techniques to kill wolves, the Mongolian wolf survived, almost certainly due to population size and decreased investment in the countryside. With the end of socialism most of the central anti-wolf policies fell away, but many of the same attitudes and trends during the socialist era continue today. By examining wolf hunting as a story with local

actors operating in a global environment, the causes of conflict with wolves, and other animals and the environment, becomes clear. Wolf extermination around the world is not attributable to Western European culture, Christianity, or population, and is instead a global reaction to threats to livestock and follows an international model of modernization which included the mass destruction of predators in order to maximize livestock production.

Conclusion

The end of Collectives... and Rise of Co-operatives?

Socialism officially ended in 1990, and collectives followed soon after in 1991. Collectives were privatized, with members received shares (*tasalbar*).⁷⁵² By 1993 the collectives had been officially divvied up, and while they could have hypothetically continued as private companies, very few survived the transition. Infrastructure that collectives celebrated such as tractors, wells, and *khashaas*, were claimed by individuals, re-appropriated by private co-operatives, or dismantled for parts. The omnipresent organizing entity for countryside life was no more.

I have been asked by both Mongolians and non-Mongolians if collectives were “good” and whether collectivization or de-collectivization was worse. This answer is impossible to answer succinctly, especially for an outsider who did not experience either process. Both collectivization and de-collectivization were a large-scale disruption of the previous socio-economic order in the countryside. Which one was better largely depended on one’s prior pre-collectivization socio-economic position, and the subsequent experience under collectives and transition to private herding. Socialism promised a utopian vision that did not come to pass, but the attempt was enough for many Mongolian herders. Those on the losing end of collectivization would be less generous, just as those on the losing side of de-collectivization condemn the process of privatization. A similar situation was found in Romania, where Katherine Verdery and

⁷⁵² David Sneath, “Mobility, Technology, and Decollectivization of Pastoralism in Mongolia,” *Mongolia in the Twentieth Century. Landlocked Cosmopolitan*, (Routledge, 1999), 223–36.

Gail Kligman show that both collectivization and decollectivization wrought great disruption in countryside life.⁷⁵³

Many foreigners in Mongolia, often involved in businesses or non-profit organizations, have a fascination with collectives. However, their understanding is often flawed; for example, one to be unnamed head of a non-profit designed to help herders claimed that collectives intentionally kept herd numbers low to prevent overgrazing. When I informed this individual that this was a fiction, and I have many documents to prove that the policy was the exact opposite, that leaders desperately tried to increase livestock, they responded that this was not the case because they heard otherwise. Just as die-hard capitalists claim that collectives disincentivized hard work and innovation, some leftists have a rose-colored view of socialism, including collectives. It is easy for some to forget that despite the obvious strengths of a social safety net collectives were fundamentally coercive and hierarchical institutions. I hope this dissertation provides a clearer view of the socialist period for herding and addresses these misconceptions.

Many former collective members lamented the change and end of collectives. It is not surprising that Minjüür, a celebrated collective leader, lamented the end of collectives (and socialism as a whole) as a major step backwards for the country. While he acknowledged problems with the socialist system, he cites the destruction of collectives and their infrastructure as proof of the failures of privatization and the democratic transition.⁷⁵⁴ To illustrate the contrast, he pointed to the 1999-2000 *zud* and its devastating effects and claimed that under the collective system such destruction did not exist. This is not factually accurate, as seen in chapter three, *zuds* in 1967/1968 and 1976/1977 caused more livestock deaths, but he uses this example to highlight

⁷⁵³ Katherine Verdery, *The Vanishing Hectare: Property and Value in Postsocialist Transylvania*, Culture & Society after Socialism (Ithaca: Cornell University Press, 2003); Gail Kligman and Katherine Verdery, *Peasants under Siege: The Collectivization of Romanian Agriculture, 1949-1962* (Princeton: Princeton University Press, 2011).

⁷⁵⁴ 87 cf. 85-88.

the weaknesses of the social safety net in the private economy versus socialism. Climatic disasters are an important method of critiquing the government.

It was not only socialist leaders who lamented the fall of collectives. Many former collective members in the oral history project looked back on the collectives with fondness as seen in the first chapter. Osor, despite his pointed criticism of the authoritarian nature of collectives, holds up collectives and socialism in positive light compared to today's youth.⁷⁵⁵ This is beyond a typical lamentation of ill-behaved youth, as the importance of the wisdom of elders in matters of herding and hunting is a consistent feature of socialist and post-socialist Mongolia.

Books published in contemporary Mongolia point back to the socialist period as a zenith of skilled hunting and herding. Advice handbooks by hunters and herders are all written by people (mostly men) who were highly decorated during the socialist era. Popular and academic books also hold up socialist-era workers as exemplars. T. Semchin's *Mongolyn Mal Azh Akhui, Ediin Zasag* is a weighty tome divided by livestock type, and each chapter features highly decorated collective herders sharing their accomplishments and sage advice for the proper care of the type of livestock they specialized in during the collectives.⁷⁵⁶ Pre-socialist hunting and herding are celebrated as well but obviously there are no living examples to cite in books. Instead, the gold standard of herders and hunters remain those that excelled during the socialist period, and there does not appear to be any argument that socialism represented a break in proper Mongolian herding and hunting knowledge. The post-socialist period is filled with anxiety over the break from a golden era of socialist herding.

⁷⁵⁵ Osor, *The Oral History of Twentieth Century Mongolia*, http://amantuuh.socanth.cam.ac.uk/search/view_summary.php?Interview=090744A&Person=990296

⁷⁵⁶ T. Semchin, *Mongolyn Mal Azh Akhui, Ediin Zasag* (Ulaanbaatar: Tod Bichig, 2017).

While there is little appetite in returning to socialism politically, today there is increasing interest in pursuing co-operatives and collectives inspired by the socialist *negdel* model. These co-operatives address many of the same problems found in the socialist period, as well as issues of increased desertification from climate change and mining. These new co-operatives lack one of the main features that made socialist collectives function: a state monopoly and centralized plan of inputs and outputs. Without the state as a guaranteed customer and inputs incoming regardless of if quotas were made, contemporary collectives are in a far more precarious position. But numerous Mongolian herders agree it is better than the alternative. Co-operatives rely on pooled resources to alleviate risk, but a large enough disaster would presumably not receive the centralized state response that the socialist government was capable of offering. But given the increasing precarity due to climate change and mining a safety net of any kind is attractive.

Mongolian herding will continue to evolve, and herders will continue to adapt as capitalism, climate change, mining, and accusations of causing desertification threatens their lives and livelihoods. Perhaps the history of socialist herding will provide examples, and counter-examples, of possible ways forward.

Collectives, Animals, and the Environment

Collectives reshaped Mongolian society, and how herders related to the environment and animals. This was through a melding of traditional strategies and a reverence for traditional knowledge of elder skilled herders with a belief of the importance of modern technology and infrastructure. Which of these two poles were viewed by socialist leaders as more important varied in each aspect of collectivization. Herders and hunters emphasized the long history of

their professions and lionized the experience of elders. In contrast, veterinary science emphasized the importance of modern schooling and medicine over pre-existing knowledge.

While Mongolian leaders pushed towards a modern socialist future, their concerns over herding remained like those of previous generations: pasture selection, skill of herders, disease, quality of livestock, disaster, and predators. They attempted to overcome these challenges with a melding of the latest Marxist science and technology along with traditional herding knowledge, and did succeed in alleviating some environmental pressure, but could not overcome all the perennial problems facing herders in Mongolia. Socialist Mongolia's struggles were found in many other modernizing countries, and Mongolians clearly positioned themselves as part of an international socialist modernization movement. However, due to in large part to the drop off of funding for collectives, the lofty goals of modernization and vast livestock increase never occurred.

The history of socialist Mongolia's human, animal, and environmental relations show that despite the common misconceptions discussed in the introduction of this dissertation, socialist Mongolian leaders wrestled with many of the environmental problems that other modernizing states did. Movements to maximize livestock production included reorganization of society, improved breeds, vaccinations, combatting disasters, and exterminating predators in both socialist and capitalist countries. Within the debate over traditional versus new methods in Mongolian herding, it was a question of which would maximize production. Human economic activity, including mobile herding, shapes the environment, herders are involved in both livestock births and deaths, and hunters will always kill animals, especially in economies of scale. There are methods that are more sustainable; in Mongolia mobile herding is more sustainable than sedentary herding, much less farming or mining. But the romanticization of

certain ways of life, like the myths of a timeless nomadic Mongolia both obscures the history of the region and dehumanizes the people in question, and creates an unrealistic idea of how humans impact their environment. In the increasingly dire situation of climate change, widespread environmental degradation, and mass destruction of wildlife, it is only possible to find solutions to address these problems when earlier periods of human-animal and environmental relationships are understood, and both the continuities and changes analyzed in both the local and global context.

Future Research

Though it at time seemed like an overwhelming endeavor, this dissertation is relatively modest in scope. It only covers the second round of collectivization and a bit of post-campaign collective life, leaving the subsequent twenty years largely unexplored. Far more apparent is the fact that the failed first round of collectivization is not covered. The largest lacuna in socialist herding remains the interregnum period from 1932 to 1955 when only a few collectives existed, and most herders organized and worked their livestock privately and created a system of exploitation that collectives aimed to address. Contemporary co-operatives and their similarities and differences to socialist collectives are also in dire need to attention. I am unlikely to be able to tackle these topics anytime soon, but I hope that future scholars will be able to do so.

What I do hope to add to this project in the future is an additional local archival research site in the Middle Gobi. This would pair well with my research in South Khangai, as the *khangai* and the *gobi* were the two ideal types by which the socialist government determined private livestock ownership. They are the two regions in Mongolia that differ the most from each other due to rainfall, fodder availability, and livestock composition.

I also plan to explore deeper histories of major animal and environmental themes I began to highlight in this dissertation. In this dissertation I already gesture to pre- and post-socialist wolf histories, and I hope to be able to expand these histories into a proper history of climatic disasters, *zud* and *gan*, in Mongolia and perhaps broader North and Inner Asia. With ever worsening contemporary climate change bringing more frequent disasters, it is all the more important to understand the history of these disasters. Another future project I hope to explore is that of the wolf in Greater Mongolia. By both reaching back centuries earlier and showing the situation of the wolf today, I hope to continue to elucidate Mongolians' historical relationship with wolves and clearly place them in the history of global wolf history. But most of all, I hope that future scholars continue to explore different topics and periods human, environmental, and animal histories, humanities, and social sciences.

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Weiner, Douglas R. *Models of Nature: Ecology, Conservation, and Cultural Revolution in Soviet Russia*. Pitt Series in Russian and East European Studies. Pittsburgh, Pa: University of Pittsburgh Press, 2000.

Willerslev, Rane. *Soul Hunters: Hunting, Animism, and Personhood Among the Siberian Yukaghirs*. Berkeley: University of California Press, 2007.

Woods, Rebecca J. H. *The Herds Shot Round the World: Native Breeds and the British Empire, 1800–1900*. The University of North Carolina Press, 2017.

Worringer, Renée. “Shepherd’s Enemy or Aşina, Böri, Börte Činō, and Bozkurt?: Wolf as Menace, Wolf as Mythical.” *Society & Animals* 24, no. 6 (2016): 556–73.

Zanca, Russell. “Writing the History of Collectivization in Uzbekistan: Oral Narratives.” *National Council for Eurasian and ...*, January 1, 2008.

Zhagvaral, N. *Aratstvo i Aratskoe Khoziaistvo*. Ulan-Bator: Akademiia Nauk Mongol’skoi Narodnoi Respubliki, 1974.

Curriculum Vitae
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Education

- Ph.D. Central Eurasian Studies, History Minor, Indiana University, 2022
Dissertation: “Milk is Gold: An Environmental and Animal History of Livestock Herding in Socialist Mongolia”

Dissertation Committee: Kathryn Graber, Christopher Atwood, György Kara, Jonathan Schlesinger, Scott O’Bryan
- M.A. Central Eurasian Studies, Indiana University, 2015
Thesis: “Representations and Memories of the Collectivization Campaigns in the Mongolian People’s Republic, 1929-1960”
- B.A. History, Ramapo College of New Jersey, 2010

Research and Teaching Interests

environmental history; animal history; mobile pastoralism; history of agriculture; climate history;
socialism; Mongolia; East Asia; Siberia; North Asia; Eurasia.

Awards, Fellowships, and Honors

- 2018 Indiana University College Arts & Humanities Institute Graduate Conference Travel Award
2016 Fulbright-Hays Doctoral Dissertation Research Abroad Fellow, Mongolia
2016 Indiana University College Arts & Humanities Institute Graduate Conference Travel Award
2016 Denis Sinor Essay Prize, “The Khiimori of the Wolf Under Socialism: Wolves, Pastoralism, and Modernity in Mongolia”
2015 Indiana University OVPIA Pre-Dissertation Research Grant
2015 American Center for Mongolian Studies Field Research Fellow
2014 American Center for Mongolian Studies Language Fellow
2014 Foreign Language Area Studies (FLAS) summer fellowship, Mongolian
2011 Foreign Language Area Studies (FLAS) academic year fellowship, Mongolian
2011 Title VIII Fellowship for summer study of Mongolian

Publications

Peer-Reviewed Journal Articles

- 2021 “Animals, Socialism, and Continuity: Wolf Hunting in the Mongolian People’s Republic.” *Inner Asia* 32, no. 2: 257–284.

Encyclopedia and Reference Entries

- In press. “Animal History in Mongolia.” *Oxford Research Encyclopaedia of Asian History*.

Translations

- 2018 “Solitude,” translation of S. Erdene’s short story “Gantsaardal,” for *Words without Borders*, October 2018 issue.
<https://www.wordswithoutborders.org/article/october-2018-dalit-writing-solitude-erdene-seng-kenneth-linden>

Book Reviews

- In press. Review of *Eurasian Environments: Nature and Ecology in Imperial Russian and Soviet History*, edited by Nicholas Breyfogle for H-Net Environment
- In press. Review of *Fear and Fortune: Spirit Worlds and Emerging Economies in the Mongolian Gold Rush* by Mette High for Mongolian Studies

Magazine Articles

- In press. “Wolf Hunting.” *History Today*.

Manuscripts in Preparation

- In prep. “Veterinarians, Vaccines, and Hybrids: Western-Style Veterinary Science in the Mongolian People’s Republic.” In preparation to submit to *Environmental History*.

Conference Activity

Panels Organized

- 2021 Organized “Interdisciplinary Approaches to Animals and the Environment in Mongolian Studies” panel at the Annual Meeting of The Mongolia Society, Indianapolis, Indiana, September 18.
- 2018 Organized “Central Eurasian Environmental and Animal Histories” panel at 19th Central Studies Society Annual Conference, Pittsburgh, PA, October 25-28.

Papers Presented

- 2022 “An Animal History of Socialist Mongolia” to be presented at Animal History Group Virtual Seminar, November 9.
- 2022 “D. Namdag’s ‘Howl of the Old Wolf’ and Wolves as Metaphor in Socialist Mongolia” presented at Central Eurasian Studies Society Annual Conference, Bloomington IN, October 20-23.
- 2021 “Environmental and Animal History of Collectivization in the Mongolian People’s Republic (1956-1960)” presented at Agricultural Cooperatives of Mongolian Peoples’ Republic (1960-1992) Conference, Ulaanbaatar, Mongolia, November 26. Virtual Event due to Covid 19.
- 2021 “Veterinarians, Vaccines, and Hybrids: Veterinary Science in the Mongolian People’s Republic” presented at Annual Meeting of The Mongolia Society, Indianapolis, IN, September 18.
- 2021 “Guards, Companions, and Vermin: Dogs in the Mongolian People’s Republic” 27 Annual Association of Central Eurasian Students (ACES) Conference, Bloomington, IN, February 28. Virtual Event due to COVID 19.
- 2021 “Veterinary Science, *Zud*, and Wolves: Environmental and Animal History of Collectivization in Mongolia,” presented at MIASU Research Seminar, Cambridge University, February 23. Virtual Event due to COVID 19.
- 2021 “Ancestors, Enemy of Livestock, and the Object of Mercy: Wolves in the Mongol Empire,” presented at Environmental History Panel for Mongol Zoominar, The Hebrew University of Jerusalem, January 22. Virtual Event due to COVID 19.
- 2020 “*Zud*, Livestock Loss, and Adaptation: Climatic Disasters in Socialist Mongolia” presented at 26th Annual Association of Central Eurasian Students (ACES) Conference, Bloomington, IN, February 29.
- 2019 “Veterinarians, Vaccines, and Hybrids in the Mongolian People’s Republic, 1954-1964” presented at 25th Annual Association of Central Eurasian Students (ACES) Conference, Bloomington, IN, February 23.
- 2018 “Ravenous Beasts, Pitiful Sinners, and Class Enemies: A History of the Wolf in Mongolia,” presented at 19th Central Studies Society Annual Conference, Pittsburgh, PA October 28.
- 2017 “Livestock, Predators, and the Environment in Socialist Mongolia,” presented at 23rd Annual Association of Central Eurasian Students (ACES) Conference, Bloomington, IN, March 4.

- 2016 “The *Khiimori* of the Wolf Under Socialism: Wolves, Pastoralism, and Modernity in Mongolia,” presented at Humanity & Other Forms of Life: Environmental Histories of the World,” Washington D.C., November 5.
- 2016 “Wolves, Pastoralism, and Modernity in Mongolia,” presented at 22nd Annual Association of Central Eurasian Students (ACES) Conference, Bloomington, IN, March 12.
- 2015 “Collectivization in the Buriat-Mongolian Autonomous Soviet Socialist Republic, 1929-1932,” presented at 21st Annual Association of Central Eurasian Students (ACES) Conference, Bloomington, IN, March 7.
- 2014 “Representations and Memories of the Collectivization Campaigns in the Mongolian People’s Republic, 1929-1960, presented at 20th Annual Association of Central Eurasian Students (ACES) Conference, Bloomington, IN, March 8.
- 2012 “Historiography of Mongol Imperial Cities,” presented at 18th Annual Association of Central Eurasian Students (ACES) Conference, Bloomington, IN, March 3.

Talks and Presentations

- 2020 “Veterinarians and Veterinary Science in the Mongolian People's Republic.” Association of Central Eurasian Students Brown Bag. Bloomington, IN, September 24. Virtual Event due to COVID 19.
- 2019 “Mongolian Animal and Environmental History.” Association of Central Eurasian Students Brown Bag. Bloomington, IN, March 6.
- 2018 “Ravenous Beasts, Pitiful Sinners, and Class Enemies: A History of the Wolf in Mongolia.” American Center for Mongolian Studies Speaker Series. Ulaanbaatar, January 16.
- 2016 “Animals, Environment, and Fieldwork in Mongolia.” Summer Language Program Brown Bag Lecture Series. Bloomington, IN, July 11.
- 2015 “Mongolian Collectivization: Environmental History, Animals, and Questions for Future Research.” Inner Asian and Uralic National Resource Center Brown Bag Series, Bloomington, IN, December 2.
- 2015 “Collectivization in the Mongolian People’s Republic, 1929-1960.” American Center for Mongolian Studies Summer Speaker Series. Ulaanbaatar, August 11.
- 2014 “Collectivization in Mongolia, 1929-1960: Current Work and Prospects for Future Research.” Inner Asian and Uralic National Resource Center Brown Bag Series. Bloomington, IN, December 2.

2011 “An Examination of the Historiography of Mongolian Imperial Cities.” Central Asian Research Roundtable. Bloomington, IN, August 3.

Teaching Experiences

St. Joseph’s University, Philadelphia:

Adjunct Instructor: “Forging the Modern World,” Spring 2022

Indiana University, Bloomington:

Primary Instructor: “Pro-seminar in Russian and East European Area Studies,” Fall 2021

Primary Instructor: “Modern Mongolia,” Spring 2021

Primary Instructor: “Introduction to Central Asia, Mongolia, and Tibet,” Fall 2020

Associate Instructor: “Global Health and Environment,” Spring 2020 with Jessica O'Reilly

Associate Instructor: “Introduction to International Studies,” Fall 2016, Spring 2017, Fall 2019
with Peter Nemes and Nicole Serena Kousaleos

Associate Instructor: “Empire of the Mongols” with Christopher Atwood, Spring 2016

Associate Instructor: “Oil, Islam, and Geopolitics,” with Gardner Bovingdon, Fall 2015

Associate Instructor: “Empire of the Mongols” with Christopher Atwood, Spring 2013

Associate Instructor: “Oil, Islam, and Geopolitics” with Gardner Bovingdon, Fall 2012

Other Professional Experiences

Communications Associate: Central Eurasian Studies Society, 2022

Graduate Assistant: Mongolia Society, 2021

Graduate Assistant: The Pan-Asia Institute, 2018-2019

Graduate Assistant: Web and Multimedia: Inner Asia and Uralic National Resource Center,
2013-2015

Research Assistant: Christopher Atwood, 2010-2011

Guest Lectures

- 2021 “Environmental anthropology and history (Mongolia, Siberia, and Inner Mongolia).” Mari Valdur’s Anthropology of East Asia. Riga Stradiņš University, Riga, Latvia, September 17. (Virtual Event due to Covid 19).
- 2018 “Challenges in Pastoral Life: Past and Present.” Kathryn Graber’s Nomads, Networks & Communities. Indiana University, Bloomington, IN, October 8.
- 2017 “Mongolia and Inner Mongolia: Historical and Contemporary Issues.” Brian Cwiek’s Literary and Intellectual Traditions: Self and Society in Contemporary China. Indiana University, South Bend, IN, April 18.
- 2017 “Mongolia and Inner Mongolia: Independence, Livestock, and the Environment.” Brian Cwiek’s Modern China and the World from Mao until Now in Local Perspectives. Indiana University, South Bend, IN, April 18.
- 2016 “Collectivization and the Environment in Socialist Mongolia.” Ron Sela’s Introduction to Central Asia, Mongolia, and Tibet. Indiana University, Bloomington, IN, November 16.
- 2015 “History of the Mongol Empire and Russia.” Ariann Stern-Gottschalk’s Old Church Slavonic. Indiana University, Bloomington, IN, October 14.
- 2015 “Recent Transitions in Mongolian Herding.” Kathryn Graber’s Nomads, Networks, and Communities. Indiana University, Bloomington, IN, March 3.
- 2013 “History of the Mongol Empire and Russia.” Ariann Stern-Gottschalk’s Old Church Slavonic. Indiana University, Bloomington, IN, October 22.

Service and Public Outreach

Peer Reviewer for *Environmental History* and *Inner Asia*.

Interviewed by *Folkwise*, December 14, 2021. <https://youtu.be/0D1nmk7tR3Q>

Wrote Article for IAUNRC “Mongolian Environmental and Animal History,” June 25, 2019

Tour for ROTC trainee group at the Mongolian Military Museum, Ulaanbaatar, July 1, 2015

Tour for visiting scholars for the American Center for Mongolian Studies, Ulaanbaatar, June 18, 2015

Tour for visiting scholars at the Mongolian National History Museum, Ulaanbaatar, July 5, 2014

Organized IAUNRC Graduate Student Brown Bag Series at Indiana University, 2013-2015

Video Conference presentation to schools and retirement homes for the IAUNRC, 2012-2015

Outreach to elementary schools for the IAUNRC, 2011-2015

Graduate and Professional Student Organization Representative for Association of Central Eurasian Students at Indiana University, 2013-2014

Memberships in Professional Associations

American Society for Environmental History
Association for Asian Studies
Central Eurasian Studies Society
American Historical Association
The Mongolia Society

Languages

English (Native)
Mongolian (speaking, reading, writing: advanced)
Classical Mongolian (reading: advanced)
Russian (reading: advanced, speaking: intermediate)
German (reading: intermediate)
French (reading: intermediate)

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